The Free Colony

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[Dedication goes here.]

Chapter 01 — "Clause 9.4.2"

Forty-seven people in a room designed for thirty, and not one of them was happy about it.

Cole Maren sat in a chair that cost someone at Asterlyne a lot of points in a procurement spreadsheet—cheap enough that nobody would notice the line item, expensive enough to signal that this process mattered. Professional. Controlled. The kind of seating that said: *We take you seriously, but not too seriously, because if you were serious people, you wouldn't be here.*

The waiting room smelled like new plastic and the desperation everyone was pretending not to emit. Fluorescent ceiling panels buzzed at a frequency Cole could feel in his molars. A tablet on the low table in front of him displayed the charter—all 247 pages of it, not the 200 they'd claimed in the recruitment materials. He'd started counting on page one and hadn't stopped.

Around him, people were talking. Not talking, really. Performing the social shapes of talking—the woman to his left asking the woman next to her whether she'd done the medical screening, both of them knowing the answer was yes, both of them needing the distraction of words. The man in the corner—contractor's shoulders, calloused hands, not the type to volunteer for anything unless there was something urgent he was running from—staring at a tablet with the concentration of someone who'd decided not to read.

Cole read.

He had the luxury of being methodical. Nobody here knew him. Nobody was going to ask why he wasn't pacing the way the young guy near the door was pacing, or networking the way the two botanists in the corner seemed to be networking, trading names and institutional affiliations like they were at a conference instead of a one-way ticket off Earth. Cole could sit. Could read. Could let the fluorescent light strip the personality out of his face until he looked like he belonged here—which is to say, he looked like someone with nothing better to do.

The contract was written in English, which was kind. It could have been written in legalese—that subspecies of English that used all the same words but rearranged them to prevent understanding. But this contract was designed to be read. Just not *by* the signatories. The structure was forward-facing, user-friendly, the language was clear, the sections labeled sensibly. A person reading it in good faith would arrive at a different understanding than a person reading it carefully.

Cole read carefully.

Section 1: Organizational Charter of the Free Colonial Initiative, Parcel 16b Settlement.

All colonists agreed to the terms without qualification, without amendment, without negotiation. Fine. Nobody negotiated with Asterlyne. That wasn't the system.

Sections 2–5: the basic infrastructure. Settlement boundaries. Resource allocation. Command structure. A temporary governance council elected by majority vote, authority subordinate to the Company Safety Officer, who retained final decision-making on all matters of environmental management and resource distribution.

The woman next to Cole glanced down at his tablet. He felt her looking. He didn't move, didn't look back, just kept reading. She went back to not reading hers.

Section 6: Ownership and Land Rights.

This was where people usually started skimming.

Upon successful establishment of self-sustaining agricultural capacity and the passage of five (5) Earth years, title to Parcel 16b shall transfer to the colonist collective, contingent upon maintenance of charter compliance and population threshold stabilization.

Cole read that sentence three times.

Population threshold stabilization.

He flipped to the appendices. Nobody flipped to the appendices. The appendices were where you found the definitions that made you understand what you'd actually agreed to.

Clause 9.4.1: Definition of "colonist collective."

Ownership stake in Parcel 16b (upon transfer) shall be distributed equally among all original signatories to this charter present and alive on Year Five, Day One, beginning at 0000 hours UTC+7. Signatories who voluntarily depart the settlement, fail to renew charter consent, or are deceased shall forfeit their stake and have such stake distributed pro-rata among remaining signatories.

Okay. Straightforward. Forty-seven of them now. If someone left early, the pie got smaller, but their slice got bigger. People understood that math. It was a motivator—every person who stayed made everyone else's stake slightly larger. Asterlyne was good at architecture like that. Creating incentives that looked aligned but actually severed the group's interest from their survival.

Clause 9.4.2: Stabilization Threshold.

Transfer of title shall occur only if, at Year Five Day One, no fewer than fifty-one percent (51%) of original signatories remain alive and present at the settlement. Should this threshold not be met, title shall revert to Asterlyne Corporation in perpetuity, along with all improvements and resources thereupon. No compensation to colonists or next of kin shall be due.

Cole set the tablet down.

He looked at it on the table like it had grown teeth.

Forty-seven people. Fifty-one percent of forty-seven was 23.97. Functionally, twenty-four. You needed twenty-four people alive in five years, out of the forty-seven who started, to own anything.

Twenty-three could die. That was the margin.

He picked the tablet back up. Read it again. He hadn't miscalculated—his math was exact, and that was the problem. Nearly half the people in this room could die, and the contract would call it a success.

Cole looked up from the screen.

The contractor was still not reading his tablet. The woman next to him was reading the same page she'd been reading five minutes ago. The botanists were talking about soil chemistry, their voices settling into the kind of comfortable technical discussion that meant they'd probably worked together before, probably had a history that didn't start in this room. Near the window, a younger guy—couldn't be more than twenty-two, twenty-three—was rereading the same section over and over, his leg bouncing with the kind of focused anxiety that suggested he was trying very hard to understand something he was afraid to understand.

Cole counted the room. There were the two botanists. The contractor. The woman next to him. The bouncing kid. A doctor, fifties, calm, reading with the measured attention of someone used to processing medical literature. A small cluster of three in the corner who seemed to know each other—energy efficient, probably academic, the type who came to this because they'd burned through their funding and a charter settlement sounded like a field opportunity. Four people he hadn't classified yet. The facilitator, who was polished and

bored in exactly the way that suggested she'd watched forty-seven batches of desperate people sign away their rights to land they'd never own.

Forty-seven faces.

Cole looked at each one and asked himself the same question: How many of these people will be dead five years from now?

Not will choose to leave. Not will want to go home. *Will be dead.*

The contractor had an old scar on his jaw that suggested he was good at surviving. That was one point in his favor. The bouncing kid looked like he couldn't survive a bad meal, but youth was its own strategy—faster healing, better reflexes, less likelihood of pre-existing conditions. The doctor had calloused fingertips that came from years of something—surgery, probably. Surgical hands were attached to people who made complicated decisions under pressure. That usually meant longevity.

He was still counting when the facilitator stood.

"We're ready to begin," she said. Her name was Melissa. It was on her badge. She said it the way you'd say: *We're ready to start the experiment.*

They were ushered down a hallway into a smaller room with individual signing stations—corporate ergonomics, each one separated by a divider so nobody had to watch anyone else sign. Privacy theater. Nobody needed privacy to sign away their rights, but it was more comfortable for everyone if they pretended they did.

Cole took his station. His tablet displayed the full charter, pre-populated with his name: COLE MAREN. His background check was complete. His medical clearance was already noted. His initial investment of fifty thousand credits—everything he'd been saving, everything he still owed on the loan that made the fifty thousand possible—was documented. His signature would make it binding.

He didn't sign immediately.

He ran through the math again.

Twenty-four alive. Fifty-one percent. Year five. Five years from day one until the clause triggered. Not five years from now—five years from the day they landed, from the moment the shuttle touched down on Parcel 16b and they became subject to the full weight of the charter.

In five years, Cole would be forty-three. Lily was nine. He'd had custody three years ago, back when the logistics job was still a logistics job and not a series of contract positions that paid less each quarter. He'd held custody like a trophy he'd won and didn't know how to carry, had let it slip through his hands the way he let everything slip eventually—good at systems, terrible at presence.

The career contracted. The apartment shrank. A two-bedroom became a studio became a room he rented by the week. The visits went from weekly to biweekly to monthly to quarterly, each reduction feeling less like a loss and more like a correction.

His ex-wife had filed for full custody eighteen months ago. She hadn't needed to file hard. He'd already surrendered the space where being a father lived.

He thought about Lily at nine, probably taller now than he remembered. The last visit had been awkward. She'd drawn a horse in colored pencil and asked if he wanted to keep it. He'd said yes. Meant it. Left it on the table when he walked out because the recruiter from Asterlyne was waiting and he needed to close the door on something, anything, to stop the feeling that everything he touched fell apart.

The horse was probably in a recycle bin somewhere.

He'd gotten the recruitment email the next day. It had landed in his inbox like an answer to a prayer he hadn't quite had the courage to articulate.

Cole signed.

He used the stylus on the tablet and dragged his name across the signature box. Official. Binding. Witnessed by timestamp, biometric scan, satellite uplink. Legally immutable.

He'd just bet the forty-three-year-old version of himself that he would be alive on Parcel 16b, one of twenty-four survivors.

He'd bet everything he hadn't already lost—on clause 9.4.2.

On the fact that he could count.

On the fact that if you counted carefully enough, you could make the math work. You could read what was written even when nobody wanted you to read it. You could understand what was being asked of you even when nobody would articulate the question.

Twenty-three people. That's what it cost.

He wasn't hoping nobody died. That would be stupid. People always died. Disease, accident, bad luck, the simple arithmetic of time. On Earth, people died too. At least here, the math was clear.

He walked out of the signing room into the hallway where the other forty-six people were filing out of their own stations, each one carrying the same tablet, each one having just signed the same charter, each one presumably having read the same clause.

Or not. Probably not.

Most of them looked like they'd been reading the user-friendly sections, the parts that promised land, ownership, a fresh start. Most of them weren't looking at the man in the corridor the way Cole was looking at them—the way you might look at a group of assets and try to calculate which ones would hold their value.

The contractor from the waiting room passed him. Scarred jaw, calloused hands. His name tag read POLK, G. He glanced at Cole the way you look at someone when you're deciding if they're competition or just another body in the headcount.

"Hell of a thing," Polk said. Not really to Cole. To the corridor, to the fluorescent light, to the general condition of signing away everything you had left.

He walked on before Cole could answer.

Cole watched him go. Polk hadn't read the contract. You could tell from the way he moved—angry but unfocused, the posture of a man who'd signed on instinct rather than analysis. He thought the danger was the frontier. Didn't know the danger was the fine print.

The corridor emptied. The fluorescent hum settled back into Cole's molars.

He'd signed up for the frontier. He'd actually signed up for the margin—the twenty-three lives between ownership and nothing.

And he was betting everything he had left—which wasn't much, which was the point—on the fact that he could count.

Chapter 02 — "Transit"

Three months in recycled air tastes like someone else's exhalation mixed with industrial scrubbers. Cole learned to stop noticing it by week two, which meant he'd learned to stop noticing a lot of things. The Asterlyne transport vessel wasn't designed for comfort. It was designed for efficiency and just enough habitability to keep the cargo alive until delivery.

The crew of forty-seven had settled into the lower decks like sediment. Bunks in columns of four. A common mess that doubled as the orientation room. A medical bay where Haruki Sato—the doctor, the calm one, the man who'd introduced himself by asking everyone their medical history instead of their name—had already organized a basic clinic. Exercise equipment that nobody used because moving in 0.7G made the stomach betray you.

Cole spent most of his time reading.

The charter existed in full digital copy on the ship's network, along with supplementary materials: geological surveys, atmospheric data, agricultural projections, structural schematics. Personnel files. Cole started with the geological surveys and worked outward — atmospheric composition, seasonal modeling, soil chemistry baselines. He read the way he'd always read corporate data: not for what was there, but for what should have been. The surveys were clean. Too clean. Methodology notes referenced comparison datasets that weren't included. Soil analysis tables started mid-sequence, as though earlier measurements had been stripped. The gaps were small and the gaps were deliberate.

It was the kind of thing you'd notice if you knew what missing data looked like. Most people didn't.

Most people were doing what they were doing in the common mess on the forty-fifth day of transit: clustering into smaller groups, forming the soft hierarchies that would become the harder hierarchies once gravity meant something again. The two botanists from the initial signing — colleagues from an Earth research institute, both women, both operating under the assumption that the settlement would have built-in scientific infrastructure — had claimed a table and were planning projects. Three academics who didn't quite know each other yet but recognized the type — the kind of people who'd chased this opportunity because their funding had ended, because they had nothing else to lose, because an off-world colony looked like a second act.

Garrett Polk had gathered about eight people around him at the far table and was talking about freedom. Not freedom as an abstraction. Freedom as a wound.

"...systems that look rational," Polk was saying, his voice the kind that filled a room whether you wanted it to or not, "built by people who've never had to live inside them. You do everything right. Follow the plan. Then you find out the plan was never yours. It was for the people who wrote it."

Eight heads nodding. Cole watched from across the mess and heard the specific bitterness underneath the rhetoric — not ideology, but damage. The anger of people who'd played by rules that turned out to be traps, who'd built things that got taken, who'd signed deals that looked like opportunity and turned out to be architecture. Polk wasn't selling a philosophy. He was selling the feeling of finally being right about who had broken you.

Ren Tsai was at a table alone, reviewing something on her personal tablet that made her frown.

Cole had learned her name from the orientation materials. Engineer. Specialty: structural systems and environmental management. She'd been quiet during the embarkation process but had asked three questions during the first orientation presentation that had made the facilitators visibly uncomfortable: questions about the gap between the projected resource allocations and the documented planetary

volatility, questions about failover systems if primary water processing failed, questions about what happened to a settlement if the Company Safety Officer position became unexpectedly vacant.

The facilitators had given the kind of answers that were technically true and completely unhelpful.

Ren had written down their answers anyway, which meant she understood that documentation mattered more than satisfaction.

Cole carried his meal tray to her table. It was a violation of the soft social rules—you didn't join someone sitting alone unless they invited you. But Cole was good at calculating when rules could be bent.

"Can I sit?" he asked.

Ren looked up. She was older than he'd initially thought—maybe mid-thirties instead of late twenties. Her face was the kind that stayed still when it was thinking, which made the moments when it moved mean something. It moved now.

"Sure," she said.

Cole sat. The chair was the kind engineered for low-G comfort, which meant it felt like sitting on a marshmallow someone had wrapped in steel.

"You asked good questions," Cole said.

"They didn't answer any of them," Ren said.

"That's usually how you know they're good questions."

Ren set down her tablet. Up close, Cole could see what she'd been reading: the resource allocation spreadsheet, compared to what looked like her own calculations. She'd been checking the math. Probably finding it didn't add up.

"What's your background?" she asked.

"Logistics. Inventory management, supply chain optimization, that kind of thing."

"So you count things."

"I keep things from running out."

Ren nodded like this explained something. It did. He could see her recalibrating what she was looking at—not just information anymore, but a problem. And problems needed people who could count.

"Why did you sign up?" she asked.

Cole had an answer prepared for this question. It was true and incomplete: "Earth didn't need me anymore. Out there, I might."

It was the kind of answer that closed conversations gently. Ren didn't push. But she looked at him the way someone looks at a calculation they don't quite believe yet, and he knew she was reading the deflection accurately. She understood that he'd answered a different question than the one she'd asked.

She didn't call him on it.

"I'm Ren," she said, and went back to her tablet.

Cole ate his meal — some kind of protein cultivate that had the texture of foam and the flavor of commitment to nutrition — and watched the common mess reorganize itself. The academics had drifted toward Polk's table, drawn by the gravitational pull of a man who sounded like he had answers. The botanists had

separated, one heading to find Haruki in the medical bay, the other — Dana Wen — settling into a corner with her notebook. Actual paper. She filled pages in handwriting so small it looked like code. Who sat where. Who ate what. Which orientation modules people skipped. She avoided eye contact with the practiced ease of someone who'd learned that being overlooked was safety. Cole noticed her because she was designed not to be noticed.

Haruki was visible through the medical bay hatch, sitting across from a colonist in what had become his daily routine — colonists sat down one by one for conversations that started as medical histories and ended with questions nobody wanted answered. How long without your medication? What happens when resupply stops? He asked them in that measured voice, as though he were merely filling in forms.

Joss Carver — twenty-two, the youngest on the manifest — was panicking and preparing in roughly equal measure. He'd cycle through the charter with his leg bouncing, then pivot to the survival appendices, building checklists, cross-referencing agricultural projections with settlement schematics. He'd watched every orientation video Asterlyne had loaded onto the network. Asked Haruki about field wound care. Asked Ren about water system failures. Over-prepared in the way that young people sometimes are when preparation is the only thing they can control.

Polk was laughing about something at his table. Not a happy laugh. The kind that lived in the space between humor and anger, the sound of a man who'd learned to make jokes about things that had broken him.

By the sixty-third day, Cole had learned the rhythms of the ship well enough to move through it without thinking. He knew which paths connected the medical bay to the agricultural storage without passing through the common mess. He knew when Ren went to the exercise equipment and came back all motion and sharp breathing. He knew that Dana did her heavy work in the agricultural lab in the early hours, when nobody else was awake.

He'd organized his own analysis by then. Built a quiet spreadsheet in a private partition of the ship's network. Listed forty-six names — Garrett Polk already filed from signing day, the man who'd said *Hell of a thing* to the corridor and kept walking, all that anger with nowhere to land. Coded them by skill set, by apparent psychological resilience, by the things they'd admitted in casual conversation about why they'd signed.

It was a monster's work, really. Ranking people by survival probability.

But Cole had stopped caring about being anything other than useful.

Polk found him on the observation deck three weeks before planet-fall. The deck was the one section of the ship that looked out at nothing — vast dark, occasional stars, Parcel 16b visible only as a brightening dot among fixed lights.

Polk was at the deck's single table, writing on a napkin. Not words. Numbers. Cole could see the shape of it from across the space — columns of figures, credit amounts, interest calculations. The arithmetic of debt. Polk was comparing what he owed on Earth against what the charter promised, drawing lines between numbers that didn't connect, running the math the way you'd run it if you were looking for an exit that didn't exist.

Cole watched. Didn't hide it.

When Polk realized he was being observed, he crumpled the napkin. The instinct was immediate — not guilt about the numbers, but guilt about being seen running them. His face rearranged itself into the big, public expression Cole had watched him wear in the mess. But the crumpled napkin was still in his fist.

"You read the whole thing, didn't you?" Polk said. "The charter."

"Yes."

"The appendices. The sub-clauses. All of it."

"All of it."

Polk leaned back. Studied Cole the way he studied people — quickly, with the intelligence he tried to keep underneath the volume. Cole could see the question forming. Not the one Polk was about to ask, but the one underneath it. The one that had been on the napkin.

"Find any way out of here?"

Cole considered the question. The honest answer was complicated. There was no way out — no early exit, no loophole that dissolved the contract, no clause that made the debt calculations on Polk's napkin come out different. But there was clause 9.4.2, which wasn't a way out. It was a way through. Five years. Twenty-four alive. Ownership in perpetuity. Polk didn't know about it. Hadn't read far enough to find it.

"No," Cole said.

Polk's face changed. Not defeat — something closer to relief. He lit up the way people light up when someone confirms what they've been afraid to believe: that the game really is rigged, that the math really doesn't work, that it isn't just them.

"No," Polk repeated, almost to himself. "No, there isn't. There never is." He smoothed the crumpled napkin against his thigh, then pocketed it. "I knew it before I signed. Built a whole business on numbers once. Did everything right. Numbers worked. System didn't." He looked out at the dark. "You run numbers long enough, you learn they only work for the people who wrote the equation."

He stood. He was done. He'd gotten what he came for — confirmation from the one person on the ship who'd actually read the contract that the contract was exactly what he already believed it was: a trap you couldn't calculate your way out of.

Cole watched him leave. Understood three things: Polk hadn't read the charter. Polk thought Cole was a fellow prisoner in resignation. And Polk had no idea that resignation and strategy look identical from the outside but are entirely different machines.

Cole didn't correct him. Didn't mention clause 9.4.2. Didn't tell him there was something in the appendices worth finding.

Some information was only useful if the right person had it.

He turned back to his tablet. The weather projections. The agricultural failure vectors. The skills that would matter in months two and three and twelve when Earth was a memory and the supply drops became theoretical.

He wasn't resigned.

He was building the mathematics of survival.

The final orientation briefing happened five days before planet-fall. All forty-seven colonists gathered in the common mess. A facilitator—not Melissa from the signing station, someone new, someone even more polished and bored—presented the settlement overview.

Parcel 16b. Coordinates. Atmospheric composition. Seasonal cycles. Agricultural viability index. She said the word *index* with the precision of someone reading from a tablet, which is exactly what she was doing.

"The viability index for this parcel," the facilitator said, "has been measured at eighty-four."

Cole looked up.

Eighty-four.

He didn't need to check his tablet. He'd memorized the data appendix weeks ago — every table, every index, every footnote the supplementary materials had buried behind the recruitment brochure. The viability index in the actual survey data was seventy-two.

Seventy-two. Not eighty-four.

A difference of twelve points. The difference between optimism and actual capability. The difference between a projectable settlement timeline and a question mark.

He looked at Ren across the mess. She was looking at him, had been looking at him, had clearly noticed the discrepancy at the same moment and was watching to see if he'd registered it. When their eyes met, she looked away—not dismissive, just confirming. You saw it. I saw it. The question became: what were they going to do about a lie that was buried in supplementary materials that most people wouldn't read?

The facilitator continued her presentation, and Cole returned to his spreadsheet, to his calculations, to the mathematics of scarcity and survival.

The brochure had promised eighty-four.

The planet, he suspected, would deliver seventy-two.

And the colony would have to make the difference work with four thousand kilometers of distance and five years of solitude and the kind of mathematics that only looked simple until you had to live inside it.

Cole started a new column in his spreadsheet.

He labeled it: *Margin for Error*.

He left the cell empty.

He didn't know yet what number should go there, or even if any number was possible.

But he was going to find out.

Chapter 03 — "Parcel 16b"

The descent came in three phases. First, the long brake through atmosphere, the shuttle shuddering and groaning the way metal groans when it's asked to defy physics and mostly wins. Second, the sight of it—planet swelling in the viewport from a dot to a thing, from a coordinate to a world. Third, the silence after the engines cut, when forty-seven people held their collective breath and tried to calibrate what they were actually seeing.

Cole watched the planet resolve from his seat, which had a window if you considered a reinforced polymer panel with limited viewing angles a window. Spiral-trunked trees dominated the landscape, their bark twisted like helical stairs climbing to canopy heights that made Earth timber seem practical. The light came through at an angle that suggested either early morning or some orbital geometry that wasn't standard, and the sky wasn't quite blue. Shifted toward green. Lavender-gray soil showed through gaps in vegetation—not barren, just different, the color of something that had been dead once and stayed that way.

Beautiful. That was the thought most of the forty-seven were having, Cole could hear it in the soft sounds they made—not gasps exactly, more like the audible equivalent of holding still. Beauty was a reasonable response to seeing a world for the first time. Cole understood beauty. He could calculate the wavelengths. But he'd trained himself not to *feel* it as a category of data that mattered. Beauty made you make different decisions. Beauty made you take risks.

He'd already calculated enough risks.

"Descent protocol," the pilot announced, her voice crackling through the shuttle's speakers. "Ground contact in approximately four minutes. Secondary teams, confirm your equipment manifest."

Ren Tsai, who'd been sitting three rows behind Cole, was already moving—engineer's efficiency, not tourist curiosity. She was checking seals, verifying that the environmental equipment cases had survived transit intact. Haruki, the doctor, was walking the narrow aisle checking on colonists, making sure nobody was about to vomit or panic or do something that would make the landing harder. The contractor—Polk—was looking at the trees with an expression Cole couldn't quite read. Not afraid. Not happy. Something in between. Maybe it was relief. Maybe it was the look of a man realizing he'd traveled as far as you could travel and the things that broke him had all stayed on Earth.

The shuttle touched down at 0847 hours, local time. The notification came through Cole's tablet: *Parcel 16b Settlement Zone. Atmospheric pressure nominal. Radiation levels acceptable. Welcome.*

Welcome. As if the planet cared.

The descent ramp lowered, and the air that came up into the shuttle was wrong in three ways simultaneously. First, there was the ozone smell—sharp, electric, the kind of smell you got from high-altitude storms. Second, something sweet underneath it, something organic, rotting, alive all at once. Third, nothing. No sound. No birds, no insects, no ambient fauna noise. Just the hum of the shuttle's idle systems and forty-seven people breathing in unison.

Cole was the fifth one down the ramp.

The soil under his boots was springy—higher moisture content than the surveys suggested, or the vegetation had worked out a water table management system that kept things damp near the surface. The air was warmer than he'd expected, which was interesting because the thermal data had been pretty clear about day-night oscillation. This was either early in the warming cycle or the measurements had been taken at a different time of year and the planet's orbital dynamics created seasonal variance the viability index hadn't mentioned.

None of that was his immediate problem.

His immediate problem was the equipment manifest, which was being offloaded by a series of industrial loaders that had their own power sources and protocols and had all been checked by people in Asterlyne facilities who'd never been to Parcel 16b and would never face the consequences of their calculations being wrong. The manifest showed: four pre-fab shelters, rated for thirty occupants at minimum spacing standards. Forty-seven minus thirty equaled a problem that had been solved by putting bunk beds closer together and hoping the structural engineers had built in safety margins they wouldn't tell you about.

Cole inventoried as the loaders set boxes down:

Medical supply cache—comprehensive list on the side panel, he skimmed it while pretending to do something else. Standard Earth medicines. Standard Earth diagnostic equipment. Quantities calculated for a baseline population of approximately twenty, contingency going to thirty. Forty-seven was not a number anyone at Asterlyne had planned for, or if they had, they'd decided the overage could be solved with mathematics that didn't include redundancy.

Agricultural supplies—seed stock in cryo-stasis, hydroponic nutrients, soil amendment compounds. Everything designed to jumpstart food production in alien soil that behaved according to specifications derived from a single survey. Dana Wen, the botanist, was checking the seed cases against her own manifests, her face doing that thing where it stayed still while something underneath it worked very fast.

Shelter composite and assembly supplies—enough to build the four structures that were currently being arranged in a grid by Polk and a cluster of other colonists who'd decided that starting work immediately was somehow less terrifying than standing still. The composite was a polymer-ceramic blend, rated for temperature oscillation within certain parameters. The parameters had a range. The night temperature data suggested they might breach that range.

Water extraction system—mechanical filters, UV treatment, mineral analysis equipment. The system was designed to process maybe 200 liters per day reliably. Cole had done the mathematics: forty-seven people, basic sanitation protocol, was approximately 100 liters daily. Comfortable margins. But that was assuming a consumption model where people showered on schedule instead of hoarding water, assuming the planet's hydrology was stable, assuming the filters worked the way they were supposed to work on water that had never been sampled in the field.

Assumptions were dangerous.

Ren materialized next to him while he was photographing the equipment layout with his tablet, building his own digital manifest against the official one. She was doing the same thing, Cole could see the photograph-and-verify rhythm.

"Medical allocation is short," she said quietly. Not a question, not a panic. Just a statement of mathematical fact. "About thirty percent of full redundancy."

"By design," Cole said. "Asterlyne was betting on low population stability. Figure if enough of us don't survive the first year, the remaining group becomes manageable within their supply calculations."

Ren was quiet for a moment. She was looking at the horizon, at the forest edge about a kilometer out, at the trees that hummed—not audibly yet, but Cole could feel something in the frequency range that made the back of his neck tense. A vibration. A suggestion of sound that wasn't quite sound.

"They knew," Ren said. "When they sent us out here with insufficient resources, they knew."

Cole had already factored this into his model. "The charter is structured to make us expendable. Until we hit the threshold. After that, we become valuable."

"So we survive not because they want us to, but because they suddenly lose something if we don't."

"Yes."

Ren looked at him. "That's a horrible system."

"It is," Cole agreed. "But it's a system. Systems are predictable. I'll take predictable horror over random chance."

The settlement assembly took most of the daylight hours. By 1600 hours, all four shelters were standing—not livable yet, still needing interior partitioning and equipment hookup, but standing. The colonists had fallen into work patterns naturally: the academics organizing a rough commons area, Polk and three others securing the perimeter with what the viability report called a "deterrent fence" and what Cole recognized as a gesture at safety that wouldn't stop anything actually determined to come through. Haruki was establishing the medical shelter setup. Dana was already into the soil, taking samples, running them through the portable analysis equipment.

Cole was finishing a grid map on his tablet, logging every resource location, every distance calculation, every vector for failure he could preempt with foresight.

The sun—wasn't quite a sun, not in the Earth sense, the light quality was wrong somehow, too green, too sharp at the edges—dropped toward the horizon sometime around 1830 hours. The temperature dropped with it, not gradually but in what felt like discrete steps. Cole checked his tablet. Readings dropping from 24 degrees Celsius at 1810 to 18 by 1830 to 11 by 1850. The rate of temperature loss was significantly steeper than the survey had projected. The survey had shown a gradual evening decline over approximately three hours. This was compression. Acute cooling.

Polk noticed it at the same time Cole did. He looked up from securing a section of perimeter fencing and registered the change, and Cole watched his face do the math in real time—contract promised certain conditions, reality was delivering different ones, those weren't bugs, they were features, and features couldn't be returned.

"Inside," Ren called out, already moving the stragglers toward the assembled shelters. "Everyone move inside the structures. Now."

The tone was different from the Earth tone, the one that had asked good questions during the briefing. This was the tone of someone who'd spent three months reading data and had just watched the data prove incomplete. This was the tone of someone whose job had just become impossible.

Forty-seven colonists filed into four shelters that had been rated for thirty.

The interior of Cole's assigned shelter—one of the four, himself in a bunk room with seven others—was a study in efficient space-wasting. The bunks were stacked in what was technically three-high but felt more like a very elaborate coffin installation. Minimal floor space. Communal sanitation in a corner that was going to create problems once more than two people decided to use it simultaneously. The shelter's environmental system—basic climate control tied to the main power grid—hummed at a frequency that suggested it was working hard at a task it hadn't been designed for.

Night temperature dropped to 3 degrees Celsius by 2200 hours.

Cole lay on his bunk, in a sleeping configuration that was designed for people whose bodies were smaller than human bodies, and listened to the shelter groan. The structure was expanding and contracting as the temperature shifted. The composite was doing exactly what composite does when you ask it to hold rigidity through thermal stress: it was complaining. Not cracking. Not yet. But the sound was the sound of something being asked to do a job within specification while knowing it didn't actually have the margin.

He could hear the other six bunkmates breathing. Someone three bunks over was crying quietly—not a full breakdown, just the kind of soft sounds someone makes when they're trying to process that they've made a mistake and can't unmake it. Someone else was reading something on a tablet, the light bleeding through the darkness—probably the charter, probably looking for a clause they'd missed, a loophole that would suddenly make this sensible.

Cole didn't sleep. He lay in the dark and listened to the shelter and listened to the planet.

Around 0200 hours, the hum changed.

Not louder. Deeper. The vibration that had been in his neck all day was now in his chest, a kind of resonance that felt like it was coming from the ground. Cole pulled up his tablet and checked the seismic sensors he'd configured in the equipment deployment logs. Nothing. No seismic activity. This wasn't the ground moving.

This was something else.

He got out of his bunk—which took an awkward maneuver, bunks were not designed for dignified exits—and moved to the shelter's single observation port. The view was limited to maybe fifty degrees, but it was enough to see the forest edge.

The trees. The spiral-trunked things that had been beautiful in the descent viewport were different at night. They were still visible—there was a faint bioluminescence, something in the bark that glowed a very pale green—and the hum was coming from them. Not an orchestrated hum, not a unified sound. Individual trees, vibrating at slightly different frequencies, creating an interference pattern that wasn't sound so much as the suggestion of sound, the ghost of music that you felt rather than heard.

And something was moving in the undergrowth.

Not approaching. Cole watched carefully. Whatever it was, it wasn't advancing on the settlement. It was there, in the trees, in the shadows that the bioluminescent glow carved out, and it was *looking*.

Cole had spent three months building a spreadsheet of survival probabilities. Had calculated medical failures and resource depletion and interpersonal conflict cascades. Had modeled every variable the transit data offered.

The viability report said nothing about fauna. Not a word. The planet was supposed to be a soil chemistry problem, a weather problem, a supply chain problem. Nobody had mentioned the possibility that something would be out there in the dark, looking back.

He'd calculated everything except what it felt like to be seen by something that had evolved on a world that had never demanded humans exist on it.

The creature—and he was certain it was a creature, singular, patient, interested—watched from the forest. Cole watched back. Neither of them moved. The hours passed like that, both of them aware of each other's presence through the dark, through the humming trees, through a silence that had nothing to do with either of them.

By 0600 hours, it was gone. The forest was still there, still humming, still glowing faintly in the pre-dawn dark. But the sense of being watched released like a held breath.

Cole went back to his bunk. Lay down. The shelter groaned as the temperature began its slow climb back toward morning, and around him the other colonists stirred in the half-dark, shifting against bunks that hadn't been designed for sleep so much as containment.

He could hear them through the thin walls. Through the partitions. Forty-seven people breathing in a settlement that had been on this planet less than a day and was already learning what the planet thought of

it.

Forty-seven.

He needed twenty-four.

The planet had been here for millions of years, cycling through seasons that nothing from Earth was designed for. They'd been here less than a day. Long enough to learn that the air was wrong, the data was incomplete, the shelters were insufficient, and something in the forest was watching.

Cole closed his eyes and did the only thing he knew how to do.

He counted.

Chapter 04 — "The Rules"

By day four, the colony had stopped thinking of the planet as an antagonist and started thinking of it as a puzzle. By day seven, the distinction didn't matter anymore. Both puzzles and antagonists could kill you if you didn't pay attention.

Cole spent the first week building systems. It was what he knew — logistics, flow, allocation, redundancy. Warehouse management on an alien world. The same principles applied: figure out what you have, figure out what you'd burn through, calculate how long before the gap between supply and need started killing people.

Water collection came first. The diurnal temperature shifts were steeper than the survey data had suggested — Ren had measured a twenty-degree Celsius swing in twelve hours, double what the viability index predicted. Cole built a schedule around it: collection during the stable morning window, containers sealed by mid-afternoon when atmospheric particles became more active in the cooling hours. Two people per station. Four-hour rotations. Clear protocols for filter type, storage method, contamination prevention.

Food rationing came second. The seed stock had gone into the lavender soil on day two, and by day five, the results were wrong in a way that didn't have an obvious explanation. Some rows took root and sprouted. Others, planted in identical soil ten meters apart, didn't germinate at all. A third set germinated, grew for two days, then wilted overnight like someone had switched them off. Dana Wen was spending twelve hours a day in the agricultural section, running the same tests on the same soil and getting different results every time. She hadn't explained the inconsistency yet, but the intensity of her focus said she was closing in. Until she did, Cole set three rationing tiers: full allocation for physical labor crews, reduced for technical and administrative, baseline for everyone else. Nobody liked the tiers. That was fine. Liking wasn't the point.

Shelter maintenance rotation came third. The pre-fab composite was warping under the UV cycle — Ren showed him the measurements, the thermal stress patterns that exceeded the rated delta every night. Cosmetic damage so far, but structural failure was trending toward month two. She'd drawn up a reinforcement plan that required redirecting labor from agricultural setup, which meant food production would slide, which meant rationing would tighten ahead of schedule. Everything connected. Pull one thread and three others moved.

Perimeter protocols came last, because Cole hadn't figured out what they were protecting against yet. The fauna in the tree line hadn't approached since the first night. The spore activity Haruki had flagged was nighttime-specific. The instability in the soil chemistry was slow, not acute. So Cole set basic rules: nobody beyond the markers after dark, buddy system for scouting parties, mandatory check-ins every four hours.

Systems. Structure. The mathematics of not dying.

The colonists hated it.

Not all of them. Some understood — the ones with technical backgrounds, the ones who'd read enough of the charter to grasp that Parcel 16b wasn't a homestead, it was a five-year survival problem with a contractual threshold. Ren didn't love the hierarchy but she respected the engineering logic. Haruki followed the protocols without comment, which was its own endorsement.

But at least a dozen of them hadn't come here for a shift schedule. They'd come for freedom — for the promise buried in Asterlyne's recruitment materials, the one that whispered: *Leave the systems behind. Start over. Be something other than what the old world made you.* And here was Cole Maren, two weeks on an alien world, already building the same architecture they'd crossed the void to escape.

Garrett Polk led the resistance. Not formally — Polk didn't organize. He just refused, and other people watched him refuse, and refusing became something you could do.

Cole found him at the eastern water station on day five, filling containers without the pre-filter. When Cole pointed it out, Polk didn't argue immediately. He just looked at Cole with something that went past disagreement into a place Cole recognized.

"The filters are slowing us down," Polk said.

"The filters are preventing us from drinking contaminated water."

"We don't *know* that." Polk set a full container down with the controlled force of a man managing his own hands. "We just think it is. Based on the survey. Same survey that said the shelters would handle the cold. Same survey that said the UV wasn't a problem. Everything they promised us was wrong, but we're still following *their* rules?"

"These are my rules," Cole said.

"That's supposed to make me feel better?"

Cole understood what he was hearing. Polk had built something on Earth — a business, a system, something that should have worked. The numbers had been right and the outcome had been wrong, and Polk had lost everything while following rules someone else wrote. Now Cole was standing in front of him with another set of rules, another set of numbers, another architecture that looked rational and promised survival. Polk wasn't seeing a water protocol. He was seeing a trap dressed up as salvation. The same trap, different planet.

When Cole explained the math behind rationing — the caloric intake calculations, the projected agricultural timeline, the consumption models that kept everyone breathing to the five-year mark — Polk listened. Heard every number. And the logic reinforced everything he already believed: that math was the language people in charge used against people like him. Not because the math was wrong. Because the math was right, and it didn't matter.

"I'm not staying here long enough for contaminated water to matter," Polk said. His voice had gone flat — not angry anymore, just settled into the conviction that the game was rigged either way. "Hoping Earth sends rescue by Year Two. Until then, I'm making this livable, not perfect."

Cole documented the deviation and moved on. But he'd seen it now. The math didn't persuade Polk. The math was the problem.

Cole was still modeling contingencies when Suri Park ate the fruit.

She was one of the ones he'd filed as useful-dangerous. Late twenties, compact, curious. The kind of person who asked questions rapidly and then acted on the answers before fully thinking them through. Useful in exploration. Dangerous in an environment where exploration was still a luxury.

Day thirteen. She'd walked the southern perimeter, mapping the immediate flora, checking what looked edible against the preliminary agricultural database. Found berries clustered on something between a shrub and a low tree. The database showed them safe. Nutrient profile good. No known toxins.

The database had been built from a single survey conducted during a single visit.

Suri ate one.

The reaction came forty minutes later. She was back at the settlement, documenting her finds, when her hands started to shake. Not from cold, not from fear — from something her nervous system was registering as a profound threat. Pupils dilated. Breathing accelerated. Within an hour, she was seizing — full tonic-clonic, her body rejecting a compound that the database said didn't exist, her immune system fighting something Earth medicine had never catalogued.

Haruki got her to the medical shelter. On her side to prevent aspiration. Muscle relaxant from the pharmaceutical stock — shouldn't have worked on an alien compound, but it slowed the seizure enough to keep her from breaking bones. He watched her through the worst of it with the steady hands of a man who had done this before and would do it again.

By day fourteen, Suri had stopped seizing.

Cole sat with Haruki while they waited for her to wake.

"She followed protocol," Cole said.

"She did." Haruki had his hands folded, still. "The database said those berries were safe. It said that based on readings taken during the survey window. Today is not the survey window."

"So the chemistry changed."

"The chemistry is always changing. On Earth we call it seasonal variation — compound expression shifts with temperature, light exposure, soil chemistry. A plant that's safe in June can be toxic in November." Haruki looked at Suri's sleeping form. "The difference is that on Earth, we've had ten thousand years to learn the calendar. Here, we don't even know the length of a season."

Cole sat with that.

The viability data wasn't wrong. It was incomplete. A single survey had captured a single moment, and they'd been navigating by it as if the planet would hold still. But the planet wasn't holding still. The soil chemistry Dana was tracking, the temperature swings Ren was measuring, the compound variations that had nearly killed Suri — all of it was moving, cycling, shifting on a schedule nobody had mapped.

They'd been reading a still photograph and calling it a map.

He went to find Dana. She was in the agricultural section, three soil samples lined up with a fourth added since morning. Same soil. Different readings.

"It's not random," she said without looking up. "There's a pattern. I don't know what's driving it yet, but the shifts aren't noise. They're signal."

"The berries Suri ate."

"Compound concentrations have shifted since the survey. Enough to cross from safe to toxic."

"How long until you can predict the shifts?"

She looked at him. Her expression was the careful blankness of someone running calculations she wasn't ready to share. "I need more data points. Weeks, maybe. If the pattern holds."

"And if it doesn't."

Dana went back to her samples.

Cole called the settlement together that evening. Not a formal assembly — people gathered by the common area between shelters where they'd been eating meals. He told them about Suri. Told them the database was unreliable. Told them the new protocol: nothing native consumed without explicit clearance from both Dana and Haruki. Everything filtered. Everything tested. Everything assumed dangerous until proven otherwise.

Polk spoke first. "So the rules change again."

"The planet changed the rules," Cole said. "I'm keeping up."

"You're good at rules, Maren. Bet you were good at them back home too."

Cole let it land. Polk wasn't entirely wrong. Cole did think in systems. He did impose structure. He did believe the mathematics of organization was the margin between survival and entropy. What Polk missed was the assumption that Cole enjoyed it.

Ren stood. Not confrontational. Just clear.

"The survey was supposed to answer these questions," she said.

"It did," Cole said. "For a specific moment in time."

"Then we need to build our own answers."

That was the cleanest thing anyone had said since landing. Cole let it settle over the group — the idea that they weren't inheritors of someone else's data anymore. They were the survey now. Whatever they learned, they'd learn by living through it.

The gathering broke apart. People went back to shelters, to tasks, to the quiet work of processing that the planet they'd signed up for was not the planet they were on.

Cole stood at the perimeter as the temperature began its drop. The forest hummed. The soil under his boots was springy, responsive — alive in ways he couldn't see and was only beginning to measure.

The planet had rules.

They just hadn't finished learning them yet.

Chapter 05 — "Three"

The first body was found at dawn.

Cole heard about it before he saw it. Haruki moved through the settlement with a particular efficiency that meant something had already failed beyond his help. They found the colonist — a man named Lev, late thirties, civil engineer from Lagos — about two hundred meters beyond the perimeter markers, in a clearing where the undergrowth thinned and the humming trees opened to actual sky.

Lev had walked out alone at dusk the day before. The buddy system was in place. The four-hour check-ins were in place. Lev had signed out of neither — just left his workstation warm and walked past the markers as if the rules Cole had spent a week building were suggestions he'd decided not to take. Ren found the gap during evening equipment count, ran the name against the check-in log, came up empty. They'd searched until dark, then stopped. Going into the forest after dark had become instinct-level stupid by now. The spore data Haruki had flagged. The temperature swings Ren had measured. Suri Park seizing on day thirteen. Everyone knew the rules about dark.

The rules existed. Lev had decided they didn't apply to him. Or he'd needed to walk badly enough that it didn't matter.

Cole arrived at the clearing while Haruki was still examining the body. No visible trauma — no wound, no animal sign, nothing a layperson would point to and call a cause. Just a man lying in a field who'd stopped breathing. The smell was already present — not rot, something else. Sweet and wrong, like overripe fruit left in closed air. Haruki looked up from Lev's face and Cole did the quick math of exposure. Eight to ten hours minimum.

"Spore response," Haruki said. His hands were gloved. Everything about his posture said this was not a surprise, which meant it was bad in a specific way. "Allergic cascade. Throat closure, pulmonary edema. The lower temperature at night activates the spore germination. I've seen similar compounds in the soil samples Dana was analyzing."

Cole knelt. Not to touch — Haruki would have objected — but to observe. Lev's lips had a blue tint. His hands were clawed, fingers rigid. There was dried crust in his airway. The man had suffocated, fighting for air the planet wouldn't let him take.

He thought about the transit interviews — Haruki's daily intake sessions, the blood panels, the allergy profiles. Lev had been screened. They'd all been screened. But the thing that killed him didn't have a name in any Earth database. The planet had made something new. A vulnerability no human body had ever encountered, triggered by a temperature shift no human schedule had accounted for.

"He didn't follow the check-in protocol," Cole said.

"No."

"Would it have mattered?"

Haruki was quiet for a moment. "If he'd gone out with a partner, the partner would have noticed the respiratory distress. Gotten him back inside the perimeter before full cascade. Maybe." He looked at the body. "But the spores were in the clearing. Once he was exposed, the timeline was short."

Cole stood. The math was already recalculating behind his eyes, but he didn't let it move his face. Forty-six. The new baseline. Not forty-seven minus one — you couldn't count backward. You had to move forward from the number that remained.

The protocols had failed their first real test. Not because they were wrong — because they assumed compliance. Cole had built a system for people who followed systems, and the first man who didn't was dead.

"We need perimeter fence," Cole said. "Real fence. Not markers."

It took four hours. Not the delicate marking he'd set up during the first week — actual barrier. They used pre-fab shelter paneling torn loose, lashed to the trees with the most stable root systems. It looked desperate and temporary and like an admission that they weren't safe in the place they'd landed. Cole worked alongside everyone else. It was easier to maintain authority if people saw you sweat.

Forty-six.

The second death came three days later.

Storm system moved in faster than the weather models predicted. Not a hurricane — the planet's atmosphere didn't seem to generate those kinds of systems — but sustained wind that came down like a hand pressing everything flat. One of the pre-fab shelters, the one they'd repurposed as equipment storage, had a structural joint that failed under sustained lateral pressure. The beam didn't drop cleanly. It twisted, caught on the shelter frame, held for a moment like it was deciding, then came down across a colonist who'd been inside retrieving supplies.

Her name was Priya. She'd been an accountant. Cole had liked her because she understood margin — the way numbers compressed when you pushed them too far. She understood the cost of precision.

They recovered her body after the wind died. Haruki said she'd died instantly. Cole wasn't sure if that was true or if Haruki was being kind. He didn't ask for clarification.

The shelter was salvageable. The joint was a design flaw in the pre-fab specifications — load-bearing connection rated for wind speeds fifteen percent below what Parcel 16b actually generated. Cole had caught it during the equipment inventory. He'd calculated that losing ten percent of shelter capacity was statistically acceptable against the labor cost of reinforcing every joint in a shelter designed and manufactured to fail at exactly this pressure. He'd made the choice. Priya had paid for it.

Forty-five.

The third death was the simplest, and that was almost worse.

A colonist named Vogel — mid-twenties, geologist, the kind of person who saw rock formations the way Dana saw soil chemistry — had been scouting a ridge system to the east during clear morning hours. Not explicitly against protocol. He'd signed out properly, taken a partner who waited at the base while Vogel climbed to get a better angle on the underlying geology. Initiative. The kind of thinking that would matter in month six or month twelve, if they got there.

Vogel slipped. Nothing exotic. The stone was more fractured than his geological eye had read from a distance. His foot went through a crack that looked solid. He tried to catch himself on a rock edge that crumbled. He fell maybe fifteen feet into a ravine that opened up sideways.

His partner heard the impact. Called for help. By the time the search party arrived, Vogel was dead. Broken neck. Not the planet's biology. Not spores or shifting soil chemistry or alien compounds the medical kit couldn't treat. Gravity. Bad footing. A ridge that looked stable to a trained geologist and wasn't.

Simple. Stupid. Human.

Haruki examined the body with the same care he'd brought to Lev's, which was a kind of respect that didn't require words. Cole watched from outside the perimeter of Haruki's work. Haruki's job was to witness death. Cole's job was to count it.

Forty-four.

Three dead in one month. One from the planet's hidden biology. One from equipment designed to fail. One from the kind of accident that happened on Earth every day — construction sites, hiking trails, anywhere gravity met bad luck. The planet didn't need to be exotic to kill them. It just needed them to be human.

Cole called the colony together at dusk on the day they burned Vogel's body. Not a memorial. Memorials took time they didn't have. He called it what it was — a logistics briefing. He stood in front of forty-three other humans and held the numbers in the air between them.

"Forty-four alive," he said. "Forty-seven landed. Three dead in four weeks. At this rate, we hit nineteen dead by month twelve. That leaves twenty-eight."

He let the number sit.

"The charter clause requires twenty-four original signatories alive at the five-year mark. That's the threshold. Below it, Asterlyne keeps the land. Above it, we own it. Right now, we're on a trajectory that dips below twenty-four before year three."

Someone shifted weight. Someone else breathed out like they'd been holding it.

"Every death from here is a number we can't recover. Every protocol violation, every unnecessary risk, every shortcut — it comes off a margin that's already thinner than it should be."

Ren Tsai stood up. Her face was sharp, engineer's problem-solving mode engaged.

"People aren't margin," she said.

Cole met her eyes. This was the conversation. This was always going to be the conversation.

"They are if you want them to be alive," he said.

The two statements hung in the air — both true, both incomplete, both impossible to reconcile. Ren didn't argue further. She sat down. Not because she'd lost, but because she'd said the thing that needed saying and Cole had said the thing that needed answering, and neither of them could close the gap between the two.

Around the settlement, the split happened in real time. Cole could see it in the faces, the posture, the way people looked at him after Ren sat down. Half of them nodded — the ones who understood that arithmetic was the only honest language left, that the numbers were the wall between them and the planet's indifference. They saw a leader. Someone willing to do the work nobody else wanted to do.

The other half looked at Ren. The ones who needed to believe that survival meant more than subtraction. That the colony was a community, not an equation. They looked at Cole and saw a machine — efficient, necessary, and something you wouldn't want to be left alone with in the dark.

Garrett Polk sat in the back and didn't nod at either of them. His face said he was running his own math, and it didn't match Cole's.

Joss Carver sat near the front, hunched forward, hands gripping his knees. He'd been prepared for this — the orientation videos, the field medicine research, the checklists he'd built during transit. He'd run the

scenarios. But his face said the scenarios hadn't included watching real numbers shrink while standing next to the people they represented.

Nobody spoke after Ren. That was the worst part — not disagreement, but the silence of people who understood the problem and couldn't see a solution that didn't require someone else to die.

The gathering broke apart. People moved back to shelters, to tasks, to the quiet private work of processing that they were forty-four and the margin was twenty, spread across fifty-five months.

In his shelter, Cole pulled the tablet where he kept his running calculations. The numbers were already updated, had been since each death. Three entries deleted. Three rows blanked. He stared at the spreadsheet until the names stopped being names and became positions — labor allocation, caloric draw, skill redundancy, loss impact.

Forty-four.

Twenty-four.

The math was simple. The math was always simple. The problem was that the math was people, and people did things like walk past perimeter markers at dusk because they needed air, or work inside shelters with faulty joints because the supplies were needed, or climb ridges because the geology mattered and the stone looked solid.

He put the tablet down. Lay in the dark. The hum of the trees came through the shelter walls — constant, indifferent, the sound of a planet that had been here for millions of years and would be here long after the last of the forty-four had been subtracted to zero.

Half the colony thought he was a leader. Half thought he was a machine.

Both were partially right. That was the part he couldn't calculate his way out of.

Chapter 06 — "Ghost Colony"

The scouting party found it by accident.

Ren had led a group west to map potential fresh water sources—the mineral content in their current reserves was shifting and Dana wanted a fallback location. They'd marked a rough grid, moved methodically through the forest, counted steps and measured declination. Standard surveying work. Cole wasn't with them. He was managing shelter reinforcement back at the settlement. He learned about the discovery from Joss Carver, who'd been trailing at the rear of the expedition and moved through the settlement looking like his skeleton wanted to escape his body.

"You need to see it," Joss said. No preamble. "Like, immediately. We're not telling anyone yet. Ren said wait for you."

The site was twelve kilometers west, deeper into the forest than Cole had approved for surveying runs. The first marker was a piece of pre-fab shelter paneling, half-absorbed by creeping vegetation. Then another. Then a small clearing where the spiral trees had been deliberately cut or had failed—hard to tell which—and the undergrowth had reclaimed the space with brutal efficiency.

Four shelter units, collapsed in various states of partial excavation by the planet. The aluminum frames were still visible, still Asterlyne's logo, but older. Previous generation. The manufacturing dates on the frame stampings read seven to eight years old. Parcel 16b had been attempted before.

Cole moved through the clearing without touching anything. Ren watched him process. Joss kept looking at the sky like he expected something to drop from it.

The equipment was mostly useless. Corroded harvest tools. Water collection systems rusted to their component minerals. A drone with its solar cells clouded beyond function. All of it was technically salvageable and all of it was worthless. The planet had spent seven years teaching these machines that staying here meant becoming part of the geology.

There was a shelter that hadn't fully collapsed. The door mechanism had seized, but the structure held. Cole worked the door open with a tool Ren handed him. Inside: dust and organized decay. Medical supplies in waterproof containers. Data tablets. A water filtration system that looked like it had been maintained until maintenance stopped mattering. Food storage units empty and lined with what looked like fungal residue.

And, in a sealed case bolted to the interior wall, a data core.

Cole opened it. The seal had held—environmental protocols working correctly even after seven years of submersion in a hostile atmosphere. The core was a standard Asterlyne model, encrypted and dated. Cole didn't try to access it on the spot. He just held it.

"This is a previous expedition," Ren said. Not a question.

"Fourteen colonists," Cole said. He was reading the manifests on the interior wall, printed on material that had survived the weather better than the metal had. "Came in on charter designation XR-Seven. Launch date seven years, four months ago."

"They failed," Joss said. Not a guess. Fact-finding.

"Completely," Cole said.

He pocketed the data core without asking permission. Ren didn't object. They marked the site's coordinates, made a note in the survey log—casual, like they'd found a previous water source they could revisit—and walked back to the settlement without talking.

That night, Cole sat in his shelter and accessed the core.

The file structure was organized the way a scientist organized data—chronological, labelled, methodical. Expedition logs. Daily resource inventories. Weather observations. Environmental sampling protocols. Crew manifests. The metadata told him what the manifests on the shelter wall hadn't: charter designation XR-Seven was a data extraction contract. No ownership clause. No 9.4.2. No threshold, no five-year mark, no path to keeping anything. Fourteen people sent to study a planet, report their findings, and wait for retrieval. The retrieval timeline was listed as "at corporate discretion upon completion of primary survey objectives."

Corporate discretion. Two words that turned a research mission into an open-ended sentence.

Elena Vasik was the expedition lead, and she wrote like a scientist—precise, minimal, focused on data that mattered. Her first-month entries had the controlled cadence of someone documenting conditions with the expectation that someone competent would eventually read them and act accordingly. Soil chemistry: fluctuating, unpredictable, tied to variables she hadn't yet isolated. Equipment sufficiency: below threshold for sustained habitation. Pre-fab shelters showing thermal stress within the first week. Medical supplies calculated for a smaller population—which, at fourteen, meant calculated for maybe eight. The same corporate arithmetic that assumed attrition would solve the supply problem.

Three deaths in the first month. Spore response, structural failure, a fall during scouting.

Cole stopped reading. Set the tablet down. Picked it up again.

Three deaths. The same three deaths. The same causes, the same order, the same planet running the same sequence on different people seven years apart. Lev, Priya, Vogel—he could see their faces overlaid on Elena's clinical entries like transparencies. She'd watched the same failures happen. Run the same postmortems. Documented the same useless lessons learned.

Eleven remaining in Elena's colony after Month One. Forty-four in Cole's. Different scales. Same trajectory.

He kept reading.

Elena's Month Two entries changed. Not dramatically—she was too disciplined for that—but the sentence length shortened. Questions appeared where observations had been. She'd started sleeping less, which she noted the way she noted soil pH: as a variable she was monitoring without intervention. The colony's social cohesion was fraying. Two of her people had wanted to signal for retrieval from the start, and the fact that retrieval required corporate discretion hadn't stopped them from arguing for it. Trust was becoming a consumable resource, and they were burning through it faster than food.

Two more deaths in Month Two. One from exposure during an overnight temperature drop the weather models hadn't predicted. One from a water contamination event—mineral content shifted between sampling and consumption. Nine remaining. Elena documented each death with the same clinical precision, but she'd started adding a single line after each entry that wasn't data. Just a name, repeated. As if saying it once in the official record wasn't enough.

Cole understood that impulse. He'd been counting names as numbers. Elena had been counting them as names. He wasn't sure which was worse.

The last entry in Elena's Month Two log was different from the others. Longer. The clinical voice cracked open, and underneath it was something that didn't belong in a research report:

"Asterlyne knows the second-year cycle. They chose not to tell us. I found it in the geological survey metadata, buried in an appendix no one was meant to read. The planet operates on multi-year orbital oscillation. The first year is survivable. The second year is hostile—fundamentally different atmospheric chemistry, accelerated biological activity, temperature extremes outside any parameter we were given. They

documented this. They had the data from orbital surveys conducted before our charter was written. They knew what Year Two would do to us, and they sent us with Year One supplies and Year One protocols and Year One expectations. The retrieval clause says 'at corporate discretion.' They are waiting for the planet to make the decision for them."

Cole closed the file.

He sat in the dark for a long time.

Then he pulled his own data package—the one Asterlyne had provided at charter signing. His own geological survey metadata. His own appendix. He scrolled through it, looking for what Elena had found. Climate modeling. Seasonal projections. Multi-year oscillation patterns. Twenty pages of dense data, and then—nothing. The appendix ended mid-section. The next page was formatted wrong, file-size misaligned with the table of contents. Cole checked the document properties. Seven pages removed. The section on second-year orbital dynamics had been redacted before he signed the charter.

Asterlyne hadn't sent them to an undocumented planet. They'd sent them to a documented planet and deleted the documentation. Known what Year Two would bring. Known the supplies were insufficient. Known the shelters would fail. Known the medical kit was designed for a population that would shrink by design.

The company had run the numbers before Cole ever signed his name.

The data core sat in Cole's shelter for the rest of the week. He didn't open it again.

Not because he'd finished. Elena's logs continued past Month Two—files labelled through months and seasons that stretched across what must have been years of entries before the collapsed shelters twelve kilometers west became the final record. The story didn't end at Month Two. The clearing told him how it ended.

But the middle was still unread. The part where Elena's colony went from nine to the silence of an abandoned clearing. The part that would tell him what the second-year cycle actually looked like from the inside, what it did to people, what it broke that couldn't be reinforced or rationed or calculated away.

He wasn't ready for that yet. He was rationing Elena the way he rationed everything else—taking only what he could use now, saving the rest for when the math demanded it.

He told no one what the logs contained. Not Ren, who'd been there and deserved to know. Not Haruki, who'd asked about the ghost colony twice since they'd returned and accepted Cole's deflection with the patience of a man who recognized strategic silence. Not the council. Not the colony.

He kept it because knowledge was weight, and he was the only one who'd volunteered to carry it. That was the logic. The cleaner logic underneath was simpler: if he told them about the second-year cycle, about the redacted appendix, about a corporation that had sent fourteen people to a planet it knew would kill them and then sent forty-seven more—he'd have to watch forty-three faces process what he'd already processed alone in the dark. He'd have to manage their fear on top of his own.

He began to study the geological appendix—the truncated version—the way Elena must have studied the complete one. Cross-referencing against Dana's soil sampling data. Looking for the pattern Elena had found in the metadata. The orbital oscillation. The cycle that would turn the planet from survivable to hostile.

Dana's data was already showing the edges of it. Mineral fluctuations that didn't track with local weather. Bacterial colony behavior that suggested a seasonal shift happening on a timescale longer than months. The evidence was there if you knew what to look for, and Cole knew now because a dead woman had written it down in a data core sealed against seven years of atmospheric decay.

Elena Vasik had found the pattern and couldn't survive it. Fourteen people, no ownership clause, no reason for Asterlyne to retrieve them, and a planet that operated on a timeline the company had understood and concealed.

Cole had a target. He had clause 9.4.2. He had Dana's soil mapping and Ren's engineering and Haruki's medicine and forty-four people who were still breathing.

Elena had none of that. And the clearing twelve kilometers west was what none of that looked like at the end.

The question was whether having better math and more people and a contractual endgame changed the fundamental equation. Whether knowing where you'd fail made it possible to fail differently. Or whether you just fell in a new direction, the same speed, hitting different ground at the bottom.

Forty-four alive.

The humming trees didn't answer. They just kept humming.

Chapter 07 — "Factions"

The colony was breaking, and Ren could feel it the way a structural engineer felt load shift in a foundation—not the crack itself, but the settling that came before.

By month three, people had stopped eating together.

It happened in stages. First the meal rotation shortened—people grabbing rations and returning to their shelters instead of sitting at the communal tables Cole had insisted on during week one. Then the small groups formed. Joss and the two youngest colonists maintaining the water filters on their own schedule, separate from the posted rotation. Dana working alone in the soil lab, ignoring the buddy protocol that existed because a man had died from airborne spores six weeks ago. Four colonists who'd bunked together on the transit ship sleeping and waking as a unit, organizing their labor around each other instead of around the settlement.

And Garrett Polk. Always Garrett Polk.

Ren was an engineer. She thought in load-bearing structures and stress distribution and the invisible mathematics of what held things together. She'd spent fifteen years on Earth designing systems that distributed force so no single point bore too much weight. The colony's social architecture was doing the opposite—concentrating stress at fracture lines and pretending the structure was sound.

She could see it. Cole couldn't. Or wouldn't. He saw the logistics: shelter reinforcement schedules, caloric intake projections, equipment maintenance rotations. All of it optimized. All of it correct. All of it useless if the people inside the system didn't trust the system anymore. Cole managed the colony the way he'd managed a warehouse—inputs, outputs, tolerances. He didn't see that the warehouse was full of people who'd come here because they were done being managed.

On day nineteen of month three, she found Marcus by the water collection array. He was adjusting a seal that didn't need adjusting, and he stopped when he saw her.

"It's fine," he said before she could ask. "Just checking."

"Dana confirmed flow rates this morning."

He straightened up—the small compensatory movement people made when they were caught, drawing themselves taller as if height could substitute for honesty.

"Garrett's worried about redundancy," Marcus said. "Thinks we should have backup systems. Independent ones. Things that don't need Cole's sign-off every time."

There it was. The framework. Cole equals control. Independent equals freedom.

Ren had heard variations of this from six people now. All of them approached it the same way—obliquely, as though they were discussing engineering philosophy instead of splitting the colony in half.

"Garrett's worried we're going to die following Cole's protocols," Ren said. "That the real issue?"

"Isn't it?" Marcus wasn't aggressive. Just tired. "Three dead in month one. Whatever systems Cole's running, they're not working."

"They're working as well as they can given what we have. Which is not great, but better than the last expedition managed."

"I haven't read anything that's going to convince me one person should decide everyone else's life expectancy," Marcus said. "Freedom's the whole point. We came here to get away from people making decisions for us."

"We came here because we had no other choice and Asterlyne had a planet," Ren said. "The freedom part was the pitch."

Marcus didn't respond. He resealed the collection array with the precision of someone who'd been told what to do and wasn't interested in the reasoning.

She found Polk at the northwest perimeter.

She'd known where to look because Marcus had been spending his shifts out here, and Marcus didn't go anywhere Polk hadn't already mapped. The clearing was sheltered by spiral trees, and in it sat the skeleton of a signal assembly—half-constructed on a wooden frame, jury-rigged from spare parts that should have been allocated to shelter reinforcement, copper wire meant for Dana's soil equipment, an antenna salvaged from the settlement's comm hub.

Polk saw her and didn't bother looking apologetic. That was the thing about Polk—he'd never learned false compliance. He stood there like a man building something unauthorized who intended to finish it.

"Before you start," he said. "This isn't sabotage. It's insurance."

"You're signaling Earth."

"Yes."

"Knowing that a signal voids the charter for everyone."

"If they even respond." Polk crossed his arms. "More likely they ignore it and we figure out another way off this rock."

"That's not how it works, Garrett. There are no passing ships out here. Asterlyne controls the relay. If a signal goes out, they have legal obligation to respond. And they'll respond with a retrieval crew and a bill for extraction that you'll personally owe for the next—"

"I'm aware of the math." He was looking at her directly, which was rare for Polk. Something in Ren's engineering stare made most people feel like she was calculating their structural integrity. Polk didn't flinch from it. "The math says stay here and die slow, hope your bones mean something in five years. Or call out, face the company, at least have a chance of getting off this planet alive."

"You never planned to stay five years."

It wasn't a question. She'd watched him on the transit ship. Watched him during orientation. Polk had signed the charter the way people sign things when the alternative is worse—not with intention but with momentum. He wanted off Earth. He didn't want this.

"I planned to not be dead," Polk said. "I planned to see my daughter again. I didn't plan for a planet that kills people with air and soil that can't decide what it is."

"Your daughter."

Polk's jaw tightened. Something behind his eyes shifted—not his expression, his calculation.

"Haven't seen her in three years," he said. "Couldn't afford to fight for custody after the creditors took everything. She's twelve now, probably. Twelve and she remembers me as the guy who couldn't pay. If I die

on this planet, she gets a ghost. If I get home—even indentured, even broke—at least I'm standing there. At least she sees me and knows I tried to come back."

Not ideology. Parenting.

Ren understood that calculus better than she wanted to. She'd left behind a partner on Earth—not a child, but someone she'd been building something with before the debt spiral hit and she took the charter because staying meant becoming someone's dependent. The reaching-for-freedom narrative never accounted for the fact that sometimes freedom was the wrong word for running away.

"Garrett. If you signal and they come and you pay the extraction debt, you'll have less capacity to fight for custody than you do now. You'll be indentured. Worth less to her, not more."

"Maybe. Or maybe I get home and we figure it out."

"We don't have bandwidth for maybe."

"You don't," Polk said. "I do. Because my daughter is the math. Your spreadsheets are just the pencil."

The argument was escalating and going nowhere. Ren could feel it—the same structural inevitability as a wall taking on more load than it could hold. Polk wasn't going to be reasoned out of this because reason wasn't the foundation. His daughter was. And you couldn't engineer around someone's kid.

She brought it to Cole that night.

He was in the main shelter reviewing equipment inventories by the rationed glow panels. Looked up when she entered, already reading her posture as bad news.

"Garrett's building a signal array," she said. "Northwest perimeter. He's going to try to call Earth."

Cole set down the tablet. "When?"

"Weeks. Four to six, depending on whether anyone actively helps him or just passively doesn't stop him."

He nodded. Not thinking. Calculating.

"If he signals, the contract voids. Asterlyne retrieves and extracts a penalty for early termination. Clause 14.3. Estimated cost: ninety-five thousand credits per colonist. At forty-four, that's four-point-two million. They won't bill the colony—they'll bill the signal initiator. Garrett personally. At standard compound rates, his granddaughter won't pay that off."

"He knows," Ren said. "He's decided his daughter is worth it."

"His daughter isn't here. Forty-four people are. His signal voids clause 9.4.2 for everyone. One man decides for all of us."

No heat in it. Just facts. Which made it worse—the cold certainty that his math took precedence over Garrett's love because numbers were reliable and love wasn't.

"You can't just tell people they're trapped," Ren said.

"I'm telling them they're free," Cole said. "They just have to survive it."

Ren heard the logic. She couldn't argue with it. The numbers were true. The clause was real. Signaling meant financial ruin, not rescue. Everything Cole said was correct.

She also heard what Cole couldn't hear in his own voice—that freedom defined by one man's arithmetic wasn't freedom. It was a different kind of contract. Survive on my terms or lose everything. Polk had heard

that exact math before, from creditors and courts and systems that told him the numbers were neutral while the numbers took his daughter away. Cole was running the same equation and calling it salvation.

"So what do we do?" she asked.

"I'll explain the financial consequences. Give him the numbers."

"He doesn't care about the numbers. That's not why he's building it."

"Then he shouldn't be building it. Whether he cares or not, the numbers are still true. His extraction bill will still be four-point-two million. His daughter will still inherit the debt—that's how generational obligation works. If he loves his daughter, he doesn't signal."

"You're going to tell a man who lost custody because he couldn't afford a lawyer that the math says he should stay trapped on another planet for his daughter's sake." Ren let that sit. "You're going to use his daughter as the reason he can't go home to his daughter."

Cole didn't flinch. "The math doesn't require him to like it."

"No. It just requires the rest of us to live with it."

Something passed between them. Not agreement. Recognition that they were standing on opposite sides of the same problem.

"What do you want me to do?" Cole asked.

"Something that isn't an equation. Something that acknowledges why he wants to signal without pretending it's unreasonable. Something that doesn't make him choose between his daughter and forty-four strangers."

"There is no option like that. Those are the actual variables."

"Then we need to change the variables. Give him a seat. A voice. Let him be part of the decisions instead of subject to them. He's not going to stop being afraid for his daughter. But maybe he stops building the array if he's not building it alone."

Cole looked at her with an expression she couldn't parse—something that might have been agreement or might have been the face of a man realizing the person across from him was solving a problem he hadn't known was the problem.

Cole talked to Garrett anyway. Gave him the numbers. Ren didn't hear the conversation, but she heard the result—Garrett refused, he was finishing the array, debt calculations didn't change his mind. Cole had offered Garrett the math and Garrett had heard exactly what he'd heard from every creditor and courtroom that had separated him from his daughter: someone with a spreadsheet telling him what his love was worth and finding it insufficient.

What changed his mind was the scaffolding.

Four days after Cole's visit, two colonists from the shelter reinforcement crew—a woman named Lin and a man named Thomas who'd been quiet since landing, the kind of person who showed up for shifts and ate alone—were reinforcing the western wall of the secondary storage shelter. The crew was short-handed. Three people assigned to the rotation had drifted into Polk's orbit and weren't showing up for communal work anymore. Cole had adjusted the schedule to compensate, spreading the remaining crew thinner across the same number of tasks.

Lin and Thomas were operating a scaffolding rig they'd improvised from pre-fab framing and cable. Standard procedure required three people—one to brace, one to lift, one to secure. They had two. Thomas

was bracing and lifting simultaneously, doing the work of exhaustion and obligation in equal measure. Lin was overhead, securing a panel that weighed more than the two-person spec allowed.

The cable slipped. Not dramatically—no snap, no explosion of violence. A slow, grinding give. The kind of failure that happened when tension exceeded tolerance by a fraction and the fraction was enough. The scaffolding shifted. Lin fell. Thomas tried to catch the rig and the torque pulled him off the platform.

Ren heard the sound from across the settlement—compressed, metal and wood and something softer underneath. She ran. By the time she got there, Haruki was already kneeling.

Lin died on impact. Thomas died that night. Haruki sat with him through it, doing what he could, which wasn't enough because the injuries were structural and there were no surgical facilities on Parcel 16b.

Forty-two.

The deaths weren't the planet. The deaths were a construction accident caused by a crew that was too small doing work that was too heavy because the colony had fractured and the fracture had a body count now. The split—the quiet redistribution of trust away from the center, people drifting into factions because they didn't believe in the system—that was the load shift Ren had felt at month three. Lin and Thomas were the crack.

She went to Polk. Not to Cole. To Polk.

He was at the array. Still building. He'd heard about Lin and Thomas. He didn't look defiant anymore. He looked like a man standing next to something he'd built while two people died somewhere he should have been.

"Two dead," Ren said. "Crew was short because your people weren't on rotation."

Polk didn't argue.

"I'm not blaming you. I'm telling you what the fracture costs. Not Cole's numbers. Bodies."

Polk looked at the half-assembled signal array—the copper wire, the salvaged antenna, the wooden frame he'd built with hands that knew construction the way Ren knew load-bearing walls. Hands that had built a co-op on Earth with the same conviction and watched it dissolve into debt.

"My daughter," he said. Quietly.

"I know. The council doesn't fix that. Nothing here fixes that." Ren kept her voice level. "But here's the offer. You dismantle the array. You get a seat on a colony council—elected, rotating, real authority over resource allocation and work assignments. Not Cole deciding alone. Not you deciding alone. A system that belongs to everyone who's still breathing."

"And the signal."

"Gone. Because you're right that one person shouldn't make decisions for forty-two people. Cole's right that the signal kills us all financially. Both things are true. The council is the only structure that holds both."

Polk was quiet for a long time. Ren watched his face—not calculating this time. Grieving. The apparatus he'd built out of wire and desperation and the ghost of his daughter's face, and it hadn't transmitted a single thing, and two people were dead, and the math still said he couldn't go home.

"If we survive long enough to invoke the clause," Ren said, "you own land. You own something that isn't debt. You become someone who built something instead of someone who owed something. Maybe that matters more to a twelve-year-old than a father who came home broke and indentured."

She didn't know if it was true. She said it because the alternative was watching the colony bleed out from a wound it was inflicting on itself.

Polk dismantled the array the next day. Didn't forgive Cole. Didn't trust the council. But he took the pieces apart with his own hands and returned the copper wire and the antenna components to the communal supply, and something shifted. Not unity. Not agreement. A framework for staying alive that wasn't built on one person's arithmetic.

It wasn't democracy. It wasn't dictatorship. It was the closest thing to governance that forty-two people on an alien planet could build out of grief and copper wire and the stubborn refusal to let the fracture kill them faster than the planet already was.

Forty-two alive. Fifty-four months left. The math was still brutal. But it was math they'd chosen together, and Ren wanted to believe that choice meant something, even if Cole couldn't quantify it.

Even if she couldn't quite make it mean enough.

Chapter 08 — "Roots"

Month five took two of them.

The first was a man named Osei. Respiratory infection. Not the spore cascade that killed Lev, but something quieter. A cough that started dry and deepened over four days until it sounded structural. Haruki treated it aggressively. Antibiotics, fluid intake, rest protocols. Osei improved on day three. Then he didn't. His lungs filled with fluid that shouldn't have been there. Something in the planet's atmospheric chemistry interacted with the infection in ways Haruki couldn't model because he didn't have a model for this biology.

Osei died on day seven. Haruki's hands were still when he came to report it.

Forty-one.

The second was exposure. A colonist named Farin on perimeter check during a temperature swing — one of the sudden drops Dana had been tracking but couldn't yet predict at this magnitude. Farin was dressed for the afternoon's warmth. By the time the two-hour check-in was missed and the search party went out, hypothermia had done its work. They found her two hundred meters past the eastern marker, sitting against a spiral tree like she'd decided to rest.

Forty.

Cole adjusted. He always adjusted. Updated the respiratory screening protocol for anyone working in spore-proximity zones. Required thermal gear for all perimeter shifts regardless of afternoon temperature. Tightened buddy-system enforcement. The protocols were sound. The kind of systems design that would have earned a commendation in his logistics career on Earth.

The protocols didn't bring anyone back.

Dana Wen was in the soil lab — a reinforced tent with a raised analysis table and equipment they'd salvaged or improvised from mining-grade supplies. Cole watched her from the entrance. She didn't know he was there. He'd learned to move through the settlement without announcing himself. Observation without intrusion.

She was covered in the lavender dust of Parcel 16b's soil. In her hair, under her fingernails, on the cuffs of her shirt where she'd wiped her hands all day. Methodical. Taking samples from marked collection points, running them through a centrifuge they'd powered by hand that morning, noting something on a paper tablet without looking up, then moving to the next station like she was the only person in the colony who understood what work actually was.

Cole had reviewed her progress reports. This month's read like the notes of someone assembling a map. Not random data points. A pattern.

"You've found something," he said.

Dana looked up. Didn't startle. She had good control of her nervous system.

"Readings from early settlement through now," she said. She set down the tablet and gestured to the analysis table. "I've been tracking mineral content, bacterial colonies, pH variance. Cross-referenced against the planetary rotation data from the original survey pack."

Cole moved closer. The tablet showed a graph — mineral concentrations plotted against time. Noise in the data, but underneath the noise was a rhythm. Clear as pulse.

"It's not random," Cole said.

"It's not random," Dana confirmed. "It follows the orbital position. When the planet's closest to the sun, these minerals are accessible. The bacterial colonies are more active. When we move out of alignment, everything shifts dormant. It's a cycle. Maybe seasonal variation based on thermal cycles we can't directly measure yet, maybe something more complex. But it's predictable."

She said this the way she said everything. No inflation. No self-congratulation. Data delivered like a work order. Part of why Cole believed her.

"I have six native species that track with the high-activity windows," Dana said. "We can plan what grows when. Stop losing crops to random soil shifts. First time we know what to plant and when to plant it."

Cole ran the math. Predictable growing windows meant extended rationing ceilings. More reliable yields. More margin. They were at forty. The trajectory had been shallow — barely holding, always at the edge. Dana's map changed it.

"How confident are you?"

"Sixty percent. Seventy if we get another two months of data. The pattern holds so far but the planet's still teaching us things. I'm not going to promise more than I can deliver."

"Show me."

She walked him through it. Ninety minutes. The bacterial analysis, the mineral mapping, the way she'd isolated variables by testing against samples from different points across the settlement's history. The work was elegant. Not because Dana was trying for elegance but because she was trying to solve a problem and precision was the byproduct.

By the end, Cole was running new projections. If the cycle held, they could adjust crop schedules. If they adjusted schedules, rationing could loosen. If rationing loosened, people ate better. Infection rates dropped. Strength levels rose. Work output increased. The math cascaded in the right direction for once.

"Present this to the council tonight," Cole said. "Full briefing. Let them ask questions."

"I'd rather you did. I'm a scientist, not a politician."

"I'll do the presentation. You sit at the front. Answer the technical questions. They need to see where the certainty lives."

That night, the colony ate a full meal for the first time since landing. Not rationed. Not stretched. Full portions. The council had authorized it — celebrating Dana's breakthrough, the opening of a timeline that didn't end in slow starvation.

People smiled. Cole watched it happen from the edge of the gathering. Joss Carver laughing at something Haruki said. Garrett Polk actually eating instead of performing nutrition. Ren making eye contact with people instead of studying the ground. The shared meal did something the council votes couldn't. It reminded them they were a group instead of a collection of individual survival calculations.

Cole ate. Didn't celebrate.

He was thinking about Elena Vasik.

He opened the data core that night. First time since month two, when Elena's entries had stopped at the boundary of what Cole could absorb. Nine survivors at the end of her second month. He'd closed the file and rationed the rest for later.

Later was now.

Elena's Month Three logs read like a mirror held at Cole's own settlement. Social fracture. Two of her nine had started operating independently — hoarding supplies, skipping communal meals, building a separate water cache. She documented the split the way she documented soil pH. As a variable she was monitoring without intervention. Her sentences were getting shorter.

Month Four. Another death. Medical complication from a wound that should have healed. Elena noted the cause, adjusted the rotation, added the name to a list growing in only one direction.

Month Five. Elena's colony found something in the soil. Not the full pattern — she was working without Dana's instrumentation — but the outline of it. The beginning of understanding that the planet operated on a cycle, that the chemistry wasn't random. Her entries picked up. Longer sentences. Questions driven by curiosity instead of desperation.

Month Six: "The soil follows the orbit. We can predict the growing windows. We can plant to the cycle instead of against it."

She'd found it. The same breakthrough Dana had presented to the council three hours ago. Seven years earlier. Fewer people.

Months Seven through Eleven: stabilization. Elena's colony found its footing. The survivors held. No deaths. Crop yields improved. The social fracture didn't heal, but it stopped widening. Elena's entries settled into something resembling routine. Weather observations. Soil data. Harvest projections. The controlled cadence of a scientist who believed the pattern would hold.

Her final Year One entry was five words.

"We're going to make it."

Cole closed the data core. Sat in his shelter. Felt the sentence settle against his chest like a stone placed carefully on a grave.

Elena had been right about the soil. Right about the cycle. Right about the growing windows. Every piece of data matched what Dana was finding now. The science was sound.

The clearing twelve kilometers west was what sound science looked like at the end.

He didn't open the Year Two files. Whatever lived in those entries — whatever turned five words of certainty into collapsed shelters and a sealed data core — he'd read it when the math demanded it. He was rationing Elena the way he rationed everything else. Taking what he could use. Saving the rest.

Three days after the full meal, Haruki appeared in Cole's doorway.

"We have a situation." Level voice. Which meant serious.

A colonist named Sarah. Construction crew. She'd reported to Haruki with a cut on her forearm — shelter repair work, minor. Cole had pulled her from the construction rotation the same day. Standard protocol. Light duty until Haruki cleared her. He'd redistributed her tasks across the remaining crew, adjusted the schedule. The system worked the way it was supposed to.

The wound had been cleaned, bandaged, treated with standard protocols. Bandage changed daily. Minor inflammation yesterday. Nothing alarming.

This morning the inflammation had progressed. Infection setting in fast. Haruki had escalated. Broad-spectrum antibiotics, wound cleaning, rest, fluids. The textbooks said this should respond within forty-eight hours.

"She's getting worse," Haruki said. "The antibiotics aren't touching it."

Cole went to the medical shelter. Sarah was on an examination bed, feverish and confused. Her arm swollen from the elbow down, the infection advancing — not localized the way human infections progressed but colonial. Something establishing an outpost and expanding.

"It's the planet," Haruki said. "The wound was clean. The pathology is — I don't have a framework for this."

The antibiotics were designed for Earth infections. This wasn't an Earth infection.

Sarah died on Day Four of the fever. Haruki was with her. Cole was in his shelter, adjusting the roster. Removing her from assignments, rotation schedules, the rationing tier. He'd memorized all the ways to make a person into a blank space in a system.

Thirty-nine.

He'd done everything right. Pulled her from rotation the hour she reported the injury. Adjusted the schedule. Haruki had treated the wound within minutes, followed every protocol, escalated at the first sign of resistance. Every input correct. Every response timely. Every optimization in place.

The planet's biology was just different. The variables underneath Cole's model were alive, evolving, indifferent to his calculations. He'd built a system for Earth and deployed it on a world that hadn't agreed to be optimized.

Sarah was the proof. Not that Cole had failed. That the math itself operated on assumptions the planet didn't share.

He thought about Elena's Year One ending. "We're going to make it." A woman who'd cracked the code, mapped the cycle, stabilized her colony. All of it correct. None of it enough.

Thirty-nine alive. Dana's map held. The soil cycle was real. The colony would eat.

The planet would keep teaching them rules one at a time. Usually by breaking something they thought was safe.

Chapter 09 — "The Count"

Six months. Cole stood in the settlement's makeshift administrative shelter—a reinforced pre-fab with a table that held the colony's maps, equipment manifests, work rotation schedules, and the running tally of who was alive and what they could do with their bodies and skills. He'd been coming here at dusk most days, reviewing the day's data, adjusting projections, doing the invisible work that made it seem like the settlement ran on something other than mathematics and fragile luck.

Thirty-nine.

He'd started with forty-seven. Eight gone in six months. Spores, structural failures, a scaffolding collapse during the faction split, exposure, infections the antibiotics couldn't reach. The specifics varied. The direction didn't. Eight subtracted from forty-seven left thirty-nine, and thirty-nine had held for three weeks.

But holding was the right word. The agricultural cycle was stable—Dana's breakthrough had loosened the rationing enough that people weren't eating at a permanent deficit. Water collection was running on schedule, the filtration system Ren had redesigned was holding, and the shelters had been patched enough to survive the UV warping that ate through the original composite. Fragile. Functional. Ren's council system was working—or not working, but functioning in the way that systems do when everyone involved has agreed to pretend the framework matters. Garrett Polk had been neutralized, which was a word Cole used in his head without examining it too closely. Polk had wanted to signal for rescue. Ren had offered him a place on the council—real input, real voice in the decisions that affected the colony. In exchange, Polk dismantled the signal array. Not because he'd changed his mind about the situation, but because the promise of agency was enough to make him believe he had options again.

It wasn't democracy. Cole knew that. Democracy required actual equality. What they had was informed consent to a hierarchy that wore the shape of shared decision-making. But the colonists had accepted it. Some because they believed in it. Some because the alternative was isolation. Most because the settlement had enough work to keep everyone distracted.

Cole closed the day's reports. The shelter was dimming as the sun moved toward the horizon. He had maybe twenty minutes of useful light left. Enough time to eat something or do something useful. He chose neither. He chose to sit at the table with a piece of paper and the knowledge that he owed a message to a daughter who didn't know she'd been abandoned on an alien world.

The message had to be simple. Cole understood that much. Lily was nine. Nine-year-olds had attention spans measured in paragraphs, not pages. He'd tried to write something the day after landing and stopped after the first sentence. Everything that came after felt like a lie or an admission, depending on how he tilted the words.

He started with the most honest thing he could think of:

Lily,

I'm on a planet very far away. The trees here are unlike anything on Earth. They have spiral trunks that twist as they grow, and they hum at a frequency you feel more than hear. At night, when the wind moves through them, the sound reminds me of—

He stopped. Reminds him of what? Her mother singing? A lullaby he'd stopped playing years ago? He scratched through the line.

The trees here hum. The sound is below human hearing, but you can feel it in your chest if you stand under them long enough. It's beautiful and strange and I think you'd want to draw it. You like drawing things that

don't exist on Earth. You draw horses with wings. You draw castles that float. This planet is full of things that would be impossible in your sketchbook, except they exist, so maybe the sketchbook was the universe's way of preparing you.

He stopped again. Too much. Too trying. Cole knew how to talk in his own head. Talking to Lily was different. She was real and distant at the same time. More real for the distance.

He started over.

Lily,

I'm on a planet very far away. The trees are beautiful. I wish you could see them.

That was true. That was the most useful truth he had. He folded the message and set it aside. Three sentences. It had taken him two hours to arrange them so they didn't sound like a man saying goodbye.

He didn't know when the message would reach Earth. The relay satellites had their own orbital mechanics. The ship that would eventually carry it back had its own schedule. Months, probably. Maybe longer. Lily would read it whenever it arrived. By then she'd be older. The trees would still be here. Cole might not be.

He pressed his thumb against his eye and held it there until he stopped thinking about any of that.

The forest changed after dark. The hum deepened—not louder but lower, finding frequencies Cole hadn't heard in six months on this planet. It pressed against his sternum like a hand. He stood outside his shelter and listened to something he couldn't name shift underneath the night.

Then the soil temperature alert Dana had rigged two months ago went off. Six degrees in one hour. Not the air. The ground.

Dana was at his shelter before the alert finished sounding. She'd been monitoring the overnight readings. Of course she had.

"Soil samples," she said. "Now."

They moved to the lab without talking. Dana went straight to the analysis equipment—no preamble, no exhaustion. Problem reduction. Data collection. The specific focus that Cole recognized as her truest mode.

The samples took thirty minutes. Cole stood at the edge of the lab and watched numbers populate her screen. Dana's patterns were still there—the predictable cycles she'd mapped—but underneath them was a new variable. Temperature shift. Mineral composition trending in a direction she hadn't tracked. Bacterial colonies that should have been dormant beginning to activate.

Dana's face when she turned from the screen. Cole had seen her process bad data before—conflicting numbers, ambiguous results. This wasn't that. This was recognition.

"It's starting," she said. "The second cycle."

The words hit something that was already waiting. Elena Vasik had written the same phrase in her Month Nine entry—Year One, the logs Cole had finished three days ago. *The second cycle.* Elena had named it. Had seen it arrive. What she did about it, how her colony responded, whether the second cycle was what finally killed them—that lived in the Year Two files. The ones he hadn't opened.

"How long?" he asked.

"Two to three weeks for the shift to complete. After that, we're in new territory."

Thirty-nine people. Systems built for conditions that were about to shift underneath them. Everything they'd constructed in six months tuned to a planet that had just changed its pitch.

"We need to go to the council," Dana said. "Tonight."

"I know." Cole's voice was flat. Not anger. Arithmetic. Six months of optimization undone by an orbital position.

"We tell them everything," Dana said. "The data. The timeline. No managing it."

Cole looked at her. Soil on her cuffs, under her nails, in the creases of her knuckles. She hadn't been entirely clean since Month Two.

"Council tonight," he said. "You present the data. I'll do the rest."

Dana gathered her samples. Cole stayed in the lab as the darkness outside became complete. The hum pressed through the shelter walls—the planet leaning against the structure, not hostile, not welcoming. Just turning the way planets do. Indifferent to what had been built on the surface.

Six months. Thirty-nine alive. Fifty-four months to go.

He walked back to his shelter. Elena Vasik's data core sat on the shelf where he'd left it after finishing Year One. The file that ended with five words: *We're going to make it.*

Year Two was the rest of the story. The part where certainty met the planet and lost.

Cole picked up the data core. Held it in the dark.

He opened the file.

Chapter 10 — "Second Cycle"

The shift happened overnight. Not literally—Cole had watched it coming for two days through Dana's soil samples, tracking the temperature curve and mineral fluctuation as the planet's orbital mechanics tipped toward the second cycle. But once it began, it moved fast enough to feel like overnight.

The vegetation died first. Not dramatically. Just stopped. The Earth crops that had been showing recovery under Dana's careful management—the wheat variants, the bean strains, the root vegetables they'd been nursing along—turned brown in their beds like someone had flipped a switch. Not disease. Not pest damage. Just the signal that their usefulness had ended and the planet was moving on.

Cole was checking the north agricultural plot on Day Seven of the shift when he first saw it with full clarity. The same plots that had fed the colony's optimism three days ago were now showing widespread dormancy. The lavender soil had darkened—more minerals, denser composition. The light from the planet's sun looked different too, shifted another degree toward green. It wasn't visible in the way weather changed on Earth. It was visible the way a mood change is visible if you're paying attention to a person's face: a small shift that meant everything underneath had reorganized.

Dana was there with him, pulling samples with mechanical precision, not commenting on what they both understood perfectly. The advantage the colony had thought they'd gained was evaporating.

"Three weeks," Dana said. She was reading her tablet, cross-referencing the new soil data against her cycle projections. "Maybe four. This matches the pattern from the data. The high-activity period is ending. The planet is entering dormancy phase."

"How dormant?" Cole asked.

"Complete," Dana said. "No Earth crops will survive the dormancy window. The soil composition becomes actively hostile to the microbiology they depend on. Some native flora might persist but it cycles down—becomes mostly inert. If your species aren't designed for the dormancy phase, the planet stops feeding them."

Cole did the arithmetic in his head. The colony was at thirty-nine. Dana's breakthrough had bought them confidence, but it had bought them seven weeks of actual extension. They'd built assumptions on top of that extension, increased consumption, prepared for expansion. All of that math was now being subtracted.

"Elena's logs?" Ren asked. She'd arrived while Cole and Dana were examining the plots, and Cole hadn't noticed her approach. She was learning to move quietly through the settlement the way Cole did, though her reasons were different. Cole was trying to observe without influencing. Ren was trying to listen without being asked to contribute.

"Month nine for Elena," Cole said. "She started serious starvation at this point. Her colony was smaller—she could stretch resources. We have more people and the same amount of dormancy."

He didn't need to finish the calculation. Ren was capable of running it herself.

Cole read Elena's Year Two entries that night. The administrative shelter with the door sealed and the hum pressing low through the walls.

Elena's Year Two opened at her Month 13. The clinical precision of her earlier entries was gone. Not replaced by desperation — not yet. By a kind of honesty that arrives when the thing you've been measuring starts measuring you back.

Month 13: Second cycle has deepened. All cultivated species dormant or toxic. Native edibles reduced to three viable candidates. Yield insufficient for nine. Rationing at levels that will produce cognitive decline within six weeks.

Nine people. Cole had thirty-nine. Four times the population, same soil, same orbital mechanics. Elena had found the cycle too. Her data had been real, her breakthrough sound. The planet didn't care about the data.

Month 14: Two members have resumed independent food caching. The colony's social contract is under revision — not formally, not through conversation, but through the slow withdrawal of shared assumption. People eat alone now.

Cole recognized it. The same thing he'd already started seeing in his own settlement — people carrying themselves differently, spending time in shelters instead of common areas, conversations getting shorter. Elena had watched it happen and recorded it with a scientist's precision. Recording wasn't preventing.

Month 15: A biological mat has appeared at the forest edge. Details in attached data. It advances slowly. We have time. I think we have time.

He marked the entry and stopped reading. The rest could wait. He was rationing Elena the way he rationed everything else — taking what he could use, saving the rest for when the math demanded it.

But the parallel was exact enough to sit in his chest. Elena's advantage had been scale — nine people could decide faster, consume less, relocate without councils or votes. Her disadvantage was the same: nine people had less labor, less redundancy, less capacity to absorb loss. One person stopping cooperation wasn't a percentage problem. It was an eleventh of everything.

Elena had the data. She had the pattern. She had everything Dana had given Cole, minus the people to make it work.

Cole had thirty-nine people and Dana's soil map and six months of agricultural data Elena never had. Those were his advantages. His disadvantage was thirty-nine mouths instead of nine, and a dormancy window that didn't care about headcount.

The watchers in the tree line became more active. Cole had noticed them before—shadows at the perimeter, movement in the canopy, the sense of being observed that was real, not paranoia. In the first cycle, they'd kept distance. Now they moved closer. Bolder. One morning, a creature that looked like it was built from cervid and praying mantis components walked through the outer perimeter and examined a supply crate before wandering back into the forest. It wasn't aggressive. It was curious.

"They're hungry too," Garrett Polk said at a council meeting. He was pointing at the perimeter watch logs, at the increasing frequency of fauna sightings. "The whole planet shifts cycles and everything that lives here needs to adjust. We're not special. We're just one more thing that needs feeding."

Cole didn't argue. Polk was right. The colony wasn't being hunted. They were just living in a system that was radically indifferent to whether they continued or stopped. The shift in fauna behavior wasn't targeting. It was adaptation. The planet was teaching every organism at once: the rules have changed. Adjust or die.

The soil rejected Earth crops entirely by Week Three of the dormancy phase. Dana had anticipated it—her maps were holding—but anticipation didn't change the fact of standing in the agricultural zone and watching months of careful cultivation become useless in a matter of days. The colony's food security, which had felt solid one month ago, suddenly looked like a calculation built on sand.

Cole issued the new rationing protocols. Reduced portion sizes. Adjusted work rotations to account for lower caloric intake. Shifted labor focus to identify and cultivate native species that Dana was mapping as dormancy-phase viable. The mathematics were clean. The implementation was brutal.

Hoarding started on Week Two of the rationing adjustment. Cole found it the way he'd found most problems—not through inspection but through observation. People moving differently, carrying weight differently, spending time in their shelters instead of the common areas. Cache sites discovered: a colonist maintaining a private food store under her shelter, another hoarding water containers in a locked compartment of the equipment shed.

He reported both to Ren.

"They're afraid," Ren said.

"Yes," Cole said.

"So they hoard. Makes sense. Fear does that."

"It breaks the colony," Cole said. "If food distribution becomes unpredictable, if people start hiding supplies instead of pooling resources, the morale failure cascades. We've accounted for voluntary compliance. If people start acting against the collective, the margin disappears."

"So what do you want to do?" Ren was watching him with an expression he was learning to read as something between exasperation and respect. She understood what he was trying to solve. She didn't agree with the solution he was reaching for. "Punish them? Make an example? Force compliance through fear of something worse than starvation?"

"I'm asking what you recommend," Cole said.

"Transparency," Ren said immediately. "Tell everyone exactly how much food exists. Tell them the timeline. Tell them the dormancy window is going to be hard and they need to understand the math so they can trust the system."

"That information is destabilizing," Cole said. "People hear 'critical shortage' and it triggers panic buying, not rational cooperation."

"People hear 'secret shortage' and they prepare for betrayal," Ren said. "At least if you're transparent, they can see the choice being made. They can participate instead of watching you calculate in private and guessing whether they're already dead."

Cole understood what she was actually saying. She was saying: stop treating the colony like a workforce you manage. Treat them like a group that gets to know what's happening.

He called for a full colony assembly. Didn't announce it formally—he had learned that the most effective way to gather people was to let them find out that the meeting was happening. Word spread fast in a settlement of thirty-nine.

He stood in front of them with the inventory data and the timeline projection and didn't soften any of it.

"We have seven weeks of rationed food if the dormancy phase holds as Dana's projections indicate," Cole said. "The dormancy window lasts approximately sixteen weeks. The gap is nine weeks. During those nine weeks, we'll need to have identified and cultivated enough native species to bridge the shortfall. Dana has narrowed it down to approximately thirty candidates that remain viable during dormancy. We'll test them for edibility and yield. Some will work. Some won't."

He showed them the rationing tiers. Showed them the work rotation that would be required to keep searching for alternate sources. Showed them the margin—what remained of it.

"We'll be hungry," Cole said. "Significantly. But the calculation shows we can survive the dormancy window if the colony acts as a unit instead of as individuals trying to protect themselves."

The silence after that announcement was profound. Not angry. Not defeated. Just the sound of thirty-nine people recalibrating their understanding of what they were attempting.

"Why tell us?" someone asked. Joss Carver, his nervous energy focused into genuine curiosity instead of anxiety. "I mean—I'm glad. I just mean, wouldn't it be easier to manage us if we didn't know?"

Cole thought about lying. It would have been simpler. A logistics problem solved through information control.

"Because you're not a system I manage," Cole said. "You're a colony I'm part of. The system works if we're deciding to stay in it together. If I'm running calculations on you instead of with you, the system fails." He paused. "There was a colony here before us. Fourteen people. Their leader had the same data we have. Same soil cycle, same projections. She wrote 'We're going to make it' at the end of her first year. By the second year, her people had stopped eating together. Then they stopped talking. Then there were six."

Ren was watching him with an expression that looked almost like surprise. Or maybe recognition. A small shift in how she was reading something about him.

The first three weeks of dormancy were the hardest. Rationing meant visible hunger. Visible hunger meant visible fraying. Conflicts over work assignments became sharper. Criticism of resource allocation became louder. The colony was hungry and afraid and aware that both conditions were deliberate mathematical choices made by the person standing in front of them.

Cole sat through it. Took the criticism. Adjusted where the calculations showed adjustment was needed, held firm where the math didn't allow flex.

Dana spent those three weeks essentially living in the forest. Out at dawn with Haruki's medical oversight, gathering samples, testing specimens for toxicity and nutrient density. Testing them on herself sometimes. Cole watched her do it once and didn't tell her to stop.

By the end of the third week, she'd identified three native species that would remain edible through the dormancy window and could be cultivated in sufficient quantity to bridge most of the shortfall.

She announced it at a colony gathering, standing next to Cole the way they'd done for the agricultural announcement in the last cycle. But this time, the tone was different. Not celebration. Survival.

"The first is a root-like structure in the spiral trees," Dana said. "High in starches and some proteins. Not palatable until processed. The second is a seeded fruit that ripens during dormancy—the timing is opposite to the Earth plants. The third is a fungal compound that my preliminary analysis shows can support bacterial colonies we use for fermentation and nutrition synthesis."

She was reading from notes. Her voice carried the specific exhaustion of twenty days in the forest and coming back with just enough.

"We'll need to shift agricultural focus immediately," Dana continued. "Stop trying to keep Earth crops viable. Concentrate on cultivating the dormancy species. The yield will be lower than the cycle-one projections, but it will be sufficient."

Cole watched the colony process that information. The hunger wouldn't end. But it wouldn't kill them either. There was a difference between those two facts, and Ren had been right to insist on transparency. The colony could see the path, see the work, see the weight. They could choose to walk it.

They wouldn't starve. They'd just be hungry for a long time. Cole could work with that.

Cole was reviewing the new agricultural rotation with Ren when he realized the planet had changed the color of the sky another degree. The green was thickening. The light was becoming something his eyes kept

trying to correct for, like looking through water that wasn't there.

"How many colonies do you think Asterlyne has sent here?" Ren asked.

"We know of one before us," Cole said. "Elena's. There were probably others. Probably failures they didn't document well enough to leave behind."

"Do you think anyone on Earth understands what this planet does?" Ren was sitting with her back against the wall of the equipment shelter, watching the agricultural zone where colonists were already beginning to transplant the dormancy species. "Like, actually understands? Or do they just look at profit margins and casualty projections and decide it's worth the cost?"

Cole thought about Asterlyne's data package, about the redacted appendix, about the viability score inflated by twelve points. About the charter designed to be unread and the clause that had only survived because no one expected anyone to live long enough to invoke it.

"They understand the math," Cole said. "They don't understand the people it kills."

Ren didn't answer. She was watching two colonists working the transplant rows in the shifted green light without complaint. People adjusting to new rules because someone had told them what the rules were.

"Your council held through this," Cole said.

"It's not mine," Ren said. "That's why it held."

Cole went back to the rotation schedules. The colony would eat less and work more and hold together because thirty-nine people had decided to hold together. Not because the math demanded it. Because Ren had been right: they'd chosen to see the weight, and they'd chosen to carry it.

The planet had turned a page. The colony was still reading.

Chapter 11 — "Creep"

Something was wrong at the forest edge.

Cole noticed it during dawn inventory on Month 8, Day 3 — a gray-brown smear in the lavender understory, twenty meters beyond the perimeter markers. A discoloration that hadn't been there the previous evening. The soil around the settlement had been shifting all month, temperatures dropping, drainage patterns changing, the whole planet recalibrating for its second pass through the orbital cycle. A new discoloration was one more variable in a system already too full of them. He logged it. Moved on.

By Month 8, Day 7, the smear had expanded to three meters.

By Day 10, it was a band ten meters wide and advancing at a rate Cole could measure against marker stones. Slow. Patient. A centimeter an hour, maybe less. He'd set Ren to charting it — time-marked photographs every four hours, distance measurements, soil samples from the leading edge. The thing moved like erosion, like time made visible.

It was Dana who named it. "The creep," she called it in the weekly resource meeting, and the word stuck because it was accurate. It crept. That was all it did — moved forward with no apparent urgency, breaking down everything organic in its path.

Haruki collected samples. Ran them past his makeshift field lab. Came back with observations: fungal network of some kind, but nothing matching Earth taxonomy. Mineralized base structure — active, flowing, consuming. It dissolved plant matter on contact, the way mold breaks down a corpse, except faster, more complete.

Cole recognized it before Dana said the word. Elena's Month 15 entry, the last one he'd read in her Year Two logs, the one that had sat in his chest for weeks: *"A biological mat has appeared at the forest edge."* He'd read that line and set the data core aside, rationing Elena the way he rationed everything else. Now the mat was here. Not in Elena's logs. On his perimeter.

He went back to the Year One entries he'd already read months ago. Month 9 landed differently now: *"The fungal bloom has accelerated since we began tracking it. Initial theory: seasonal response to orbital position. The structure maintains internal moisture and temperature regulation — it's not dying back. It's feeding."*

Month 11: *"We attempted containment with fire. The accelerant ignited, but the creep adapted — routed around the burn, moved deeper into the soil. The burned section appears to have accelerated its growth rate. Chemical barriers purchased from Asterlyne inventory: effective for 4-6 weeks. After that, adaptation. The thing learns."*

He opened Elena's Year Two files past where he'd stopped. Month 16: *"The creep has consumed the eastern shelter line. We're relocating again. Running out of room."*

Cole closed the data core and walked to the perimeter to watch it move.

It was beautiful in a way that made him uneasy. The texture was almost organic — a network of filaments so fine they looked like lace from a distance, except the lace was dissolving the soil beneath it, breaking down the biomass left by the second-cycle plant die-off. The color was gray-brown-lavender, shifting in the low light. It didn't move like a wave. It moved like breath. Expansion and rest, expansion and rest.

"It's not attacking," Dana said, coming up beside him. She had a specimen container in one hand, a measurement tape in the other. She'd spent three days collecting samples, running composition analysis on the compound structure. "It's decomposing."

"It's advancing on the settlement."

"It's doing what it's evolved to do. The second cycle brings dormancy, die-off, dead matter. The planet has a cleanup system." Dana crouched at the creep's edge, studying the gradient where the fungal network met unaffected soil. "If we were a forest, we'd welcome this. Nutrient cycling. Renewal."

"We're not a forest."

"No. But we're in one. There's a difference."

Cole understood the distinction intellectually. It didn't change the math. At current advancement rate, the creep would reach the perimeter shelters in seventy to eighty days. The core settlement — where the medical facility was, where the food stores were, where most of the colonists slept — was another two hundred meters inland. Call it eleven weeks. Call it the time until the second cycle deepened and nothing was predictable anymore.

He brought it to Ren.

"We need to relocate," she said. Not a question. A statement she'd already mapped the implications of.

"We need to understand it first. Elena tried containment. Fire didn't work. Chemicals bought them six weeks. After that—"

"After that, they abandoned the site and lost the agricultural work they'd already done. We don't have Elena's luxury. We're at thirty-nine. She started with fourteen."

Cole didn't correct her. She meant Elena was running the math differently — fewer people meant earlier desperation meant faster decisions. Ren's logic was sound. Elena's colony had mobility. The Free Colony was rooted.

Dana led them deeper into the research, setting up a makeshift lab in one of the cleared shelters. She collected samples from different points along the creep's boundary, analyzed the internal structure under magnification — a repurposed engineering microscope, never meant for biology — tracked the compound's response to various external stimuli. Ren helped. Joss Carver volunteered to assist, ferrying equipment, taking notes with the concentration of someone trying to prove his utility. Cole watched Dana work the way she always worked: hands steady, face neutral, the specimen container held like it mattered more than the thing consuming it. She'd handled Marcus Reeves's shelter samples the same day the body was found, pulling creep specimens from the wall breach while Haruki processed what was left inside. She hadn't hesitated. Cole filed that.

It took Dana two weeks to map the pattern.

The creep's composition shifted with depth. The surface layer was aggressive — breaking down plant matter at acceleration. The middle layers were transitional, the filaments more tightly woven. The deepest sections, several centimeters down, were crystalline. Mineralized. Dormant.

"It's storing," Dana said, showing Cole the cross-section. The compound was sealed in a transparent container, and under the magnification lens, the internal structure was almost geometric. "Look at the ratio of active to inert material. The active processes break down the biomass, and then the mineral structures preserve and store what it's extracted. It's not just decomposing. It's sequestering. Building something."

"Building what?"

"I don't know yet. But it's intelligent in the way a system can be intelligent. It's responding to the planet's needs, not expressing malice. It's not our enemy, Cole. It's the planet's immune system. It just happens to be cleaning a space we're occupying."

The distinction was fine enough that it didn't matter. The creep was still advancing on the settlement.

Polk wanted to burn it. Stood up in the council meeting and said they should trench the perimeter and light it. Cole vetoed. Polk pushed back — wanted to know why they were studying the thing instead of fighting it. Cole could have explained Elena's data, the fire adaptation, the chemical failure. He didn't. Polk hadn't earned the logs. Polk wanted action, immediate and decisive. Cole wanted a solution that would hold. Those two wants collided in the daily council meetings, where Polk's frustration mounted and Cole's silence only deepened it.

"You've got a plan," Polk said after one session, catching Cole outside the council shelter. "I can see you running numbers in your head while the rest of us talk. So either share the math or stop pretending this is a democracy."

Cole looked at him. "It's not a democracy. It's a survival problem."

"Same thing, where I come from. The people who do the math get to make the rules, and the rest of us get to live with it."

Polk walked away. Cole watched him go and thought about the signal array, the rescue frequency, the man who'd wanted off this planet from the moment he arrived. Polk's instincts weren't wrong. They were just expensive.

On Month 9, Day 2, one of the perimeter shelters ceased reporting.

It was a routine check — the supply tech who worked the eastern shelter line didn't show for the morning count. Cole sent a search team. They found the shelter intact but unsealed. The opening in the wall had been gradual — the creep had grown through the composite material, patient and methodical, following the path of least resistance. The colonist — a man named Marcus Reeves, thirty-one, former software engineer who'd taken the settlement logistics role because it kept him occupied and away from processing why he'd left Earth in the first place — was still inside.

Haruki did the field examination. Cole watched from a respectful distance, close enough to understand, far enough to preserve something like dignity for what remained. The creep had been indiscriminate. Reeves's lower body was dissolved to the point where the fungal network had replaced what should have been there — not in a clinical, educational way, but in a way that made clear the organism considered organic matter as raw substrate. His upper body was intact. His face was untouched. His eyes were closed, or dissolved to where it appeared they were closed.

Haruki said, "He was unconscious before the significant dissolution." Nothing else. The clinical economy of it was the mercy — what Haruki chose not to speculate about, the questions he didn't answer.

Cole helped Haruki carry what was left to the processing area. They didn't call it cremation — the planet's high-temperature cycles and the shelter's heating system could serve the same purpose. Haruki prepared the body with the same precision he applied to everything, which was the only dignity available: careful, methodical, without performance or false ceremony.

No one saw the body except Cole and Haruki. Cole kept it that way, not through explicit instruction but through presence — staying near the processing shelter, making it clear that this particular space was closed. The colonists understood. They always did. Death was common enough that they'd learned the etiquette of it.

But the etiquette was different this time. The other deaths had been comprehensible — spores, falls, infections, structural failure. Human-scaled problems with human-scaled causes. The creep wasn't human-scaled. The colonists didn't know what had happened to Marcus Reeves's body, but they knew the shelter wall had been breached from the outside by something that moved slowly enough to be invisible and fast

enough to kill a man in his sleep. That knowledge sat in the settlement like a change in air pressure. People stopped sleeping near the perimeter. Two colonists asked to move their shelter assignments inland. Three asked Haruki how it happened and got the same clinical economy Cole had received. Nobody asked Cole. They'd learned that Cole's silence on the specifics of death meant the specifics were worse than the fact of it.

The count dropped to thirty-eight.

That night, Cole spread Ren's time-marked photographs across the floor of his shelter and did the work.

The creep's advance wasn't uniform. The photographs showed it moving faster through areas with dense organic material — the composting zones, the plant waste from the agricultural experiments, the paths where foot traffic had compacted biomass into the soil. It moved slower over rocky patches, mineral-rich ground, areas where the planet's bedrock was close to the surface. He marked the rates on the map. Drew the projection lines. Checked them twice.

Eleven weeks to the core shelters at current speed. But the current speed was the second cycle's opening phase. Elena's logs said the creep accelerated as the cycle deepened. If it doubled — and Elena's data suggested it would — the timeline compressed to six weeks. Maybe five. The perimeter shelters were already compromised. The northern agricultural plots, where the dormancy-phase species Dana had cultivated were the colony's only reliable food source, sat directly in the creep's path. Seventy days. Maybe less.

Elena had been competent. She'd had the data, the scientific precision, the survival instinct. She'd relocated three times. The third relocation was made with six people remaining. The creep had consumed the other eight — not through malice, through patience. Elena's colony hadn't lost a war. They'd lost a race against something that never tired, never stopped, never needed to win quickly.

Elena never solved this. Cole sat with that fact the way he sat with all the facts that mattered — quietly, completely, until it stopped being information and became weight.

He pulled her logs again. Re-read the containment entries. Her conclusion, written in Month 17 after the third relocation: *"The creep isn't something we can fight. It's something we can only move ahead of. Every settlement we establish becomes a temporary barrier — the creep consumes the organic substrate we've established and then continues. We are not the problem. But we occupy the problem's path."*

Three relocations. Each time, Elena's colony left behind everything they'd built. Each time, they built less, moved fewer people, held less ground. The trajectory was clear: retreat until there's nowhere left to retreat to.

Cole looked at the geological survey data from the original viability report — the same report that had inflated the habitability score by twelve points, the same one with the redacted appendix. The data was compromised, but the topographic mapping was harder to fake. Four kilometers east, the elevation rose. Rock substrate. Mineral-rich ground with less biomass accumulation. If the creep was a decomposer, it would struggle where there was nothing to decompose. The colony could relocate to higher ground, build on stone instead of soil, strip the organic matter from the perimeter.

It was possible. Elena had relocated three times to lower ground, chasing organic soil for agriculture, never breaking the pattern. Cole could break it. Build where nothing grew. Trade agricultural advantage for defensibility.

It was also possible that he was wrong, the way Elena had been wrong three times before she stopped writing.

Cole brought the plan to Ren.

"We have eleven weeks to the core shelters," he said. "Maybe six if it accelerates the way Elena's data suggests. But Ren — the agricultural zone is in the path. Seventy days, maybe less."

"I know," Ren said. She had her own copy of the photographs, her own projection lines. She'd been running the same numbers. "Once we lose the food production zone, the timeline accelerates. Shortages, morale collapse, decision-making degrades. We move before Day 70 or we move under emergency conditions."

"The creep isn't even at full speed yet. If the second cycle intensifies—"

"It will. And we'll be in the process of relocation when it does, carrying everything we've built on our backs, moving a population that's increasingly malnourished and frightened. Cole, I'm not being pessimistic. I'm reading the pattern." She laid out the timeline on a map, marked the creep's current position and projected advancement. "We have two weeks to decide. Four weeks to plan. Eight weeks to move everything. After Day 70, it's emergency extraction, and we lose infrastructure."

Cole understood what she wasn't saying: we lose the people who can't move fast.

"I scouted the high ground east of here," Cole said. "Rock substrate. Higher elevation. Less organic material for the creep to feed on. Four kilometers. The topographic data in the viability report shows cleared platforms near the drainage features — enough space for shelter construction. Water access from the natural drainage."

"You're talking about starting over."

"I'm talking about surviving."

"Those aren't the same thing," Ren said. "Half this colony will refuse. They've built here. Planted here. They know this ground. You're asking them to walk four kilometers into terrain they've never seen and trust that the math works."

"The math does work."

"Then bring it to a vote."

Cole didn't answer immediately. Ren watched him, and he could feel her reading the hesitation. He didn't trust a vote. Not because he didn't trust the colonists — because he didn't trust fear to produce good decisions. People under survival pressure voted for the familiar. They voted to protect what they had, even when what they had was already dead. A vote on relocation would be a vote on whether to grieve the settlement they'd built, and grief didn't follow timelines.

"A vote takes time we don't have," Cole said.

"Then what are we surviving for?" Ren said. "If you relocate thirty-eight people without their consent, you're not leading a colony. You're running a prison with better scenery."

The words landed. Cole felt them in the same place he felt the math — the place where logic and something harder to name shared space.

"Call the vote," he said.

Ren organized it in two days. Full colony assembly. Every colonist present, every voice counted.

Cole presented the data. The creep's advance rate. The agricultural zone timeline. The higher ground, the rock substrate, the four-kilometer walk. He showed them the map. He showed them Elena's containment

data — fire's failure, chemical adaptation, the pattern of retreat. He didn't tell them how Elena's story ended. He told them enough.

Half the colony pushed back. Not Polk's faction — Polk surprised everyone by staying quiet, arms crossed, listening. The resistance came from the people who'd built the settlement. The water system engineers, the shelter constructors, the agricultural teams who'd spent eight months learning the soil. They'd made something here. It worked. Walking away felt like admitting the planet had won.

A woman named Kira, who'd designed the water collection system, stood up. "We adapt. We've been adapting since Day 1. We figure out the creep the way we figured out the soil cycle, the way we figured out the rationing. We don't run."

Dana answered before Cole could. "The creep adapts faster than we do. Fire accelerated it. Chemicals bought six weeks. Every strategy we deploy, it routes around. This isn't a problem we solve from here. It's a problem we survive by not being here."

The debate went for three hours. Cole watched it happen and said nothing after his initial presentation. Ren moderated. Voices rose. People argued about shelter construction time, about agricultural restart costs, about the risk of moving malnourished colonists four kilometers through hostile terrain. About Marcus Reeves and what the creep had done to his shelter and whether the perimeter was safe for anyone sleeping within two hundred meters of the forest edge.

The vote was close. Twenty-one to seventeen, with Ren abstaining as moderator.

Twenty-one to relocate. Seventeen to stay and fight.

Cole looked at the seventeen. He knew the math on what staying meant. He also knew that seventeen people had just been told their judgment was overruled by four votes, and they'd be carrying shelter beams across four kilometers of alien terrain for a plan they didn't believe in.

Polk had voted to move. When it was over, he found Cole outside the assembly shelter.

"I'm done watching this place take pieces of us," Polk said.

Cole nodded. Polk walked away. Cole stood in the dark and listened to the creep advancing somewhere beyond the perimeter markers, patient and slow, and thought about Elena's three relocations and the six people she had left when she made the third one, and the fact that Elena had been smarter than him, more experienced than him, and it hadn't been enough.

He had to be enough. Twenty-one people had voted that he was. Seventeen had voted that he wasn't. Either way, they were all moving east in the morning.

Chapter 12 — "Democracy"

The vote had been twenty-one to seventeen, and Ren could feel the seventeen in every interaction for the first forty-eight hours after it passed.

She'd pushed for the vote because she didn't trust Cole to relocate thirty-eight people on arithmetic alone. Cole had resisted because he didn't trust fear to produce good decisions. They'd both been right. The vote happened, the margin was four, and now seventeen colonists who'd voted to stay were being asked to dismantle the settlement they'd built with their own hands and carry it four kilometers east because twenty-one people and a fungal network had overruled them.

Ren took the close margin as her signal to get detailed. Speed and structure were the only tools that would keep the seventeen from calcifying into permanent opposition.

She organized the relocation in six days, which meant planning it backward from Cole's timeline and forward from what seemed physically possible. Thirty-eight colonists, limited equipment, four kilometers of terrain between the old settlement and the new site on the high ground. The northern agricultural zone had to be harvested before the creep reached it. The shelters had to be dismantled and transported or rebuilt. Water systems had to be reestablished. Medical supplies had to be moved with redundancy — can't afford contamination or loss mid-transport.

Ren divided the colony into work teams. She didn't ask permission. She presented the structure to Cole, who nodded, and then she presented it to the colony as fact rather than suggestion. The seventeen who'd voted to stay didn't refuse to work — that would have meant refusing to survive — but the resistance lived in the small hesitations, the slower pace, the silence where collaboration should have been. Ren watched it and decided the only solution was making the work so immediate and so physical that grievance didn't have room to breathe.

The problem was that knowledge and execution were different objects.

Day One of the relocation: the agricultural team harvested the northern plots. Thirty-eight people working in the shadow of the creep's advance, pulling crops with the knowledge that this was the last harvest from this soil. The work was physically brutal and emotionally strange — mourning a garden while trying to feed your survival. Ren worked the southern plots with five others, moving methodically through the plants Dana had identified as most likely to survive transplantation. Dana was there too, hands deep in the soil, knowing exactly which species had taken root well enough to be worth moving, which had to be left.

They'd known each other for ten months. In that time, Ren had watched Dana move through the colony with the precision of someone who'd calculated exactly how much space she was allowed to occupy. Quiet. Necessary. Present but not imposing. Ren had developed a respect for that kind of economy — the refusal to waste motion or words. She'd also recognized it as a survival technique, the body language of someone who'd learned early that taking up room was dangerous.

"We're losing three-quarters of this," Dana said, pointing at the transplant pile. "The soil composition at the channels is different. Rock-based substrate, higher mineral content. The plants that thrived here might not establish there."

"Then we take the seeds," Ren said. "Learn to grow what the new soil wants."

Dana looked at her like Ren had suggested something philosophical. "We're not adaptable enough for that. We think we are. We think we're survivors. We're just people carrying what we know to a place that doesn't want it."

Ren didn't argue. Dana was right in a way that stopped argument. They just moved plants, chose which ones to carry, which ones to leave for the creep to process into whatever the planet needed next.

That night, the first death came not from the relocation but from the thing that preceded it.

Thomas Chen, age 51, construction worker who'd been managing the shelter-deconstruction team, had a cardiac event while supervising the removal of the eastern shelter beams. Haruki found him on the ground, respiration shallow, the kind of happening that in a proper hospital would have been reversible with the right intervention delivered in the right time window. Haruki had neither. He had morphine and a shelter and the knowledge that Thomas's heart had decided to stop during the last moment of the relocation's early stage, when supplies were stretched thin and attention was divided.

Cole sat with Thomas. Ren watched from a distance, not intruding but close enough to see Cole's face, which remained neutral in the way that people's faces became neutral when they were doing math inside their heads. By the time Haruki closed Thomas's eyes, Cole had already subtracted him from the thirty-eight and begun recalculating margins.

The count was thirty-seven.

Day Two and Three: the physical relocation began in earnest. Ren coordinated the transport teams, pacing them to avoid exhaustion-based accidents, rotating roles to prevent muscle strain from becoming injury. She moved between the teams, watching for signs of failure. A colonist named Patricia developed a cough during the water system relocation — not alarming yet, but Ren noted it, marked it as a potential future complication.

On the night of Day Three, the temperature dropped eleven degrees in two hours. They'd learned to expect the swings from the second cycle, but not while moving across open terrain with no shelter overhead. A colonist named Noor — forty-three, electrician, one of the seventeen who'd voted to stay — collapsed during the night transport. Hypothermia compounded by dehydration and three days of physical labor on reduced rations. Haruki found her unresponsive behind the carrying line. He worked on her for forty minutes in the dark while the transport team stood around him holding crates they couldn't set down on open ground. She didn't come back.

Thirty-six.

Ren redistributed Noor's transport load, adjusted the schedule to include mandatory thermal checks every hour, and kept the teams moving. There was no time to stop and no shelter to stop in — they were between settlements, exposed, carrying everything they owned across four kilometers of terrain that belonged to something other than them. The seventeen who'd voted to stay said nothing. Noor had died doing the thing she'd voted against, and the math of that was worse than the cold.

Day Four and Five: the transport continued. Ren watched the remaining colonists for signs of breakdown — physical or otherwise — and saw both. People moved slower. Spoke less. The relocation was bleeding them through accumulated stress the way the creep bled the forest through patience.

On Day Five, during a night transport run, one of the carrying teams encountered terrain they'd misjudged. The equipment manifest listed seventeen items as critical — medical supplies, water filtration components, seed stock for crops. James was carrying one of the backup water filtration units, walking a path that had seemed navigable in daylight but had transformed into something treacherous in the darkness. His foot caught. His balance failed. He fell, and the filtration unit fell with him, and his right leg bent in a way that legs shouldn't bend.

Haruki splinted it in the field. The fracture was compound and dirty, which meant infection was not just possible but approaching inevitably. They carried James to the new settlement, and Haruki did what he could — cleaned the wound with boiled water, set the bone as well as field medicine allowed, wrapped it

immobilized. James didn't cry. He just lay in the medical shelter and did the same math Cole was doing, which was the calculation of whether his utility was greater than the resource cost of keeping him alive.

"He'll be functional," Haruki told Cole and Ren, using the medical term that meant mobile enough to contribute but disabled enough that he'd need support. "In three weeks, maybe four. The infection risk is moderate if we manage it carefully."

The phrase "if we manage it carefully" was Haruki's way of indicating that careful management was his priority but not guaranteed. Ren understood. Cole did too.

On Day Six, they completed the initial transport. The old settlement was stripped of everything portable and useful. The new site at the channels was beginning to look less like a refugee camp and more like a settlement — the shelters reassembled with careful attention to position, the agricultural plots staked out in places Dana had identified as having suitable soil composition, the medical shelter established as a secondary priority after water and food systems.

That was when the work team clearing the new site discovered the channels had structure.

Ren was coordinating the final supply transport when one of the excavation team ran over, breathless with discovery rather than panic. "You need to see this," he said. His name was David, mid-forties, geologist on Earth though his job here was general construction. He had the expression of someone who'd encountered something that rearranged his understanding of the problem.

The channels were deeper than they'd realized. The surface cut ran five meters below the soil line, but when David's team started clearing rock for shelter foundations, they found that the channels continued further down. More than that: they weren't natural erosion patterns. The walls were too regular. The substrate was too uniform. And the mineralized substance that filled the deepest sections wasn't random accumulation — it had geometric structure, almost like crystalline growth, or deliberate storage.

Ren crouched at the edge of the excavated section and looked at what remained of an infrastructure that had been built by something that wasn't human and wasn't recent. The channels were carved, not eroded. The mineral deposits were arranged, not scattered. The system was, by any measure that mattered, intentional.

"How old?" she asked David.

"I can't tell. Geologically, it could be anything from five hundred to five hundred thousand years. But it's old enough that the rock has partially reabsorbed the carved sections — there's weathering, mineral deposition, the kind of slow integration that happens over long timescales. Nothing here is recent."

Ren stood and looked at the empty space where the ancient settlement had been. Whatever had lived here once had built infrastructure. Water management systems, at minimum. Possibly agricultural. Possibly something else entirely — a system that had no Earth analogy, designed for needs that Earth minds couldn't imagine.

She walked to the medical shelter where Cole was checking on James's condition. Cole looked up when she entered, reading her face the way he'd learned to read hers — for signs of crisis or discovery.

"The channels aren't natural," she said. "They're architecture. Something built here. A long time ago."

Cole was quiet for a moment. Then: "How long?"

"David doesn't know. Old enough that it's been integrated into the geology. Thousands of years, probably. Maybe longer."

Cole stood and walked to the shelter entrance, looking out at the new settlement and the channels beyond it. The evening was coming on, and the sky above Parcel 16b was shifting toward its greenish tint. The trees hummed, the sound that had become so familiar Ren barely noticed it anymore.

"We're not homesteading," Cole said. It wasn't a question.

"No. We're inheriting."

Cole nodded like that was a calculation that fit into some equation he'd been running. Maybe it did. Maybe it changed everything about the math, or maybe it didn't change anything. Maybe either way, there were thirty-six colonists alive and one whose compound fracture was already incubating the kind of infection Haruki couldn't guarantee he could manage.

The creep hadn't followed them up. Ren had walked the eastern perimeter that morning — the rock substrate was clean. Whatever the fungal network needed, it wasn't here. The higher ground was defensible not because they'd outrun the thing, but because the planet's own decomposition system stopped where there was nothing left to decompose. One problem solved by geography. The rest unsolvable by anything except time.

Ren thought about Thomas Chen's cardiac event on Day One, about Noor cooling on open ground while the transport team stood in the dark holding crates they couldn't set down, about Patricia's cough, about James's leg and the infection already building in the dirty wound, about the thirty-eight who'd become thirty-six in six days, about the system this planet had built for its own renewal and the people they'd buried in its soil trying to establish a foothold.

She thought about democracy and whether it meant anything when the margin was four votes and everyone was already dying.

"We need to assign research teams," Ren said. "Figure out what the channels were built for. If there's infrastructure, there might be systems we can use. Water management, at minimum."

Cole looked at her. "That assumes the builders solved the same problems we're trying to solve."

"They lived here. They built. They survived something. If they didn't, this infrastructure wouldn't exist."

"They're gone," Cole said. "Whatever they were, they're not here. We have thirty-six people and a planet that changes the rules every orbital cycle. Channels are interesting. They're not food, shelter, or medicine."

"They might be all three," Ren said. "We survive by understanding the system we're in. That system includes infrastructure someone else built. We study it. We learn. We use what's useful."

Cole didn't argue further. Ren understood that as agreement — Cole was too practical to ignore a potential resource, even if his instinct was to minimize distraction. She'd push the research forward, and Cole would allocate people to it, and they'd find out what the channels meant. Or they wouldn't. But at least they'd look before the planet decided they weren't worth the space.

Chapter 13 — "The Structure"

The channels went deeper than anyone had expected.

In the two weeks since the relocation, David's excavation teams had been clearing rock for shelter foundations and uncovering more of the network that ran beneath the settlement. What had looked like drainage cuts on the surface turned out to be the top layer of a system that extended at least twelve meters into the bedrock. Cole stood at the edge of the deepest excavation trench on Month 11, Day 4, looking at walls of carved stone filled with a substance that caught the light like smoky quartz.

Dana had been studying it since the discovery. She'd collected thirty-seven samples from different points in the network, mapped the mineral composition at each depth, cross-referenced the crystalline structure against her creep data. The results came back on a morning when the sky was doing its green-shift thing, the light falling through the spiral trees at an angle that made the channel walls glow faintly from within.

"Same compound," Dana said. She was crouched at the edge of the trench, holding a sample container up to the light. Her voice had the quality it got when data confirmed something she'd suspected but hadn't wanted to be right about. "The base molecular structure is identical to the creep. Same organic-mineral hybrid. Same filament architecture at the microscopic level."

Cole looked at the substance in the container. Inert. Glassy. Nothing like the slow-moving biological mat that had driven them from the original settlement.

"It's not active," he said.

"No. It's ancient. Mineralized. The organic components have been replaced by mineral analogs over time — the same way petrified wood preserves structure after the original material is gone. This is what the creep becomes. Or what it was. The timeline runs in both directions." Dana set the container down carefully. "Cole, the creep isn't a disease. It's a phase. The channels are full of the end product. The planet builds these networks the way coral builds reefs — living processes that create mineral infrastructure over deep time."

Cole processed that. The creep they'd fled from was the active version of the substance lining the walls beneath their feet. The ancient builders hadn't carved channels and then filled them. They'd used the creep — or something like it — to build.

"How old?" he asked.

"I can't tell precisely. David's geological estimates put it at tens of thousands of years minimum. The mineralization is complete. Whatever was alive in these walls hasn't been alive for a very long time."

"But the builders were alive. Something lived here that understood how to use this."

Dana stood. Brushed the rock dust from her knees. "Something lived here that built infrastructure on a planetary scale. The channels aren't local. They branch. Every time David's team clears a new section, they find more connections. This isn't a settlement. It's a network. Drainage, nutrient transport, maybe communication. Maybe something we don't have a word for."

Cole looked at the trench. The carved walls. The mineralized substance that had been deposited with geometric precision into rock that was older than human civilization. He felt the weight of it — not reverence, not awe. Something more practical. The recognition that every assumption the colony had made about this planet was built on a surface reading. Below the surface, the planet had a history, and they were standing on it without knowing the first chapter.

The colony took the news in pieces.

Ren organized a presentation. Dana delivered the scientific data. David showed the excavation maps, the branching network, the depth measurements. Cole stood in the back and watched thirty-five faces absorb the information that the ground beneath their shelters was architecture.

The reactions split along lines Cole had learned to predict. The practical contingent — the builders, the water engineers, the people whose survival instincts ran toward the tangible — wanted to know if the channels could be used. Water management. Drainage. Storage. If the ancient builders had solved the problems the colony was still fighting, maybe their infrastructure was the answer.

The philosophical contingent — smaller, quieter, harder to identify until they spoke — wanted to know what this meant. Who had been here. What had happened to them. Whether the colony had any right to build on top of something they didn't understand.

Garrett Polk, characteristically, occupied both camps at once. "Can we drink from the channels?" he asked. Then, before Dana could answer: "And what killed the things that dug them?"

Dana answered the first question. "The water flow through the upper channels is clean. Mineral-rich but potable. We've been using it already — the drainage features David identified are part of this system. So yes. We've been drinking from the channels since we arrived."

She didn't answer the second question. Nobody could.

Cole's interiority during the presentation was simpler than anyone watching him would have guessed. He ran the math. The channels existed. The channels carried water. The channels provided defensible infrastructure on rock substrate the creep couldn't colonize. Did the channels change the survival math? No. The colony was at thirty-six, the same thirty-six it had been since Noor died on Night Three of the relocation. The channels didn't add people. They didn't subtract threats. They provided resources the colony was already using without knowing what they were.

Did the channels change the moral math? Cole didn't let himself answer that. The moral math was Ren's territory. She'd fight it out in council, argue about inheritance and obligation, push for research teams to study the builders' legacy. Cole would let her. Not because he agreed or disagreed, but because the moral questions didn't change the number. Thirty-six. Twenty-four needed. Forty-eight months remaining.

Elena's logs never mentioned this. Her colony had built twelve kilometers west, on different terrain. She'd found the same creep, the same orbital cycles, the same slow death. But she'd never stood over a trench cut into bedrock and realized the planet had been inhabited before. That absence in her data was its own kind of information. The planet was large enough to contain different stories. Elena's and Cole's were parallel but not identical. The channels were his alone.

Ren pushed for research teams. Cole allocated three people: Dana for the biological analysis, David for the geological survey, and a rotating fourth position for general assistance. He kept the teams small because every person studying channels was a person not building shelters, not tending the dormancy-phase crops, not maintaining the systems that kept thirty-six people breathing.

Suri Park volunteered for the fourth position on the first day.

Cole almost said no. Not because Suri was unqualified — she'd been working as Dana's field assistant since the fruit incident in Month One, when she'd eaten the native berries that nearly killed her and then come back the next week asking Dana to teach her how to test samples properly. Suri had the curiosity that made people useful and the eagerness that made them careless, but eight months of working with Dana had filed the carelessness down to something closer to controlled intensity. She asked questions before she touched things now. She waited for data before she acted.

Cole said yes because Suri had earned it. She'd survived the thing that should have taught her to be afraid, and instead it had taught her to be precise. He respected that more than he respected caution.

The research moved quickly. Over six weeks, the team mapped the channel network beneath the settlement and extending two hundred meters in each direction. The branches were systematic — main arteries splitting into secondary channels, secondary channels splitting into capillary networks so fine they could only be detected with Dana's ground-penetrating analysis. The geometry was consistent. The mineralized compound filled every channel to a uniform depth, as though the entire network had been activated simultaneously and then gone inert at the same moment.

Dana's working theory: the channels were a planetary circulatory system. During active orbital phases, living creep — the biological mat — would flow through the network, transporting nutrients, breaking down dead matter, redistributing minerals. During dormant phases, the compound would mineralize, preserving the infrastructure for the next cycle. The builders hadn't fought the planet's cycles. They'd built with them. Used the creep as a construction material, a transport medium, a living tool.

"It's elegant," Dana said one evening, spreading her maps across the research shelter's table. Cole, Ren, and Suri were there. The light outside was fading, the green-shifted sky darkening toward something that wasn't quite night. "The planet has a circulatory system. The builders understood it. They didn't try to stop the cycles or survive them — they integrated. The channels are infrastructure that works with the planet instead of against it."

"Infrastructure that's been dead for tens of thousands of years," Cole said.

"Dormant," Dana corrected. "The compound mineralizes during dormancy. That doesn't mean the system is permanently inactive. It means it's waiting."

Cole heard the word and filed it. Waiting. The channels were waiting. The compound that had killed Marcus Reeves, that had driven them from the original settlement, that had consumed Elena's colony centimeter by centimeter — that substance, in its ancient form, was sitting in the walls beneath their shelters. Dormant. Mineralized. Waiting.

"Waiting for what?" Ren asked.

"For the cycle to deepen enough to reactivate it. The surface creep is the active phase. What's in the channels is the stored phase. If the orbital mechanics produce a deep enough cycle — one that goes past what we've already seen — the stored compound could theoretically reactivate."

"Theoretically," Cole said.

"Based on the data I have. The mineralization in the deepest channels is complete. Those sections haven't been active in geological time. But the shallower channels — the secondary and capillary networks closer to the surface — the mineralization is less complete. Younger deposits. More recent cycles."

Cole looked at the map. The deep channels, fully mineralized, ran like bones beneath the settlement. The shallower ones branched upward, closer to the surface, the compound less glassy, more granular. Transitional. The deeper you went, the older and more inert the material. The shallower you went, the closer it was to the thing that still moved through the forest.

"We need to map the activation thresholds," Suri said. She was leaning over the table, tracing a capillary branch with her finger. "If we can determine what conditions trigger reactivation in the shallow channels, we can predict when sections become dangerous."

It was a good question. Cole recognized it as the kind of question that came from someone who'd learned to think in systems — not just what is happening, but what would cause it to happen differently.

"Agreed," Dana said. "I'll design the testing protocol. We'll need ground temperature data, mineral composition at various depths, and samples from the transitional zones — the sections where full mineralization hasn't occurred."

Cole approved the expanded research. Allocated one additional day per week for deep-channel exploration. The colony could afford it. The dormancy-phase crops were established, the water systems were running through the channels' own drainage, and the creep hadn't followed them to the rock substrate. For the first time in months, Cole felt something that wasn't dread. Not optimism — he didn't trust optimism. Something more structural. The sense that the problem had a shape he could see, and the shape had edges he could work with.

The channels were a system. The creep was a phase of that system. The planet operated on cycles that could be mapped, predicted, integrated. Dana had cracked the soil. She was close to cracking the creep. The builders had already solved this problem, thousands of years ago. Their solution was carved into the bedrock. All the colony had to do was read it.

Cole believed that. Standing over the maps, looking at the elegant branching network, listening to Dana explain the circulatory logic, watching Suri trace the capillary paths with her finger — he believed they were close to understanding. The planet wasn't hostile. It was a system. Systems could be learned.

That belief was the most dangerous thing Cole had carried since landing.

Month 12, Day 8. Cole, Dana, Suri, and Ren descended into the deepest accessible section of the channel network.

The excavation team had opened a shaft two weeks earlier — a natural fracture in the bedrock that intersected one of the primary channels. The channel was wide enough to walk through at the upper levels, narrowing as it descended. The walls were lined with the mineralized compound, the surface catching their lamplight in slow ripples of smoky translucence. The air was cool. Dry. It smelled like stone and something faintly metallic, the same trace mineral scent that lived in the water they'd been drinking.

They'd explored this section three times before. Each time, the compound had been inert. Glassy. Cold to the touch. Dana had taken samples from the walls at every depth, tested conductivity, moisture content, thermal response. Dead material. Museum-quality preservation of something that had once been alive, now serving only as infrastructure.

Cole led. Ren followed with the mapping equipment. Dana stopped at intervals to sample the wall composition, noting changes in the mineralization gradient. Suri moved between them, documenting, asking questions, pressing her palm flat against the channel walls the way she'd started doing on the second expedition — feeling for temperature variations, moisture, anything the instruments might miss.

"The gradient is shifting," Dana said at the seven-meter depth mark. She was studying a sample under portable magnification, the light from her headlamp pooling on the container. "The mineralization is less complete here. See the granular structure? This section is younger. Deposited during a more recent cycle."

Cole looked. The compound in the walls did look different — less glassy, more textite. The surface had a faint roughness, like sugar that hadn't fully dissolved.

"Recent meaning what?" he asked.

"Hundreds of years instead of thousands. Maybe less. The transition between full mineralization and partial is gradual. We're moving down through time layers — the deepest channels are the oldest, the shallower ones are newer."

"We're going deeper," Cole said. "So we're going older."

"In the main channels, yes. But the capillary branches that intersect the primaries can be any age. Some were deposited recently — within the current set of orbital cycles. The planet keeps building."

They continued down. The channel narrowed at the nine-meter mark. Cole had to turn sideways to pass a rock shelf that jutted into the passage. Beyond it, the channel widened again into a junction — two primary channels meeting at an angle, the walls thicker with the mineralized compound, the geometric precision of the carved stone visible where the coating had cracked and fallen away.

Suri moved ahead of Cole into the junction. She did that — moved toward the interesting thing, the next data point, the question that was forming in her head. Dana had trained the recklessness out of her, but the curiosity remained. It was why she was useful. It was the thing Cole valued.

"The walls are different here," Suri said. She was pressing her palm against the junction wall, the way she always did. "Warmer. Not warm, but warmer than the upper sections. Can you feel it?"

Cole placed his hand on the wall. She was right. A few degrees above the ambient rock temperature. Not alarming. Consistent with geothermal activity at depth. He noted it.

Dana was ten meters back, still sampling at the gradient transition. Ren was between them, recording the junction's dimensions.

"I want to check the capillary branch," Suri said, pointing at a narrow channel that split off from the junction at a downward angle. It was barely wide enough for a person. The mineralized compound on its walls was visibly different — more granular, less glassy, the surface rough under the lamplight. A younger deposit. Closer to active.

"Take a temperature reading first," Cole said.

Suri pulled the thermal probe from her kit. Held it against the capillary wall. "Four degrees above ambient. Consistent with what we've been seeing. No anomalies."

"Go ahead. Stay within voice range."

Suri entered the capillary branch. Cole watched her lamplight shrink as she moved down the narrow passage, her shoulders brushing the walls, the light catching the granular compound on either side of her. She was taking samples as she went — scraping the wall surface into collection vials, labeling them, methodical.

Cole turned back to the junction. He was examining the geometric patterns in the carved stone — the precision of the angles, the uniformity of the channel width — when the air changed.

Not temperature. Not smell. Something more fundamental. A vibration, subsonic, the same frequency range as the humming trees but concentrated, directional. It came through the rock. Through his hands where they rested on the junction wall. Through the soles of his boots. The channel was resonating.

Dana felt it too. She was on her feet, moving toward him, her face carrying the expression she wore when data reorganized itself faster than she could process.

"Cole," she said. "The thermal readings just spiked. The capillary networks. All of them. Simultaneously."

He turned toward the capillary branch where Suri had gone. The lamplight was still visible, thirty meters down the narrow passage. Suri's voice came back: "The walls are changing. The surface — it's getting soft. Like the mineralization is reversing."

Cole was already moving. The passage was tight. His shoulders scraped the walls. The compound on either side of him — the glassy, inert, ancient material — was warm now. Not geothermal warm. Active warm. The

surface had developed a sheen, a faint moisture that hadn't been there ten minutes ago. The mineralization was reversing. The stored phase was waking up.

"Suri, come back. Now."

"I'm coming. The floor is — Cole, the floor is moving. There's flow. It's thin but it's moving."

He could see her lamplight bouncing as she turned. Twenty meters between them. The capillary channel was too narrow for him to pass her. She had to come to him.

Then the vibration deepened. The walls pulsed — not metaphorically, not in his imagination. The compound expanded. The channel narrowed by centimeters. The floor, which had been solid rock coated with mineralized compound, was now coated with something that had the consistency of wet calcium. Flowing. Slowly. The dormant channels reactivating in response to the deepening cycle, the same way the surface creep had activated months ago, but down here the compound was concentrated, old, and dense.

Suri was moving toward him. Fifteen meters. She was fast. She was precise. She was doing everything right.

The compound on the floor was rising. Not like water — like something growing. The filaments emerging from the mineralized base, the same lace-like structures Dana had documented in the surface creep, but denser. Older. Fed by whatever reserves the ancient network had stored during its long dormancy.

"Cole." Suri's voice wasn't a scream. It was confusion. The tone of someone encountering a variable that didn't match the model. "It's on my boots. I can't — it's dissolving the soles."

He could see her now. Twelve meters. She was walking, not running, because running in a narrow channel with dissolving footing was how you fell, and falling was how you died. She was being precise. She was thinking.

The compound was at her ankles.

Cole pushed deeper into the capillary. His own boots met the flow — thin, warm, the surface of the rock slick with reactivated compound. He felt the dissolution start on the rubber soles. The filaments were indiscriminate. Marcus Reeves. The same process. Except Reeves had been asleep and this was happening in real time, in a channel barely wide enough for one person, with Suri ten meters ahead of him and the gap between them full of something that was waking up faster than either of them could move.

"Suri. Keep coming."

"I am." Her voice was controlled. Tight. She was looking down at her feet, at the compound climbing her boot shafts. She took another step. Another. Eight meters.

Cole reached for her. The channel was too narrow. He couldn't get past the rock shelf that jutted into the passage. His arm extended into the space, his hand open, and Suri's hand reaching back, and between them the compound flowing, rising, the ancient system cycling into its active phase in a section that had been dormant every time they'd walked through it.

Suri's feet stopped moving. The compound had reached her shins. She looked down. Looked at Cole. Her face held the expression of someone doing a calculation that didn't produce a survivable answer.

"I can't feel my feet," she said.

"Suri."

"I know." Two syllables that held everything — the understanding, the mathematics, the impossibility of her position. She reached her hand forward. Cole stretched until his shoulder ground against the rock shelf. Their fingers touched. The compound was at her knees.

The dissolution was fast. Faster than the surface creep. Concentrated. The ancient compound, reactivated after centuries or millennia of dormancy, had reserves the surface version didn't. It moved through Suri's lower body with the efficiency of a system resuming function after a long pause — not aggressive, not hostile. Just operational. Doing what it was designed to do: break down organic material, cycle nutrients, build infrastructure. Suri was organic material. The compound didn't distinguish.

Ren was behind Cole, pulling at his shoulder. "Cole. Come back."

"No."

"You can't reach her. Cole. You can't."

Suri's hand went slack. Her eyes were open but the focus was gone — shock, neural disruption, the same unconsciousness that had been Haruki's single mercy for Marcus Reeves. She was unconscious before the significant dissolution. That was the only comfort available, and it wasn't enough.

Cole let Ren pull him back. They retreated up the channel, boots dissolving, the compound following them at the pace of something patient, and reached the junction as the capillary branch behind them filled with active compound. The main channels — the deep, fully mineralized arteries — remained inert. The activation was localized. A capillary response. A shallow branch waking up because the cycle had deepened past the threshold the younger deposits needed.

Dana was at the shaft entrance, pulling them up. Cole's hands were bleeding where the rock shelf had scraped them. He didn't feel it.

Haruki went down with a sealed suit and a thermal probe six hours later, after the activation subsided. The compound had re-mineralized. The capillary branch was inert again, the walls glassy, the floor solid. As though nothing had happened.

There was nothing left to recover.

Haruki's report was brief. Same dissolution pattern as Marcus Reeves. Accelerated by concentration and confinement. The compound had consumed everything organic and deposited the minerals into the channel walls. Suri Park was part of the infrastructure now. Built into the system she'd been studying.

Thirty-five.

Cole sat in his shelter that night with the thermal data from the capillary branch. The readings were clear. The shallow channels — the younger deposits, the sections where mineralization was incomplete — had reactivated when the second orbital cycle deepened past a threshold Dana's models hadn't predicted. The deep channels, fully mineralized, remained inert. The activation was a gradient: the younger the deposit, the lower the threshold needed to reactivate it.

They'd explored that capillary three times before. Each time, the compound had been dormant. Each time, the thermal readings had been normal. The section was safe because the data said it was safe, and the data was a snapshot of a system in motion, and Cole had read the snapshot as the whole picture because he'd wanted to. Because the channels felt like an answer. Because the planet's infrastructure felt like something he could learn, map, predict, use.

He hadn't miscalculated. The channels had been dormant. His readings were accurate. His protocols were sound. He'd sent Suri into a passage that every data point said was safe, and the data points were correct at the time of collection and obsolete by the time she reached the thirty-meter mark.

The planet wasn't hostile. It was incomplete. His understanding was incomplete. Those were the same thing.

He'd been confident. Standing over Dana's maps, tracing the elegant branching network, listening to the circulatory logic, feeling the shape of a problem he could finally see — he'd believed he was close. The builders had solved this. The solution was in the rock. All the colony had to do was read it.

Suri had died while Cole was reading. She'd died in the space between his understanding and the planet's actual complexity. She'd died because Cole believed he'd figured it out, and believing you've figured it out is the moment the system shows you what you missed.

He thought about Elena. Three relocations. Each time, a retreat from something she thought she understood. Elena was smarter than him. More experienced. She'd watched the creep consume her colony and she'd never found the channels, never had the infrastructure data, never had Dana's maps or David's excavations. She'd failed with less information. Cole was failing with more.

The difference wasn't the data. It was the confidence the data produced. Elena had been cautious and died slowly. Cole had been confident and Suri had died quickly. Neither approach protected you. The planet didn't care about your strategy. It cared about its cycles, its systems, its ancient circulatory logic that had been running since before humans existed and would continue running after they were gone.

Thirty-five. The count that matched his worst-case projection minus one. He'd built a model in his head on landing day — a curve of expected attrition, flattening over time as the colony learned and adapted. The model was holding. The model was accurate. Suri Park was a data point on a curve that Cole had drawn before he knew her name, and the fact that the curve predicted her death didn't make it acceptable. It made it his.

Not because he'd been reckless. Because he hadn't been reckless enough. He'd been careful, methodical, precise. He'd read the data. He'd followed the protocols. He'd believed the system was knowable. The planet had shown him otherwise, and Suri had been standing in the space where the lesson landed.

Cole turned off the lamp. Sat in the dark. The hum of the trees pressed through the shelter walls, the same subsonic frequency that ran through the channels, through the rock, through the ancient compound that was dormant now but wouldn't always be.

He didn't count. He didn't calculate. He just sat with the weight of a number that used to be a person, and let it be heavy.

Chapter 14 — "Signal"

The soil analyzer weighed eleven pounds and looked exactly like what it was supposed to be — a portable spectrometer modified for field use, cased in reinforced polymer with Asterlyne's logo stamped on the base plate. Dana had requested it as part of her botanical equipment manifest before departure. Legitimate. Documented. One of thirty-seven items she'd signed for on the transport vessel, each one cataloged against her research assignment.

The comm array nested inside the spectrometer's housing weighed four ounces. It drew power from the same battery pack. Used the same antenna port. Transmitted on a frequency buried in the spectrometer's standard diagnostic band, indistinguishable from equipment telemetry unless you knew the encoding protocol. Asterlyne's technical team had built it. They'd given it to her three days before launch, in a windowless office on the fourth floor of the onboarding center, the same building where Cole had been reading the two-hundred-page charter one floor below.

Dana powered it on.

The screen was small. Two inches. Monochrome. The text came through in blocks — compressed, stripped of formatting, the kind of communication designed to leave no fingerprint. She'd been receiving and transmitting through this screen for thirteen months. The rhythm was fixed: transmit window every eleven days, aligned with the planet's magnetic cycle, when atmospheric interference dropped low enough for the signal to reach the relay satellite Asterlyne had parked in high orbit. One relay satellite. One frequency. One person on the ground with access.

Her handler didn't have a name. A designation: FIELD-SUPPORT-7. The messages arrived formatted as equipment diagnostics. The questions embedded in the telemetry looked like calibration requests to anyone who didn't know the pattern.

She knew the pattern.

Dana opened the current batch.

Thirteen months of reports. She could recite the categories without looking: soil composition data by quadrant, crop yield measurements, water quality metrics, caloric intake estimates, weather pattern observations, equipment status and degradation rates. The scientific data Asterlyne had contracted her to collect. Legitimate research outputs that any agricultural specialist would generate. If someone found the transmissions and decoded them, they'd see what looked like a dedicated scientist sending her findings to the company that funded the expedition.

The other categories she didn't let herself recite: colony population status, leadership structure, interpersonal conflicts, resource allocation decisions, morale assessments, individual behavioral profiles.

She typed up the report the way she always typed it up. Data first. Clean. Quantitative. Growing conditions in the relocated settlement during Months 11 and 12 — the rock substrate at the channel site had different thermal properties than the original soil. Crop transplants from the first settlement showed forty percent viability. Native species from Dana's cycle mapping were performing better on the new terrain. Water supply through the channel drainage was reliable. Mineral-rich but potable.

Then the qualitative section. Council governance stable. Ren Tsai's democratic framework operational. Garrett Polk integrated into the council, no longer pursuing rescue signal. Colony morale impacted by Suri Park's death in the channels. Cole Maren maintaining operational command through logistics control.

Dana stopped typing. Looked at the last sentence. Deleted "through logistics control." Retyped: "Cole Maren continuing to manage colony operations."

The difference was nothing. The information was the same. But the first version sounded like an assessment of a vulnerability, and the second sounded like a status report. Dana had become expert at this distinction — the tiny calibrations that let her believe she was reporting data, not enabling action. The line between observation and intelligence was a line she redrew every eleven days, and every eleven days it moved a little further from where she'd originally placed it.

She finished the report. Agricultural data, population count, social dynamics, resource status. Hit the compression protocol. The transmission would go out during tonight's window.

Sixty thousand credits. Medical debt. Her mother's oncology treatment on Earth — the three-year protocol that saved her life and generated a bill that would take Dana fourteen years to pay on a botanist's salary. Asterlyne's offer had been simple: two years of field reports, debt erased. Not reduced. Erased. The kind of number that makes you stop calculating and start rationalizing.

Dana had done both. She'd calculated the odds — forty-seven colonists, five-year charter, the survival projections she'd read in the data appendix that most people skipped. The math said some of them would die. The math said the data she was sending wouldn't change that. Growing conditions and soil composition didn't kill people. Resource allocation reports didn't subtract from the headcount. She was sending information that Asterlyne could get from their own survey data if they bothered to look. She was just making their jobs easier.

That's what she told herself on Day 1. On Day 30. On Day 90. On Day 180, when she transmitted the colony's first death toll alongside her crop yield data and didn't pause between the two entries.

Thirteen months in, she still told herself the same thing. The words hadn't changed. The weight of them had.

The new questions arrived three days before the next transmission window.

Dana opened the diagnostic batch during her morning soil sampling routine, the spectrometer propped on a rock at the edge of the relocated settlement's southern agricultural plot. The green-shifted sunlight made the screen hard to read. She angled it with her body, blocking the light with her shadow. A scientist checking her equipment. Nothing to notice.

FIELD-SUPPORT-7's questions had always followed a pattern. Agricultural: soil composition, growth rates, cycle projections. Logistical: supply inventory, equipment degradation, energy reserves. Social: leadership dynamics, faction status, morale indicators. Dana had answered all of them for thirteen months. The pattern was familiar. Comfortable, almost.

This month's batch broke the pattern.

Confirm current settlement coordinates. Provide GPS-equivalent positioning relative to original landing zone.

Detail water source locations and flow rates. Include redundancy assessment — single source vs. multiple.

Assess structural vulnerability of primary shelters to sustained wind event (40+ kph, 6+ hours). Include load-bearing analysis if available.

Identify supply chain dependencies on individual colonists. Which operational functions are performed by single individuals with no trained backup?

Dana read the questions twice. Then a third time. The spectrometer hummed in her hands, running its actual soil analysis in parallel with the comm protocol, and for a moment the two functions — the real work and the

hidden work — occupied the same space in her hands with a clarity that felt physical.

Settlement coordinates. They'd relocated. Asterlyne's original survey data placed the colony at Parcel 16b's designated landing zone, four kilometers west. The company didn't know where they were now. The channel site wasn't on any Asterlyne map. The question wasn't scientific curiosity. It was positioning.

Water source locations. Redundancy assessment. Single source versus multiple. Not a hydrological question. A vulnerability question. If the colony depends on one water source, how do you compromise it?

Structural vulnerability to sustained wind events. Load-bearing analysis. Not an engineering question. A stress-test question. How much force does it take to break what they've built?

Supply chain dependencies on individual colonists. Single points of failure.

Dana closed the screen. Put the spectrometer down. Picked up a soil sample container and held it with both hands until the tremor in her fingers passed.

She knew what the questions were. She knew what they meant. The shift from data collection to targeting was as clean as a phase change in one of her mineral samples — same substance, different state, different function. Asterlyne wasn't studying the colony anymore. They were mapping it the way you mapped terrain before an operation. Entry points. Pressure points. Break points.

Dana stood in the morning light at the edge of a field she'd planted, holding a soil container she'd designed, looking at equipment she'd modified to betray every person who depended on her work, and she felt the ground shift beneath her the way it always shifted on this planet. Not physically. Categorically.

She could stop. She could stop right now. Destroy the comm unit. Tell Cole. Tell Ren. Accept whatever came next — exile, judgment, the look on Haruki's face when he learned that the person he'd toasted at dinner was feeding coordinates to the company that had left them to die.

Dana put the soil container down. Picked up the spectrometer. Walked back to her shelter.

She would transmit. Not because the rationalization still held — it didn't, and she'd stopped pretending it did somewhere between the question about water sources and the question about structural vulnerabilities. She would transmit because stopping now raised a different set of calculations. If she went silent, Asterlyne would know the asset was compromised. They'd adjust. Send the next expedition with better surveillance, or worse, assume the colony had turned hostile and accelerate whatever timeline the targeting questions were feeding. Silence wasn't neutral. Silence was a signal too.

So she'd give them coordinates. Not the real ones. Close enough to satisfy the format, offset enough to be useless for anything precise. She'd give them water data. Accurate hydrology, vague positioning. Structural vulnerabilities — she'd describe the shelters as stronger than they were. Load-bearing capacity inflated. Wind tolerance overstated.

And the single points of failure question. She'd answer it honestly: no single colonist represented an irreplaceable operational function. The colony had cross-trained. Redundancy was built in.

That was a lie. Dana herself was the single point of failure for agricultural science, creep research, and soil cycle management. She was the answer to the question she was being asked.

She wouldn't write that.

The creep samples were waiting in the research shelter.

Dana worked through the afternoon the way she worked through every afternoon — precisely, completely, inside the data the way other people lived inside their own heads. The creep compound from the channel

walls sat in sealed containers on her analysis table. Twelve samples, collected at varying depths from the capillary networks that had killed Suri Park six weeks ago.

The work was the only clean thing she had. The rest of her life on this planet was a construction — the careful scientist, the quiet contributor, the person who took up exactly the right amount of space. But the research was real. The data didn't know who was reading it. The samples didn't know what she'd done that morning.

She was close to something. The mineralized compound from the ancient channels and the active creep from the surface shared the same base molecular structure, but the mineralized version had undergone a specific chemical transformation. The organic filaments had been replaced by mineral analogs — petrification, essentially. The process was driven by a catalyst she'd isolated three weeks ago: a mineral compound present in the rock substrate, concentrated in the deeper geological layers.

If the mineralization process could be triggered artificially — if Dana could synthesize the catalyst and introduce it to active creep — the living compound would mineralize. Become inert. Stop advancing. The planet's own biology, turned against itself. Or rather, accelerated. The creep was always going to mineralize eventually. Dana was looking for a way to make eventually happen now.

The math was promising. Her synthesized catalyst showed eighty-percent efficacy in contained samples. Active creep exposed to the compound began mineralizing within hours. The filaments stiffened. The dissolution stopped. The substance transformed from something that consumed organic material on contact to something that sat in a container looking like smoky quartz.

Eighty percent wasn't enough. Field conditions were different from lab conditions. Concentration, temperature, exposure time — all variables she needed to control before she could propose deployment. But the principle was sound. The planet had already solved this problem. The ancient builders had lived with the creep by integrating its cycle. Dana was trying to do something simpler: interrupt it.

She worked until the light shifted. Logged her findings in the research notes she shared with the colony. Separate from the research notes she shared with Asterlyne.

The overlap between the two sets of notes was ninety percent. The missing ten percent was the catalyst synthesis protocol. Dana hadn't transmitted that yet. She'd transmitted the discovery — the mineralization chemistry, the base compound analysis, the theoretical framework. But the specific protocol, the ratios, the synthesis steps — she'd held those back.

Not out of principle. Out of something colder. If Asterlyne had the synthesis protocol, they could neutralize the creep without the colonists. They could send a second expedition equipped with the solution Dana had built from thirteen months of fieldwork, land them on a planet they'd already mapped through her reports, and operate without the messy variable of forty-seven — thirty-five — people who'd signed a charter that included clause 9.4.2.

Dana hadn't framed it that way in her mind until now. She'd told herself she was holding back the protocol because it wasn't ready. Because eighty percent wasn't publishable. Because a responsible scientist doesn't release incomplete data.

She was holding it back because it was the only leverage she had left.

Cole had started leaving Elena Vasik's log entries in the common shelter.

Not all of them. Selected passages. Printed on the colony's limited paper supply, the ink fading at the edges where the printer's cartridge was running low. He'd begun after the assembly in Month Seven, when he'd told the colony about the previous expedition — fourteen people, same planet, same data, same cycles. He'd given them the summary then. Now he was giving them pieces of the source.

Dana had read every entry he'd posted. Most of the colony had. Elena's voice carried a specific authority — the authority of someone who'd stood exactly where they were standing and hadn't survived it. Her observations about soil cycles confirmed Dana's data. Her weather predictions matched the patterns they'd observed. Her notes on social fracture read like meeting minutes from the colony council.

Tonight, a new entry was pinned to the common shelter's board. Elena's Month 14. Dana read it standing in the doorway, the shelter empty, the rest of the colony at the evening meal she'd excused herself from.

Elena's handwriting — transcribed by whoever had coded the data core — was precise in the early entries and increasingly compressed in the later ones, as though the physical act of recording was consuming resources she couldn't spare. Month 14 was still in the precise phase. Still the scientist. Still measuring.

Month 14, Day 6. Supply manifest for the second-quarter delivery arrived via comm relay. Contents significantly reduced from the contracted quantities. Protein stores at sixty percent of agreement. Medical supplies at forty percent. Tool replacements absent entirely.

I compared the manifest against the contractual minimum. The reductions correspond to categories I've reported in my field updates — categories where I described the colony as self-sufficient or making progress. Protein reduced because I reported successful native food sourcing. Medical supplies reduced because I reported low injury rates during the stable period. Tool replacements absent because I reported equipment in serviceable condition.

Asterlyne is adjusting supply manifests based on our reports. The information I send them is being used to calculate the minimum viable support. Not the contracted support. The minimum. Every competence I demonstrate becomes a justification for reducing what they provide.

I am making us expendable by proving we are capable.

Dana read it twice.

The second reading was slower. She went through it the way she went through mineral analysis — breaking each sentence into components, testing the logic, looking for the seam where the observation became the implication.

Elena had been filing field reports. Standard expedition protocol. She'd reported honestly — progress, capability, adaptation. And Asterlyne had used that data to calculate how much less they could provide. Every piece of good news from the surface became a line item subtracted from the supply manifest. The colony's competence was weaponized against them.

Dana's hands were still. She was very good at keeping her hands still.

Elena's entry didn't mention an informant. Didn't use the word spy or asset or betrayal. But the mechanism was there. Elena had filed reports. Asterlyne had adjusted manifests. The reports were the channel through which the colony's own survival data flowed upward and became the justification for withdrawal.

Elena had been doing it through the official comm relay. The standard reporting structure. She hadn't needed a hidden comm unit or a modified spectrometer. The betrayal was built into the protocol itself. Filing a report was filing a report. Doing your job was doing your job. The company didn't need to recruit an informant when the system itself performed the function.

But Asterlyne had recruited one anyway. They'd recruited Dana. Which meant the official reports weren't enough. They wanted a second channel. An asset with specific instructions, specific questions, specific targeting data that the standard reports didn't capture. Leadership profiles. Social fractures. Structural vulnerabilities.

The pattern was older than her. Elena's colony had been consumed by the same mechanism seven years earlier. Different implementation, same architecture. The company built the betrayal into the charter the way they built the insufficient medical kits — not as an accident, not as an oversight, but as a feature. The information flowed up. The support flowed down. The gap between the two was where colonies died.

Dana wondered if Elena had figured it out. If she'd stood in her own common area and read a supply manifest and felt the same recalibration Dana was feeling now — the recognition that the system wasn't broken. The system was working exactly as designed. Elena's "We're going to make it" was the same kind of certainty Dana had carried into her contract with Asterlyne: the belief that the arrangement was adversarial but survivable. That you could work within the structure and come out the other side with the debt erased and the guilt manageable.

Elena hadn't come out the other side.

Dana unpinned the entry. Read it a third time. Pinned it back. Left it exactly as it was. Walked to her shelter in the dark, past the common meal she could hear but didn't join, past Haruki's medical shelter where the light was still on, past the research tent where her creep samples sat in their containers waiting for tomorrow's analysis.

The transmission went out at 03:40, during the magnetic window. Dana lay on her cot with the spectrometer balanced on her stomach, the two-inch screen casting pale light on the shelter's ceiling. The data compressed. The signal found the relay satellite. The relay satellite found whatever Asterlyne endpoint was listening.

Settlement coordinates: offset by 1.3 kilometers to the northeast. Close enough to look accurate. Far enough to matter.

Water sources: accurate hydrology, imprecise positioning. The channel drainage system described in general terms, nothing that would let someone find the specific inlets.

Structural vulnerability: overstated capacity. The shelters could handle forty-kph winds for six hours. She reported they could handle fifty for eight.

Single points of failure: none identified. The colony had cross-trained. Redundancy was built in.

Four lies nested in thirty pages of accurate data. The ratio felt like something Dana's mother would have appreciated — the oncologist's daughter, administering a precise dose of deception to keep the host organism alive.

Dana powered down the spectrometer. Set it on the floor beside her cot. The shelter was dark. The hum of the trees pressed through the walls, the same frequency she'd been hearing for thirteen months, the one that lived in the chest more than the ears. Outside, the colony slept. Thirty-five people who depended on her soil maps, her crop schedules, her creep research, her analysis of the planet's cycles. Thirty-five people she was saving with one hand and selling with the other.

She was the most useful person in the colony. She was the most dangerous person in the colony. The two facts occupied the same body, breathed the same air, worked with the same soil-stained hands. There was no version of Dana Wen where one existed without the other. The research was real. The betrayal was real. The catalyst sitting in her lab could save every person here, and the data sitting in Asterlyne's servers could make saving them unnecessary.

Sixty thousand credits. Her mother's life. Thirty-five strangers on a planet that recycled everything, including loyalty.

Dana lay in the dark and listened to the hum and didn't sleep.

Chapter 15 — "Supply Lines"

The supply drop was due at Month 13.

Clause 12.8 of the charter, Section IV, Subsection C: "Asterlyne Corporation shall provide semi-annual resupply deliveries during Years Two through Five, contents to be determined by operational need assessments conducted in accordance with Appendix G." The language was boilerplate. The obligation was contractual. The delivery window, per the logistics schedule embedded in the charter's appendix, placed the first Year Two drop at the end of Month 13, calibrated to orbital transit calculations and the company's standard shipping cycle from the relay depot at Kepler-442 station.

Cole had the date memorized the way he'd memorized the viability score, the headcount, the caloric burn rate per colonist per day. Numbers lived in him. They organized the noise into something he could hold.

Month 13 passed. He gave it two weeks for transit variance. Weather on the orbital approach, docking delays, the kind of corporate inefficiency that slowed everything Asterlyne touched. He'd built supply chains on Earth. He knew the difference between late and absent. Late had a shape — a delay curve that bent but resolved. Absent was flat. A line that didn't move because nothing was coming.

By Month 14, Day 20, the line was flat.

He ran the inventory. Food stores: six weeks at current rationing, eight if he dropped the physical labor tier to reduced intake. Medical supplies: Haruki was down to baseline antibiotics and a dwindling stock of the anti-inflammatory compound that kept James's leg from swelling shut. James's compound fracture from the relocation had healed wrong — functional, Haruki said, which meant James could walk but not without cost, and the cost was managed by medication they couldn't replace. Water filtration membranes: two spare sets. When those degraded, they'd be drinking through charcoal and hope.

The quarterly drops in Year One had been thin but present. Equipment rated for twenty, medical kits stocked for fewer, seed stock that assumed a climate the planet didn't have. Asterlyne had met the letter of the contract the way a landlord meets code — minimum viable compliance. But the drops had come. On schedule. A crate of protein concentrate, replacement tool heads, water purification tablets. Not enough. Never enough. But real. Physical evidence that something on the other end of the supply chain was still counting them as alive.

Cole sent a formal contract compliance inquiry through the comm relay on Month 15, Day 1.

The relay was the colony's only link to Asterlyne. A satellite in high orbit, company-owned, company-maintained, routing communications between the surface and whatever corporate endpoint received them. Messages took between four and eleven days depending on orbital position and relay queue priority. Cole had sent seven formal communications in fifteen months. Supply requests, status reports, the initial complaint about the viability score discrepancy from the transit data. Asterlyne had responded to three. Two were automated acknowledgments. One was a three-paragraph letter from a department called Charter Success Operations that addressed none of his specific concerns and wished the colony "continued progress toward charter milestones."

He drafted the inquiry in the comm shelter — a modified pre-fab at the eastern edge of the settlement, fitted with the relay interface and a small terminal Ren had rebuilt from salvaged equipment. The shelter smelled like warm polymer and the faint metallic tang that came off the channel walls when the air was humid. Cole typed standing up, the way he'd typed inventory reports in warehouses on Earth. Standing meant it was work. Sitting meant it was personal.

To: Asterlyne Corporation, Charter Compliance Division Re: Supply Delivery — Year Two, Period One Charter Reference: Clause 12.8, Section IV, Subsection C

This communication serves as formal notice that the scheduled semi-annual resupply delivery for Year Two, Period One, has not been received. The delivery was due at the conclusion of Month 13 per the logistics schedule outlined in Appendix G of the charter agreement. As of this communication, we are sixty-one days past the contracted delivery window.

Current supply status: — Protein stores: 43% of contracted minimum — Medical supplies: below operational threshold — Equipment replacement: zero deliveries received — Water filtration: two replacement cycles remaining

Please confirm revised delivery timeline and manifest contents at your earliest opportunity.

Cole Maren, Colony Operations Parcel 16b Charter, Signatory #1

He read it twice. The language was precise, contractual, stripped of anything Asterlyne could read as emotional. He'd learned that from the charter itself — the document was designed to make human need sound like a logistics variance, and the only way to communicate through it was to speak its language. Desperation wasn't a recognized input. Clause references were.

He sent the inquiry. The terminal confirmed relay handshake. The message was in the system, traveling at the speed of corporate infrastructure toward a department that may or may not have people in it who read what colonists sent.

Then he went outside and looked at the sky for the contrail of a ship that wasn't there.

The response came twenty-three days later.

Cole was in the agricultural zone when Ren found him, walking between the rows of native plants Dana had mapped onto the settlement's new terrain. The rock substrate grew different things. Hardier root systems, lower yield, a bitter tuber that tasted like parsnip crossed with something chemical. The colony ate it because the colony ate what the planet provided. Preferences were a luxury they'd stopped discussing around Month 8.

Ren had the printout. She handed it to him without comment, which meant she'd already read it, which meant her face — neutral, controlled, the expression she wore when she was calculating how angry to let herself be — was the review.

Cole read.

Dear Mr. Maren,

Thank you for your continued communication regarding the Parcel 16b charter. Your dedication to operational transparency is noted and appreciated by the Charter Success team.

We are aware of supply chain disruptions affecting multiple charter operations across the current cycle. These disruptions are the result of factors beyond Asterlyne's direct operational control, including revised interstellar logistics protocols, relay station maintenance schedules, and resource allocation adjustments across our active charter portfolio.

We want to assure you that Asterlyne remains fully committed to the success of the Parcel 16b charter and its participants. Revised delivery windows are currently being assessed by our logistics division, and we anticipate providing updated timeline projections in the coming quarter.

In the interim, we encourage the colony to continue leveraging local resources in alignment with the self-sufficiency objectives outlined in your charter agreement (see Section VII, "Adaptive Resource Management"). Asterlyne's charter framework is designed to support colonist ingenuity and resilience, and we are confident in your team's ability to navigate this transitional period.

We remain your partners in this endeavor.

Warm regards, Charter Success Operations Asterlyne Corporation

Cole read it twice. The first time for content. The second time for what wasn't there.

No revised delivery date. No manifest. No acknowledgment of the specific supply shortfalls he'd itemized. No reference to Clause 12.8 or the contractual obligation it established. The response was 247 words of corporate warmth wrapped around a void. It said everything a response was supposed to say — acknowledgment, assurance, forward-looking optimism — and committed to nothing.

"Supply chain disruptions." The phrase sat in Cole's chest like a stone. On Earth, supply chain disruptions meant a container ship stuck in a canal or a warehouse strike delaying distribution by six days. Here, supply chain disruptions meant the company that owned the only route between this planet and everything else had decided the route wasn't worth running. The disruption wasn't mechanical. It was decisional. Someone at Asterlyne had looked at a spreadsheet, found the line item for Parcel 16b resupply, and made a choice.

"Revised delivery windows are currently being assessed." Currently being assessed meant no one was assessing anything. The language was a holding pattern designed to prevent the next communication without providing grounds for a formal complaint. You couldn't file a breach claim against a company that was "assessing." Assessment was the corporate equivalent of the planet's dormant phase — a state that looked like activity but produced nothing.

"We encourage the colony to continue leveraging local resources." Cole almost admired the construction. The contract guaranteed resupply. The response reframed the colony's survival without resupply as an "objective" of the charter itself. Section VII, "Adaptive Resource Management," was a two-page section about supplementing corporate supplies with local resources. Not replacing them. Supplementing. Asterlyne was citing a supplementary clause to justify abandoning the primary obligation. The footnote had swallowed the text.

He folded the printout. Put it in his pocket. Looked at Ren.

"They're not coming," he said.

Ren nodded. She'd known before he said it. She'd known when she read the letter. Probably before that — probably from the moment the Month 13 window closed and the sky stayed empty. Ren had grown up inside systems that promised transparency and delivered opacity. She'd left Earth because the surveillance state that monitored everything somehow never noticed the things that mattered. She recognized institutional abandonment the way a doctor recognized symptoms. The diagnosis preceded the test.

"Council first," she said. "Then everyone."

"Council first. Then I'll tell them."

"We'll tell them. Together."

Cole looked at her. She looked back. The negotiation was in the eye contact — Cole's instinct to deliver bad news alone, to be the one who absorbed the reaction, to stand in front of thirty-five people and let them project whatever they needed onto the man holding the number. Ren's insistence that leadership was plural. That bearing it together wasn't weakness.

"Together," he said.

The council met that evening in the common shelter. Five members: Cole, Ren, Garrett Polk, Haruki, and Kira — the water systems engineer who'd voted against the relocation and carried that opposition into a council seat that functioned as institutional conscience. She challenged every proposal. She demanded evidence. She was exhausting and necessary.

Cole read the Asterlyne response aloud. Let the words land without interpretation. Then he laid out the inventory numbers. Six weeks of food at current rations. Medical supplies trending toward zero. No replacement parts for infrastructure that was already jury-rigged past its design life.

The room processed it the way rooms process information that confirms what everyone already suspects — not with shock but with the particular silence of people rearranging their interior architecture around a fact they'd been building walls against.

Garrett Polk spoke first. "So the signal array I wanted to build — the one you shut down because it would void the charter." He paused. Not for effect. Polk didn't do rhetorical pauses. He paused because the sentence he was constructing had a weight he wasn't sure he wanted to put down yet. "That was to call for rescue from the same company that just told us to go leverage our local resources."

"Yes," Cole said.

"And if I'd built it. Sent the signal. Asterlyne would've come?"

"They'd have sent a retrieval crew. Billed us for extraction. Voided the charter."

"But they'd have come."

"To collect a debt. Not to help."

Polk sat back. His face did the thing it did when he was processing a conclusion he didn't like — a tightening around the jaw, the eyes going flat and calculating. Cole had seen the same expression during the signal array confrontation in Month 4, when Polk had weighed escape against entrapment and found them identical. Now he was weighing it again, and the math was worse. The company he'd wanted to signal for rescue was the same company that had just stopped sending supplies. The rescue and the abandonment came from the same building.

Kira leaned forward. "What does the contract say about breach? If they don't deliver, we have standing to—"

"Arbitration," Cole said. "Clause 17.3. All disputes under the charter agreement are subject to binding arbitration administered through Asterlyne's designated arbitration body."

"Asterlyne's designated—"

"Their arbitration body. Their appointees. Their process."

"And the arbitration filing requires—"

"A functioning comm relay. Which they own. Which routes through their satellite. Which they can restrict, delay, or terminate at their discretion under Clause 17.8, 'Communications Infrastructure Management.'"

Kira sat back. She was an engineer. She understood closed systems — circuits with no external input, feedback loops that referenced only themselves. The charter's dispute mechanism was a closed circuit. The entity you complained about was the entity that administered the complaint. The channel you complained through was the channel they controlled. The process was self-referencing, self-adjudicating, and functionally inoperable by design.

"So there's no one to call," Kira said.

"There's no one to call."

Haruki, who had been quiet through the entire exchange, said: "What are we telling the colony?"

Cole looked at him. Haruki's question wasn't about communication strategy. It was about what kind of truth they were going to deliver. The full truth — that the supply chain was severed, the contract was unenforceable, and the company that owned their charter had effectively abandoned them — was a truth with a body count. Not because the information was dangerous but because hope, once removed, left a space that panic filled.

"The truth," Ren said. "All of it."

"The truth all at once can break things that don't heal," Haruki said. He wasn't arguing against transparency. He was noting the medical reality that psychological shock produced physiological consequences, and the colony's reserves — physical, emotional, caloric — were already below the threshold where resilience was automatic.

"Withholding it breaks things too," Ren said. "The hoarding's already started. People can feel it."

She was right. Cole had noticed the signs over the past two weeks. Colonists eating faster at shared meals, taking portions back to their shelters instead of eating in the common area. Small caches appearing — protein bars tucked into personal storage, water containers filled beyond daily need. The colony's social architecture, which Ren had spent months building through shared meals and council transparency, was developing cracks that followed the same fault lines as the supply shortage. People reverted to individual survival when they sensed the group couldn't protect them. It was biology, not betrayal. But it would kill them just as effectively.

"Tomorrow morning," Cole said. "Full colony. We tell them everything."

He told them in the morning, standing in front of thirty-five people in the common area between the shelters Dana had helped position for optimal growing light. The sky was doing its green-shift thing, the light falling through the spiral trees at the settlement's edge in long, filtered columns. A beautiful morning to deliver the news that they were alone.

Cole didn't give a speech. He didn't know how to give speeches, and the colony didn't need rhetoric. They needed the number.

"The supply drop isn't coming," he said. "Asterlyne responded to our inquiry. There is no revised delivery date. There is no commitment to resupply. The language of their response indicates a decision, not a disruption." He held up the printout. "Anyone who wants to read the full text can. Ren has copies."

The silence wasn't dramatic. It was computational. Thirty-five brains running the same calculation at different speeds, arriving at the same answer by different routes. Some got there in seconds — the ones who'd already been hoarding, already bracing, already building the interior architecture of a life without external support. Some took longer. A few looked at the sky, as though the supply shuttle might materialize if they checked at the right moment.

"How long do we have?" someone asked. Cole didn't track who. The question came from the middle of the group, from the anonymous center where individual voices blurred into collective need.

"Food: six weeks at current ration. Eight if we adjust. Dana's agricultural program is our primary food source going forward. The native species she's mapped will sustain us if we expand the plots and manage the

growing cycle correctly." He looked at Dana, standing at the edge of the group, arms crossed, face still. "Water is stable. The channel drainage system is reliable. Medical is the pressure point. Haruki."

Haruki stepped forward. Spoke the way he always spoke — gentle, precise, clinical only when the clinical was the mercy. "We have antibiotics for approximately six weeks. Anti-inflammatories for four. Anesthetics for two, maybe three procedures. After that, we're working with what the planet provides. Dana and I have identified native compounds with analgesic and antimicrobial properties. They're not substitutes. They're alternatives."

The word sat in the air. Alternatives. The medical version of Asterlyne's "adaptive resource management." The colony was being told to adapt, by people they trusted, using the same logic the company had deployed. Except Haruki meant it honestly, and Asterlyne hadn't, and the colonists could tell the difference. Trust lived in the gap between those two uses of the same word.

Ren spoke last. She talked about the council's plan — expanded food production, resource sharing protocols, a medical rationing system Haruki had designed. She talked about the structures they'd built and the systems that worked. She didn't talk about the contract, or the arbitration clause, or the fact that the company's dispute mechanism was designed to be unreachable. That was Cole's weight. She carried the forward-looking part. He carried the closed door.

The meeting ended. People dispersed. Some went to work. Some went to their shelters and didn't come out for hours. The colony absorbed the information the way it absorbed everything — unevenly, individually, in the privacy of thirty-five separate reckonings with the same fact.

The fights started within the week.

The first fight was over food. Two colonists in the supply shelter, one accusing the other of taking an extra ration. Ren broke it up. The accusation was true — the accused had taken a protein bar beyond his allocation. The accuser had been watching because she was considering doing the same thing. The fight wasn't about a protein bar. It was about the architecture of scarcity, and the way scarcity made surveillance into survival and generosity into risk.

The second fight was worse. A construction crew argument about shelter maintenance priorities that escalated into shoving, then a thrown tool, then Haruki treating a laceration above someone's eye while Cole stood in the doorway and tried to calculate whether the energy spent on anger was a net loss the colony could absorb.

The hoarding accelerated. Cole found a cache under a colonist's cot — three days of rations, a water bottle, a thermal blanket. He didn't confiscate it. He sat with the colonist, a woman named Val, who'd been an accountant on Earth and had signed the charter because her firm had automated her position and her severance didn't cover the gap between unemployment and homelessness. Val didn't apologize for the cache. She looked at Cole with the expression of someone who'd done the math and found the same answer he had.

"I know," she said. "I know it doesn't help."

"It doesn't help," Cole confirmed.

"But I can see it. I can touch it. It's mine."

Cole understood. Scarcity reduced people to their most primitive accounting — what's mine, what's yours, what I can hold in my hands. The communal systems Ren had built were social technology, fragile and dependent on the belief that the group was stronger than the individual. When that belief cracked, the technology failed. People didn't stop being communal because they were selfish. They stopped because the math no longer supported it.

He left Val's cache where it was. Told Ren. Ren disagreed — said the caches undermined the rationing system, that transparency was the only way to maintain trust. Cole said trust was already gone. What they were maintaining was function. The distinction mattered. You could function without trust. You couldn't function without food.

They compromised. Public inventory counts, weekly. Every colonist could see exactly what existed and exactly what was allocated. No confiscations. No punishments. Just the numbers, laid bare, so the math was shared even when the trust wasn't.

It slowed the hoarding. It didn't stop it. Nothing would stop it until the food supply stabilized, and the food supply wouldn't stabilize until Dana's expanded agricultural program produced enough to replace what Asterlyne would never send.

A colonist named Webb walked into the forest at dawn on Month 16, Day 9.

Cole learned about it from the perimeter check. The morning buddy-system rotation — two colonists per shift, four-hour circuits, the protocol Cole had built in Week One and reinforced after every death that originated beyond the markers — reported that Webb had left his shelter before first light, walked past the eastern perimeter, and continued into the spiral-trunked trees without stopping, without speaking to the team on watch, without taking water or supplies.

Webb was forty-one. Former logistics coordinator — one of the few colonists whose Earth career had any overlap with what the colony needed. He'd been competent. Steady. Not loud, not invisible. The kind of person who showed up for shifts, did his allocation, ate his ration, and went to sleep without complaint. He'd voted with the twenty-one during the relocation. He'd served on Ren's supply committee. He hadn't hoarded. He hadn't fought. He'd done everything right.

Cole organized the search party. Four colonists, armed with the makeshift tools that passed for weapons on a planet where the threats were biological and chemical rather than predatory. They followed Webb's trail through the understory — boot prints in the lavender soil, broken stems, a path that didn't zigzag or hesitate. He'd walked in a straight line. East. Away from the settlement, away from the channels, away from the perimeter and the systems and the numbers.

They searched for two days. On the second evening, Cole called it off. The forest was too large, the colony too small, and every person searching for Webb was a person not producing food, not maintaining infrastructure, not keeping the systems alive that kept the rest of them breathing.

Haruki found the body on Day 12. Three days after the search ended. Two kilometers east, at the base of a spiral-trunked tree that was wider than the shelters. Webb was sitting against the trunk, legs crossed, hands in his lap. No visible trauma. No signs of the planet's particular violences — no dissolution, no spore damage, no allergic cascade. He looked like a man who'd sat down and stopped.

Haruki's assessment was brief. Exposure. Dehydration. Possibly hypothermia during the night cycle. The specific cause was almost irrelevant. Webb hadn't died of the planet. He'd died of the absence of a reason to stay alive on it. He'd come to Parcel 16b looking for stability — a contract, a structure, a system that functioned — and found a planet that changed its rules every orbital cycle and a company that stopped sending supplies and a future that narrowed every time he looked at it. The accumulation had finally exceeded what his architecture could hold.

Cole stood over the body and did the thing he always did. The count.

Thirty-four.

He carried it back to the settlement with Haruki. They buried Webb near the eastern perimeter, in the soil between the markers and the tree line, the boundary between the world they'd built and the world that had

been here before them. Ren said a few words. Cole didn't. He stood at the edge of the group and watched the dirt fill in over a man who'd done everything right and died because doing everything right wasn't the same as having something to do it for.

That night, Cole sat in the comm shelter with the charter open on the terminal. The full document. Two hundred pages. He'd read it three times since landing — once in the onboarding center, once on the transit ship, once in Month 6 when the second cycle began. Each reading had revealed something the previous one hadn't. The contract was a living document in the worst sense — not because it changed, but because the reader changed, and the language shapeshifted against each new context.

He went to Clause 17. Dispute Resolution.

17.1: Any dispute arising under or in connection with this charter agreement shall be resolved exclusively through binding arbitration.

17.2: Arbitration shall be administered by the Asterlyne Corporate Arbitration Council (ACAC), in accordance with ACAC procedural rules as amended from time to time.

17.3: All arbitration filings must be submitted through the designated communications infrastructure provided under Section IX of this agreement.

17.4: The arbitration panel shall consist of three arbitrators selected by the ACAC from its approved roster.

17.5: The decision of the arbitration panel shall be final and binding on all parties, with no right of appeal.

He read 17.3 again. All arbitration filings must be submitted through the designated communications infrastructure. Section IX defined the communications infrastructure as the orbital relay satellite. The orbital relay satellite was Asterlyne property, maintained by Asterlyne, operated under Asterlyne protocols. To file a complaint against the company, you used the company's equipment, through the company's system, to reach the company's arbitration body, staffed by the company's appointees.

Clause 17.8: *"Asterlyne Corporation reserves the right to perform maintenance, modification, or temporary suspension of communications infrastructure as required for operational integrity. Such actions shall not constitute breach of charter obligations."*

They could shut down the relay. Call it maintenance. The arbitration clause required the relay. If the relay was down, the filing couldn't be made. If the filing couldn't be made, the dispute didn't exist. If the dispute didn't exist, the breach was theoretical. The system wasn't broken. The system was designed.

Cole scrolled to Section IX. Communications. Clause 9.1 through 9.7. Standard infrastructure provisions. Clause 9.8: "Communications services are provided on an as-available basis and are subject to modification at Asterlyne's sole discretion." As-available. Sole discretion. Eight words that turned a contractual right into a corporate courtesy.

He went back to Clause 12.8. The supply obligation. Read it with the filter of seventeen clauses of dispute resolution that funneled every complaint through a channel the company controlled.

"Asterlyne Corporation shall provide semi-annual resupply deliveries during Years Two through Five, contents to be determined by operational need assessments conducted in accordance with Appendix G."

Contents to be determined by operational need assessments. Who conducted the assessments? Appendix G, Paragraph 4: "Operational need assessments shall be performed by Asterlyne's Charter Support Division based on available data, including but not limited to field reports, environmental monitoring, and resource utilization metrics."

Available data. Field reports. The reports Dana was sending through her hidden comm unit — Cole didn't know that. But Elena had known something adjacent. Elena's Month 14 log entry, the one Cole had posted in the common shelter, the one Dana had read three times: *I am making us expendable by proving we are capable*. Elena had filed standard reports. Asterlyne had used them to calculate the minimum. The mechanism didn't need a spy. The mechanism was the system itself.

Cole closed the charter. Sat in the comm shelter in the dark, the terminal's standby light casting a pale rectangle on the wall. The hum of the trees pressed through the shelter walls. Outside, the colony was trying to sleep. Thirty-four people in shelters they'd built themselves on ground they didn't own, eating food the planet grudgingly provided, drinking water from channels carved by something that had been here before them and was gone.

No one was coming.

He'd known it intellectually since Month 13, when the delivery window closed and the sky stayed empty. He'd known it strategically since the Asterlyne response, when 247 words of corporate poetry confirmed that the absence was policy, not accident. But knowing a thing and understanding it were different operations, and understanding arrived now, in the comm shelter, in the dark, with the charter's language still scrolling behind his eyes.

There was no external recourse. The arbitration was unreachable. The comm relay was a leash. The supply obligation was a sentence that Asterlyne could render meaningless through the same document that established it. The contract was self-consuming — rights defined in one clause, neutralized in another, the architecture so dense that no single reading could hold the whole picture. You had to read it three times, four times, with the context of fifteen months on a planet the company had surveyed and abandoned and surveyed again, before the shape emerged.

The forty-seven had always been alone. From the moment they signed. From the moment Cole sat in that onboarding center and read two hundred pages while everyone else skimmed and initialed. The contract wasn't a ladder. It wasn't even a leash. It was a room with a door that opened inward, and the key was on the outside, and the lock was labeled "Dispute Resolution."

Except for one clause. One line buried in the middle of a document designed to be unread, written by lawyers who'd calculated the odds of anyone surviving long enough to invoke it.

Clause 9.4.2. Fifty-one percent of original signatories alive at the five-year mark. Twenty-four out of forty-seven. Land transfers in perpetuity.

The clause didn't require arbitration. Didn't require Asterlyne's approval. Didn't route through the comm relay or the corporate assessment process. It was self-executing. A trigger built into the contract's own logic, activated by a single condition: survival. The only right in the charter that the company couldn't adjudicate, delay, or redefine.

Because they'd never expected anyone to survive long enough to invoke it.

Cole sat in the dark. Thirty-four. He needed twenty-four. Ten lives of margin. Thirty-six months remaining. Every system on the planet trying to subtract from a number that had to hold.

He didn't feel hope. Hope was a word for people who hadn't read the contract. What he felt was closer to recognition — the cold clarity of seeing the entire board, every piece, every rule, and understanding that the game had exactly one winning move, and it was the one he'd identified on Day Zero in a corporate waiting room on Earth while forty-six other people skimmed and signed.

Stay alive. Keep them alive. Count the days.

He turned off the terminal. The pale rectangle on the wall disappeared. The hum of the trees was the only sound. Cole sat in it and let the recognition settle, not like comfort, but like a foundation. The kind of thing you could build on, if you were willing to build on something that cold.

Chapter 16 — "Fever"

The first case appeared on Month 17, Day 3.

A colonist named Dara woke with a temperature of 39.2, a dry cough, and a headache she described to Haruki as "a band across the front, like pressure." Haruki noted the symptoms, gave her water and the last of the ibuprofen he'd been rationing since Month 12, and told her to rest. He didn't quarantine her. There was nothing in the symptom profile that suggested contagion — fever and headache on Parcel 16b could mean anything. Atmospheric spore exposure. Soil contact. A native compound triggering an immune response. The planet had a dozen ways to make a person sick, and they'd cataloged fewer than half.

By Day 5, there were four more cases. By Day 7, eleven.

Haruki quarantined on Day 5. Too late. The pathogen was already through the colony, carried by shared meals, shared tools, shared air in shelters that had never been designed for airborne containment. Cole watched the numbers climb and did what he always did — built a system. He divided the settlement into zones. Healthy colonists in the western shelters. Symptomatic in the eastern two, closest to the medical shelter. A corridor of open ground between them that people crossed only with purpose and speed.

The system was sound. The system was also irrelevant. By the time he implemented it, half the colony had been exposed.

Haruki's diagnosis came on Day 8, delivered in the medical shelter to Cole and Ren while three colonists lay on cots behind them, breathing in the shallow rhythm of people whose bodies were fighting something they couldn't see.

"It's not alien," Haruki said. He was standing at his workbench — a repurposed equipment crate fitted with a flat surface and the portable diagnostic kit that had been insufficient since Day One. His hands were steady. They were always steady. "The pathogen is human. Influenza variant, mutated. Our closed population, limited genetic diversity, recycled air in the shelters — the virus has been cycling through us in subclinical form since transit, probably. Mutating in a biome it wasn't evolved for. The planet's atmosphere has trace compounds that interact with human respiratory tissue in ways we don't fully understand. Something accelerated the mutation."

"How bad?" Cole asked.

Haruki looked at him. The look said more than the words that followed, the way Haruki's looks always said more. He communicated diagnosis through eye contact before he communicated it through language, as though the clinical precision was a translation of something he'd already understood at a level below speech.

"For healthy adults with adequate nutrition and rest, the fever runs five to seven days. Unpleasant. Survivable. For anyone with compromised respiratory function, weakened immune reserves, or pre-existing injury —" He paused. Not for drama. Haruki didn't do drama. He paused because the next sentence required accuracy, and accuracy in medicine sometimes meant waiting for the right word. "The risk is significant."

Cole heard the categories and his mind populated them instantly. Compromised respiratory function: Patricia, whose cough had started during the relocation and never fully resolved. Eight months of low-grade bronchial irritation, treated with Dana's botanical tinctures, managed but not cured. Pre-existing injury: James, whose compound fracture from the relocation had healed wrong, whose immune system had spent months fighting the inflammation that Haruki managed with a dwindling supply of anti-inflammatories that the supply drop would have replenished if the supply drop had come. Weakened immune reserves: half the colony. Everyone who'd been rationing themselves so others could eat. Everyone who'd been sleeping in

shifts, working double rotations, burning through caloric reserves that were never replenished because the planet's food sources sustained life without restoring it.

"Dana," Cole said.

"I've sent her the pathogen data. She's already working."

Dana was in the research shelter, surrounded by the organized chaos of someone racing a clock they couldn't see. Sample containers lined the bench. Three native plant specimens were laid out on the flat surface, root systems exposed, leaves separated into individual piles. The portable analysis kit — the same one she'd used to crack the soil cycle, the creep composition, the channel network's mineral biology — was running a comparison that made a soft clicking sound every four seconds as it processed.

She didn't look up when Cole entered. She was holding a leaf up to the lamplight, studying the vein structure with the intensity of someone reading a sentence that contained a word she almost recognized.

"Haruki sent the viral profile," she said. "I've been cross-referencing against the botanical database I've built. There are six native species with compounds that interact with human biology. Three are toxic. Two are inert. One —" She set the leaf down. Picked up a root segment. "This one has antiviral properties. I identified it during Month 9 when I was cataloging the dormancy-phase species. The compound inhibits viral replication in the lab samples. Slowly. Not like Earth antivirals — it doesn't kill the pathogen. It slows it down enough for the immune system to catch up."

"How slowly?"

"Three to four days to reach therapeutic concentration in the body. The fever runs five to seven. If I can get it into people within the first forty-eight hours of symptoms, it shortens the course by two days and reduces peak temperature by about a degree and a half."

Cole processed the math. A degree and a half was the difference between a fever the body managed and a fever that cooked the brain. Two days was the difference between an immune system that held and one that collapsed. Dana's compound wasn't a cure. It was a margin. A thin one. But margins were what Cole worked with.

"How much can you produce?"

"I've been growing this species in the secondary plots since Month 11. I have enough root stock to treat twenty people. Maybe twenty-five if I reduce the concentration and extend the interval."

"Thirty-four people in the colony."

"Twenty-five doses."

The gap sat between them. Nine people who wouldn't get the compound. Nine people whose immune systems would fight the virus alone, at full strength, for the full duration. Cole's mind went where it always went — to the triage. Who needed it most. Who could survive without it. The calculation was automatic, a reflex built into him the way warehouse managers learned to sort inventory by urgency without thinking about it. The bodies on the cots weren't inventory. He knew that. He'd been learning that for seventeen months. But the reflex still fired.

"Prioritize the compromised," he said. "Patricia. James. Anyone Haruki flags as high-risk. Then the infrastructure-critical — you, Haruki, Ren, the water team. Everyone else gets it if there's enough."

Dana nodded. She'd already been thinking the same thing. She was a scientist; triage was data-driven allocation by another name. She went back to the root stock, began the extraction process, and Cole left her to it.

Hana died on Day 11.

She wasn't in the priority group. Not compromised, not infrastructure-critical, not on Haruki's high-risk list. Cole's triage had placed her in the tier that received the compound if supply allowed. Supply hadn't allowed. She'd been working double agricultural shifts since Month 12, splitting her rations with a younger colonist who needed the calories more, sleeping in four-hour intervals in a shelter she kept under-insulated because others needed the material. Nine months of quiet subtraction. The virus found a body that had been running on less than minimum, and a body running on deficit fought the way anything fought when the reserves were gone — briefly, and then not at all.

Haruki sat with her through the last hours. Cole was there at the end — standing in the doorway of the medical shelter, watching Haruki hold Hana's hand while her breathing went from shallow to intermittent to still. She was forty-one. Former agricultural researcher who'd signed the charter when her university's funding collapsed. She'd volunteered for Dana's experimental planting rotations before anyone else. She carried soil samples in her pockets the way other people carried worry stones, rubbing them between her fingers during council meetings, her mind already in the next growing cycle. Cole had seen her do it a hundred times without understanding it was her version of counting.

The colony was at thirty-three. Cole counted it before he could stop himself. Before the grief or the anger or whatever the feeling was that tightened his throat when Haruki pulled the blanket up and said, softly, the way he said everything, "She's gone." The number came first. It always came first. Thirty-three. He needed twenty-four. Nine of margin. The number should have felt like enough. It didn't feel like anything. It was just a number in a room where a woman had stopped breathing.

James died two days later. Day 13. The compound fracture had been managed for eight months on a diminishing supply of anti-inflammatories and Haruki's precise, exhausting regimen of physical therapy and wound management. James's body had been fighting two battles — the fracture's chronic inflammation and the daily caloric deficit of colony life — and when the virus arrived, it found a system that had nothing left to give. The fever spiked to 40.8 on Day 10. Dana's compound brought it down to 39.4. Haruki did everything a doctor with limited supplies and unlimited attention could do. James's immune system, hollowed out by eight months of fighting on two fronts, surrendered on the third.

He was thirty-six. Former construction foreman. He'd taken the compound fracture during the relocation — Night Five, carrying a shelter beam across uneven ground in the dark, the kind of work that should have been done by equipment they didn't have. He'd never complained about the pain. He'd complained about the rationing, about the council's decisions, about the weather and the food and the color of the sky, because James was the kind of man who complained about everything except the thing that was actually killing him. Cole had respected that without understanding it. Now he understood. Complaining about small things was how James kept the large thing from becoming real.

Thirty-two.

The number arrived and Cole held it the way he held all the numbers — in the center of his chest, behind the sternum, where it sat with the weight of a stone he couldn't put down and wouldn't put down because the weight was the point. The weight was what kept him counting.

Joss Carver's fever started on Day 9. Late onset. He'd been in the healthy zone, working water filtration, staying away from the medical shelter the way twenty-three-year-olds stayed away from things that scared them — not by avoiding them but by being aggressively useful somewhere else. He'd doubled his shifts. Carried water. Cleaned the filtration membranes Cole had been rationing since the supply drop didn't come. He'd worked until his hands cracked and his shoulders ached and his body, running on inadequate food and accumulated sleep debt, finally opened a door the virus walked through.

Haruki put him in the medical shelter on Day 9. Cole saw the name on the intake log and felt something shift in his chest that wasn't the stone of numbers. Something less organized. Less useful.

The fever climbed. 38.5 on Day 9. 39.1 on Day 10. 39.8 on Day 11, the day Hana died across the shelter, separated from Joss by three cots and a curtain that didn't block sound. Joss heard Hana's breathing stop. He didn't say anything. His eyes were open, glassy, fixed on the shelter ceiling, and Cole, sitting on an equipment crate next to the cot, watched the knowledge pass across Joss's face like weather.

Dana's compound reached Joss on Day 10. Full dose, within the window. His body was young, resilient, undamaged by chronic injury or eight months of bronchial inflammation. The compound should have worked the way it worked on the other healthy adults — peak fever reduction, shortened course, survivable misery. But Joss's immune system had been running on empty since before the virus arrived. The doubled shifts, the inadequate calories, the sleep he'd traded for productivity. He'd been eating his own reserves for weeks, and the virus found an account with nothing in it.

Day 12. Temperature 40.1. Haruki's face when he read the thermometer was the steadiest version of fear Cole had ever seen — not the absence of it but the absolute containment of it, the way a dam holds water not by being unaffected but by being engineered to bear the pressure without moving. Haruki adjusted the compound dosage. Applied cold compresses. Elevated Joss's legs to manage the blood pressure drop that came with sustained high fever. He did everything a doctor does when the medicine is working too slowly and the body is burning too fast.

Cole stayed.

He'd been in the medical shelter since Day 10. Not continuously — he left for council meetings, for the brief daily briefings with Ren about the colony's functional status, for the twenty minutes each morning when he walked the perimeter and counted shelters and told himself the systems were holding. But he came back. Every time. Sat on the equipment crate next to Joss's cot and waited for the thermometer to say something different.

He didn't know when Joss had become the person he sat with. The kid had been a name on a manifest at first — twenty-two, over-prepared, nervous, the type who asked too many questions during orientation because silence terrified him more than looking foolish. Cole had categorized him during transit the way he categorized everyone: useful, marginal, liability. Joss had been marginal. Young. Untested. His anxiety was a resource drain — people spent energy reassuring him instead of working.

Seventeen months had changed the categorization. Not because Cole's system had been wrong but because the variables had shifted. Joss had found water on the second day, identifying a mineral signature in the channel drainage that improved filtration. He'd built the secondary membrane system during Month 8 when the primary filters started degrading. He'd taught two other colonists the maintenance protocol, creating redundancy in a skill set the colony couldn't afford to lose. The nervous kid who asked too many questions had become a quiet, competent twenty-three-year-old who asked the right questions and then built the answers.

Cole had watched it happen. Had watched it the way he imagined fathers watched things — from a distance that felt chosen but wasn't, with a pride that had no right to exist but did anyway, rooted not in ownership but in witness.

Now he sat next to the cot and listened to Joss breathe.

Day 13. Night. The worst one.

Joss's temperature hit 40.4 at sundown. Haruki was treating James in the adjacent section — James, who would die before morning, whose body was already in the process of surrender though no one had named it

yet. Haruki had left instructions: cold compresses every thirty minutes, small sips of water if Joss could swallow, and a dose of Dana's compound at midnight that represented the last of the concentrated extract before she had to switch to the diluted batch.

Cole did the compresses. Wrung the cloth in the basin of channel water, folded it, placed it on Joss's forehead. The water was cool, mineral-rich, slightly cloudy with the dissolved sediment that gave it its particular taste. Joss flinched each time the cloth touched his skin. His body was so hot that the cool water felt like ice to him. His hands gripped the edges of the cot. His fingers were white at the knuckles.

"Talk to me," Joss said. His voice was cracked. Thin. The voice of someone whose throat had been raw for four days.

"About what?"

"Anything. I can't — when it's quiet I can hear my own heartbeat and it's too fast and I start counting it and then I can't stop counting."

Cole understood that. The tyranny of counting. He'd been doing it since Day Zero.

"What do you want to hear?"

"I don't care. Tell me about Earth. Tell me about before."

Cole sat with the question. Before. The word covered thirty-eight years of a life he'd left because it had stopped containing reasons. Warehouse floors and shift schedules and an apartment that shrank every month and a custody hearing where a judge explained, with professional compassion, that an absent father was a concept, not a parent. Before was a place Cole had organized into boxes the way he organized inventory — labeled, shelved, accounted for, never opened.

"I have a daughter," he said.

The words left his mouth and sat in the air between them, surprised at their own existence. Cole hadn't said them aloud since landing. He'd thought them — every day, multiple times, the way a tongue returns to a broken tooth. But thinking and saying were different operations. Thinking was private. Saying was a door that opened in both directions.

Joss turned his head on the cot. His eyes were fever-bright, glassy, but present. Focused on Cole's face with the intensity of someone who understood they were being given something.

"What's her name?"

"Lily."

"How old?"

"She's ten. She likes drawing horses. She thinks I'm on a work trip."

The lie. The same lie he'd written in the message that took him two hours to compose in Month 6 — three sentences about trees and distance and nothing about why. The lie that made the distance manageable because the truth made it monstrous. He hadn't gone on a work trip. He'd calculated the odds of his own survival, signed a contract that bet his life against a corporate clause, and traveled to a planet where the air smelled like ozone and the trees hummed at frequencies below hearing, because staying on Earth meant watching his daughter grow up through a window that got smaller every year, and leaving meant the window might open again in five years if enough people didn't die.

He'd never said that to anyone. Not to Ren, who'd seen through his deflections since transit. Not to Haruki, whose diagnostic gaze read emotional pathology as fluently as physical. Not to the data core in his shelter

where Elena Vasik's ghost narrated a parallel failure with a scientist's precision. He'd said it to nobody because saying it would require examining the logic, and the logic, examined, looked like this: he had abandoned his daughter in order to earn the right to return to her. The math was sound. The math was always sound. And the math was the ugliest thing he'd ever built.

"Is she like you?" Joss asked.

Cole looked at the kid — twenty-three, burning with fever, dehydrated, possibly dying, and asking whether a ten-year-old girl on a planet he'd never see resembled the man sitting on an equipment crate holding a damp cloth. The question was generous in a way that Cole didn't deserve and couldn't deflect.

"I don't know," he said. "I wasn't there enough to find out."

Joss was quiet for a while. His breathing was audible — that labored, conscious breathing of someone whose body was demanding more air than the lungs wanted to provide. The medical shelter's walls flexed slightly in the night wind. Outside, the trees hummed.

"You'll find out," Joss said. "When we get through this."

When. Not if. The kid was running a 40.4 fever and he said when. Cole felt the crack in his chest widen — not the stone of numbers, not the weight of the count, but something underneath it. Something the numbers had been sitting on top of, pressing down, keeping sealed. The thing beneath the math.

He put the cloth on Joss's forehead. Joss flinched and gripped the cot's edge. Cole didn't take his hand. Didn't say anything reassuring. Sat there in the dark with a twenty-three-year-old who might die before morning and a ten-year-old who existed in a message he'd sent eleven months ago across a distance measured in light-years, and felt the math crack.

Not break. The math didn't break. The math was structural — it held the colony, it held the clause, it held the count. But the thing the math was for — the reason underneath the calculation — shifted. Moved. Became visible through the crack the way light becomes visible through a fracture in a wall.

He wasn't counting to twenty-four because twenty-four was the number that triggered the clause. He was counting because every number was a face, every face a person who was alive because the systems held, the compound worked, Haruki's hands were steady, and Dana's plants grew in the right soil at the right time. Every number was someone who breathed and ate and argued and slept and woke up and did it again, not because a contract told them to but because they were still here and being here was the thing. The only thing.

Cole sat in the medical shelter and held a cloth against a burning forehead and understood, for the first time in seventeen months, that the math had never been the reason. The math was the tool. The reason was the kid on the cot. The woman who'd died that morning. The man dying across the shelter. The thirty-two people in the shelters outside, sleeping or not sleeping, afraid or not afraid, alive.

The reason was that he didn't want them to die.

Not for the count. Not for the clause. Not for the arithmetic that turned survival into ownership. He didn't want them to die because they were his, the way Lily was his — not by possession but by proximity, by shared oxygen, by the accumulated weight of seventeen months of keeping them breathing. He'd become responsible for them the way you become responsible for anything: by staying.

Joss's fever broke on Day 15.

Cole was there. He'd been there for six days. Ren had run the colony in his absence — the systems he'd built were robust enough to function without him, which was either a testament to their design or evidence that

he wasn't as essential as he'd convinced himself. Ren handled it with the pragmatic efficiency that made her dangerous and necessary. She didn't comment on Cole's absence from operations. She understood what was happening in the medical shelter without being told, the way she understood most things — by reading the structure of the situation and inferring the human architecture inside it.

The fever dropped from 39.6 to 38.1 between midnight and dawn. Haruki checked it twice because the first reading seemed wrong — too good, too fast, the kind of improvement that sometimes preceded a final spike. The second reading held. Joss's body, young and stubborn and running on whatever reserve a twenty-three-year-old's cells kept hidden for exactly this kind of crisis, had turned the corner.

Joss slept. Actually slept — not the fitful, fever-driven half-consciousness of the past week but real sleep, his breathing deep and even, his hands unclenched for the first time in days. Cole watched him for twenty minutes. Counted his breaths the way he counted everything. This time the counting felt different. Not inventory. Not triage. Just attention.

Haruki came over. Stood next to Cole. Looked at the sleeping kid with the expression of a doctor who'd won a fight he'd expected to lose.

"He's going to be all right," Haruki said.

"The others?"

"The compound is working. Slowly. Most of the active cases are past peak. We'll lose the next few days to recovery, but the fever's breaking across the colony." He paused. Did the thing Haruki did when he was transitioning from clinical to personal — a small shift in posture, a softening around the eyes that most people wouldn't notice. "You should eat something."

"I'm fine."

"You haven't eaten in thirty hours. You're not fine. You're functional, which is a different thing." Haruki looked at him directly. "He's going to wake up. You should be standing when he does. Standing requires calories."

Cole almost smiled. Haruki's mercy was always practical. The man didn't say take care of yourself because he cared about you. He said eat because your body is a system and systems require input. It was the kindest form of pragmatism Cole had ever encountered.

He stood. His knees ached — six days on an equipment crate, moving only to wring cloths and check temperatures and walk to council meetings where he contributed nothing because his mind was in the medical shelter. His back had stiffened into a posture that wasn't quite standing and wasn't quite sitting but was the shape of a man who'd been holding vigil.

He walked outside.

The settlement was doing its morning thing — people moving between shelters, the water team running the filtration check, smoke from the cooking area where someone was heating the bitter tubers that passed for breakfast. The sky was pale green. The spiral-trunked trees at the settlement's edge caught the early light and cast long shadows that rotated slowly as the planet turned, the shadows moving in patterns that were alien and, after seventeen months, almost familiar.

Thirty-two people. Two dead. The rest recovering, or recovered, or never sick in the first place. Thirty-two people eating and walking and working and being alive on a morning that looked like every other morning except that Cole was seeing it differently.

He'd walked out of the medical shelter and the count had come — automatic, reflexive, the first thing his mind did when it encountered the colony. Thirty-two. But the number didn't settle into the place it usually

settled, the cold ledger behind his sternum where the count lived alongside the target and the margin and the days remaining. The number went somewhere else. Somewhere less organized. Somewhere that felt more like the crack in the wall of the medical shelter where the light came through.

Thirty-two people he didn't want to lose.

Not thirty-two units of a survival equation. Not the margin between here and clause 9.4.2. Thirty-two people whose names he knew, whose habits he'd memorized, whose losses he'd carried from the signing room to here. Hana, who carried soil in her pockets. James, who complained about everything except the thing that killed him. Webb, who'd done everything right. Lev and Priya and Vogel and Osei and Farin and Sarah and Lin and Thomas and Marcus and Thomas Chen and Noor and Suri. Fifteen names. Fifteen subtractions from a number that had started at forty-seven and now sat at thirty-two and would keep subtracting because the planet didn't care about arithmetic and neither did disease and neither did the slow erosion of people who ran out of reasons before they ran out of breath.

Cole stood in the morning light and felt the math crack wider. The structure held. The count continued. But the reason underneath it — the cold engine that had driven him since Day Zero, the calculator that turned people into margin — that mechanism had shifted. Not failed. Shifted. The way a building shifts on its foundation during a seismic event. Still standing. But the angles were different now, and the light came in through places it hadn't before.

He went to the cooking area. Ate a bowl of the bitter tubers. Tasted them for the first time in months — the chemical undertone, the gritty texture, the warmth. Sat with three colonists who were eating in silence, the companionable silence of people who had survived the same week and didn't need to talk about it. He ate with them. Let the silence hold.

Then he went back to work.

Chapter 17 — "Elena, Year Two"

Cole read the last of Elena Vasik's Year Two logs on a night when the settlement was quiet and the hum of the trees had dropped to the frequency he felt in his molars.

He was in his shelter. The data core sat on the makeshift desk he'd built from salvaged equipment panels — the same desk where he tracked the count, wrote messages to Lily, and ran the calculations that kept thirty-two people eating. The data core's screen was small, its backlight dying in the way all Asterlyne equipment died: slowly, predictably, without apology.

He'd been rationing Elena the way he rationed everything. A few entries at a time, spaced across months, taken when the colony's situation aligned with hers closely enough that the data was useful. Her Year One had been a map. Her Year Two had been a warning. What remained was the ending.

He opened the files past Month 15.

Elena's colony had been nine at the start of Year Two. The entries from Months 13 through 15 — the ones Cole had read during the creep crisis — had documented the dormancy phase, the food shortage, the biological mat at the forest edge. Clinical language, specific data, a scientist still doing science.

Month 16 was different.

Month 16, Day 4. The creep has consumed the eastern shelter line. We're relocating again. Third time. Running out of room. Eight of us. Katya isn't speaking to anyone. Not hostile. Just finished. She does her work and eats her portion and sleeps with her back to the rest of us. I don't think she's made a decision to withdraw. I think she's run out of the specific energy that connecting to other people requires, and without resupply of that energy, the function has shut down. I've seen equipment do the same thing.

Cole read it in the half-dark. Katya wasn't a person he knew. She was a data point in a dead woman's log, a name attached to a behavior Cole recognized because he'd been watching it happen for twenty months. The slow shutdown. Not despair — something more mechanical than despair. A conservation response. The organism reducing its outputs to match its inputs, and social connection was the first line item cut because it cost the most and returned the least in immediate survival terms.

He'd seen it in his own colony. After the fever. After Hana and James. The thirty-two who remained had pulled closer in some ways — shared meals continued, the council met, Ren's systems held. But the texture had changed. People talked less. Laughed less. The jokes that had emerged during the middle months, the ones Cole didn't always understand, had gone quiet. The colony wasn't fracturing. It was dimming.

Month 17, Day 1. The creep isn't something we can fight. It's something we can only move ahead of. I've stopped thinking of it as a threat and started thinking of it as a tide. You don't fight a tide. You build above the waterline. But we've been building above waterlines for seventeen months and the water keeps rising and the tools keep breaking and the people keep getting lighter.

Getting lighter. Cole sat with that. He knew what Elena meant. Not physically, though that too. Lighter in the way people lose substance when the thing holding them together — the shared project, the collective bet, the daily act of choosing this over nothing — starts losing its gravity. People don't leave a group by walking away. They leave by becoming less present while still standing in the same room.

Month 18. Month 19. The entries compressed. Shorter paragraphs. Fewer data points. The spectrometer readings and soil analyses that had filled Elena's early logs disappeared. She'd stopped measuring the planet. She was measuring the people.

Month 19. Seven. Daniil died last week. Exposure. He was experienced. He knew the thermal protocols. He walked the perimeter at dusk the way he'd walked it two hundred times, and this time his body didn't generate enough heat to compensate for the temperature drop because his body had been running at deficit for four months and there was nothing left to burn. I wrote "exposure" in the log. The real cause of death is accumulation.

Seven. Cole's mind did the thing it always did. Elena's colony: fourteen to eleven to nine to eight to seven. Months of subtraction. Not dramatic. Not violent. Just the steady arithmetic of a group running below the threshold where loss could be absorbed.

Month 20. Six. Anya fell. Simple. The kind of fall that breaks an ankle on Earth and gets you a walking boot and six weeks of jokes about clumsiness. Here it broke her ankle and the bone didn't set right because Daniil had been the one who knew field medicine and Daniil was dead and I am a geologist, not a doctor. The infection started on day three. I tried. I had compounds. None of them worked fast enough. She died on day eight and the five of us sat with her and nobody said anything because there was nothing to say that we hadn't already said for the sixth and seventh and eighth and ninth and tenth time.

Cole closed his eyes. Opened them. The data core's backlight flickered, the screen dimming and recovering in a rhythm that felt almost organic, like something breathing.

He scrolled forward. The entries got shorter.

Month 22. Five. No deaths. The absence of death as an event worth recording.

Month 24. Four. Katya. Not exposure, not infection, not the planet. She walked into the forest at dawn and didn't walk back. I sent Tomas to find her. He found her. She was sitting against one of the spiral-trunked trees with her eyes closed and her hands in her lap and she wasn't dead yet but she wasn't coming back. Tomas carried her to the shelter. She died that night. Her body gave up before she did, or after she did, depending on how you measure it.

Cole had met people who'd stopped. On Earth, in the warehouse circuits, in the housing blocks where the jobs ran out before the rent did. People who went through the motions with a precision that masked the fact that the engine driving the motions had been switched off. The body could run on habit for a long time. Weeks. Months. The appearance of function without the function itself. Katya had been running on habit since Month 16, when Elena had noted the withdrawal. Eight months of mechanical existence, and then the mechanism stopped.

Month 25. Month 26. Three people. Elena, Tomas, and someone she referred to only as M.

Month 26. Three. We don't eat together anymore. Not a decision. Just the natural consequence of there being no reason to eat together when the meal is the same, the room is the same, and the conversation was exhausted four months ago. I eat at my desk. Tomas eats in his shelter. M eats wherever M happens to be, which is a question I've stopped asking because asking requires an energy I'm conserving for other functions.

I wonder if this is how colonies die. Not in a single catastrophic event but in the slow subtraction of the things that make a group of people a group instead of a collection of individuals who happen to occupy the same coordinates. The meals go first. Then the conversations. Then the eye contact. Then the physical proximity. You drift apart inside a space small enough to hold you together, because togetherness is a choice, and choices require calories you don't have.

Cole read it three times.

He thought about the common area at the settlement where thirty-two people still ate together most evenings. Where Ren still called council meetings and the arguments were still real, still heated, still

evidence that people cared enough to disagree. He thought about Joss, recovering from the fever, teaching water filter maintenance to two younger colonists with a patience that looked like something he'd learned from watching Haruki. He thought about Garrett Polk sitting in the common area after dinner, not talking to anyone in particular but present, occupying space in a room because occupying space in a room was different from occupying space in a shelter alone.

The colony was dimming. But it hadn't gone dark. Not yet. The distance between dimming and dark was the distance Elena had traveled in the months between sixteen and twenty-six, and Cole was reading the map of that distance in a dead woman's handwriting.

The last entry he read was dated Month 26, Day 11. Three people left. Elena, Tomas, and M. The scientist's precision had thinned to something rawer — not data anymore, not observation. Diagnosis.

The planet isn't killing us. We stopped being worth keeping alive. Not to the planet — the planet doesn't have an opinion. To ourselves. We stopped investing in each other. We stopped eating together, stopped arguing, stopped making the daily thousand small decisions that turn a group of people into a community. A community is an act of will maintained against entropy, and when the will fails, the entropy doesn't need to work very hard. It was already winning. It was always winning. We just stopped pushing back.

I don't blame the planet. I don't blame Asterlyne, though they built the conditions. I don't blame the people who died, or the ones who withdrew, or Katya, who walked into the forest because the forest was quieter than the silence between us. I blame the fact that survival isn't enough. You can keep a body alive on calories and shelter and the basic mechanics of biological persistence, and the person inside that body will still find a way to die if there's nothing to survive for beyond the act of surviving.

We had data. We had the soil cycle and the weather patterns and the creep maps and enough native food to keep six people breathing. We had everything except a reason to breathe together.

Cole closed the data core. Set it on the desk. There were more entries — the logs continued past Month 26, into whatever came after three. He didn't open them. The diagnosis was enough. The ending could wait.

She'd been smarter than him. Better trained. More disciplined. She'd had the data, the patterns, the intelligence to read the planet correctly. Everything Dana had given Cole, Elena had earned on her own. And it hadn't been enough. Not because the planet was too hostile or the supplies too thin or the deaths too many. Because the people had stopped being people together.

Fourteen became nine became six became three.

And Elena, with two people still breathing beside her, had written the diagnosis with a scientist's clarity: *We stopped being worth keeping alive.*

Not to the planet. To each other.

Cole didn't sleep that night. He sat at his desk and looked at the data core and thought about what he'd been doing for twenty months and what he'd failed to do.

He'd built systems. Water collection, food rationing, shelter rotation, perimeter protocols, the medical triage that had kept Haruki functioning, the agricultural priorities that had kept Dana productive, the council structure Ren had designed and he'd learned to trust. The colony's infrastructure was sound. The mechanics of survival were holding.

The mechanics of survival weren't the same thing as survival.

He thought about the common meals growing quieter. About the colonists who ate faster now, who carried portions back to their shelters, who came to council meetings because the schedule said to and left when

the agenda was done without staying to talk. He thought about the perimeter checks that used to be social — two people walking and talking, the buddy system doubling as the only time some colonists had a sustained conversation — and were now silent. Efficient. Professional. Dead.

He thought about Joss saying *when*, not *if*, in the medical shelter with a 40.4 fever. The crack in the math. The light through the fracture. Thirty-two people he didn't want to lose — not for the count, not for the clause, but because they were his. And he'd been so focused on keeping them alive that he'd missed the thing Elena had seen: alive wasn't enough.

The colony needed to know what had happened to Elena's people. Not the summary he'd given them in the Month 7 assembly — fourteen people, same data, stopped eating together, down to six. Not the selected log entries he'd been pinning to the common shelter board, curated for usefulness, stripped of the personal. They needed the actual story. The full arc of a group that had everything except the one thing that mattered.

He talked to Ren first. Morning, before the colony woke. She was checking the water system's overnight readings in the equipment shelter, her hands moving over the valves with the automatic competence of someone who'd been maintaining the same infrastructure for twenty months.

"I want to share Elena's logs," Cole said. "The Year Two entries. All of them."

Ren didn't stop what she was doing. She adjusted a valve, noted a reading on her tablet, moved to the next junction. Cole had learned that Ren processed information physically — she kept her hands busy while her mind worked, and the quality of her response was proportional to the time she spent not looking at you.

"Why now?"

"Because we're heading where she went."

Ren looked at him then. Not with surprise. With the specific attention she gave to things that confirmed a suspicion she'd been carrying. "The dimming."

She'd noticed it too. Of course she had. Ren read social architecture the way Dana read soil chemistry — through pattern recognition, through the small data points that aggregated into a diagnosis.

"Not the crisis kind," Ren said. "Not like the factions in Month 4 or the hoarding in Month 7. This is different."

"Quieter."

"Quieter," she agreed. "People are still functioning. The systems work. But the energy behind the functioning is different. People used to argue at council because they cared. Now they agree because it's faster."

Cole nodded. "Elena's colony didn't break. It dimmed. And by the time Elena recognized what was happening, the pattern was too deep to reverse."

Ren closed the valve she was working on. Set down the tablet. Crossed her arms — her thinking posture, the one that meant she was weighing a principle against a pragmatic concern and trying to find the space where both could exist.

"Which entries?"

"The ones about what happened when they stopped being a group. The meals. The silence. What Katya did. What it looked like from inside."

"That's not data. That's a dead woman's grief."

"It's both."

Ren studied him. Cole stood with it. He'd learned to stand inside Ren's scrutiny the way he'd learned to stand inside the planet's weather — not comfortably, but without flinching.

"You're going to use Elena's story to scare them into staying connected," Ren said. "Show them the worst case. The ghost story. What happens to a colony that stops trying."

"Yes."

"That's manipulative."

"That's leadership."

The words landed between them like a stone dropped into still water. Ren's expression didn't change. She held the eye contact the way she held difficult positions in council — not with aggression but with the specific patience of someone who believed that truth required sustained attention.

"Leadership that depends on fear isn't leadership," Ren said. "It's management."

"Leadership that ignores information because it might scare people isn't leadership either. It's cowardice."

Ren was quiet for a long moment. The water system hummed. Outside, someone was starting the morning cooking routine — the sound of the fire being stoked, the clatter of the cookware they'd fabricated from salvaged materials.

"Both," she said. "You're right and it's manipulative. Those aren't mutually exclusive."

"I know."

"So you'll do it knowing that."

"I'll do it knowing that."

Ren picked up her tablet. Went back to the valve readings. Cole waited, because with Ren the answer always came after the work resumed, never during the silence.

"Then I'll be there when you do," she said. "Because if you're going to show them what a colony looks like when it dies, someone needs to be standing next to you showing them what one looks like when it doesn't."

He shared them that evening.

Not at a formal assembly. Those had a weight the colony associated with crisis — bad numbers, rationing changes, the kind of information that arrived in a room where everyone was standing because sitting meant you might not want to stand up after hearing it. Cole pinned the entries to the common shelter board the way he'd been doing for months, but this time he pinned all of them. Month 16 through Month 26. Twelve entries on the colony's limited paper, the ink fading at the edges, the text dense and small because Cole had fit each entry onto a single sheet.

He added nothing. No commentary, no framing, no logistics briefing to contextualize the data. Just Elena's words, in order, starting with the scientist who was still measuring and ending with the woman who understood what the measurements meant.

Then he stood near the board while people read.

They came in small groups. The dinner crowd, drifting from the cooking area to the common shelter the way they did most evenings — not because the shelter was comfortable but because the alternative was eating alone in a shelter that flexed in the wind. Joss came first, still moving carefully from the fever recovery, reading with the focused attention of someone who'd almost died and was recalibrating his understanding of

what dying looked like. Dana came, read, left without comment. Haruki read the medical entries — Anya's ankle, the infection, the detail about field medicine lost when Daniil died — and his face did something Cole had never seen. Not grief. Recognition. The look of a doctor reading the exact moment when another doctor's absence killed someone.

Garrett Polk stood in front of the board for eleven minutes. Cole timed it without meaning to. Polk read the entries about silence — the meals ending, the conversations stopping, the drift from community to coexistence. His face was unreadable. He'd been the loudest voice in the colony for twenty months, the man who argued against every system and challenged every calculation and made the council meetings longer by the specific force of his refusal to accept anything at face value. He read about Elena's colony going silent, and he stood there for eleven minutes without saying a word.

When he turned around, he looked at Cole. The look was complicated. Cole couldn't parse it — not fully. It contained something that might have been anger and something that might have been understanding and something that was definitely the recognition of a man who'd spent his adult life fighting systems that looked rational on paper and destroyed people in practice, reading about a system — the system of human connection — that had failed not because it was rational but because it was fragile.

Polk went to the cooking area. Got a second portion of the bitter tubers. Brought it back and sat down in the common shelter and ate it there, slowly, in a room that was filling with people who were reading about what happened when people stopped filling rooms.

Ren stood near the entrance. She didn't read the entries — she'd read them months ago, when Cole had first shown her the data core. She watched the colony read. She was doing the thing she'd promised: standing next to the story of death and being the evidence of life.

The entries stayed on the board for a week. Cole didn't take them down. Didn't reference them in council. Didn't deliver a speech about community or connection or the importance of shared meals. The entries did the work. Elena's voice, precise and fading, carried an authority that Cole's couldn't — the authority of someone who'd stood exactly here and lost.

The colony responded in ways Cole hadn't predicted. Not with fear. Not with the urgent overcorrection of people who'd been shown the abyss and flinched. With something quieter.

The common meals got slightly longer. Not dramatically. An extra ten minutes, maybe. People staying after the food was gone, sitting with each other, not filling the silence but not fleeing it either. The perimeter checks became conversational again — two people walking the boundary, talking about nothing consequential, the words mattering less than the fact that they were being exchanged.

Joss organized something. Cole didn't know what to call it. Not a celebration, not a ceremony. Just an evening where the younger colonists gathered in the common shelter after dinner and Joss told a story about his first week on the planet, about the alien cervid that had walked through the outer perimeter and examined a supply crate, and how he'd been so terrified he'd hidden behind Dana's spectrometer, which weighed eleven pounds and wouldn't have stopped anything. People laughed. Not a lot. But enough.

Haruki started eating dinner in the common area again. He'd been taking meals in the medical shelter for three months — working through dinner, treating the meal as fuel rather than occasion. After Elena's entries went up, he came to the common area with his bowl and sat next to Polk, of all people, and they ate in silence for four evenings in a row before Haruki said something that made Polk laugh, and the sound of Polk laughing was surprising enough that three people turned to look.

None of it was dramatic. None of it was the kind of transformation that would make a good story. It was thirty-two people making the choice Elena's colony had stopped making — the choice to occupy the same space at the same time for no reason other than the fact that the space was shared.

Cole watched it happen. He didn't take credit. He didn't mention Elena again. The dead woman's words sat on the common shelter board, fading in the green-shifted light, and the living colony moved around them like water around a stone.

Ren was right. It was manipulative. He'd used a dead woman's grief to scare his colony into staying human.

Ren was also right about the other thing. She'd stood at the entrance and watched the colony read and watched the colony respond, and she'd never said I told you so. She'd said something else, three days later, while they were reviewing the agricultural rotation in the equipment shelter.

"Elena deserved better."

"Yes."

"Not from you. From her people. From Asterlyne. From the whole architecture that put her there."

"Yes."

Ren adjusted a valve. Noted a reading. Moved to the next junction.

"We're not going to fix that," she said. "We're not going to retroactively save her colony or change what Asterlyne did or make the contract fair. We're just going to not repeat it."

"That's the plan."

"It's not a plan. It's a choice. Thirty-two people making the same choice every day."

Cole looked at the equipment shelter wall. At the water system Ren maintained, the pipes and junctions and valves that kept the colony hydrated through the planet's shifting chemistry. Infrastructure. The mechanical version of what Elena had lost — the invisible system that kept things flowing.

"Thirty-two," he said.

"Thirty-two," Ren said. She turned back to the valves. "Make sure they keep choosing."

That night, Cole went to his shelter and opened the data core one last time. Not to read. To sit with it. The screen was dark. The data inside was complete — Elena Vasik's entire record, from the clinical precision of Month 1 to the quiet devastation of Month 26.

He thought about Elena's final entry. *The planet isn't killing us. We stopped being worth keeping alive.* He thought about the thirty-two people in the shelters around him — eating, sleeping, arguing, recovering, choosing. Choosing every day to be a colony instead of a collection of individuals dying in proximity.

The math hadn't broken. The count was still there, still running, still the structure that held the colony's survival in a framework of numbers. Thirty-two. He needed twenty-four. The margin was eight. Four years and eight months remained. The planet would keep subtracting.

But the thing beneath the math — the thing that had cracked in the medical shelter while Joss burned with fever — was open now. The light came through. And in that light, the numbers looked different. Not cold. Not warm, either. Human. Each one a face he knew, a voice he recognized, a choice being made every morning to get up and keep going.

Elena had understood too late that data wasn't enough. That the soil cycle and the weather patterns and the creep maps and the native food sources were tools, not reasons. The reason was the room where people chose to eat together. The reason was Polk sitting in the common shelter for eleven minutes reading about silence and then going to get a second bowl.

Cole put the data core in the bottom of his supply crate. Elena had given him what he needed. The ending — whatever waited past Month 26 — wasn't his to read. Not yet.

He lay on his cot and listened to the hum of the spiral trees pressing through the walls of the shelter, the frequency that lived in his chest, the sound of a planet that didn't care whether he succeeded or failed but would be there, humming, either way. He counted the breaths of the colony the way he'd counted everything since Day Zero. Not inventory. Not triage. Just attention.

Thirty-two people breathing in the dark.

He fell asleep counting.

Chapter 18 — "The Creep Solution"

The third orbital phase changed the soil on Day 4 of Month 21.

Dana had been monitoring the transition for three weeks — daily samples from six locations around the settlement, analyzed against the baseline data she'd built over twenty months of continuous measurement. The planet's orbital position shifted its relationship with the parent star by fractions of a degree across months, and those fractions cascaded through the biosphere with the patient inevitability of a chemical reaction reaching equilibrium. First the light spectrum shifted. Then the atmospheric chemistry. Then the soil.

The first two phases had taught her the rhythm. Phase one: growth, stability, the period when Earth crops took uncertain root and the planet's native biology operated in something resembling equilibrium. Phase two: the acceleration — creep, dormancy, the planet's decomposition systems running at full capacity, breaking down organic material, reshuffling the biological deck. Phase three was supposed to be recovery. The planet rebuilding after the purge.

She hadn't expected what the recovery actually looked like.

The soil sample from Site 3 — the agricultural plot closest to the channel network's southern terminus — contained a mineral compound she'd been trying to synthesize for seven months. Not trace amounts. Not the deep geological concentrations she'd been extracting with primitive drilling techniques and processing through her inadequate lab setup. The compound was in the surface soil. Accessible. Abundant. The planet's own geological cycle had brought it up from the substrate layers where it had been locked during phases one and two, depositing it in concentrations that made her synthesized version look like a child's approximation.

Dana held the sample container up to the light. The soil was darker than phase-two soil — richer, denser, with a faint crystalline shimmer that caught the green-shifted sunlight and scattered it into specks of prismatic color. Beautiful. She'd stopped noticing beauty in the samples around Month 8, when the soil had become purely functional — data, not landscape. The shimmer brought it back.

She ran the analysis three times. The portable spectrometer — the real function, not the hidden one — confirmed each run. The mineral catalyst that transformed active creep into inert crystal was present at 340 parts per million. Her synthesized version had achieved 80 parts per million on a good day, and she'd been working with half a kilogram of processed rock dust to get there.

Three hundred and forty parts per million. In surface soil. Available for collection with a shovel.

Dana sat on the research shelter's floor with the sample container between her knees and felt the solution complete itself in her mind the way solutions did — not as a flash of insight but as the final piece of a structure she'd been building for months sliding into position with an almost audible click. The catalyst. The channels. The creep's own biological pathways.

The ancient builders had known this. The channel system carved into the bedrock wasn't drainage or irrigation. It was delivery infrastructure. The channels ran through the substrate at precisely the depth where the mineral catalyst concentrated during phase three. The builders — whatever they'd been, however long ago — had constructed a network for distributing the compound that neutralized the creep. They'd built the solution into the planet's own architecture. They hadn't fought the cycle. They'd routed it.

And now, twenty-one months into a charter that had given her nothing except debt erasure and guilt, Dana could do the same thing.

She spent four days confirming it.

Not because the data was ambiguous. The data was clean — cleaner than anything she'd produced in twenty months of fieldwork. The catalyst compound mineralized active creep in contained samples within hours. She'd established that in Month 14 with her synthesized version. The naturally occurring compound was orders of magnitude more concentrated, and the reaction was proportionally faster. In her test containers, active creep exposed to phase-three soil transformed from biological mat to crystalline mineral in under ninety minutes. The filaments stiffened. The dissolution chemistry shut down. The substance that had consumed Marcus Reeves from the waist down, that had killed Suri Park in the channel network, that had driven the colony from its first settlement — stopped.

She spent four days confirming because confirmation was the part of science she could control. The laboratory was hers — the only space in the settlement that belonged entirely to her professional identity, the identity she'd built between the real work and the hidden work. In the research shelter, surrounded by sample containers and the spectrometer that served two masters, Dana Wen was a botanist solving a problem. Not a debtor. Not an informant. Not the most dangerous person in a colony that called her the most useful.

Day 1: Efficacy testing. Six concentrations of the naturally occurring catalyst against standardized creep samples. All six achieved full mineralization. Optimal concentration identified: 200 ppm in solution, half the naturally occurring abundance. The planet had overbuilt the mechanism. The solution was more than sufficient.

Day 2: Delivery modeling. Dana walked the channel network with Ren's engineering surveys and her own soil maps, plotting the pathways where catalyst-rich solution could be introduced at the highest points and flow by gravity through the channels' natural gradient. The infrastructure was intact. Twenty months of observation had shown the channels were self-maintaining — the mineralized compound in their walls resisted both creep intrusion and physical weathering. They'd been built to last. They'd lasted.

Day 3: Persistence testing. How long did the mineralized barrier hold? She placed active creep samples against surfaces treated with the catalyst. Twelve hours. Twenty-four. Forty-eight. The mineralized surface remained inert. The creep couldn't recolonize treated ground. The solution wasn't temporary. It was permanent, or close enough to permanent that the distinction was academic.

Day 4: Integration. Dana laid out the complete protocol on the research shelter's workbench, written in the clean handwriting she used for colony-facing documents. Harvest catalyst from phase-three surface soil. Process into solution using water from the channel drainage. Introduce solution at twelve identified entry points along the channel network's upper gradient. Let gravity do the distribution. The channels would carry the catalyst through the settlement's substrate, creating a mineralized boundary the creep couldn't cross.

The planet's own biology, routed through the planet's own infrastructure, using a compound the planet produced on its own schedule.

She stood in the research shelter and looked at the protocol and felt two things simultaneously.

The first was the satisfaction of a problem solved. Clean. Complete. Elegant in the way the best science was elegant — not by being complicated but by being simple. The answer had been here the entire time, embedded in the planet's cycles, waiting for someone to read it correctly. Elena Vasik's colony hadn't known to look. They'd fought the creep with fire and relocation, working against the system instead of within it. Dana had the advantage of Elena's failure and twenty months of data. The solution was hers, but the groundwork was the planet's.

The second thing she felt had no scientific terminology. It sat in her chest like a compound she couldn't identify — heavy, reactive, unstable. Because the protocol she'd written in her clean handwriting for the

colony was the same protocol she would transmit to Asterlyne in six days, during the next magnetic window, through the spectrometer that sat on the shelf three feet from where she was standing.

She'd held back the synthesis protocol in Month 14. Kept the specific ratios, the processing steps, the concentration thresholds locked in her head while transmitting the theoretical framework. She'd told herself it was because the data was incomplete. Eighty percent efficacy wasn't publishable. A responsible scientist didn't release preliminary results.

None of that applied anymore. The data was complete. The efficacy was confirmed. The protocol was written. And in six days, she would transmit it to a company that had stopped sending supplies, stopped responding to contract inquiries, and started asking questions about structural vulnerabilities and single points of failure.

Dana picked up the protocol document. Held it in both hands. The paper was from the colony's limited supply — the same stock Cole used for Elena's log entries on the common shelter board, the same stock the council minutes were printed on. Finite. Real. The weight of it was negligible. The weight of what it contained was something she'd carry until she stopped carrying anything.

She transmitted on Month 21, Day 10.

The magnetic window opened at 02:15 local time. Dana lay on her cot in the dark with the spectrometer on her stomach, the two-inch screen casting its pale monochrome light on the shelter ceiling, and typed the report that made thirty-two people expendable.

The agricultural data went first. It always went first. Growing conditions, phase-three soil composition, crop status. Clean data, quantitatively precise, the kind of report a field botanist would generate. Then the creep research section. She'd been reporting progress on the creep for seven months — the mineralization chemistry, the channel system analysis, the catalyst identification. Each report had been carefully calibrated: enough data to satisfy FIELD-SUPPORT-7's requirements, enough omission to maintain the leverage she'd identified in Month 14. The synthesis protocol had been the gap. The thing she held back. The one piece of information that separated theoretical knowledge from practical deployment.

She typed the protocol now. Harvest methodology. Processing steps. Optimal concentration: 200 ppm in solution. Delivery via gravity-fed channel network at twelve identified entry points. Persistence: indefinite under observed conditions. Field efficacy: confirmed across all test parameters.

Every word was accurate. Every specification was precise. Dana didn't lie in this section because the data didn't require lying. The truth was sufficient for what Asterlyne wanted. With this protocol, any competent botanist could replicate the creep neutralization on any planet with a similar geological profile. The solution was transferable. Portable. Asterlyne could send a new expedition with the protocol loaded onto a data tablet, and the next group of colonists — or the next group of company employees, because why bother with charters and clauses when you had the science? — would have the creep solved before their first Month 8.

Dana knew what that meant. She'd known since Day 4, when she stood in the research shelter holding the protocol in both hands and felt the unstable compound in her chest react. She was giving Asterlyne the one thing the colony had that the company didn't: the answer. The creep was the planet's primary defense against occupation. Asterlyne's viability data had been incomplete. Their previous expedition had failed. The colony's survival was an anomaly the company hadn't predicted, built on Dana's work, Cole's systems, Ren's governance, Haruki's medicine. All of it hinged on the creep — the problem that made Parcel 16b too dangerous for standard corporate exploitation.

The problem she'd just solved.

If Asterlyne had the creep solution, they didn't need the colonists. The clause 9.4.2 threshold — twenty-four alive at five years, land transfers in perpetuity — was a nuisance written into a charter no one expected to be invoked. The company had designed the contract assuming failure. Dana had just removed the last obstacle to that assumption becoming irrelevant.

She hit the compression protocol. The data compressed. The signal found the relay satellite. The relay satellite found the corporate endpoint.

Dana powered down the spectrometer. Set it on the floor. Lay in the dark and listened to the hum of the trees and thought about her mother's oncology treatment — the three-year protocol, the sixty thousand credits, the debt that had brought her here. Her mother was alive because of that debt. Thirty-two people were at risk because of how she was paying it.

She'd done the math so many times the numbers had lost their edges. Sixty thousand credits against thirty-two lives. The calculation was obscene. She'd known it was obscene since Month 3, when the first colonist died and her transmission that week included a population status update that read: *Colony personnel: 46. One mortality, non-hostile cause. Colony operations unaffected.* She'd filed a death the way she filed a soil sample. Category, classification, next data point.

Twenty months later, the deaths had names she knew and faces she couldn't stop seeing and a weight that sat on her chest alongside the spectrometer every eleven days when the magnetic window opened. She carried it because stopping meant consequences she wasn't ready to calculate, and the calculations she was ready for were the ones that let her keep going.

Tomorrow she would teach Cole's team how to save the colony she was betraying.

Cole brought six people to the research shelter at dawn.

He'd read the protocol the previous evening — Dana had given it to him on paper, the colony-facing version, the version that didn't include the fact that an identical copy was traveling at the speed of corporate infrastructure toward an Asterlyne server. Cole had read it the way he read everything: once for content, once for gaps, a third time for the math. He'd found no gaps. The math was clean. He'd looked at Dana with an expression she couldn't fully read — something between respect and the specific wariness of a man who understood that elegant solutions sometimes hid costs.

He hadn't asked where the elegance came from. He never asked about her process. He trusted her data because her data had never been wrong, and that trust was the worst thing Dana carried because she'd earned it with work that was real while using it as cover for work that wasn't.

The six were the deployment team: two from Ren's engineering group, two agricultural workers who knew the soil, Joss Carver, who'd volunteered because Joss volunteered for everything since the fever, as though surviving had given him a debt he could only pay with his body, and a quiet woman named Lina who maintained the secondary water systems and knew the channel network's physical layout better than anyone except Dana.

Dana briefed them in the research shelter, standing at the workbench with the protocol document and three sample containers — raw phase-three soil, processed catalyst solution, and a chunk of mineralized creep that looked like smoky quartz.

She kept it simple. The planet's third orbital phase deposited a mineral compound in the surface soil. That compound, when dissolved in water and introduced into the ancient channel network, would create a mineralized barrier that neutralized active creep on contact. The channels' natural gradient would distribute the solution. Gravity was the mechanism. Time was the variable — full coverage of the settlement's substrate would take three to five days, depending on flow rate and channel obstruction.

She held up the mineralized sample. "This is what active creep becomes when it contacts the catalyst. The organic filaments transform into mineral crystal. The dissolution chemistry stops. It's permanent."

Joss reached for the sample. Turned it in his hands. The smoky crystal caught the light from the shelter's entrance and threw a small spectrum across the workbench.

"How much soil do we need?" Cole asked.

"Four hundred kilograms, minimum. For full saturation of the primary channels. Eight hundred for redundancy."

"Where?"

"Anywhere on the southern slope. The phase-three deposit is consistent across the settlement's footprint. Surface collection. No drilling."

Cole nodded. "Timeline?"

"Harvest and process today and tomorrow. Deploy on Day 3. Let the channels work for five days. Test the perimeter on Day 8."

She watched Cole calculate. He did it the way he always did — silently, the numbers moving behind his eyes like machinery, each variable slotting into a framework she could almost see in the micro-movements of his jaw. He was computing labor allocation. Six people on harvest and processing for two days. Channel deployment on Day 3 required access to twelve entry points, some of which were in terrain that needed scouting. The colony's work schedule would need adjustment. Food production, shelter maintenance, perimeter checks — all the systems Cole managed would absorb the temporary loss of six workers.

"We can do it in three days if we add two more to the harvest team," he said. "I'll pull from the construction rotation."

"Three days is fine. The creep's advance rate is stable. We have the margin."

Cole looked at her. The word *margin* hung between them. He used it differently than she did — for Cole, margin was the distance between alive and dead, measured in headcount and the arithmetic of clause 9.4.2. For Dana, margin was the space between a reaction proceeding and a reaction stalling, measured in concentration and temperature and time. They were talking about the same thing in different languages.

"Do it," he said.

The harvest was simple work. Hard, physical, the kind of labor that quieted the mind by filling the body. Dana worked alongside the team on the southern slope, driving a shovel into phase-three soil that came up dark and glittering, loading it into repurposed equipment crates they dragged to the processing site on salvaged polymer sheets. The work had a rhythm. Dig, load, drag, dump. The planet's green-shifted light fell across the slope in long columns filtered through the spiral trees, and the soil smelled like mineral and something faintly electric — ozone's cousin, the scent Dana had stopped noticing months ago and started noticing again because she was paying attention.

She was paying attention because the work was almost over. Not the harvest — the work of carrying two identities in one body. Twenty months of transmissions. Twenty months of calibrating the line between observation and intelligence, between data and betrayal. The creep protocol was the last piece Asterlyne needed. The planet's primary defense, neutralized. The colony's survival data, complete. Her usefulness to FIELD-SUPPORT-7 was approaching the asymptote where maintaining an asset cost more than the information it produced.

She could stop. After this transmission cycle, after the protocol was received and acknowledged, she could destroy the comm unit. Tell Cole. Accept whatever came. The calculation she'd been avoiding for twenty months was becoming simpler with each shovelful of dark soil: the debt was finite. The betrayal was compounding.

But she didn't stop. She dug soil, loaded crates, worked alongside Joss, who talked while he worked because talking was how Joss processed being alive, and she said nothing because saying nothing was how Dana processed everything.

The processing took a full day. Dissolving the catalyst into channel water, filtering the sediment, calibrating the concentration with her field kit. She tested each batch against a creep sample. Ninety minutes to full mineralization. Consistent across all twelve batches. The chemistry held.

Day 3. Deployment.

Dana led the team into the channel network at first light. The channels ran beneath the settlement in a web of carved bedrock — narrow passages, some wide enough to walk through, some requiring hands and knees. The entry points were scattered across the settlement's footprint, marked with the cairns Ren's engineering team had placed during their initial survey. Dana had identified twelve optimal injection sites where the channel gradient would carry the solution to maximum coverage.

At each site, the process was the same. Pour three liters of catalyst solution into the channel opening. Watch it pool, then flow, following the ancient gradient the builders had carved into the bedrock. The solution was pale — almost clear, with a faint mineral cloudiness that caught the light like diluted milk. It flowed the way water flows in a well-made channel: smoothly, without pooling, finding the path cut for it.

Site 1. Site 2. Site 3. Each pour was fifteen minutes of preparation and thirty seconds of execution. Dana watched the solution disappear into the channels and thought about the builders. Who they'd been. How they'd lived with the creep — not by fighting it, not by running from it, but by building infrastructure that routed the planet's own chemistry against the threat. They'd understood something Dana had taken twenty months to learn: the planet wasn't hostile. The planet was a system. Systems could be read. Once read, they could be worked within.

Elena Vasik's colony had tried to fight. Burned the creep. Relocated three times. Ran out of room. Fourteen became six became one became zero. Elena had been a geologist. She'd had the data to read the system. She hadn't had the time, the people, or the specific convergence of knowledge that Dana had — a botanist's understanding of biology, an engineer's channel maps, a logistics manager's framework for deployment. The solution required all of them. It required the colony.

By noon, all twelve sites were treated. The catalyst solution was in the channels, flowing through carved bedrock toward the settlement's perimeter, where the active creep had maintained a slow, patient advance for months. Dana sent Joss and Lina to the eastern perimeter to observe.

Two hours later, Joss came back at a run.

"It's working." He was out of breath. Not from the distance — from the seeing. His face had the expression Dana recognized from her own experience of watching data confirm a hypothesis: the particular shock of the world matching the prediction. "The creep at the eastern edge — it's crystallizing. You can watch it happen. The surface goes cloudy and then it hardens and then it just — it's rock. It's turning into rock."

Dana went to see.

The eastern perimeter had been the active creep's closest approach to the settlement — four meters from the outermost shelter, advancing at the steady centimeter-per-hour rate Cole had mapped months ago. The

biological mat was thick here, a dark, wet-looking surface that dissolved organic material on contact, the thing that had killed Marcus Reeves and driven the colony from its first home.

It was stopping.

The leading edge of the creep was transforming. The dark, wet surface was going pale — cloudy, then opaque, then crystalline. The organic filaments that gave the creep its dissolving function were stiffening, mineralizing, becoming the same smoky quartz Dana had shown the team in the research shelter. The process moved visibly. Not fast — not the dramatic freeze of a chemical demonstration — but visibly. Standing at the perimeter, you could watch the boundary between active and inert creep advance outward. An inch every few minutes. The planet's decomposer, neutralized by the planet's own mineral chemistry, delivered through the planet's own infrastructure.

Dana stood at the perimeter and watched it happen. Around her, colonists gathered. Word moved through the settlement the way information always moved — not through announcements but through the social network that Ren's governance had kept alive and Elena's warnings had reinforced. People came to the eastern edge and stood and watched the creep die.

Nobody cheered. The colony had been past cheering since the fever. But the silence had a different quality than the dimming silence Cole had identified and Elena had described. This silence was attention. Thirty-two people watching something they'd feared for thirteen months stop.

Cole stood at the back of the group. Dana saw him. His face was doing the thing it did when the math changed — the recalculation, the machinery behind the eyes adjusting to a new variable. He caught her looking. Nodded. Once. The nod said: *It works.* It also said: *Thank you.* It also said something Dana couldn't read, something that lived in the space between the logistics manager who counted people as margin and the man who'd sat with Joss through a fever and talked about his daughter.

Dana nodded back. Then she went to the research shelter to log the field results. To record the data. To be the scientist.

Haruki toasted her at dinner.

He'd brought out the last of a fermented compound he'd been aging since Month 12 — a concoction made from native fruit that tasted like something between cider and turpentine. He'd been saving it. For what, he'd never said. Haruki saved things the way he did everything — quietly, without announcement, producing them at the moment they were needed with the precision of a man who'd spent his life understanding what bodies required and when.

He stood at the cooking area with a cup of the ferment in one hand and said, in his gentle, measured voice: "To Dana. Who read the planet correctly."

Thirty-two cups raised. The ferment was divided across too many containers, each portion barely a mouthful. Dana drank hers. It was terrible. Medicinal, sharp, with a sweetness that arrived late and stayed too long. She'd never tasted anything more clearly in her life. Every chemical note registered — the sugar converted to alcohol, the native enzymes that gave it its harshness, the mineral undertone from the channel water Haruki had used in the fermentation. She tasted it the way she analyzed soil: component by component, the whole somehow exceeding the sum.

Ren found her after the toast. Dana was sitting at the edge of the common area, holding her empty cup, watching the colony eat dinner with the particular attention she gave to things she was cataloging.

Ren sat next to her. Close enough to be present. Far enough to give her room.

"You know what you did," Ren said.

"Solved a chemistry problem."

"You're the reason we'll survive Year Two."

The sentence landed on Dana like a physical weight. Not because it was praise. Because it was true, and because the truth had two faces, and Ren could only see one of them.

"The planet solved it," Dana said. "I just read the answer."

Ren looked at her. The direct eye contact that people found aggressive but Dana found precise — the engineer's assessment, the structural analysis conducted in real time. Ren was reading her the way Ren read infrastructure. Looking for stress points. Load-bearing walls. The places where the structure was holding and the places where it wasn't.

"You've been quiet," Ren said.

"I'm always quiet."

"Quieter than your quiet. Since the fever."

Dana held the empty cup. The dregs of Haruki's ferment left a film on the inside that caught the lamplight. "The work takes a lot."

Ren accepted that. Not because she believed it was the whole truth — Ren was too sharp for that — but because she believed in the space between what people said and what they meant, and she knew that space was sometimes the only privacy a person had.

"Come eat," Ren said. "With everyone. Not at the edge."

Dana almost said no. The edge was where she belonged — close enough to be counted, far enough to be separate. The position she'd maintained for twenty months, the careful calibration of proximity and distance that let her exist in the colony without being fully of it. Belonging required honesty. Dana's honesty was rationed more carefully than the food supply.

She went to the common area. Sat between Joss and a colonist named Vance who maintained the shelter waterproofing. Ate the bitter tubers and the native grain Dana herself had mapped onto the agricultural rotation seven months ago. Listened to Joss tell a story about the deployment — how the creep had crystallized in front of him, how he'd touched it afterward and it was warm, the mineralization generating heat the way all phase changes did. People laughed at the right parts. Not the desperate laughter of Month 8 or the brittle laughter of Month 17. Real laughter. The sound of people who'd been afraid for a year and had just watched the thing they feared turn to stone.

Dana sat in the middle of it and felt the unstable compound in her chest react. Not an explosion. A slow precipitation. The kind of reaction that produced crystals: orderly, permanent, very clear.

She was saving these people. She was selling them. The solution she'd built from twenty months of fieldwork and genuine scientific ability was being deployed by people who trusted her while the same solution traveled through a relay satellite toward a corporation that would use it to make their survival irrelevant. The creep was neutralized. The colony was safe. And Asterlyne now had everything it needed to replace them.

Dana ate her dinner. Thanked Haruki for the toast. Went to her shelter while the colony continued celebrating something real that she'd made possible, and lay on her cot in the dark, and did not sleep.

The response came nine days later.

FIELD-SUPPORT-7's transmissions arrived during the magnetic window at 02:15, the same schedule Dana had followed for twenty months. She opened the diagnostic batch in her shelter, the spectrometer's two-inch screen casting its pale light on the ceiling, the hum of the trees pressing through the shelter walls at the frequency she'd stopped noticing and started noticing again.

The standard acknowledgment was brief. *Creep neutralization protocol received. Data quality: excellent. Synthesis parameters confirmed against independent modeling. Results consistent with projected geological phase analysis.*

Independent modeling. Asterlyne had been running their own analysis. They'd been comparing her data against their projections, testing her results before she'd confirmed them herself. She wasn't a researcher to them. She was a calibration point. The company had the model. She was providing the ground truth.

Below the acknowledgment, a new instruction set. Shorter than usual. Two lines.

Revised priority assessment required.

Assess structural dependency on individual colonists. Identify single points of failure.

Dana read it three times. The spectrometer's screen flickered on the second reading — the backlight dying the way all Asterlyne equipment died, slowly, predictably, without apology.

The questions weren't new. She'd answered a version of them in Month 14. Supply chain dependencies. Individual operational functions. Single points of failure. She'd lied then — told FIELD-SUPPORT-7 the colony had cross-trained, that redundancy was built in. The lie had been plausible because it was partially true.

But the questions were different now. Not in language. In context. In Month 14, they'd been embedded in a batch that included structural vulnerabilities, water source locations, geographic positioning. Part of a broad mapping exercise. The kind of intelligence gathering that could serve multiple purposes, that maintained the fiction of operational assessment.

Now the questions stood alone. No structural analysis. No geographic positioning. Just people. Who matters. Who can be removed.

Dana could write the list without thinking. She'd been living inside the colony's operational architecture for twenty months. She knew who mattered the way she knew soil chemistry — through daily observation, repeated measurement, pattern recognition.

Cole Maren. Logistics, leadership, the framework that kept thirty-two people functioning as a unit. Without Cole, the systems degraded within weeks. He was the load-bearing wall.

Ren Tsai. Engineering, governance, the social infrastructure Cole's systems didn't cover. Without Ren, the colony fractured along the fault lines that had been forming since Month 4. She was the connective tissue.

Haruki Sato. Medicine. Irreplaceable. No backup. The colony had one doctor and the doctor was fifty-three and tired and the only reason a dozen people were still breathing.

Dana Wen. Agriculture, creep management, soil science. The colony's food supply and environmental defense depended on knowledge that existed in one person's head.

Four names. Four points of failure. Remove any one and the colony's probability of reaching the five-year threshold dropped below viability. Remove two and it collapsed.

They were asking her to write a kill list. Corporate language, corporate channels, embedded in a diagnostic batch that looked like equipment telemetry. But the request was unambiguous. You identified single points

of failure in a system you intended to disrupt. You didn't map vulnerabilities in systems you planned to support.

Dana powered down the spectrometer. Set it on the floor. Lay on her cot in the dark.

The hum of the trees pressed through the shelter walls. Outside, the colony slept. Thirty-two people who had toasted her nine days ago, who had watched the creep turn to stone, who had eaten dinner together in a common area that stayed full because Elena Vasik's warnings had made them choose connection over isolation. Thirty-two people whose names she knew and whose trust she carried and whose survival she'd just made both more certain and more precarious in the same transmission.

She did not sleep.

Chapter 19 — "Narrowing"

The colony stabilized the way a broken bone stabilizes — not by returning to what it was but by calcifying around the fracture into something harder, less flexible, functional in a different way.

Month 23. The creep system held. Dana's catalyst solution moved through the ancient channels with the patient reliability of infrastructure built by something that understood the planet's rhythms better than the colonists ever would, and the biological mat that had driven them from their first settlement continued to crystallize at the perimeter, centimeter by centimeter, the boundary between threat and safety advancing outward in a slow mineral tide. The food systems produced. Not abundantly — the third orbital phase's recovery wasn't the generous season Dana had hoped for, the native crops yielding at seventy percent of her projections — but consistently. Enough to eat. Enough to maintain the caloric baseline Haruki monitored with the quiet precision of a man who understood that the distance between surviving and declining was measured in grams.

Ren's council met every five days. The agenda had structure now — not the improvised triage of the early months, where every meeting was a crisis response, but actual governance. Water system maintenance. Agricultural rotation. Shelter repair schedule. Perimeter monitoring. The mechanical business of keeping thirty-two people alive on a planet that hadn't killed them in weeks.

Cole attended every meeting. He sat in the back and listened and watched the council function without him at the center, and he felt something he couldn't identify. Not relief. Not loss. Something in between — the specific sensation of a man who had built a machine and was watching it run. That was the point. The machine didn't need him anymore.

He still counted. Every morning, before the colony woke, he walked the settlement's perimeter in the green-shifted pre-dawn light and counted the shelters and the bodies inside them. Thirty-two. The number sat in his chest the way numbers always did — structural, load-bearing, the architecture of survival expressed in a single figure. But the weight of the number had changed. It used to feel like inventory. Now it felt like attendance.

Month 23, Day 19. An accident.

Vance, the shelter waterproofing specialist, fell from a roof during a routine repair. The shelter was one of the colony-built structures on the high ground — rougher than Asterlyne's pre-fabs, lower to the ground, designed by Ren's engineering team for the planet's wind patterns rather than corporate aesthetics. Vance had been on the roof a hundred times. His foot found a section where the binding compound had degraded — a failure Dana's botanical sealant was supposed to prevent, a failure that meant the sealant's effective life was shorter than projected — and he went sideways off the edge and landed on the rock substrate that had saved them from the creep.

Haruki set the broken arm. Treated the concussion. Vance was back on light duty in two weeks, moving carefully, testing handholds before he trusted them, the kind of recalibration that happened when the body learned a lesson the mind already knew.

Not fatal. But Cole registered it. The shelter sealant degrading meant maintenance schedules needed revision. The revision meant labor reallocation. The reallocation meant someone else's task got delayed, and the delay cascaded through the colony's operations in a pattern Cole could see and most people couldn't, because most people experienced the colony as a series of daily moments and Cole experienced it as a system of interdependencies where every failure propagated.

He revised the maintenance schedule that night. Added a quarterly sealant inspection to the rotation. The colony absorbed the change the way it absorbed everything — with a brief disruption and a return to rhythm.

Month 24, Day 7. An illness.

Not the fever. Something smaller — a gastrointestinal pathogen, probably native, that moved through seven colonists in ten days. Dana traced it to a batch of the native tubers harvested from a plot where the soil chemistry had shifted during the phase transition. The compounds that made the tubers edible in phase two had altered in phase three. Not dramatically. A three-percent change in alkaloid concentration. Enough to cause forty-eight hours of cramping and nausea in adults whose digestive systems were adapted to Earth biology, not the planet's shifting menu.

Haruki managed it. Hydration, rest, the bland protein paste from the original supply manifest that nobody liked and everyone ate when their stomach wouldn't accept anything else. All seven recovered. No deaths. The tuber plot was flagged and the harvest protocol updated with a testing requirement that added two days to the agricultural cycle.

Cole watched the seven recover and thought about the three-percent shift. Such a small number. The planet didn't need to be hostile. It just needed to be itself — a system in constant motion, variables adjusting on timescales the colonists could track but not always anticipate. Every time they mapped a pattern, the pattern refined itself by fractions, and the fractions accumulated into events that tested the colony's margin.

The margin was shrinking. Not because the deaths were accelerating — they'd slowed dramatically since the fever, since the creep solution, since the colony had learned enough of the planet's language to avoid the worst of its grammar. The margin was shrinking because the colony was smaller. Thirty-two people absorbed a three-percent alkaloid shift as a bad week. Twenty-five would absorb it as a crisis. Twenty would absorb it as a death.

Month 25, Day 3. The fauna.

They still didn't understand the fauna. Twenty-five months on the planet and the creatures in the tree line remained peripheral — observed, cataloged by Dana's increasingly detailed biological surveys, but never fully comprehended. During phase one, they'd watched from the forest edge. During phase two, they'd moved closer, bolder, as if the creep's expansion pushed them toward the settlement the way a rising river pushed animals to higher ground. During phase three, they'd retreated. Not disappeared. Retreated. Deeper into the spiral-trunked forest, where the hum of the trees intensified and the understory grew dense with lavender growth that Dana said was the planet's version of rapid recovery — biomass replenishing after the creep's purge.

A colonist named Okafor was bitten on the morning of Day 3.

He'd been checking the southern water collection array — a network of condensation traps Ren's team had installed along the slope where the channel network surfaced. Routine work. The path was familiar, beaten smooth by months of daily foot traffic. The creature was coiled at the base of a collection unit, its body a mottled gray-lavender that matched the substrate so precisely that Okafor didn't see it until his hand was on the unit's access panel and the thing moved.

The bite was on his right forearm. Two puncture marks, small, clean, spaced eighteen millimeters apart. Okafor walked back to the settlement with his left hand clamped over the wound and his face the color of ash and told Haruki, "Something bit me at Station 7."

Haruki examined the wound. Applied pressure. Drew a sample. The venom — if it was venom; Haruki said the word provisionally, the way he said everything medical on a planet where human terminology was approximation — caused rapid localized tissue inflammation and a systemic histamine response that

dropped Okafor's blood pressure in the first hour. Haruki treated for anaphylaxis. Used the last epinephrine auto-injector from the original medical kit — the kit stocked for twenty, serving thirty-two, depleted methodically over twenty-five months of injuries and illnesses that Asterlyne's planners had never anticipated because Asterlyne's planners had never intended for anyone to be alive long enough to need them.

Okafor survived the first hour. His blood pressure stabilized. The tissue inflammation spread from the bite site to his shoulder in a pattern Haruki called "unusual but manageable." Dana brought a poultice of native compounds she'd been testing for anti-inflammatory properties — the same species she'd studied for the fever treatment, different preparation, different application. It helped. The swelling plateaued.

Then, on Day 4, the secondary reaction began. A cascade of neural symptoms — tremors, confusion, difficulty speaking — that didn't appear in any Earth toxicology Haruki knew. The venom wasn't attacking the tissue anymore. It was interacting with Okafor's nervous system in a way that Earth medicine couldn't model because Earth medicine had never encountered the specific molecular architecture of a compound that had evolved on a planet with different atmospheric chemistry, different electromagnetic conditions, different everything.

Haruki did everything he could. Cole sat outside the medical shelter while Haruki worked and listened to the sounds that came through the walls — the doctor's steady voice giving instructions to Dana, who assisted with a competence born of twenty months of being the closest thing the colony had to a second medical professional. The rustling of supplies being organized and reorganized. The silence that was worse than the sounds.

Okafor died on Day 5. Twenty-six months on the planet. A bite from a creature no one had seen clearly enough to describe, delivering a compound no one could analyze with the equipment they had, killing a man who had survived the transit, the landing, the factions, the creep, the relocation, the fever, and twenty-five months of daily existence on a world that hadn't stopped being alien just because they'd learned some of its rules.

Thirty-one.

Cole stood at the perimeter that evening and did the math.

Thirty-one. The number slid into the framework he'd been running since Day Zero — the projection he'd built in his head while lying in a pre-fab shelter on the first night, counting forty-seven and calculating how many he'd lose. He'd modeled scenarios. Best case: thirty-five at two years. Moderate case: thirty at two years. Worst case: twenty-eight at two years, with losses front-loaded in the first twelve months and tapering as the colony adapted.

Thirty-one at twenty-five months. Between moderate and worst case. Tracking exactly where he'd predicted if you plotted the curve and smoothed the noise and accounted for the variables he hadn't known about — the creep, the fever, the specific character of a planet that taught you its rules by breaking them.

He'd been right about the math. He'd built the model on Day One and the model had held, within a margin of error that a logistics professional would consider acceptable, across twenty-five months and sixteen deaths. Sixteen names he could list in order. Sixteen faces that appeared in the space between waking and sleeping, not as hauntings but as data points that had been people and were now entries in a ledger he kept in a part of his mind that he'd designated for the purpose and couldn't redesign.

Lev. Priya. Vogel. Osei. Farin. Sarah. Lin. Thomas. Marcus Reeves. Thomas Chen. Noor. Suri Park. The one who walked into the forest. Hana. James. Okafor.

He'd been right about the math. The model had held. The projection was accurate.

He'd been wrong about what it would feel like.

On Day One, the model had been abstract. Numbers on a curve, probabilities assigned to outcomes, the clean arithmetic of a man who'd spent his career managing systems where the units were pallets and hours and truck routes. People were a variable. Attrition was a rate. The projection said sixteen deaths in twenty-five months and the projection had been right and standing at the perimeter of a settlement he'd helped build, watching the green-shifted twilight settle over the spiral trees, Cole felt each of those sixteen names in his body with a weight that arithmetic couldn't carry.

He'd built the model to survive. The model had worked. And somewhere between the model and the moment — between the day he'd counted forty-seven faces in a corporate waiting room and the evening he stood at thirty-one and felt the number like a stone behind his ribs — the purpose had changed. He wasn't running a survival calculation anymore. He was living inside the answer to a question he hadn't known he was asking.

Twenty-four. He needed twenty-four at five years. The margin was seven. Thirty months remained. The model said he'd make it. The model had always said he'd make it. The model didn't say anything about the sixteen names that lived in the space the math created, because the math didn't have a function for the specific gravity of absence.

The council met two days after Okafor's death.

Ren ran the meeting with the efficiency she'd developed over twelve months of governance — agenda items distributed on the colony's limited paper, time allocated, decisions recorded by a rotating secretary. The agenda was routine. Water system status: stable, one junction showing wear that Ren's team would repair. Agricultural report: Dana's phase-three yield projections, adjusted downward by four percent based on the tuber alkaloid incident. Shelter maintenance: Vance's fall had exposed the sealant degradation issue, inspection schedule revised. Medical: Haruki's inventory, now critically short on anti-inflammatories and entirely out of epinephrine.

Cole reported the count. He always reported the count. "Thirty-one."

The number sat in the room the way it always did — heavy, present, the pulse of the colony rendered in a single figure that everyone heard and nobody wanted to discuss. They discussed everything else. The water junction. The sealant schedule. The agricultural adjustments. The business of survival conducted with the practiced fluency of people who'd been doing it for two years.

Then the agenda ended and nobody left.

This was new. Three months ago, the end of the agenda had been the end of the meeting — people stood, returned to tasks, the council chamber emptied with the efficiency of a system designed for function. After Elena's logs went up on the common shelter board, something had shifted. The end of the agenda became the beginning of a different kind of meeting. Unstructured. Unpurposed. People staying in the same room because the room was shared and sharing was a choice they'd learned to make consciously after reading about a colony that stopped making it.

Garrett Polk was telling a story. Cole had heard Polk tell stories before — in the early months, the stories had been recruitment tools, narratives about freedom and the systems that crushed it, wielded with the confidence of a man who believed his own rhetoric and the desperation of a man who needed others to believe it too. The stories had changed. This one was about a construction site on Earth — Polk's co-op, the shared labor model, the business he'd built and lost. He was telling it to two younger colonists who hadn't heard it, and the way he told it now was different from the way he would have told it in Month 4. Less anger. Less ideology. Just a man describing something he'd made, how it worked, why it didn't, what he'd learned. The younger colonists listened. One of them asked a question about the structural engineering. Polk

answered with specifics — load calculations, material tolerances, the math of building something that was supposed to stand.

On the other side of the room, Joss Carver was teaching water filter maintenance to two colonists who'd been assigned to the secondary system. He had the filter components laid out on a cloth — the membrane, the housing, the chemical neutralization stage Dana had designed — and he was explaining each one with a patience that Cole recognized as inherited. Not from Cole. From Haruki. The gentle precision of a man who understood that teaching was the most efficient form of redundancy, that every skill transferred was a single point of failure eliminated.

Joss had changed. The gangly, over-eager kid who'd bumped into things and talked too fast and volunteered for everything because volunteering was how he processed the terror of being twenty-two on an alien planet — that kid was still visible, in the gestures, in the occasional filler word that slipped through. But the frame had filled. Not physically, though that too — the colony's diet and labor had built muscle where anxiety had burned it. The change was structural. Joss moved through the settlement with a purpose that wasn't borrowed from someone else's urgency. He'd found his own.

Cole watched from the back of the room and felt something in his throat he didn't name. Not the stone of numbers. Not grief, not pride, not the complicated weight of a man watching a younger man become something. Something without a word. The feeling of seeing a thing continue.

The settlement had names now.

Not the settlement itself — that was still the settlement, or the colony, or the high ground, depending on who was talking and whether they were speaking in logistics or emotion. But the places within it had acquired the unofficial taxonomy of any lived-in space. The Bench — the rock outcropping near the common area where people sat after dinner. The Drip — the water collection junction that had leaked intermittently for four months before Ren's team fixed it, the name surviving long after the problem. South Kitchen — the cooking area closest to the agricultural plots, where Dana ate most mornings, early, alone with her soil samples and the first light. The Board — the common shelter's message wall, where Elena's logs still hung and where the council minutes were posted and where someone, anonymously, had started pinning observations about the planet. "The cervids are back at Station 12." "The eastern creep boundary advanced 0.2m overnight — still within normal range." "The trees hum louder after rain."

Cole noticed the names because naming was a form of ownership that didn't require a clause. Nobody had voted on the Bench. Nobody had proposed the Drip in council. The names had grown the way the colony's culture had grown — organically, through use, through the accumulated weight of people referring to the same place in the same way until the reference became the thing.

There were inside jokes he didn't understand. References to events he'd been present for but hadn't experienced the way others had — a shared memory that had been processed through communal retelling until the original event was less important than the story of the event. The time Joss had hidden behind Dana's spectrometer. The sound Polk made when he tasted Haruki's ferment for the first time. The morning a cervid walked through the common area during breakfast and stood at the Board as if reading the notices before Ren shooed it out with an engineering survey.

Cole didn't understand all of it. He didn't need to. The culture wasn't his — it was theirs, the colony's, the emergent property of thirty-one people choosing to occupy the same space with enough consistency that the space developed a character. He'd built the systems that kept them alive. Ren had built the governance that kept them together. But the culture was something nobody had built. It had grown in the gaps between the systems, the way the native plants grew in the gaps between the channel network's carved bedrock — unplanned, persistent, rooted in whatever the environment provided.

He watched it and felt the unnamed thing in his throat again. The feeling of seeing something continue that he hadn't made and couldn't control and didn't want to control. The feeling, maybe, of a man who'd spent his life counting things discovering that some things grew without being counted.

Month 26, Day 14. Cole wrote to Lily.

He sat in his shelter at the desk he'd built from salvaged panels — the same desk where he tracked the count, where he'd read Elena's logs, where the data core now sat in the bottom of his supply crate, closed for good. The colony's limited paper was in front of him. A pencil. The relay satellite overhead, Asterlyne's infrastructure, the only connection between Parcel 16b and a daughter who was eleven years old now and might have received his first message or might not have, because the relay was Asterlyne-controlled and Asterlyne had reasons to read his correspondence and reasons to block it and Cole didn't know which they'd chosen.

The first message had been three sentences and two hours. The trees. The beauty. The avoidance. He'd described the planet the way a tourist described a postcard — surface, sensation, nothing underneath.

Twenty-six months had passed since that message. Sixteen people had died. The colony had relocated, survived a fever, solved the creep, read a dead woman's logs, and learned to eat dinner together on purpose. Cole had sat with a twenty-two-year-old burning with fever and said Lily's name out loud for the first time, and the saying had cracked something in the mathematics he'd built his survival around, and the crack had let light through, and the light had shown him what the numbers looked like when you stopped using them as walls.

He picked up the pencil and wrote.

I'm on a planet very far away. I came here because I'd run out of reasons to stay. I'm finding new ones.

Three sentences. This time it took four minutes. He folded the paper, walked to the communications hub, entered the transmission queue. He didn't reread it. Not because he was avoiding the words. Because the words were right and rereading would make him doubt them, and doubt was a luxury he'd spent twenty-six months learning to distinguish from caution.

The message entered the relay. The relay was Asterlyne's. The distance was immeasurable in any unit that mattered — not kilometers or light-minutes but the specific distance between a man on an alien planet and a girl who thought he was on a work trip and might, by now, have stopped believing that. The message would travel that distance or it wouldn't. He'd said what was true. That was all he could control.

He went back to his shelter. The hum of the trees pressed through the walls. The settlement — his, theirs, thirty-one people's — breathed around him in the dark. He listened to it the way he listened to everything. Not counting. Attending.

The wellness check arrived on Month 26, Day 22.

Cole was in the communications hub reviewing the colony's outgoing message queue — a task he'd taken on after the supply drops stopped, monitoring the relay for any Asterlyne response to his contract compliance inquiries, which had gone unanswered for eleven months. The hub was a repurposed equipment shelter fitted with the colony's communication array, a system Ren had rebuilt from the original Asterlyne components after Polk's signal array was dismantled. It worked. Barely. The magnetic window for clear transmission opened every eleven days, and the relay satellite — Asterlyne's relay satellite, maintained or not maintained at their discretion — accepted outgoing signals with a consistency that felt less like reliability and more like surveillance.

The incoming message was flagged as priority. Cole hadn't seen a priority flag in months. The last one had been the supply chain disruption notice — corporate poetry for abandonment, the polished language of a company informing its assets that the investment had been deprioritized.

He opened it.

ASTERLYNE CORPORATION — CHARTER DIVISION RE: Parcel 16b Wellness Assessment To: Charter Signatories, Parcel 16b

As part of our ongoing commitment to charter success, Asterlyne's Colony Welfare team is conducting a routine wellness assessment across all active charter sites. Your cooperation ensures continued alignment between corporate support infrastructure and colonist needs.

Please provide the following at your earliest convenience:

1. Current colony population (total living signatories) 2. General health status of colony population 3. Current resource sufficiency assessment (food, water, shelter, medical) 4. Any operational concerns requiring corporate attention

Asterlyne values the health and safety of every charter participant. Your response enables us to calibrate support resources effectively.

Warm regards, Colony Welfare Division Asterlyne Corporation

Cole read it twice.

The language was warm. Friendly. The specific temperature of corporate communication designed to simulate concern — every word chosen for its absence of legal commitment, every phrase structured to request information while offering nothing in return. "Ongoing commitment to charter success" from a company that had stopped sending supplies ten months ago. "Calibrate support resources effectively" from a company whose support resources had been calibrated to zero. "Warm regards" from a division that may or may not have existed before this message was drafted.

They were asking how many were alive.

Cole sat in the communications hub and felt the question settle into the framework he'd been building for twenty-six months. Asterlyne knew the timeline. They'd written the charter. They knew clause 9.4.2 required twenty-four alive at five years. They'd sent a data extraction team seven years before and watched it fail. They'd sent forty-seven people with insufficient equipment and inflated viability data and a contract designed to be unread. They'd had an informant transmitting colony data for twenty months — Dana's reports, which Cole now knew about and which Asterlyne didn't know he knew about.

They were recalculating. Dana had gone silent six months ago — the comm unit destroyed, the transmissions ended. Asterlyne's last data point was thirty-two people and a creep solution that made the colony viable. They didn't know about Okafor. They didn't know the count was thirty-one. They didn't know the margin between the colony's current number and the clause threshold was seven.

The wellness check was an inventory request dressed in concern. They wanted the number. They wanted to run the same calculation Cole ran every morning — the projection, the curve, the probability of twenty-four at five years — and they wanted to run it with current data because their current data was six months stale.

Cole closed the message. Sat in the communications hub. The relay satellite overhead, waiting. The magnetic window open for another three hours, long enough to compose and transmit a response that would give Asterlyne everything they needed to determine whether the colony was worth disrupting or whether time and the planet would do the disrupting for them.

He thought about Dana's reports. Twenty months of data transmitted through a hidden comm unit — population counts, resource allocations, structural vulnerabilities. Asterlyne had been watching through Dana's eyes, and when Dana's eyes closed, they'd lost their feed. The wellness check was the replacement. Less granular. Less reliable. But a number was a number.

He thought about Elena Vasik's colony. Fourteen people, data extraction contract, no ownership clause. Asterlyne had watched that colony die. Had they sent wellness checks? Had they calibrated support resources while Elena's fourteen became nine became six became one? The pattern was older than Cole's colony. The architecture of corporate abandonment, dressed in warm regards.

He thought about responding. A number. Thirty-one. What would Asterlyne do with it? Run the projection. Determine the probability. If the probability of reaching twenty-four was high enough to trigger clause 9.4.2 — to transfer land rights in perpetuity, to lose a planet's worth of resources to a group of colonists who'd survived their own contract — then the company would act. Not with warm regards. With whatever action the charter's fine print permitted, or the fine print's silence enabled.

He didn't respond.

He closed the communications hub. Walked back to the settlement in the green-shifted dark. The trees hummed. The shelters sat solid on the high ground, built by hands that had learned the planet's materials, maintained by systems that worked because people woke up every morning and chose to work them. Thirty-one people sleeping in the dark of a world that didn't care about corporate wellness assessments or charter clauses or the specific arithmetic of survival.

End of Year Two. Thirty-one alive. The margin was seven. The projection held.

Asterlyne's message sat unanswered in the communications hub, its warm regards cooling in the relay buffer like heat leaving a body.

Cole went to his shelter. Lay on his cot. Listened to the hum. Didn't count.

Slept.

Chapter 20 — "Silence"

The relay went quiet on Day 3 of Month 27, and Ren knew what it meant before Cole did.

Not the equipment. The equipment was fine. She'd rebuilt the colony's communication array herself from Asterlyne's original components after Polk's signal array was dismantled, and she maintained it the way she maintained everything — with scheduled inspections, redundancy checks, and the specific attention of a woman who understood that the difference between a functioning system and a dead one was usually a corroded junction nobody bothered to examine. The array worked. The relay satellite accepted outgoing signals on its eleven-day cycle. The magnetic window opened and closed on schedule.

Nothing came through.

The wellness check Cole had left unanswered sat in the outgoing buffer like a question that had been asked and retracted. Asterlyne had wanted a number. Cole hadn't given them one. And now the company had stopped asking.

Ren had grown up inside surveillance. Not the dramatic kind — not cameras and jackboots, nothing that made for compelling resistance narratives. The mundane kind. Debt monitoring. Employment tracking. The quiet infrastructure of a system that watched you because watching was cheaper than helping, and the data you generated by existing was worth more than anything you produced on purpose. She'd spent fifteen years on Earth inside that architecture — designing physical structures while her financial structures were monitored, logged, scored, and reported to entities she'd never meet. The debt spiral that had driven her to the charter hadn't been a failure. It had been a feature. The system that tracked her spending also extended her credit, and the credit generated the debt, and the debt generated the data, and the data fed the system that tracked her spending.

She knew what surveillance felt like. The particular texture of being observed — not the paranoia, which was just anxiety wearing a reasonable mask, but the structural awareness. You developed it the way you developed any sense: through exposure, through repetition, through the accumulated experience of living inside a system designed to know more about you than you knew about yourself.

She also knew what it felt like when the watching stopped.

It had happened once on Earth. Three months before she signed the charter. Her credit monitoring service had gone silent. No alerts, no score updates, no helpful suggestions for managing her debt. Just quiet. She'd felt relieved for two days before the restructuring notice arrived — the one that consolidated her obligations under a single corporate entity, tripled her interest rate, and offered the charter as an alternative to twenty years of minimum payments that would never reach the principal.

The watchers stopped watching when they'd already decided what to do with you. The silence wasn't absence. It was the gap between the decision and the execution.

Ren stood in the communications hub on Day 3 of Month 27 and listened to the relay's carrier signal — the faint, steady hum that meant the satellite was overhead and the window was open and the channel was clear — and heard nothing underneath it. No incoming queue. No priority flags. No corporate poetry about calibrating support resources.

She found Cole at the perimeter. He was doing the morning count — the walk he took every day before the colony woke, moving through the green-shifted pre-dawn light, tallying shelters and the bodies inside them. Thirty-one. Ren had stopped finding the ritual strange somewhere around Month 14. It was just what Cole did. The way she checked valve pressures and junction seals before anyone else was awake. Private maintenance of the system each of them carried.

"Asterlyne's gone quiet," she said.

Cole didn't stop walking. He adjusted his pace to include her — not slowing, not speeding, just widening the pattern so she occupied the space beside him. He'd learned to do that. Or she'd learned to read it as intentional. Either way, they walked the perimeter together now, which was different from walking the perimeter at the same time.

"How long?"

"The wellness check was the last incoming. Twenty-six days ago. They haven't acknowledged Cole's compliance inquiries. Haven't responded to any outgoing. The relay's clear — it's not a technical fault."

"They're recalculating."

"They're done calculating," Ren said. "That's worse."

Cole looked at her. The look lasted two seconds, which was a long time for Cole. His face was doing the thing she'd learned to read over twenty-seven months — the neutral mask that wasn't a mask but a resting state, the face of a man whose default expression was the one that revealed nothing because revealing things cost energy he was spending elsewhere. Behind the neutral, the machinery moved.

"You think they've decided something."

"I think they stopped needing our data. Dana's transmissions gave them twenty months of intelligence. Your wellness check asked them for an update they should already have. When they didn't get it, they didn't follow up. They didn't escalate. They went silent."

She watched him process it. Cole processed information the way she processed structural loads — silently, in a framework that wasn't visible from outside but produced results you could measure in the decisions that followed.

"What does silence buy them?" he asked.

"Time. Information asymmetry. We don't know what they know. We don't know what they're planning. The silence costs them nothing and costs us everything — attention, anxiety, the bandwidth we'd spend monitoring for the thing that isn't coming yet."

Cole nodded. The nod was small. It meant he'd already arrived at the same conclusion and was filing her confirmation alongside his own.

They walked the rest of the perimeter without talking. The spiral trees hummed in the pre-dawn, the frequency Ren felt in her sternum, the sound that had been alien on Day One and was now just the sound of the place. The shelters sat solid on the high ground, built by her engineering teams from the planet's materials and the colony's labor. They were better structures than Asterlyne's pre-fabs — lower, wider, shaped for the wind patterns she'd mapped over two years. They looked like they belonged to the ground they stood on.

The colony she'd helped build was being watched by a company that had stopped watching, and Ren couldn't fix that the way she fixed a corroded junction. Some systems were designed to be opaque from the inside.

The relationship had changed.

Ren noticed it the way she noticed structural shifts — not in a single moment but in the accumulation of small data points that, plotted on a curve, described a gradient she hadn't anticipated.

Month 8: she'd stood in the equipment shelter and told Cole that freedom imposed by one man's arithmetic wasn't freedom. She'd meant it. He was a logistics machine running a survival calculation, and the calculation was correct. That was the problem. You couldn't build a colony on correct. You built it on chosen.

Month 12: she'd organized the relocation while Cole calculated the creep's advance rate, and they'd divided the problem the way a load divides across a truss — each member carrying its share, the structure holding because the distribution was right. She'd pushed for the vote. He'd pushed for speed. The vote had been close and the relocation had been brutal and they'd both been right and two people had died and the rightness hadn't protected anyone.

Month 17: she'd stood at the entrance of the common shelter while the colony read Elena Vasik's logs and Cole stood near the board, and she'd watched him do something she hadn't thought he could do — use a story instead of a number. Manipulative, she'd called it. Leadership, he'd said. Both true. She'd stayed because someone needed to be standing next to the story of death as evidence of life, and she'd stayed because somewhere between Month 8 and Month 17, she'd stopped seeing Cole as the problem.

Now, Month 27, walking the perimeter together in the pre-dawn, she tried to identify what she saw instead.

Not a leader. Cole would reject the word. He managed. He counted. He built systems that kept people breathing and revised the systems when the breathing changed. Leadership implied authority and Cole's authority was the authority of the man who happened to be right about the math, which was the most fragile form of authority there was — it lasted exactly as long as the math held.

Not a friend. Friendship required a symmetry that didn't exist between them. Ren argued with Cole the way she argued with structural calculations — not from opposition but from the need to verify. Cole tolerated her arguments the way he tolerated the planet's weather — as a variable he couldn't control that sometimes improved his outcomes. They didn't confide. They didn't share. They exchanged information with the efficiency of two systems optimized for different functions running on the same infrastructure.

Something else. Something that didn't have a word because the conditions that produced it didn't exist in contexts where words got made. Two people who'd built a settlement on an alien planet, who'd buried sixteen bodies in alien soil, who'd watched a colony survive things that should have killed it and things that shouldn't have, who argued less now because the arguments had been replaced by something more efficient — the ability to look at the same problem from two sides and trust that the other side was load-bearing.

Ren thought about her partner on Earth. Mika. The person she'd been building something with before the debt spiral hit. Mika had been an architect — the kind who designed buildings rather than the kind who kept them standing. They'd argued about structure the way Ren and Cole argued about the colony: from adjacent perspectives, each seeing what the other missed, the disagreements productive because they were grounded in shared investment.

She'd left Mika to avoid becoming someone's dependent. Signed the charter. Crossed the space between Earth and Parcel 16b in a company ship, and the distance had been measured in months but felt like it was measured in the specific kind of loss that came from choosing survival over love and knowing the choice was right and hating that it was necessary.

What she had with Cole wasn't what she'd had with Mika. It wasn't romantic — the thought arrived sometimes, in the way thoughts arrive when two people spend enough time in proximity, and she dismissed it each time with the engineering pragmatism she applied to everything. Structural analysis: a romantic entanglement between the colony's two primary decision-makers would introduce a dependency that compromised both their functions. The calculation was cold and correct and she didn't make it because she was cold. She made it because she'd learned on Earth that some structures couldn't bear the weight they were asked to carry, and the kindest thing was to not load them.

What she had with Cole was closer to what soldiers had. She'd never been a soldier. But she'd read enough, listened enough, understood enough of human architecture to recognize the specific bond that formed between people who'd been inside the same disaster long enough that the disaster became the shared language. You didn't need to like each other. You didn't need to understand each other. You needed to trust that when the load shifted, the other person would take their share without being asked.

Cole took his share. Every time. Without being asked. That was the thing she'd learned about him over twenty-seven months — the thing that had changed her from an engineer who saw a logistics machine into an engineer who saw a man carrying a structure he'd built for everyone else while the structure he'd built for himself was the smallest room in the settlement. His shelter. His cot. His data core. His count.

She didn't tell him any of this. She didn't need to. The perimeter walk was enough. The shared silence in the pre-dawn, the two of them moving through the green-shifted light, counting the colony from different angles and arriving at the same number.

Month 28, Day 11. The path.

A colonist named Yuki had been walking the southern route to the water collection array for eight months. Same path every morning. The route ran along the slope where the channel network surfaced, following a trail beaten smooth by daily foot traffic — the kind of path that existed because enough people had walked the same line that the ground conceded.

Ren had inspected the route twice. Once in Month 20, as part of her quarterly infrastructure review. Once in Month 24, after the rains softened the substrate and she'd flagged three sections where erosion was undercutting the trail's eastern edge. She'd marked the sections with cairns. Issued a verbal advisory at council. Added it to the maintenance rotation.

The cairns were still there on Day 11. The advisory was still in the council minutes. The maintenance rotation had been delayed — twice — because the colony's labor allocation was stretched across too many systems with too few people. Thirty-one people maintaining infrastructure designed for forty-seven. The math had always been bad. Twenty-seven months of attrition had made it worse.

Yuki walked the path at dawn. Ren reconstructed it afterward from the physical evidence and the testimony of Lina, who'd been at the water array when Yuki didn't arrive on time. The section she'd flagged in Month 24 — the one closest to the channel network's southern junction, where the slope dropped three meters to the bedrock below — had eroded further over the past three months. Not dramatically. The kind of erosion that happened in centimeters, invisible to anyone who walked the same path every day because daily familiarity was the enemy of noticing change.

Yuki's foot found the edge where the edge used to be and wasn't. She went over the side. Three meters to the bedrock. A fall that would have broken an ankle on Earth, gotten treated, generated a funny story about clumsiness. On Parcel 16b, with a medical kit stocked for twenty and depleted across twenty-seven months, with a doctor who was fifty-three and running on reserves that Ren could see diminishing in the specific way Haruki moved slower now and rested more and said nothing about either — on Parcel 16b, a broken ankle was a compound fracture and a compound fracture was an infection risk and an infection risk was a probability that Haruki managed with the native compounds Dana had developed but couldn't guarantee because Earth medicine didn't apply cleanly to Earth biology operating inside an alien biosphere.

Yuki's fracture was bad. Not the bone — the bone Haruki could set. The laceration where the exposed substrate had torn her calf open. Deep, contaminated with the mineral-rich soil the colony lived on, the same soil that grew their food and killed their infections with equal chemical indifference.

Haruki worked on her for three days. Dana brought compounds. Cole adjusted the work rotation to cover Yuki's water system shifts. Ren inspected the path and found what she'd expected: the erosion she'd

flagged, advancing at the pace erosion advanced, unmarked by anyone because the maintenance rotation hadn't reached it.

Yuki died on Day 14. The infection had entered the bone. Haruki's native compounds slowed it. Didn't stop it. The planet's microbiology worked on different rules than Earth's, and the rules changed with the orbital phase, and the phase-three recovery that had been milder in every other respect had produced a soil chemistry that was, in this specific interaction with this specific wound, aggressively pathogenic.

Thirty.

Ren stood at the erosion site the evening after and looked at the three-meter drop to the bedrock below. The cairns she'd placed in Month 24 were still visible. Warnings that nobody had acted on. Not because they didn't care. Because the bandwidth to care about an erosion flag was the same bandwidth required to maintain the water system, inspect the shelters, manage the agricultural rotation, monitor the creep perimeter, attend council, eat, sleep, and continue existing on a planet that demanded attention the way a newborn demanded attention — constantly, indiscriminately, with no regard for what else you were carrying.

She added the path repair to the next day's work schedule. Moved two people from agricultural duty. Got it done. The fix took four hours and should have taken one, because the two people she'd pulled from agriculture were tired in the specific way that twenty-seven months of unbroken labor made people tired — not exhaustion, which implied a recoverable state, but depletion. The body's reserves drawn down to a level where every task took longer and every shortcut became tempting and every temptation was a risk that the colony's shrinking margin couldn't absorb.

Month 28, Day 23. The water.

The filtration system at Junction 4 had been jury-rigged in Month 9. Ren remembered building it. She'd designed the original assembly from Asterlyne's components — standard colony water purification, rated for twenty people and eighteen months. By Month 9, the colony had thirty-nine people and a water supply that flowed through channels carved by something ancient and filled with mineral concentrations the original filtration media couldn't handle.

She'd redesigned the system. Pulled the polymer membrane from the backup unit — the unit that was supposed to be redundant, the fail-safe that lived in a crate marked EMERGENCY in Asterlyne's stenciled corporate font. She'd cut the membrane to fit the junction housing, sealed it with Dana's botanical adhesive, and installed it with the confidence of an engineer who understood that improvisation was just engineering with less margin.

Nineteen months later, the seal failed.

Not the membrane. The membrane was holding — degraded, operating at sixty percent of its original efficacy, but holding. The seal. Dana's botanical adhesive had been formulated for the planet's phase-one chemistry, and the compound's binding properties had shifted across two orbital transitions in ways Dana hadn't predicted because predicting required testing and testing required time and materials the colony didn't have. The adhesive softened. The seal separated. A gap opened between the membrane and the housing — millimeters, invisible from outside, enough.

Unfiltered channel water entered the settlement's drinking supply for approximately thirty-six hours before Dana caught it in a routine quality check. Thirty-six hours. Not long. Long enough.

The channel water was clean by most measures — the ancient infrastructure filtered sediment and the mineral concentrations that had challenged the original filtration system were within tolerable ranges during phase three. But the water carried something Dana identified after the fact: a microbial load from the channel network's deeper sections, where the mineralized creep compound created an environment that

fostered organisms adapted to the planet's specific chemistry. The organisms were benign in the channels. In human digestive systems, they produced a toxin that attacked the intestinal lining with a specificity that suggested the chemistry was incidental, not hostile. The planet hadn't designed a weapon. The planet had produced a molecule that happened to be incompatible with human tissue the way pollen happened to be incompatible with certain immune systems.

Twelve colonists showed symptoms within forty-eight hours. Nausea, cramping, dehydration. Haruki triaged. Most recovered in three to five days. Dana synthesized a binding agent from native compounds that neutralized the toxin in the gut.

Two didn't recover.

Kenji, forty-one, the colony's secondary communications technician. He'd been maintaining the relay equipment since Ren had taught him the system in Month 14. Quiet, reliable, the kind of person who occupied his role with the minimum of friction and the maximum of competence. The toxin hit him harder than the others — Haruki couldn't explain why without the diagnostic equipment he didn't have. Some bodies were more susceptible. Some systems were already closer to the edge. Kenji's system had been running at deficit longer than most, because communications maintenance meant irregular sleep patterns aligned to the magnetic window schedule, and irregular sleep compounded across months into the kind of physiological debt that a healthy body could carry and a depleted body couldn't.

Kenji died on Day 28. Haruki said organ failure. The clinical term for a body that had been asked to do too much for too long and stopped.

A woman named Priti, thirty-six, agricultural team. She'd been one of Dana's first students in the field — learning the soil cycle, the planting schedules, the native species that supplemented the colony's food supply. She'd been rationing herself. Ren discovered this afterward, when she went through Priti's shelter and found the food stores — portions set aside, carefully wrapped, dated. Priti had been eating two-thirds of her allocation for at least two months, hiding the remainder in her shelter. Not hoarding. Giving. The surplus portions had been appearing in the common stores, unlabeled, and Cole's inventory system had logged them as rounding variance.

Priti's reserves were already gone when the contaminated water hit her system. Her body couldn't mount the response. Dana's binding agent arrived too late for tissue that was already compromised by months of self-imposed deficit. She died on Day 30, two days after Kenji, and Ren sat with her because Haruki was treating the other ten and Cole was recalculating the water system and someone needed to be in the room when a woman who'd been feeding the colony with her own portion stopped breathing.

Twenty-eight.

Ren repaired Junction 4. Replaced the seal with a new formulation Dana developed in three hours of focused lab work — a phase-three-stable adhesive that would hold until the next orbital transition, probably. Tested the entire filtration network. Found two more junctions where the original adhesive was degrading. Replaced those too. Added a weekly seal inspection to the maintenance rotation, which was already longer than the available labor could cover.

The system was fixed. The two people it had killed were buried in the soil of the slope below the settlement, alongside the others, in graves that faced the spiral trees because someone — Ren didn't know who, it had started before anyone decided it formally — had established the convention that the dead should face the forest. As if the trees were something to look at. As if looking mattered once you'd stopped.

Month 29. The respiratory infection moved through the colony like weather.

Mild. Dana said so. Haruki confirmed. A pathogen that had mutated somewhere in the closed ecosystem of thirty human bodies living in proximity on an alien world — not the fever of Month 17, which had been vicious and fast, but something lower-grade. Cough, fatigue, mild temperature elevation. Dana had compounds. The native antiviral she'd developed during the fever was effective at lower doses. The infection would run its course in seven to ten days. Nobody should die.

Ren watched it move through the colony and thought about the word *should*. An engineering word. Load capacity: this beam *should* hold. Structural integrity: this seal *should* last. The word carried a confidence interval that nobody stated, and the confidence interval was where the failures lived.

Twenty-two colonists caught it. Some shook it in four days. Some took the full ten. Most continued working, because the colony didn't have the margin for twenty-two people to rest simultaneously. They worked slower, coughed into their elbows, took Dana's compounds, and moved through the settlement with the glazed determination of people who'd been sick before and would be sick again and had learned that illness on Parcel 16b was a tax, not a crisis.

A colonist named Emile didn't recover.

Emile, forty-eight, construction and maintenance. He'd been one of the quieter members of the colony — not withdrawn, not antisocial, just a man who showed up for shifts and did his work and ate in the common area and spoke when spoken to and occupied the specific social niche of a person whose reliability was his identity. Ren had worked with him on the relocation in Month 10. He'd carried more than his share without mentioning it. He'd been carrying more than his share ever since.

His reserves were gone. Not in the way Priti's had been — Emile ate his full allocation, slept his assigned hours, followed every protocol. But the reserves weren't measured in food and sleep alone. They were measured in the accumulated deficit of twenty-nine months of labor without rest, twenty-nine months of grief absorbed without processing, twenty-nine months of the specific toll that living on the margin extracted from bodies that had been designed by evolution for a planet that wasn't this one.

The infection settled into his lungs. Dana's compounds managed the viral load but the secondary bacterial infection — the one Haruki had warned about, the one that happened when a respiratory pathogen weakened the tissue enough for the planet's ubiquitous microbial community to colonize — moved faster than the treatment. Haruki escalated. Used the last of three different antimicrobial preparations. The planet's biology, as it had with Sarah's wound infection twenty-three months ago, didn't respond the way Earth medicine expected.

Emile died on Day 19 of Month 29. In his sleep. Haruki found him during the morning check — still in his cot, face turned toward the shelter wall, the cough finally quiet. The silence of a body that had stopped asking for help because the body had stopped.

Twenty-seven.

Ren helped carry him to the slope. She dug. The soil was loose in phase three — dark, mineral-rich, the soil Dana harvested for the creep catalyst. Good soil. The kind of soil that grew things. They put Emile in it and Ren stood at the grave and thought about the confidence interval hiding inside the word *should* and how the interval was wider than anyone admitted and the failures it contained were people.

Month 30, Day 6. The cascade.

A communication oversight: Cole's revised water system schedule hadn't been updated on the common board after Junction 4's repair. The old schedule showed a monitoring rotation that no longer existed. Ren's repair had changed the checkpoint sequence, and the change had been communicated verbally to the water

team but not recorded in writing because the colony's administrative bandwidth — the capacity to document, distribute, and verify procedural changes — had been degrading alongside everything else.

A supply miscalculation: the agricultural team, short-staffed after Priti's death and the respiratory infection's residual drag on productivity, miscounted a harvest. Twelve kilograms of native grain stored in the secondary shelter instead of the primary cold store. The grain spoiled in forty-eight hours. Not a crisis in isolation. Twelve kilograms was two days of supplemental calories for twenty-seven people. The deficit propagated through Cole's rationing tiers and produced a three-day stretch where the colony ate at baseline instead of standard.

A fall: a colonist named Deshi, thirty-nine, on reduced calories and the tail end of the respiratory infection, working a perimeter check that should have been routine. The terrain between the settlement and the southern water array — the same path where Yuki had fallen, now repaired — required attention at a switchback where the slope steepened. Deshi's attention was divided. His body was depleted. He stepped wrong. Not the erosion this time — just the specific failure of a tired foot on uneven ground.

The fall broke his wrist. Not his ankle, not his leg. His wrist. A minor injury. Haruki splinted it. Deshi returned to light duty in two days.

Then the infection. The same soil-borne pathogen that had killed Yuki. The wrist laceration was small — a scrape from the substrate, barely deep enough to warrant the antibacterial wash Haruki applied. But the phase-three microbiology didn't need depth. It needed access. The organisms entered through the scrape and the infection moved through tissue that was already operating at deficit — reduced calories, depleted immune reserves, the respiratory infection's inflammatory residue still drawing resources the body didn't have.

Deshi's wrist swelled. Then his forearm. Dana brought compounds. Haruki escalated treatment. The infection responded initially — plateaued, retreated, gave every indication of the slow, grudging recovery the colony had come to expect from the planet's biology interacting with Earth medicine. Then it advanced again. The plateau had been a pause, not a reversal. The organisms adapted, or the body's defenses failed to sustain the counter-response, or some combination of variables that Haruki couldn't isolate without equipment he didn't have.

Deshi died on Day 14. A communication oversight that led to a supply miscalculation that led to reduced calories that led to a routine fall that led to a minor laceration that led to an infection that led to a death. Each link in the chain was small. Each link was survivable in isolation. The chain killed him because the colony didn't have the bandwidth to catch any single link before it connected to the next.

Twenty-six.

Cole stood at the perimeter the evening after Deshi's burial and Ren found him there. She didn't need to ask what he was doing. He was counting. He was always counting. But the posture was different from the morning walks. In the mornings, the count was maintenance — verification, the daily audit of a system's critical metric. In the evenings, after a death, the count was something else. Ren could see it in the line of his shoulders, the way his hands hung at his sides, the specific stillness of a man who was holding a number inside his body and the number was heavier than the numbers used to be.

"Twenty-six," he said. Not to her. To the perimeter. To the trees.

"The margin is three."

"Two." He turned. His face was neutral. The machinery behind it wasn't. "Twenty-four is the threshold. I need twenty-four at five years. The margin is two."

Ren did the subtraction. Thirty months gone. Thirty months left. Two people between the clause's threshold and failure. Two people between the colony owning its land and Asterlyne owning everything.

"The planet's milder now," she said. "The third cycle is —"

"The planet isn't killing us anymore." Cole's voice was flat. Not cold — flat, the way a surface is flat when what's underneath it has been compressed. "Yuki fell because a path eroded and nobody fixed it. Kenji and Priti died because a seal failed and we didn't have replacement parts. Emile died because a mild infection met a body that had nothing left. Deshi died because nobody updated a schedule." He looked at her. "The colony is killing the colony."

Ren didn't argue. She couldn't. The engineering analysis was identical to Cole's: the system was failing not from external load but from internal fatigue. The components were worn. The maintenance intervals were exceeded. The redundancy had been consumed by twenty-nine months of operating beyond design specification. The planet hadn't changed. The colony had depleted.

"Then we maintain harder," she said.

"We're maintaining at capacity. There is no harder. There's fewer people doing the same work, which means more fatigue, which means more errors, which means more deaths, which means fewer people." He paused. "It's a feedback loop. Elena's colony hit it at nine. We're hitting it at twenty-six."

"Elena's colony didn't have Dana's compounds. Or the creep solution. Or the council. Or each other."

Cole looked at her for longer than he usually looked at anything. The machinery behind his face was doing something Ren couldn't read — not calculation, not the recalibration she'd learned to recognize. Something that operated in a register she didn't have access to, the way certain frequencies were inaudible not because they didn't exist but because the equipment couldn't detect them.

"Each other," he said.

"That's what I said."

He didn't answer. He turned back to the perimeter. The trees hummed. The sky shifted from green to the deeper green-black of the planet's night cycle, the stars overhead different from Earth's in ways Ren had stopped cataloging because the catalog changed nothing and the difference was just the distance, expressed in light.

She stood next to him. Not talking. The silence between them was different from the silence between Cole and the perimeter. The perimeter silence was a man counting. This silence was two people sharing the weight of a number that neither of them could carry alone, in a place where carrying things alone was how people died.

They stood there until the hum shifted to its nighttime frequency, and then they walked back to the settlement together, and the walking was enough.

The storm hit on Day 19 of Month 30.

Not a major event. The colony had survived worse — the wind events of phase two, the temperature crashes that had killed Noor during the relocation, the electrical storms of Month 15 that had shut down the relay for three days. This was a phase-three storm: rain-heavy, low wind, the planet's atmosphere redistributing moisture with a patient thoroughness that soaked the soil and swelled the channel network and turned the settlement's drainage paths into temporary streams.

Ren's infrastructure held. The shelters she'd designed for the high ground channeled water through the carved bedrock the way the ancient builders had intended — off the living surfaces, into the channel

network, down the gradient to the lower elevations where the creep had been neutralized. The water system absorbed the surge. The agricultural plots, planted in Dana's phase-three-optimized locations, drained without flooding. Twenty-seven months of engineering, maintained by twenty-six people running on less than they needed, and the system held.

The storm passed in nine hours. The colony emerged to assess damage. Minor: two shelter panels displaced, a section of perimeter fencing pulled loose by a drainage channel that had overspilled its banks, tool storage containers that had shifted in the mud.

And something else.

A colonist named Ora found it on the southern slope, near the path where Yuki had fallen. The storm's runoff had cut a new channel through the loose soil — a narrow erosion line, half a meter deep, following the terrain's natural gradient toward the bedrock. At the bottom of the new channel, exposed by the water's passage, sat a piece of equipment.

It was small. Rectangular. Polymer casing, dark gray, with a seam line that indicated it opened. Not colony equipment. Not from the supply manifest. Not from any inventory Ren maintained. The casing was scuffed and soil-stained but intact — designed for environmental exposure, rated for conditions that suggested its manufacturer had expected it to be outside, hidden, operating unattended.

Ora brought it to the common area. Set it on the workbench. Three colonists gathered. Ren arrived within minutes — any unidentified equipment was her domain, and the colony's protocol for found objects was simple: don't open it, don't activate it, bring it to engineering.

She examined the casing. The polymer was high-grade — better than anything in the colony's supply chain, better than Asterlyne's standard-issue equipment. The seam line ran along the long axis. No visible fasteners. Magnetic closure, probably. She turned it in her hands and found the manufacturer's mark embossed in the casing's underside: a small logo, half-obscured by soil, that she didn't recognize.

Dana arrived. Ren saw her cross the common area with the particular stride Dana used when she was moving toward something instead of away from it — faster than her usual pace, her face carrying an expression Ren couldn't parse. Not surprise. Not curiosity. Something sharper. Something that had its own momentum.

"Let me see it," Dana said.

Ren handed her the device. Dana turned it over. Her hands were steady. Her face was not. Something passed across it — a microexpression, the kind Ren had learned to read in structural inspections when a hairline crack told you more than the intact surface surrounding it.

Dana looked at Ren. Then at the three colonists standing around the workbench. Then at the common area entrance, where Cole was walking toward them, drawn by the same signal that drew everyone — the disruption in routine, the gravity of anomaly.

"I know what this is," Dana said.

Her voice was even. The steadiness was the kind Ren recognized from her own experience — not calm but controlled, the specific sound of a person managing the distance between what they felt and what they showed because the distance was the only thing keeping the structure from shifting.

Ren watched Dana hold the device and saw the crack widen. Not in the casing. In Dana's composure. In the architecture of a woman who'd been holding something for a long time and the ground had just moved underneath it.

"Dana," Ren said.

Dana set the device on the workbench. Her hands left it slowly, the way hands leave something they've held for too long — not releasing but relinquishing. She looked at Ren. The look was the longest Dana had ever sustained eye contact with anyone in the colony, and Ren, who found direct eye contact natural, felt the weight of it. Something was being communicated in the look that Dana's words hadn't carried. A freight. A confession that hadn't started yet but was already in the room.

Cole reached the workbench. Looked at the device. Looked at Dana.

The silence in the common area had the particular density of air before a storm — charged, heavy, the kind of silence that wasn't absence but presence. The sound of something about to happen.

Dana picked up the device. Held it against her body the way a person holds something that belongs to them. And Ren, watching from two meters away with the structural awareness she'd spent thirty years developing, felt the load shift.

Chapter 21 — "Confession"

Dana held the device against her ribs and walked out of the common area without looking back.

She could feel Ren's eyes on her. Cole's. The three colonists at the workbench. The weight of their attention was physical — a pressure between her shoulder blades that she carried across the common area and down the path toward the shelters, the polymer casing warm against her body from thirty months of burial and the heat of her hands.

She didn't run. Running would have been an answer to a question nobody had asked yet. She walked at the pace of a woman returning to her shelter with a piece of equipment, which was true, and the truth of it was the thinnest skin over the thing underneath, and the thing underneath was thirty months of transmissions and sixty thousand credits and a company that had asked her to identify who to kill.

The comm unit. Her comm unit. The spectrometer housing had split during the burial — the storm's erosion or the soil chemistry or time doing what time did to polymer under alien conditions. The comm array was exposed. The encoding board visible through the crack in the casing. Anyone with technical knowledge — Ren, certainly, within minutes — would have identified it. Not a spectrometer. Not agricultural equipment. A transmitter.

Dana reached her shelter. Set the device on her cot. Stood over it with her hands at her sides and breathed.

Six months of silence. She'd stopped transmitting on Day 14 of Month 24, the day FIELD-SUPPORT-7's instructions had arrived with the efficiency of a surgical instrument: *Assess structural dependency on individual colonists. Identify single points of failure.* She'd read the words on the two-inch screen and felt the mechanism she'd been operating inside complete its transformation — from data collection to targeting to something she didn't have a euphemism for.

She'd powered down the spectrometer. Wrapped it in a sample cloth. Walked to the southern slope at dawn and buried it in loose soil near the path to the water array, thirty centimeters deep, covered with a flat rock she could find again if she needed to.

She'd never gone back. Six months. The longest silence since she'd activated the comm unit on Day 1. FIELD-SUPPORT-7 had received no reports, no data, no acknowledgment. Just absence. The asset gone dark. Asterlyne's feed cut. The company recalculating in the gap Dana left, which was the same gap the wellness check had tried to fill, which was the same gap Cole had refused to close.

And now the storm had dug it up. The planet's own erosion, impartial, bringing buried things to the surface the way the creep brought mineralized layers up through the substrate. The planet didn't care what was hidden. The planet cycled.

Dana looked at the device on her cot. The cracked casing. The encoding board's circuitry visible through the split. The manufacturer's mark that wasn't Asterlyne's standard issue because it wasn't standard issue — it was intelligence hardware, purpose-built, given to her in a windowless office by people whose names she'd never learned.

She could destroy it. Right now. Break the casing, pull the board, crush the components, scatter the pieces in the channel network where the mineralized substrate would absorb them. Nobody had examined it. Ren had held it but hadn't opened it. The three colonists at the workbench hadn't known what they were looking at. Cole had arrived but Dana had taken it before he'd touched it. The window was open. She could close it.

She could keep the secret for the rest of her life on this planet. Carry it the way she'd carried it for thirty months — in the space between the real work and the hidden work, in the gap between the person the colony trusted and the person Asterlyne had contracted.

Dana sat on the edge of her cot. The device beside her. The shelter quiet. The hum of the trees pressing through the walls — the same frequency she'd been hearing since Day 1, the one that lived in the chest.

Elena Vasik's words arrived the way they'd been arriving for months, unbidden, in moments when Dana's own language failed.

We stopped being worth keeping alive.

Not to the planet. To each other.

Dana had read that entry on the common shelter board six months ago, standing in the doorway after excusing herself from the evening meal. Elena's diagnosis of a colony that died not from external threat but from internal erosion — the slow withdrawal of investment, the quiet subtraction of trust, the mathematics of people who stopped being a group and became bodies dying in proximity.

Dana was the erosion. She was the quiet subtraction. She'd been transmitting the colony's data to the company that had abandoned them for twenty months, and the data had been used to calculate the minimum viable engagement, and the minimum had been nothing, and Dana had kept transmitting anyway because the debt was real and the rationalization was functional and stopping meant confronting the gap between what she'd done and what she told herself she'd done.

She'd stopped. Six months ago. But stopping wasn't confession. Stopping was a closed valve. The pressure behind it remained.

Dana picked up the device. Held it in both hands. The weight was negligible — four ounces of circuitry and polymer. The weight of what it represented was something she'd been carrying in her body for thirty months, and the body was tired of it, and the tiredness wasn't exhaustion but the specific depletion of a person who had been two people for too long.

She stood up. Walked out of her shelter. Turned left toward Cole's.

Cole's shelter was the smallest in the settlement.

Dana had noticed this the way she noticed everything about the colony's infrastructure — as data, cataloged and filed in the part of her mind that ran continuously whether she wanted it to or not. The shelter he'd built during the relocation was six square meters. Ren's was eight. The common shelter was twenty. Even Joss Carver's shared quarters were larger. Cole had allocated himself the minimum — a cot, a desk built from salvaged panels, storage for the data core and the paper supply and the inventory records he maintained by hand. The space of a man who'd given everything to the system and kept the smallest room for himself.

He was there. Sitting at the desk. The data core in its crate underneath, closed — he'd stopped reading Elena's logs months ago, but the crate was still there, the way a finished book stays on a shelf. The paper was out. He was working on something — the rationing calculations, probably, or the maintenance schedule revisions that followed every death like administrative grief.

Dana stood in the entrance. The shelter had no door. None of them did. Privacy on the planet was a matter of convention, not construction — you didn't enter someone's shelter uninvited the way you didn't read someone's correspondence. The social architecture Ren had built, functioning on trust.

Trust Dana had been violating since Day 1.

"Cole."

He looked up. His face did the thing it always did — the neutral assessment, the machinery behind the expression calculating inputs. He saw her. Saw the device in her hands. Registered the anomaly of Dana Wen standing in his shelter entrance holding a piece of equipment that wasn't agricultural.

"The thing from the storm."

"Yes."

"Ren couldn't identify it."

"Ren didn't get the chance." Dana stepped inside. The shelter was small enough that two people standing changed its character — from solitary to occupied, from Cole's space to shared space. She could feel the threshold she was crossing, and it wasn't the physical one. "I took it before she could open it."

Cole's eyes went to the device. Then to Dana's face. Then back to the device. The calculation was visible — the specific pattern of a man who processed information by running it against every framework he'd built and checking for fit.

"It's yours," he said.

Not a question. Dana felt the sentence land with the precision Cole applied to everything. He'd seen her cross the common area with the particular stride she used when she was moving toward something instead of away from it. He'd seen the microexpression Ren had seen. He'd arrived at a conclusion before Dana had spoken a word, because Cole's frameworks included a model of every person in the colony, and Dana's model had a gap in it that he'd been looking at for longer than she knew.

"It's mine."

She set the device on his desk. The sound it made against the salvaged panel was small and final. Cole looked at it. Didn't touch it.

"Tell me," he said.

She told him everything.

Not selectively. Not in the calibrated portions she'd been managing for thirty months — the data separated from the intelligence, the observation distinguished from the betrayal, the careful language that let her believe she was reporting and not destroying. She told him everything because the device was on his desk and the split casing was showing the encoding board and the pretense that it was a spectrometer was lying on the floor between them where pretenses went when they stopped working.

The contract. The windowless office on the fourth floor of the onboarding center, three days before launch, while Cole was one floor below reading the charter that would become the colony's constitution. The technical team that modified the spectrometer — or built the spectrometer around the comm unit, she'd never been sure which came first, the science or the surveillance. The designation: FIELD-SUPPORT-7. The eleven-day transmission cycle aligned to the magnetic window. The reporting categories: soil, crops, water, weather, equipment, population, leadership, morale, conflict.

The debt. Sixty thousand credits. Her mother's oncology treatment — the three-year protocol that had saved a life and generated a bill that would follow Dana into any future she tried to build. Asterlyne's offer: two years of reports, debt erased. The simplicity of the transaction. The specific clarity of a number large enough to make you stop calculating and start rationalizing.

The transmissions. Twenty months. Reports that started as data and became intelligence and became targeting. The shift she'd felt in Month 14 when the questions changed — coordinates, water sources, structural vulnerabilities, single points of failure. The lies she'd embedded — the offset coordinates, the inflated structural ratings, the cross-training fiction. The lies that let her believe she was managing the damage instead of causing it.

The creep solution. Transmitted in full. The synthesis protocol she'd held back in Month 14, released in Month 21 because the data was complete and the rationalization was exhausted. The knowledge that Asterlyne now possessed everything they needed to neutralize the planet's primary threat without the colonists. The knowledge that she'd made them expendable.

The stopping. Month 24. FIELD-SUPPORT-7's final instruction: *Identify single points of failure.* The moment the mechanism she'd been operating inside completed its transformation and Dana couldn't pretend the transformation was something else. She'd buried the device. Six months of silence. No final report. No explanation. Just absence.

She told him all of it standing in his six-square-meter shelter, her hands empty, the device on the desk between them like evidence at a trial that hadn't started yet.

Cole listened.

He listened the way he listened to everything — completely, without interruption, his face in the neutral state that wasn't blankness but processing. His body was still. His hands were on the desk, palms down, fingers spread slightly, the posture of a man who was holding himself in place while the information rearranged something inside him.

When she finished, the shelter was quiet. The hum of the trees outside. The distant sound of the colony's evening activity — voices, movement, the sound of twenty-six people who didn't know what Dana had just said.

Cole's face did something she hadn't seen before. The neutral shifted — not to anger, not to the cold assessment she'd expected, not to the calculated response of a man running a variable through a framework. The shift was smaller than that. A recalibration. The specific movement of a man who had built a model that contained a gap and was now watching the gap fill with something that changed the model's outputs without breaking the model itself.

He'd known. Not the specifics. Not the device or the designation or the transmission cycle. But the gap in Dana's model — the space where the data didn't fit, where her behavior had edges that didn't align with the person she presented — he'd been looking at that gap. He'd chosen not to fill it. The recalibration wasn't surprise. It was confirmation arriving in a shape he'd been holding space for.

"Are you still transmitting?"

One question. The only question that mattered operationally. Not *why* or *how could you* or the moral architecture that would come later. Are you still transmitting. Present tense. Active threat or historical damage.

"No. Six months."

"Why now?"

The question wasn't about the storm. Wasn't about the device surfacing. The question was about Dana standing in his shelter instead of burying the device again, deeper, somewhere the erosion couldn't reach.

Dana looked at the comm unit on his desk. The cracked casing. The encoding board that had carried thirty months of data from the planet's surface to a relay satellite to a corporate endpoint where people she'd never met used her observations to calculate the colony's expendability. She looked at it and felt the weight of it in her body — not the four ounces of hardware but the thirty months of carrying two identities in one frame, the specific exhaustion of a person who had been the most useful and the most dangerous and had run out of the energy required to be both.

"Because I'm not worth keeping alive if I don't."

The words came out steady. She'd been holding them for months — not rehearsing, not planning. Holding. The way you hold a weight you've been carrying too long, the muscles locked in position until the position becomes the person, until letting go requires more effort than holding on. Elena's words, traveling through her. The dead scientist's diagnosis, applied to the living traitor.

Cole heard it. She watched him hear it — the sentence landing in the framework he'd built, the framework that contained Elena's logs and the colony's count and the specific gravity of every person who'd died and every person who remained. He heard Elena's words inside Dana's voice and the recognition crossed his face like a shadow passing.

He looked at the device. Then at Dana. The machinery behind his expression completed its cycle and what emerged was something she hadn't calculated for.

Not forgiveness. The word was too large, too clean, too complete for what she saw. Something smaller. Harder. More useful. The expression of a man who had been doing math on human survival for thirty months and had learned that the math included damage, included betrayal, included the specific weight of a person who had saved the colony with the same hands that sold it, and the subtraction of that person would cost more than the damage she'd done.

"How much did they pay you?"

"Sixty thousand. Medical debt. My mother."

Cole nodded. The nod was small. Not absolution. Acknowledgment. He knew what debt did. He'd watched forty-seven people sign a charter because Earth had made staying more expensive than leaving. He'd been one of them.

"Who else knows?"

"Nobody."

"The council. Ren."

"Nobody," Dana said. "Just you."

Cole sat with that. She watched him process the isolation of her position — thirty months of carrying the secret alone, six months of carrying the silence alone, and now the confession delivered to one person in a six-square-meter shelter while the colony ate dinner fifty meters away.

"Stay here," he said.

He stood. Walked out. Dana stood in his shelter alone with the device on his desk and listened to his footsteps recede and didn't move.

He came back with Ren.

Ren's face when she entered the shelter was the face of an engineer who'd detected a structural failure and was already calculating the load redistribution. She looked at Dana. Looked at the device on the desk. Looked at Cole.

"Tell her," Cole said.

Dana told her.

The second telling was different from the first. Not in content — she gave Ren the same account, complete, unedited. The difference was in what the telling cost. The first confession had been extraction — pulling something out of herself that had been embedded for thirty months, the pain of removal. The second was

exposure — standing in front of a woman who'd built the colony's democratic architecture on the principle of shared information and shared consequence, and admitting that Dana had been the violation of that principle since before the architecture existed.

Ren listened differently than Cole. Cole listened with his body still and his face neutral, processing. Ren listened with her arms crossed and her jaw set and her eyes fixed on Dana with the direct contact that some people found aggressive and Dana, in this moment, found appropriate. Ren's anger wasn't performed. It was structural — the response of a system that had been compromised at a load-bearing joint.

When Dana finished, Ren's first word was not a question.

"A vote."

Cole: "No."

"The colony decides. That's the system. That's what we built."

"Not at twenty-six."

The argument was fast. Contained. Two people who'd been arguing for thirty months and had developed the specific efficiency of disagreement that came from shared investment. Ren's position was principle: the colony had a right to know that its data had been transmitted to the company that abandoned them. Every person who'd trusted Dana with their food systems, their medical compounds, their survival — they deserved to decide what happened next. Democracy wasn't a luxury. Democracy was the architecture that kept them from becoming Elena's colony.

Cole's position was arithmetic: the colony was at twenty-six. The margin was two. A revelation of this magnitude would fracture whatever social cohesion they'd rebuilt since the fever, since the creep solution, since the slow bleeding of Months 27 through 30. The fracture would cascade. People would stop trusting Dana's agricultural data. They'd stop trusting the creep solution. They'd stop trusting each other, because if Dana had been transmitting, who else might be? The paranoia would consume the bandwidth they didn't have, and the bandwidth deficit would produce errors, and the errors would produce deaths, and the deaths would subtract from a number that couldn't afford subtraction.

"You can't decide this for thirty people," Ren said.

"I'm not deciding for thirty people. I'm deciding for twenty-four. The twenty-four who need to be alive in two years."

"And what happens when they find out you hid it? Because they will. They always do. And then the fracture isn't about Dana. It's about you. It's about us. The council that knew and didn't tell."

Cole went quiet. Ren had found the structural flaw in his position and driven a load-bearing argument through it. He stood in his shelter with his hands at his sides and his face doing the recalculation she'd forced.

"Thirty days," he said.

"What?"

"Dana stops all contact. The device is destroyed. Tonight. The confession goes to the council in thirty days. Full colony vote after that."

"Why thirty?"

"Because I need thirty days to build the support structure that keeps the colony from collapsing when it hits." He looked at Ren. "You know I'm right."

"I know you're calculating."

"Same thing."

"It's not," Ren said. "But I'll give you the thirty days."

Dana had been standing in the shelter during the entire exchange. Neither of them had asked her opinion. She hadn't offered one. Her opinion had been forfeited thirty months ago in a windowless office on the fourth floor of an onboarding center, when she'd accepted a modified spectrometer and a designation and a debt erasure that was really a purchase.

Ren turned to her. The look was long. Direct. The engineer assessing damage, calculating repair timelines, determining whether the structure was salvageable or condemned.

"You stopped six months ago."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"They asked me to identify who to kill."

Ren's jaw tightened. The anger was still there — structural, load-bearing, not going away. But something else arrived alongside it. Not sympathy. Recognition. The specific awareness of a woman who'd signed a charter because debt had made staying impossible, looking at another woman who'd signed a different contract for the same reason.

Ren left without saying anything else. The shelter was Cole and Dana and the device on the desk and the hum of the trees and the silence that followed a structural event.

"Go to your shelter," Cole said. "Don't talk to anyone tonight."

Dana walked to the entrance. Stopped.

"Cole."

He looked at her.

"The creep solution works. The agricultural protocols work. Everything I built for the colony is real. The science was never part of the contract."

"I know," he said.

She left.

Cole waited until the colony was asleep.

The settlement quieted in stages — the common area emptying after the evening meal, shelters sealing against the night air, the last conversations trailing into the sounds of twenty-six people settling into the specific rhythms of unconsciousness. The hum of the trees deepened as the temperature dropped, the nighttime frequency that Cole felt in his sternum.

He picked up the device from his desk. Held it the way Dana had held it — against his body, the polymer casing pressing against his ribs. Four ounces. The weight of twenty months of intelligence transmitted through a spectrometer disguised as agricultural equipment, routed through a relay satellite to a company that used the data to calculate the colony's expendability. The weight of a woman's debt. A mother's oncology treatment. The specific mathematics of desperation that Asterlyne built into every contract because desperation was a resource and resources were what corporations extracted.

He walked to the perimeter. Past the shelters. Past the common area where Elena's logs still hung on the board. Past the water junction Ren had repaired and the agricultural plots Dana had mapped and the channel network that ran through the settlement's substrate like the circulatory system of something ancient and patient.

He found a flat rock at the edge of the cleared ground, where the settlement met the planet's undisturbed surface. The spiral trees stood beyond, humming. The green-shifted sky held the faint luminescence of the planet's night — not dark the way Earth was dark, but dim, the specific half-light of a world whose atmosphere scattered starlight differently.

Cole set the device on the ground. Picked up a rock. Dense, mineral-rich substrate, the same rock that had saved them from the creep. The weight of it filled his hand.

He didn't make it a ceremony. Didn't make it a lesson. Didn't think about what the device represented or what its destruction meant or the symbolism of a man breaking a woman's betrayal with the planet's own stone.

He brought the rock down. The polymer casing cracked. He hit it again. The encoding board shattered — circuitry and substrate separating, the small components that had carried Dana's reports scattering into fragments. Again. The comm array, the antenna port, the battery housing. Again. Pieces. Again. Smaller pieces.

He gathered the fragments. The planet's soil was loose at the surface — Dana's phase-three recovery, the dark mineral-rich earth that grew things. He dug with his hands. A hole the size of two fists, thirty centimeters deep. He put the fragments in and covered them. Pressed the soil flat. Placed the flat rock over the site.

The planet would absorb it. The soil chemistry would corrode the circuitry. The mineral cycles would incorporate the polymer. In a year, maybe less, the fragments would be indistinguishable from the substrate. The planet recycled everything. Even this.

Cole stood up. His hands were dirty. The soil was under his nails, in the lines of his palms, the same soil that grew the colony's food and held the colony's dead. He looked at the flat rock and the undisturbed surface around it and the spiral trees humming beyond and felt something settle in his chest that wasn't relief and wasn't satisfaction.

Mercy. The word arrived from somewhere he didn't usually access — the part of his framework that didn't run on arithmetic, the part that had cracked in the medical shelter during the fever when he'd said Lily's name aloud, the part that had widened every time a number became a face and a face became a person he couldn't afford to lose and couldn't afford to keep and kept anyway.

He'd destroyed the device himself. Hadn't asked Dana to do it. Hadn't made her watch. Hadn't turned the destruction into a consequence or a penance or a condition. He'd taken the thing from his desk and walked into the dark and broken it with a rock and buried the pieces because that was the simplest way to make it gone, and simplicity was the most merciful thing he knew how to offer.

Twenty-six. The margin was two. In thirty days the colony would learn what Dana had done, and the fracture would come, and Cole would need every hour between now and then to build the structures — social, political, logistical — that would keep the fracture from becoming a collapse. The arithmetic of mercy: destroy the weapon, preserve the person, prepare the ground.

He walked back to the settlement. His hands were dirty. He didn't wash them. The soil dried on his skin as he walked, tightening, the planet's chemistry interacting with his own in the small and constant way it had been interacting for thirty months.

He passed Dana's shelter. The light was off. She was inside, or she wasn't. It didn't matter. What mattered was that she'd walked into his shelter and told him the truth, and the truth had changed the model without breaking it, and the model — the framework he'd been building since Day Zero, the architecture of survival that held twenty-six lives in a structure of numbers and systems and the specific gravity of human persistence — the model was still standing.

He went to his shelter. Sat at his desk. The space where the device had been was empty. A clean rectangle in the faint dust, the ghost of something that had been there and wasn't.

Cole put his dirty hands on the desk and sat in the quiet and didn't count.

Chapter 22 — "The Vote"

The council learned on Day 31.

Cole had asked for thirty. Ren gave him thirty. He'd used every hour — not building alliances, not politicking, not the social architecture that came naturally to people who thought in relationships instead of systems. He'd built support structures. Redundancies. Quiet conversations with the colonists he judged most stable: Kira, whose opposition during the relocation vote had been principled and whose principles included hearing people out. Dara, whose fever had left a stiffness in her joints that slowed her mornings but not her judgment. Two others who carried weight in the colony's informal hierarchy — the hierarchy that existed underneath Ren's democratic architecture the way bedrock existed underneath soil, unseen and load-bearing.

He hadn't told them about Dana. He'd told them the colony would face a test. That cohesion would matter more than anger. That the next month would determine whether they were a group or a collection of people dying in proximity. Elena's words, weaponized for survival. Manipulative. Leadership. Same thing.

On Day 31, Cole walked to the council chamber — the largest shelter, built during the relocation, where Ren's governance system operated on a schedule of five-day meetings and the slow accumulation of collective decision-making. Seven council members sat in the arrangement Ren had designed: a rough semicircle, no head position, sight lines open. Ren at the center by convention, not authority.

Cole stood at the entrance and said, "Dana has something to tell you."

Dana walked in behind him. She carried nothing. Her hands were empty and visible at her sides, the posture of a woman who had decided that concealment was finished and the only thing left was to stand in the open and let the open do its work.

She told the council. Third time. Cole had heard the first telling in his shelter — the extraction, the device on his desk, the words coming out with the specific pain of removal. Ren had heard the second — the exposure, the democratic architect learning that her architecture had been compromised at its foundation. The third telling was different again. Public. Clinical. Dana's voice flattened to the register she used for soil chemistry reports and agricultural assessments — data delivered without inflection, because inflection would have been a request for something she'd forfeited the right to request.

The contract. The windowless office. FIELD-SUPPORT-7. The eleven-day transmission cycle. Twenty months of reports. Soil, crops, water, weather, equipment, population, leadership, morale, conflict. The shift in Month 14 — coordinates, water sources, structural vulnerabilities. The creep solution transmitted in full. The stopping. The burial. Six months of silence.

She did not say *because I'm not worth keeping alive if I don't.* That had been Cole's. Private. Between the two of them in a six-square-meter shelter with the hum of the trees outside. She gave the council the facts and let the facts speak in whatever voice the council chose to hear.

The silence after was three seconds. Cole counted.

Then Garrett Polk stood up and the silence broke.

Cole had seen Polk angry before. The transit ship, when Polk had argued against Cole's systems with the specific fury of a man who recognized institutional logic and hated it on principle. The faction months, when Polk had built a signal array from salvaged components and the conviction that calling for rescue was the only rational act. The relocation vote, when Polk had voted to move and done it loudly, choosing survival over the opposition he'd been building.

This was different. Polk didn't stand the way he stood when he was performing conviction for an audience. He stood the way a man stands when the ground shifts — fast, reactive, the body responding before the mind has processed the input.

"She was transmitting." Not a question. Polk's voice was flat. "Twenty months. To the company."

"Yes," Dana said.

"While we were dying. While the creep was eating our shelters. While we were rationing food and burying people in alien dirt. She was sending reports to the people who left us here."

"Yes."

Polk turned to Cole. The look was the one Cole had learned to read over three years — the assessment of a man who calculated differently than Cole but calculated just as constantly, running the numbers against a different framework, arriving at conclusions that were shaped by different losses.

"You knew."

"Thirty-one days."

"And you didn't tell us."

"I needed time to prepare."

"Prepare." Polk tasted the word. "You needed time to calculate."

"Yes."

Polk's jaw worked. Cole watched the muscles move under the sunburned skin and read the calculation happening behind the expression — not the performance, not the rhetoric, but the actual computation. Polk was running the same math Cole had run in his shelter thirty-one days ago. Twenty-six minus one. The subtraction and what it cost. The margin and what it meant.

"She made us expendable," Polk said. "The creep solution. She gave them the creep solution. They don't need us anymore. They can send another expedition with her data and skip the part where people die figuring it out."

"That's correct," Cole said.

"And you want to keep her."

"I want to keep twenty-six people alive."

Polk stared at him. Three years of antagonism compressed into a look that contained everything Polk had ever thought about Cole Maren — the logistics machine, the man who counted faces like inventory, the calculator who'd turned survival into arithmetic and arithmetic into authority. The look also contained something newer. Something that had been building since the relocation, since Polk had voted to move and watched the move kill two people and knew that staying would have killed more. The recognition that Cole's math wasn't wrong. That hating the math didn't make it wrong.

Three council members spoke in rapid sequence. Kira: "She betrayed every person in this settlement." Dara, rubbing the stiffness from her wrist: "We trusted her with our food systems. Our medical compounds. Our survival." A woman named Lina, water systems, who'd been at the array the morning Yuki didn't arrive: "If Asterlyne sends another expedition with her data, we lose everything. The charter. The land. Five years of dying for nothing."

"Expelled," Kira said. The word landed in the council chamber with a weight that exceeded its two syllables. "She leaves the settlement. Takes what she can carry. That's the precedent."

Cole felt the word settle into his framework. Expelled. There was nowhere to go. The original settlement was reclaimed by forest and creep. The planet's third-cycle mildness was relative — milder than the season that had spawned the creep, not mild by any standard that supported a human being alone. Expelled meant dead. Not immediately. Not cleanly. But dead, in the specific and protracted way that isolation killed on a planet whose dangers were calibrated for groups and whose mercy didn't extend to individuals.

"The precedent," Cole said, "is that we don't have one. Nobody's been expelled. The charter doesn't provide for it. Ren's governance framework doesn't include it. We'd be inventing a punishment for a crime we don't have a law for, and the punishment is death."

"The crime is treason," Lina said.

"The crime is debt," Cole said. "Sixty thousand credits. Medical. Her mother. Asterlyne offered erasure for data. The same transaction they offered all of us — sign here, leave Earth, and we'll call the ledger clean. Dana signed a different version of the same contract."

The council chamber was quiet. Cole could feel the argument landing in different ways across the seven faces — some hearing the parallel and resisting it, some hearing it and recognizing themselves in it, some hearing it and not caring because the betrayal was larger than its cause.

"That doesn't excuse it," Kira said.

"No. It explains it. And I'm not asking for excusal. I'm asking for a vote."

Ren called the vote that evening.

Not a council vote. Colony-wide. Every living colonist. The principle she'd fought for since Month 8 — that decisions affecting the whole belonged to the whole, that governance was architecture and architecture required load distribution, that no single point of failure should determine the colony's course. She'd argued for transparency when Cole wanted secrecy. She'd argued for process when Cole wanted speed. She'd given him thirty days and the thirty days were spent and the process was here.

Twenty-five people gathered in the common area after the evening meal. The space was the largest in the settlement — a shelter Ren had designed during the relocation with dimensions calculated for assembly, the ceiling high enough that voices didn't compress, the sight lines arranged so everyone could see everyone. Democratic architecture made physical.

Dana stood at the center.

Cole watched from the back. He'd said what he could say to the council. The colony was a different audience — not seven people who'd been prepared, but twenty-five who were learning now, in this room, that the woman who'd saved them from the creep had been feeding their data to the company that abandoned them. The information moved through the crowd the way the pathogen had moved through the colony in Month 17 — fast, indiscriminate, producing different reactions in different systems.

Anger. Visible in the bodies that tensed, the faces that hardened, the hands that clenched at sides. Some of it directed at Dana. Some at Cole, for the thirty-one days. Some at the colony itself — the diffuse, unfocused rage of people who'd survived everything the planet could do and were now learning that the threat had been inside the perimeter the whole time.

Fear. Quieter than the anger but deeper. If Dana was transmitting, who else? If the company had ears inside the colony for twenty months, what did they know? What had they done with it? The silence from Asterlyne

— the months of nothing, the wellness check, the gap — reframed as surveillance rather than abandonment. The two possibilities coexisted: they'd been abandoned *and* watched. The company had stopped providing but hadn't stopped collecting.

Dana stood in the middle of it and said nothing.

Cole had expected her to defend herself. A rational actor would — would explain the debt, the mother, the coercion, the stopping, the six months of silence that proved the break was real. Dana was a rational actor. She'd been calculating for thirty months, balancing the colony's survival against Asterlyne's contract with the precision of a woman who understood that both sides of the equation contained her and the equation couldn't be solved without sacrifice.

She didn't speak. She stood in the common area with her hands at her sides and her face holding an expression Cole couldn't categorize — not defiance, not contrition, not the blankness of a person who'd withdrawn. Something else. The expression of a woman who had decided that speaking was another form of management, and she was done managing. Twenty-five people would decide her fate and she would stand here while they did it, and her silence was not passivity. It was the only honest thing left.

Ren spoke first. Not as moderator — as advocate. The democratic architect arguing for the principle that underpinned the architecture: that people were more than their worst decisions, that a colony built on subtraction would subtract itself to zero, that mercy was structural, not sentimental. Her voice carried the combative precision Cole had learned over three years — the questions that were arguments, the directness that some people found aggressive and twenty-five people, in this room, needed.

Cole spoke second. Not passion. Arithmetic. Twenty-six. The clause threshold was twenty-four. The margin was two. Two years remaining. Subtracting Dana meant subtracting the colony's primary agricultural scientist, the architect of the creep solution, the person whose botanical knowledge had saved more lives than any other single factor since landing. The math didn't excuse betrayal. The math said they couldn't afford the consequence.

He watched the argument land. Some faces calculating. Some faces hardening against the calculation — hearing Cole reduce a moral question to logistics and hating him for it the way Polk had hated him for it since Day 1. Some faces caught between, which was where Cole needed them.

Garrett Polk sat at the back of the common area. He'd been silent since the council meeting. Not the performative silence of a man building to a speech — Cole knew that version of Polk, had watched it operate for three years, the rhetorical machine warming up before the declaration. This was different. Polk was sitting with his forearms on his knees and his hands hanging loose and his face pointed at the floor, and Cole couldn't read it.

The discussion ran for two hours. Voices rose and fell. Arguments circled: the betrayal, the debt, the creep solution, the count, the principle, the precedent. Kira argued for expulsion with the clarity of a woman whose convictions were load-bearing. Dara argued for a middle path — restricted access, supervised work, trust rebuilt through demonstrated loyalty. Joss Carver, twenty-five now and carrying himself with a stillness he hadn't had at twenty-two, said, "She stopped. That matters." Lina said, "She stopped because they asked her to pick targets. What if they'd asked her something smaller? Would she have stopped then?"

Nobody could answer that. Dana didn't answer it. She stood in the center and let the question exist.

Cole watched Polk the way he'd watched the creep advance — tracking movement, calculating trajectory, waiting for the turn.

It came at the end.

Ren called for the formal vote. Stay or expelled. Binary. The architecture of democracy reduced to its simplest load: yes or no, and each answer carrying the weight of a life. She asked for raised hands. The colony would see itself decide.

Stay went first.

Hands rose. Cole counted. He always counted. Fourteen. Then fifteen — Joss, late, his hand going up with the deliberate motion of a young man who wanted the act to mean something. Cole's hand was sixteen. Ren's seventeen. The number sat at seventeen and the room held its breath in the way rooms hold breath — not literally, but in the specific collective tension of a group watching a margin emerge.

Polk raised his hand.

Eighteen.

Cole saw it happen the way he saw everything — as data, processed through the framework, cataloged and analyzed. But the framework stuttered. Polk's hand was steady. His face was still pointed down, the expression Cole couldn't read still unreadable. The hand went up the way a structural beam accepts load — not gracefully, not willingly, but because the alternative was collapse.

Two more hands followed Polk's. Twenty. The count for expulsion was five. The margin was decisive but Cole didn't feel it as decisive. He felt it as twenty people choosing to carry a weight that five people refused, and the five weren't wrong to refuse. They were lighter. That was all.

Ren recorded the vote. Her voice was steady. "Dana Wen remains a member of this colony. The vote is twenty to five." She paused. The pause was the democratic architect honoring the process, the silence between verdict and consequence. "The record requires a stated reason from each voter. For the record."

The reasons accumulated. Cole listened. Most were practical — the creep solution, the agricultural knowledge, the mathematical argument he'd made. Some were principled — Ren's mercy, Joss's belief in the capacity for change. Some were blunt: "I don't forgive her. I need her."

Polk's turn. The formal question, the record.

He looked up. First time since the vote began that his eyes left the floor. Cole saw his face and the expression he hadn't been able to read resolved into something he recognized — not from Polk's repertoire of performances but from a deeper register, the one that lived underneath the rhetoric and the fury and the calculation. The expression of a man looking at a trap he understood because he'd been inside one.

"She's the reason the creep didn't eat us," Polk said.

Five words. Factual. Sufficient for the record. Polk sat back. His hand dropped. Cole watched him and saw what the five words didn't carry — the weight behind them, the thing Polk didn't say and wouldn't say and didn't need to say because Cole, who had spent three years reading Garrett Polk's calculations, could see the variable that had tipped the math.

Polk knew what it felt like to be locked into a deal that looked like freedom until the terms revealed themselves. He'd signed a co-op charter on Earth that had been rational, principled, correct. The numbers worked until the system didn't. He'd signed the Asterlyne charter because geography was the only surrender he could afford. He'd built a signal array because calling for rescue was the only escape he could calculate. Every contract Polk had ever signed had become a cage, and Dana's Asterlyne deal — the debt, the windowless office, the modified spectrometer, the sixty thousand credits — was the same architecture.

Polk hadn't voted to save Dana. He'd voted to not watch it happen again. Cole saw it the way he saw structural failures — the specific pattern of a load that shifted not because the beam was strong but because the alternative was a collapse the beam couldn't witness.

Cole didn't say any of this. Didn't acknowledge it. Polk wouldn't have wanted acknowledgment. The vote was enough. The hand raised, the five words spoken, the record closed. Something had shifted in Polk — not a reversal, not an apology, not the dramatic conversion that stories demanded. A small thing. A recognition that math — his, Cole's, anyone's — didn't protect you from the cost of staying. The recognition lived in the hand he'd raised and the face he'd pointed at the floor and the five words that said one thing and meant another.

Trust shattered differently than shelters.

Shelters broke along stress lines — predictable, visible, repairable with the right materials and enough labor. Trust broke along fault lines nobody had mapped, in directions nobody had predicted, producing damage that couldn't be measured with Ren's engineering instruments or tracked in Cole's inventory.

The colony's trust in Dana fractured cleanly. People who'd worked beside her in the agricultural plots, who'd learned her planting schedules, who'd eaten food she'd grown and taken compounds she'd synthesized — they looked at her differently now. Not with hatred, which would have been simpler. With the specific recalibration of people who'd discovered that a foundation they'd built on was made of different material than they'd assumed. The work continued. Dana's knowledge was irreplaceable. But the conversations shortened. The eye contact reduced. The invisible architecture of social proximity — who sat near whom at meals, who walked beside whom on paths, who spoke first in shared spaces — rearranged itself around the new information.

The colony's trust in Cole fractured differently. He'd known for thirty-one days. He'd prepared instead of disclosing. The thirty days he'd asked for and Ren had granted were, for some colonists, thirty days of deception by a different name. Cole heard it in the council meetings that followed — the questions that weren't questions, the pauses that lasted a beat too long, the specific attention people paid to his statements as if checking each sentence for what it concealed.

He absorbed it. The same way he absorbed the count — as data, load-bearing, structural. The colony's trust in him had always been conditional. They trusted his math. They trusted his systems. They trusted that when he said twenty-four, he meant twenty-four, and the number carried the weight of every decision he'd made to reach it. The thirty-one days had introduced a variable the trust hadn't accounted for: Cole's willingness to withhold. The variable changed the equation without breaking it. The math still held. The man behind the math had become opaque.

Ren's trust was the hardest to track because Ren didn't fracture the way other people fractured. She processed damage the way she processed structural loads — silently, in a framework that wasn't visible from outside, producing results measured in decisions rather than expressions. She continued to walk the perimeter with Cole in the pre-dawn. She continued to argue with him in council. The arguments were the same. The silences between them were different — carrying a weight that hadn't been there before the thirty-one days, the specific gravity of a compromise she'd granted against her principles because his arithmetic had been correct.

The rebuilding took months. Not a project. Not a plan. An accretion. Trust returned in small deposits — a shared meal where someone sat next to Dana by choice instead of proximity. A council meeting where Cole's recommendation was accepted without the pause. A morning where Ren's silence felt like companionship instead of assessment.

The colony rebuilt something more fragile than shelters. Fragile wasn't weak. Fragile was honest. The thing they'd had before — the assumption of shared purpose, the unexamined conviction that everyone inside the perimeter was working toward the same survival — that had been strong and false. What replaced it was weaker and true. They knew what they were now. A group of people who'd been betrayed by one of their

own and had chosen to keep her, because the alternative was a subtraction the math couldn't survive and the mercy couldn't afford.

Month 34, Day 11. A fall.

A colonist named Wei was reinforcing the roof structure on the secondary storage shelter — a building that housed the colony's reserve food supply and the equipment Ren had classified as critical redundancy. The shelter's support beams had been showing stress fractures for weeks. Cole had scheduled the repair. Ren had designed the reinforcement. Wei had volunteered because Wei volunteered for everything structural, the way some people volunteered as a form of communication — saying *I'm here, I'm useful, I'm worth keeping* through the language of labor.

The beam Wei was bracing shifted. Not dramatically. The kind of shift that happened when loads redistributed during repair — the structure compensating for the temporary removal of a component by transferring weight to adjacent members. The adjacent member was the beam Wei was standing on. It held for two seconds. Then it didn't.

Wei fell four meters to the substrate floor. The sound reached Cole at the water junction, sixty meters away. Not a crash — a specific, contained report, the sound of a body meeting stone at a velocity the body wasn't designed for. Cole was running before he'd processed the sound into meaning.

Haruki was there in three minutes. Wei was conscious. Breathing. The fall had broken his pelvis and three ribs and the ribs had punctured something inside that bled. Haruki worked with his steady hands and his measured voice and the native compounds Dana had developed for internal trauma — a coagulant derived from the same species that produced the creep catalyst, the planet's biology turned toward repair instead of dissolution.

Wei died on Day 13. Not from the fall. From the bleeding that Haruki couldn't stop with compounds designed for a biology that wasn't Earth's, applied to injuries that needed a surgical theater and a blood supply and equipment that had never been in the manifest because the manifest had been designed for twenty people who weren't expected to survive long enough to need surgery.

Twenty-five.

Cole buried Wei on the slope facing the spiral trees and revised the structural inspection schedule and didn't say what he was thinking, which was that the beam had been on the repair list for three weeks and the repair had been delayed twice because the colony's labor allocation couldn't cover every task and the task that got delayed was always the one that hadn't killed anyone yet.

Month 35. A cough.

Patricia had been coughing since the relocation. Cole remembered it — Month 10, Day 3, the night transport across open terrain when Noor had died of hypothermia. Patricia had caught something in the cold. The cough had persisted through months of treatment, Dana's compounds managing it to a level that let Patricia function but never eliminating the underlying pathology. Haruki had flagged it. Repeatedly. In his quiet way, in the margins of medical reports, in the conversations he had with Cole after the colony slept — the conversations where Haruki said the things the colony couldn't hear.

"Her lungs are compromised," Haruki had said in Month 30. "The planet's microbiology has established a presence I can't clear with what I have. She's stable. She's not improving."

"Timeline?"

Haruki's pause had been the answer before the words arrived. "I don't know. Months. A year. It depends on what else happens."

What happened was Month 37. A cold snap — not dramatic, not the lethal temperature crashes of phase two, but enough. Three nights where the temperature dropped below the threshold Patricia's lungs could manage. The cough deepened. The infection that had been chronic became acute. Dana brought everything she had. Haruki spent four days in the medical shelter, adjusting compounds, monitoring respiration, doing the quiet and relentless work of a doctor fighting a losing action with inadequate weapons on terrain that favored the enemy.

Patricia died on the evening of Day 16. In the medical shelter, with Haruki sitting beside her and Cole standing at the entrance and Ren outside because someone had to be outside, holding the space between the dying and the living, maintaining the boundary that kept the colony's grief from becoming the colony's paralysis.

Twenty-four.

Cole felt the number arrive in his body the way he'd felt every number since Day 1 — physical, structural, the architecture of survival settling into a new configuration. But twenty-four was different. Twenty-four was the number he'd calculated in the signing room on Earth, sitting in a corporate waiting room surrounded by forty-seven desperate people, reading a two-hundred-and-forty-seven-page charter that nobody else had read, finding the clause buried in Section 9, Subsection 4, Paragraph 2, and doing the math. Fifty-one percent of forty-seven. Twenty-four.

The threshold.

He stood at the entrance of the medical shelter while Haruki covered Patricia's body with a blanket and felt the number close around him like a door. Not behind him. Around him. Twenty-four in every direction — above, below, each side. The exact number. The precise margin between ownership and loss, between the colony surviving as a legal entity with rights to its land and the colony surviving as a population with no claim to anything.

Zero margin. Every person was the threshold. Every cough, every fall, every shifted beam and eroded path and three-percent alkaloid variation — every variable the planet and the colony could produce was now a threat not just to the individual but to the clause itself. Twenty-three was failure. Twenty-three meant the contract held for Asterlyne and five years of dying had purchased nothing.

Cole walked to the perimeter that evening. The trees hummed. The sky was the deep green-black of a planet settling into its nighttime rhythm. The settlement sat solid on the high ground — shelters built by colonists, infrastructure maintained by colonists, food grown by colonists, graves dug by colonists. Everything they'd built. Everything they'd lost to build it. Twenty-three people and the ghosts of twenty-three others, all of it balanced on a number that Cole had calculated in a signing room and carried in his body for three years.

He felt it. Not as math. As weight. The specific, physical weight of twenty-four lives that he couldn't afford to lose and couldn't guarantee to keep. The count that had started as inventory and become attendance and become something else — a word he didn't have, or a word he wouldn't say, something that lived in the space between arithmetic and the reason arithmetic existed.

Twenty-four. The door closed. The margin was zero. And Cole stood at the perimeter of a settlement that didn't have a name yet and breathed the alien air and held the number and didn't let go.

Chapter 23 — "No Margin"

Twenty-four was a different number than twenty-five.

Cole had carried every number since forty-seven. Carried them the way the channel network carried water — structurally, without choice, because the architecture existed and flow was what architecture did. Forty-seven had been abstract. Forty-four had been alarming. Thirty-nine had been the first number that felt like weight instead of data. Thirty-one had matched his model and the matching had taught him that accuracy was not the same as comfort. Twenty-six had been the margin of two, the feedback loop, the colony killing the colony.

Twenty-four was the threshold.

He'd known this number since Day Zero. Calculated it in a corporate waiting room with fluorescent light and contract tablets and forty-six other desperate people who hadn't read the document they were signing. Fifty-one percent of forty-seven. Twenty-four. The number that meant the land transferred. The number that meant five years of dying had purchased something.

Now he was inside it. Not approaching it, not calculating its probability, not modeling the curve that would carry the colony toward or away from it. Inside it. The number wrapped around the colony like a skin, tight, with no give. Every person was the threshold. Every cough was the threshold. Every shifted beam and softened seal and eroded path was the threshold.

Patricia had been the last subtraction. Month 37. The cough that had started during the relocation — Month 10, the night transport, the cold that had killed Noor and planted something in Patricia's lungs that Haruki had managed for twenty-seven months without defeating. The cold snap. The deepening. The four days in the medical shelter while Haruki worked with compounds that slowed the pathology but couldn't reverse it. And then the silence in the medical shelter that was different from all other silences because it meant a body had stopped.

Twenty-four.

Cole had stood at the entrance and watched Haruki cover Patricia's body and felt the number close around him, and the closing had been physical — chest, throat, the backs of his hands — because twenty-four was the number that ended the math. Not finished it. Ended it. There was no more projection. No more curve. No more model running in the back of his mind, calculating probability and attrition rate and the distance between where they were and where they needed to be. They were where they needed to be. Exactly. The distance was zero.

The distance being zero meant the distance could only become negative.

Year Four. The colony lived on the threshold the way the spiral trees lived in the planet's soil — rooted, but aware that the ground moved.

Cole watched it change them. Not dramatically. Not the way crisis changed people — fast, visible, the sudden reconfiguration of behavior that accompanied the creep or the fever or Dana's confession. This was slower. Tectonic. The shift that happened when a group of people understood, collectively and without discussion, that each of them was the last person.

Some became careful. Obsessively careful. The kind of careful that added three minutes to every task because each step was checked and each check was verified and each verification was a small prayer to the mathematics of survival that the mathematics would hold. A colonist named Dara, who'd been on water system maintenance since the relocation, started walking the path to the southern array with her left hand

on the slope wall, trailing her fingers along the substrate, feeling for the specific looseness that preceded erosion. She'd been walking the path for two years without touching the wall. Now she touched it every time. The hand was a sensor. The sensor was fear, rationalized into protocol.

Some became reckless. Not wild — not the performative recklessness of people who'd given up. A quieter kind. The recklessness of fatalism, where the understanding that any moment could be the subtraction produced not caution but a loosening. If the number could change at any time, then the careful measuring of risk was an illusion, and the illusion was exhausting, and the exhaustion itself was a risk. A colonist named Beck started volunteering for the perimeter patrols that nobody wanted — the night shifts, the ones where the fauna was more active and the terrain was harder to read in the green-dark. He wasn't suicidal. He was tired of calculating.

Cole became both.

He walked the perimeter every morning with the same meticulous attention he'd brought since Day One — counting shelters, counting bodies, verifying the number that was now both goal and razor. He checked the structural assessments Ren filed every five days. He reviewed Dana's agricultural projections, the medical inventory Haruki updated weekly, the water system status reports that flowed through Ren's engineering team. Every system. Every variable. Every number that fed into the larger number.

And then, in the hours between the systems, he did things that weren't careful. Walked further into the forest than protocol allowed. Sat on the bedrock at the edge of the channel network where the ancient infrastructure dropped into darkness, his legs hanging over a drop that wasn't dangerous until it was. Stood in the agricultural plots at dusk when the fauna moved through the tree line, watching the creatures that had killed Okafor with a compound nobody could analyze, and didn't retreat to the shelters when the light faded.

Ren noticed. She noticed everything structural.

"You're taking risks."

"I'm sitting on rocks."

"You're sitting on rocks at the edge of a four-meter drop after dark on a planet that killed a man with a single bite."

Cole looked at her. They were standing in the common area after the evening meal, the space Ren had designed for assembly, where the colony gathered by habit now rather than schedule. Twenty-four people. He could see all of them from where he stood. He could always see all of them.

"I need something the math can't give me."

"What's that?"

He didn't answer. Not because he was deflecting — the old reflex, the one that had kept Lily's name out of his mouth for eighteen months, the one that turned personal questions into silence. He didn't answer because the answer was still forming, somewhere in the space between the number he carried and the reason he carried it, and the forming wasn't complete.

Ren didn't push. She'd learned when to push and when to stand beside the silence and let it work. She'd learned it the way she'd learned the planet — through exposure, through error, through the accumulated experience of two people who'd been inside the same structure long enough that the structure had become a language.

She went back to her meal. Cole went to the perimeter. The trees hummed.

He opened Elena's logs for the last time on a night in Month 40 when the settlement was quiet and the sky was the deep green-black he'd stopped calling alien because alien implied a comparison to something else and he didn't compare anymore. This was the sky. The only one.

He'd been parceling Elena's logs across three years. Reading in fragments the way you read a cautionary text — slowly, in portions small enough that the warning could be absorbed without overwhelming the capacity to act on it. He'd shared the survival data with the colony. The agricultural findings, the weather patterns, the soil cycle mappings that had helped Dana refine her phase models. The story of what happened when a group stopped being a group. He'd used Elena's words the way he used every tool — instrumentally, for the colony's survival, without sentiment.

He hadn't read the end.

The data core sat in the bottom of his supply crate, closed since Month 26 when he'd sent the second message to Lily and stopped counting as inventory and started counting as attendance. He'd told himself the logs were finished. He'd used what he needed. The rest was a dead woman's private correspondence and he had no right to it and no need for it.

Both things were true and neither was the reason he hadn't opened them.

He opened them now.

He'd read through Month 26 — the social collapse, the colony that stopped eating together, the deaths that thinned nine to three, the diagnosis Elena had written with three people still breathing: *We stopped being worth keeping alive.* He'd pinned those entries to the Board. He'd used them. Past Month 26, he'd stopped.

The entries past Month 26 were short.

Month 27. Two. Elena didn't describe how Tomas died. Just: *Tomas is gone. I'm not going to write the details. The details don't help. The pattern is the same as every other death — the planet, the deficit, the margin that finally reached zero. The specifics vary. The arithmetic doesn't.*

Month 28. One. Elena alone.

Cole read the final entries in the dark of his shelter with the hum of the trees pressing through the walls and the colony breathing around him — twenty-three other people sleeping or keeping watch or sitting in their shelters with their own thoughts, alive on a planet that had been killing people longer than any of them had been trying to survive it.

Elena's last three months were written in a voice Cole recognized. Not the clinical scientist. Not the colony leader running systems and counting bodies. A person. Alone. Writing because writing was the last act of someone who still believed the words would be read. Someone who still believed in a future that contained other people.

She described the trees. The hum. The way the light shifted at dawn. She described the fauna watching from the tree line — the same creatures Cole had watched for three years, patient, observing, neither hostile nor helpful. She described the soil under her hands. The channel network she'd never understood. The settlement she'd built that was already being reclaimed by the planet's slow, persistent biology.

She didn't describe loneliness. She described the absence of logistics. No systems to run. No count to maintain. No variables to track. The silence of a woman who'd been managing a colony and was now managing nothing, and the nothing was louder than any number had been.

Her second-to-last entry was a paragraph. Cole read it twice.

I keep thinking about the channels. The infrastructure. Something lived here and built systems and the systems outlasted whatever built them. The creep comes and the creep goes and the channels remain. I don't know if that's hope or not. It might just be geology. But I keep thinking about it. Something built things that lasted. And then the something was gone and the things were still here. Maybe that's enough. Not the survival. The lasting.

Her final entry was two words.

Enough, now.

Cole sat with them. Two words that contained a woman's entire trajectory — the scientist, the leader, the last survivor, the person who'd decided that the record was complete. Not a surrender. Not despair. A closing. The specific finality of someone who'd said everything she had to say and was choosing to stop saying it.

He didn't know how Elena had died. The data core didn't say. The body wasn't in the wreckage — reclaimed by the planet, by the creep, by the slow dissolution that turned everything organic into something the soil could use. She'd been alone for three months and then she'd written two words and then she'd stopped writing.

Cole closed the data core. Held it in his hands for a moment. The weight of it — not the physical weight, which was negligible, but the weight of fourteen lives compressed into data that had become his ghost narrative, his parallel, his map of what failure looked like so he could navigate away from it.

He'd navigated away from it. Twenty-four. Elena's fourteen had become nine had become three had become one had become zero. Cole's forty-seven had become twenty-four and held. The holding was the difference. The holding was the thing Elena hadn't had — not because she was less capable, not because she'd made worse decisions, but because her charter had no clause 9.4.2, no ownership threshold, no mathematical reason to believe that survival purchased anything beyond another day of surviving.

He put the data core back in the crate. Closed it.

In the morning, he walked twelve kilometers west.

The ghost colony was barely visible now.

Three years of the planet's biology had done what three years of biology did — reclaimed, absorbed, dissolved the boundaries between what humans had built and what the planet produced. The pre-fab shelters were collapsed under the weight of growth, their Asterlyne logos faded to suggestions under layers of the lavender-gray organic matter that covered every surface the forest touched. The equipment was half-buried. The clearing Elena's colony had made was no longer a clearing — the spiral trees had advanced into it, their trunks grown through the wreckage, their roots breaking the pre-fab composite the way roots broke concrete on Earth, slowly and without malice.

Cole stood at the edge of what had been a settlement and saw the future his colony had avoided. Not a graveyard. A place returning to the planet that owned it. The human presence reduced to shapes under growth, contours in the soil, the geometry of right angles softening into the planet's preferred curves.

He'd come here once before. Month 2. The scouting party, the discovery, the sealed data core. He'd told no one. Had taken the logs and read them in secret and used the information the way he used everything — as input, as advantage, as the currency of a man who believed knowledge was leverage and leverage was survival.

Three years later, the secrecy felt like a different person's decision. Not wrong. Not right. Just the choice of a man who'd been calculating in a framework that hadn't yet learned to include the people inside it. He'd shared the logs eventually. Shared them with the colony because Elena's warning was more valuable as a

shared text than a private advantage. The sharing had been manipulative and necessary and both things existed simultaneously and Cole had stopped trying to resolve the contradiction.

He gathered stones.

The substrate here was different from the high ground where the colony lived. Softer. More organic matter, less bedrock. The stones he found were small — fist-sized, rounded by water and weather, the kind of stones that accumulated in drainage lines. He carried them to the center of what had been Elena's settlement.

He didn't know where she'd died. Didn't know if she'd been in a shelter or outside or somewhere in the forest when the two words became the last words. It didn't matter. The cairn wasn't a marker. It was an acknowledgment. Stones placed by a man who'd survived what she hadn't, on ground that was hers in the only way that mattered — she'd lived here, she'd built here, she'd kept records that had saved the people who came after.

He built the cairn without ceremony. Stone on stone. The physical act of stacking — choosing each piece for its shape, finding the angle where weight held weight, building something that would stand until the planet took it the way the planet took everything. He didn't count the stones. He built until the cairn felt finished, and the feeling was not architectural but intuitive, the sense of a structure that had reached its proper height.

He stood back. Looked at it. A pile of rounded stones in a clearing that wasn't a clearing anymore, surrounded by the wreckage of a colony that had failed, under the green-shifted sky of a planet that hadn't noticed the failure because the planet didn't notice.

No words. He'd considered bringing something — a piece of Elena's log, a transcription, some fragment of her writing to attach to the cairn the way memorials on Earth attached names to stone. He'd decided against it. Elena's words were in the common shelter, on the board, being read by the colony she'd never met. Her words were working. The cairn was for the silence that came after the words.

Cole walked back to the settlement. Twelve kilometers through the forest, the spiral trees humming around him, the fauna watching from the understory with the patient observation they'd maintained for three years. He didn't hurry. The walk took four hours. He arrived at the settlement in late afternoon with dirt on his hands and his boots and the front of his shirt, and the dirt was from Elena's ground, and he didn't wash it off until evening.

Joss found him three days later at the water junction.

Cole was running the weekly seal inspection Ren had added to the rotation after Junction 4's failure — the adhesive check, the membrane assessment, the systematic verification that the thing keeping contaminated water out of the colony's supply was still doing its job. He'd taken the task himself. Not because others couldn't do it. Because the task required the specific attention of a man whose relationship to maintenance had become personal, and the personal had become the only motivation strong enough to sustain the attention the colony needed.

Joss walked up the path from the settlement with the stride Cole had watched evolve over three years — no longer the gangly, over-eager motion of the twenty-two-year-old who'd bumped into things and dropped things and caught them. Twenty-five now. The body had settled into itself. The movements were deliberate without being slow, economical without being stiff. He moved like someone who'd learned that the ground under his feet wasn't guaranteed and had adjusted his relationship to it accordingly.

"Cole."

"Junction's holding. Membrane at fifty-two percent. Seal's stable."

"That's not why I'm here."

Cole looked up from the junction housing. Joss was standing three meters away with his hands in his pockets and his face carrying an expression Cole had never seen on him — not the nervousness that had been Joss's default for the first year, not the earnest determination that had replaced it in the second, not the quiet competence that had defined the third. Something new. The expression of a young man about to ask for something he'd been thinking about for a while.

"The settlement needs a name."

Cole set down the inspection tool. Sat back on his heels. Looked at Joss.

"It has a designation. Parcel 16b."

"That's Asterlyne's designation. It's not a name. It's a line item on a corporate ledger."

Cole heard the sentence and heard underneath it the three years that had produced it. Joss at twenty-two, nervous, over-prepared, using filler words and hedging. Joss at twenty-five, standing at a water junction telling Cole that the corporate designation for their home wasn't good enough anymore. The distance between those two people was measured in deaths and decisions and the slow, accretive process of a person becoming someone they hadn't planned to be.

"It's not mine to name," Cole said.

"It's not Asterlyne's either. Not anymore."

The words landed with a weight that exceeded their syllable count. Cole felt them settle into the framework — not the logistics framework, not the survival calculation, but the other thing, the one that had been growing in the spaces between the systems, the thing he didn't have a word for because the conditions that produced it didn't exist in contexts where words got made. The colony had culture. The colony had the Bench, the Drip, South Kitchen, the Board. The colony had inside jokes he didn't understand and shared memories he'd been present for but hadn't experienced the way others had. The colony had names for its parts but not for its whole.

Joss was asking for the whole.

"Talk to the council," Cole said. "Talk to Ren."

"I'm talking to you first."

"Why?"

"Because you're the one who's going to say it doesn't matter. And I want to get that conversation out of the way before we have the real one."

Cole looked at Joss and saw, for a moment, the thing he usually kept behind the framework — the thing that lived in the space between the count and the reason for the count, between the father who'd lost custody of a nine-year-old on Earth and the man who'd been watching a twenty-two-year-old become twenty-five on an alien planet. The thing that wasn't replacement. Wasn't substitution. Just the specific, unrequested weight of caring about someone who was becoming something and knowing that the becoming was partly because you were there to witness it.

"It doesn't matter," Cole said.

Joss smiled. The smile was small and knowing and completely unbothered by the dismissal, because Joss had heard Cole say things didn't matter before and had watched the things matter anyway.

"I know," Joss said. "Council meeting's in two days. We'll put it on the agenda."

He walked back to the settlement. Cole watched him go and felt the unnamed thing in his throat — the same thing he'd felt watching Joss teach water filter maintenance, watching the culture grow in the gaps between the systems, watching the colony become something he'd built the scaffolding for but hadn't designed.

He went back to the junction. The seal held. The membrane filtered. The water ran clean.

The council meeting was on a Thursday. Ren chaired it with the efficiency she'd refined over eighteen months of democratic governance — agenda distributed, time allocated, the semicircle of council members arranged in the open sight lines she'd designed for transparency.

The name was the last item. Joss had placed it there — after the water system report, after the agricultural projection, after Haruki's medical inventory update that listed the compounds they had and the compounds they didn't and the timeline before the ones they had ran out. The business of survival first. Then the business of belonging.

Ren opened the item. "The younger colonists have proposed that the settlement be formally named. Joss will present."

Joss stood. He didn't speak the way Cole spoke — minimal, data-driven, the rhetoric of a man who trusted numbers over sentences. Joss spoke the way Joss spoke. Direct, slightly too fast, the earnestness audible in the cadence, but the filler words gone now, burned away by three years of learning to say things that mattered in a place where mattering was measured in survival.

"We've been calling this place the settlement, or the colony, or the high ground, depending on who's talking and what they're talking about. Some of us call it home. Some of us haven't called anything home since Earth. The place has names for its parts — the Bench, the Drip, South Kitchen. It doesn't have a name for itself. I think it should."

He sat down. The council considered.

Ren opened the floor. Twenty-four people in the common area — the full colony, not just the council, because Joss had asked for a colony-wide vote and Ren had agreed because the democratic architect in her recognized that naming was an act of collective ownership and collective ownership was the architecture's purpose.

Suggestions came slowly. The colony wasn't practiced at ceremony. They were practiced at rationing, at maintenance schedules, at the daily mechanics of staying alive. Naming felt different. Naming felt like a claim, and the claim felt presumptuous on a planet they'd survived but hadn't conquered, in a settlement they'd built but might not keep, on land that a corporate charter said belonged to a company that had stopped talking to them.

"Vasik." A colonist named Ora said it quietly. The name of the dead scientist whose logs had become the colony's shared text, whose warnings they'd read on the Board, whose cairn sat twelve kilometers west in a clearing that was no longer a clearing. A memorial. An honoring.

Silence. People considering. Elena's name, carried by a settlement that existed because her colony hadn't. The weight of it was right. The weight was almost too much.

"The Channels." Kira. Practical. The ancient infrastructure they'd learned to read, the system that carried the creep solution, the carved bedrock that told them something had lived here before and built things that lasted. A name that acknowledged inheritance. That they weren't the first.

More silence. People calculating. Not Cole's kind of calculation — the social kind, the one that weighed meaning against sound against the daily practice of saying a word a thousand times until the word became the place.

Garrett Polk spoke from the back of the room.

"Holdfast."

He said it the way he said things now — not with the rhetorical force of the man who'd argued against Cole's systems in Month 4, not with the declarative confidence that had built a signal array and nearly dissolved the charter. Quieter. The word delivered without performance, as if it had been sitting in his mouth for a while and he'd decided to let it out.

Someone laughed. Not unkindly. The word sounded like a joke — hold fast, grip the margin, hang on with both hands to the thing that was trying to shake you loose. Polk's face didn't change. He hadn't meant it as a joke. Or he had, and the joke had a foundation underneath it that was deeper than the laugh.

"Holdfast," Joss repeated. Testing the sound. Cole watched Joss roll the word through whatever internal process a twenty-five-year-old used to evaluate whether a word was large enough to contain a place.

"We're holding fast," someone said. Cole didn't catch who. The sentence came from the middle of the group, from the cluster of colonists who occupied the social center that Cole had never been part of and didn't need to be.

"Better than Asterlyne's margin," someone else said.

Ren called the vote. She didn't need to count. The hands went up in a wave — not simultaneous, not rehearsed, just the slow accumulation of twenty-four people deciding that a word was the right word. Some hands went up immediately. Some paused, considering, and then rose. Polk's hand was already up. He'd voted for his own suggestion with the particular conviction of a man who'd said something true and recognized it as true and didn't need to wait for consensus to know it.

Cole raised his hand. Last. Not because he was undecided — because he was watching. Twenty-three hands in the air, twenty-three people choosing a name for the place they'd built. He'd been watching for this. Three years, without knowing what to call it. The colony becoming something that wasn't his to make. The emergent property of people who'd survived together long enough that the surviving had produced something the survival couldn't explain.

Holdfast.

Ren recorded the vote. Her voice was steady. "The settlement is named Holdfast. The vote is unanimous." She paused. The pause was the democratic architect honoring the moment, the silence between a decision and its consequence. "The record is closed."

No ceremony. No cheers. The colony dispersed the way it dispersed from every meeting — people standing, returning to tasks, the life of the settlement resuming its rhythm. The rhythm had a name now. That was all. A word that meant hold fast, grip the edge, survive the margin. A word Garrett Polk had said in a room of twenty-four people who'd been dying together for three years.

Cole stayed in the common area after the others left. Sat on the Bench — the rock outcropping near the entrance, the one with the name that nobody had voted on. The settlement was quiet in the way it was quiet after evening meals — not empty, just settled. People in shelters. People at the perimeter. People in the agricultural plots, checking Dana's phase-three species in the last light.

Holdfast.

He didn't care about the name. He tested the thought and found it true and then found something underneath it that was also true and more important. He didn't care about the name. He cared that they'd chosen it together. He cared that Joss had come to him at a water junction and said the corporate designation wasn't good enough. He cared that Polk had spoken a word that was a joke and a truth and the colony had heard both. He cared that twenty-four hands had gone up in a room Ren had designed for exactly this — collective decisions, shared weight, the architecture of people choosing together.

That was the real work. Not the count. Not the systems. Not the logistics framework that had kept the colony breathing for three years. The real work was the shift — the one that had been happening since the fever, since Joss's bedside, since the first message to Lily, since the second. The shift from running a survival calculation to living inside a thing worth surviving for. The name didn't matter. The naming did.

Cole sat on the Bench at Holdfast and listened to the trees hum and held the number — twenty-four, the threshold, the exact margin of zero — and the number was still heavy and the number was still the architecture of everything he'd built. But the architecture had a name now. And the name had been chosen by the people inside it. And that was something the math had never predicted and couldn't explain and didn't need to.

He went to his shelter. The smallest room. His cot, his desk, his data core in the closed crate. The paper on the desk where he tracked the count. He picked up the pencil. Wrote the number. Twenty-four.

Under it, for the first time, he wrote the name.

Holdfast.

Chapter 24 — "The Shuttle"

The sound reached Holdfast before the light did.

Cole was at Junction 3, running the membrane check Ren had added to his rotation after the contamination event in Month 28. Hands in the housing. Mind in the seal — the adhesive margin, the degradation rate, the specific texture that distinguished a membrane at fifty percent from one at forty-nine. The routine of a man who'd learned that the distance between safe water and poison was measured in percentages that dropped while you slept.

He heard it as a low tear across the upper atmosphere. Not thunder — too sustained, too directional. A sound that moved. Cole's hands stopped inside the housing. He tilted his head toward the green-shifted sky and listened to the sound track from east to northwest, descending, carrying the specific harmonic of friction against atmosphere that he hadn't heard in five years.

A ship.

He pulled his hands from the junction. Stood. The sound was already fading — the descent carrying whatever made it beyond Holdfast's horizon, toward the original settlement coordinates twelve kilometers west. The place they'd abandoned. The place the forest had reclaimed. The place where Elena's cairn sat in a clearing that wasn't a clearing anymore.

Cole stood at Junction 3 with his hands wet from the membrane housing and his chest doing something the math couldn't explain. Five years. No communication since Month 30 — the wellness check, the silence, the word "Residents" on the final transmission. And now a ship, breaking atmosphere without warning, landing where Asterlyne's GPS coordinates said the colony should be. Where the colony hadn't been for three years.

Ren reached him in four minutes. She'd been at the agricultural terrace with Dana, reviewing the third-cycle planting schedule. She came up the path at a pace that wasn't running but wasn't walking — the engineer's stride, efficient, controlled, the body responding to urgency without surrendering to it.

"You heard it."

"Yes."

"Landing vector puts it at the original site."

"Yes."

Ren stood beside him. They looked west, toward the tree line, toward the twelve kilometers of spiral forest between Holdfast and the place they'd left. The trees hummed. The sky showed nothing — whatever had descended was below the canopy now, on the ground, at coordinates that corresponded to a corporate file labeled Parcel 16b, Settlement Zone Alpha.

"Asterlyne," Ren said. Not a question.

"Nobody else has the coordinates."

"Nobody else has the reason."

Cole felt the sentence land. Nobody else has the reason. Five years and eleven days into the charter. Eleven months and nineteen days from the clause. Twenty-four colonists. The exact number. The threshold Asterlyne had designed the contract around, betting against it the way insurance companies bet against longevity — not hoping for death, just pricing it accurately and collecting the premium.

Twenty-four colonists had survived the premium.

"I need to go there," Cole said.

"We need to go there."

He looked at her. Ren's face was holding the expression he'd learned to read over four years — the engineer assessing a structural load, calculating whether the foundation could take the weight. The foundation, in this case, was him. She was deciding whether Cole Maren could walk into a room with Asterlyne's representative and not do something the colony couldn't survive.

"I won't do anything," he said.

"I know. That's why I'm coming."

They took Garrett Polk.

Cole hadn't planned it. Polk was at the perimeter when they left — the early patrol, the route that traced the eastern edge of Holdfast where the channel network surfaced and the bedrock dropped toward the forest. He saw them walking west with purpose and fell into step without asking.

Three people walking through the spiral forest toward a corporate shuttle that had landed on their abandoned settlement. The math of it settled into Cole's framework the way every configuration settled — as a calculation of risk and resource. Cole: the charter's reader, the man who'd found clause 9.4.2 in a waiting room and carried it for five years. Ren: the architect, the democratic principle that had kept the colony from becoming one man's arithmetic. Polk: the dissenter who'd voted with his jaw set and his hands unclenched and the specific conviction of a man who understood contracts because contracts had destroyed him.

The walk took three hours. They didn't talk for the first two.

The forest was different than it had been four years ago, when Cole had walked to the ghost colony site to recover Elena's data core. The second and third orbital cycles had reshaped the understory — new growth in patterns Dana had mapped, the lavender ground cover thicker in some sections and absent in others, the creep's ancient infrastructure visible in exposed channel walls where the soil had shifted. The trees were the same. The hum was the same. The planet's indifference was consistent in a way that Cole had come to find not comforting exactly, but stable. The trees didn't care who walked under them. The trees would be here after the walkers were gone. There was something in that.

Polk broke the silence.

"What are they offering?"

"I don't know."

"You know."

Cole walked. Polk was right. Cole knew the way he knew the membrane percentage at Junction 3 — not from observation but from the accumulated logic of a system whose patterns he'd internalized over five years. Asterlyne had sent a shuttle. Not a supply drop. Not a communication. A shuttle — a vehicle designed to carry people away from the surface. The corporation's silence for fourteen months, followed by a physical presence. The timing: eleven months from the five-year mark. Enough time to renegotiate. Not enough time for the colony to forget it had an exit.

"They're offering a way out," Cole said. "Structured as generosity. Designed as subtraction."

"Subtraction from what?"

"Twenty-four."

Polk was quiet for thirty paces. Cole counted. He always counted.

"If anyone leaves, the count drops."

"If anyone leaves, the count drops below the threshold. The clause can't be invoked. Asterlyne retains the land. Five years of dying buys nothing."

"I know what it buys," Polk said. The sentence carried weight that exceeded its syllable count. Cole heard underneath it the co-op, the debt, the daughter, the custody hearing he'd lost because the legal system priced justice and he couldn't afford the asking rate. Polk knew what contracts bought. Polk knew what they cost.

They walked the last hour in a silence that had changed shape — not the silence of people who had nothing to say but the silence of people who had said enough and were saving what remained for the room ahead.

The shuttle sat in the original clearing like a surgical instrument on a patient's skin.

Clean. White. The Asterlyne logo on the hull — the same logo Cole had seen on contract tablets and equipment manifests and the pre-fab shelters that had warped in the UV cycle and collapsed in the wind and been abandoned three years ago. The logo looked obscene against the backdrop of the spiral forest. Too clean. Too designed. The planet had spent five years teaching Cole that surfaces degraded, that materials warped, that the only things that lasted were the things that adapted. The shuttle hadn't adapted. It had arrived.

The clearing was barely a clearing. The forest had advanced into the original settlement the way the creep advanced — slowly, inevitably, without hostility. The pre-fab shelters were shapes under growth. The landing zone Asterlyne's GPS had identified was a square of compressed soil where the shuttle's landing gear had flattened the vegetation back to something approximating a surface. Around the shuttle, the spiral trees stood at the clearing's edge, their trunks grown three years' worth of diameter, their hum steady and unconcerned.

A figure stood at the base of the shuttle's ramp.

Cole saw the suit first. Gray. Clean. Pressed. The kind of fabric that required infrastructure to maintain — dry cleaning, climate control, the invisible machinery of a civilization that treated the surface presentation of its employees as a line item. The suit was a message before the person inside it spoke: we still have these things. We still have all the things you don't.

The face above the suit was professional. Mid-forties. A smile calibrated for reassurance — wide enough to communicate warmth, controlled enough to maintain authority. The kind of smile Cole had seen in the onboarding center on Earth, on the faces of the facilitators who'd walked forty-seven desperate people through a two-hundred-and-forty-seven-page contract designed to be unread. Corporate warmth. Manufactured empathy. The specific expression of a company whose human resources department had determined that sincerity was a productivity metric.

"Mr. Maren." The representative extended a hand. The hand was clean. The nails were trimmed. Cole looked at the hand and felt the dirt under his own nails and the calluses on his palms and the specific roughness that five years of alien soil produced on skin that had once been soft enough for a corporate waiting room.

He shook the hand. The grip was practiced.

"I'm Graham Lyle. Asterlyne Charter Relations." The representative's eyes moved to Ren, to Polk. The assessment was quick and professional — categorizing, prioritizing, determining which of the three required the most careful handling. Cole watched the assessment happen and recognized it. He'd done the same thing in the signing room on Day Zero. Forty-seven faces. Strengths, weaknesses, who works, who complains. The representative was doing inventory.

"Ms. Tsai. Mr. Polk." Lyle knew their names. Of course he knew their names. Twenty months of Dana's reports. Colony structure, social dynamics, leadership hierarchy, factional tensions. Asterlyne had a file on every colonist alive and dead, organized by threat level and utility, cross-referenced with the contract clauses each colonist was most likely to invoke. Cole felt the knowledge settle into his framework like a stone dropping into water.

"You know our names," Ren said.

"Your colony's progress has been of significant interest to the company." Lyle's smile held. "We've been following your journey with admiration."

Cole heard the word *journey* and cataloged it. Journey. Not survival. Not ordeal. Not the five years of deaths and disease and the creep dissolving a man from the waist down and a woman coughing for twenty-seven months until the coughing stopped because she stopped. Journey. The corporate vocabulary that turned suffering into narrative and narrative into a thing that could be managed.

"We haven't heard from Asterlyne in fourteen months," Cole said.

"Supply chain disruptions. Revised delivery infrastructure. I won't pretend it wasn't a failure on our end." Lyle's transparency was rehearsed, but the rehearsal was good — the practiced candor of a representative who'd been briefed on the colony's isolation and instructed to acknowledge it early, to name it before they could name it, to own the failure as a tactic of control. "I'm here to make it right."

"How," Ren said.

Lyle reached into the shuttle. Produced a tablet. Sleek. New. The screen bright with the specific luminosity of technology that hadn't been exposed to Parcel 16b's UV cycle. He held it the way a man holds a gift — angled, offered, the gesture of generosity performed for witnesses.

"Renegotiation."

Cole read the new contract standing in the clearing while Polk leaned against a spiral tree trunk and Ren paced a perimeter around the shuttle that looked casual and was cartographic — she was mapping the shuttle's systems, its fuel capacity, its communications array, the infrastructure of the corporate machine that had landed in their abandoned settlement.

Lyle stood at the base of the ramp with his hands clasped behind his back. Patient. The patience of a man who'd been told the colony's leader would read every word, because the colony's leader had read every word of the original charter in a waiting room on Earth while forty-six other people skimmed and signed.

The new contract was forty-two pages. Shorter than the original. The brevity was intentional — a document designed to feel reasonable, to present itself as the distillation of the original's complexity into something cleaner, simpler, fairer. Cole read it the way he read everything: with the understanding that the architecture of a document revealed the intentions of its architect.

Article 1. Voluntary Termination of Charter Obligations. Any colonist who signed the original charter could, at their discretion, terminate their participation. No penalties. No debt recovery. No breach of contract claims. The language was generous: "Asterlyne Corporation recognizes the extraordinary contributions of Parcel 16b colonists and waives all outstanding obligations incurred under the original charter."

Article 3. Transport. Shuttle capacity for up to twenty-four passengers. Return to Earth. Transit time: three months. Arrival coordinates: the same port they'd left from. Full medical care during transit. Reintegration support upon arrival. The language was warm: "Asterlyne is committed to ensuring a smooth and supported transition for returning colonists."

Article 5. Debt Resolution. All pre-charter debts forgiven. Credit restoration. Employment assistance. Housing placement. The package was comprehensive in the way that insurance settlements were comprehensive — designed to make the recipient feel whole while ensuring the payer's exposure was capped and the recipient's claims were extinguished.

Article 7. Non-Disclosure Agreement. All colonists who accepted the renegotiation agreed to full confidentiality regarding charter operations, settlement conditions, mortality events, and corporate communications. The language was neutral: "To protect the privacy of all parties and the proprietary nature of charter operations."

Article 9. Waiver. The clause Cole had been looking for. He read it twice. Three times.

"By accepting the terms of this Renegotiation Agreement, the undersigned voluntarily and irrevocably waives all rights, claims, and entitlements under the original charter, including but not limited to those arising under Section 9, Subsection 4, Paragraph 2 (Land Transfer Provisions)."

Cole lowered the tablet. The clearing was quiet. The trees hummed. The shuttle sat on the compressed soil with its clean hull and its corporate logo and its capacity for twenty-four passengers, and the document in Cole's hands was a surrender shaped like mercy.

He looked at Lyle.

"Debts forgiven. Transport home. NDA. In exchange for clause 9.4.2."

"In exchange for a fresh start," Lyle said. The correction was smooth. Practiced. The reframing of a legal waiver as a human opportunity, the specific corporate alchemy that turned a contract into a story.

"What happens to the land?"

"Asterlyne's long-term development plans for Parcel 16b are proprietary. What I can tell you is that the company is committed to sustainable stewardship of all charter properties."

Cole translated. The planet gets mined. The channels get excavated. The creep solution Dana gave them gets applied at industrial scale. Holdfast gets bulldozed. The cairn he'd built for Elena gets dissolved by equipment that doesn't notice it.

"You have eleven months," Lyle said. The smile shifted. Not wider. Not narrower. Deeper. The professional warmth acquiring a layer of subtext that the smile's calibration couldn't hide. "A lot can happen in eleven months."

Cole heard it. The threat that was not a threat. The observation that was a promise. Eleven months at twenty-four. No margin. Every cough. Every fall. Every shifted beam. The company didn't need to kill anyone. The planet was a collaborator. Statistics were a weapon. Time was on the side of the entity that could afford to wait.

Ren stopped pacing. She'd heard it too. Cole saw her face — the engineer assessing structural load, finding the weight beyond tolerance. Not because the representative had said something extreme. Because the representative had said something true.

Polk hadn't moved from the tree trunk. His arms were crossed. His face was the one Cole had learned to read in council meetings — the calculation running behind the expression, the numbers turning over in a

framework Cole understood because his framework ran the same operations on different data. Polk was hearing "debts forgiven" and the words were doing something to him that the words didn't do to Cole or Ren. The words had a daughter inside them.

Cole watched Polk's jaw tighten. Watched the muscles work under the sunburned skin. Watched the calculation that wasn't logistics or ideology but something older and less solvable — the computation a father runs when someone offers him a path back to the child he left, and the path requires him to abandon the people he's survived with. Garrett Polk's co-op had been a rational decision. His charter signing had been a rational decision. His signal array had been a rational decision. Every rational decision had cost him something he couldn't get back. And now a man in a gray suit was offering to give one of those things back, and the price was another thing Polk couldn't calculate.

Cole looked at the tablet. Forty-two pages. Article 9. The waiver. The clause he'd found in a waiting room on Earth, the arithmetic that had sustained him through forty-seven to twenty-four, the number that was the reason for every system and every schedule and every membrane check and every count and every message to a daughter who was fourteen now and drew horses and thought her father was on a work trip or had stopped thinking about him entirely.

"I have a question," Cole said.

Lyle's smile recalibrated. "Of course."

"How many other charters have invoked 9.4.2?"

The smile held. Cole watched it hold the way he watched membranes hold — tracking the degradation, looking for the percentage where hold became failure. Lyle's smile was professionally maintained. The maintenance showed.

"Questions regarding competing charter structures are best addressed through our formal arbitration process." Lyle's voice was steady. Rehearsed. But the rehearsal had a seam in it — the specific pause between "formal" and "arbitration" that revealed the sentence was not an answer but a redirection. "Which, as you're aware, requires functional communications infrastructure."

Cole was aware. The arbitration clause in the original charter — Section 14, Subsection 2 — required a functioning comm relay for dispute resolution. The comm relay was Asterlyne's. The same relay that routed messages to Lily. The same relay that had carried Dana's reports for twenty months. The same relay that Asterlyne could disable at any time, for any reason, because the infrastructure of justice was owned by the entity the justice was meant to constrain.

The representative had just told him everything by telling him nothing. The process you've already tried. The one we control. The one that doesn't work. No charter had invoked 9.4.2. Or if one had, the arbitration system had resolved the invocation in Asterlyne's favor, because the system was Asterlyne's, the way the shuttle was Asterlyne's, the way the pre-fab shelters had been Asterlyne's, the way the contract was Asterlyne's — every tool in the structure designed by the entity the structure was meant to regulate.

Cole handed the tablet back.

"We'll discuss it."

"Take your time." Lyle accepted the tablet with the smooth coordination of a man closing a presentation. "The shuttle will remain at these coordinates for seventy-two hours. After that, the offer stands through the formal communication channels. You have eleven months."

The repetition was the threat. You have eleven months. The first time was information. The second time was a countdown.

They walked back to Holdfast in the green-dark of late afternoon.

The forest closed around them the way it always closed — not hostile, not welcoming, just present. The spiral trees doing what they'd done for longer than humans had been a species. Growing. Humming. Processing the light of a star that wasn't Sol through biology that wasn't Earth's. Cole walked between Ren and Polk and felt the shuttle sitting twelve kilometers behind him like a door left open in a house he'd spent five years building walls around.

Polk spoke first.

"Debts forgiven." Two words. The same two words from Article 5, lifted from the contract and set down in the forest air between them. Cole heard what the words carried when Polk said them — not the legal provision, not the financial instrument. A girl. Sixteen now, maybe seventeen. Old enough to understand why her father had left. Old enough to have decided whether to forgive him for it. Polk's debt wasn't sixty thousand credits. Polk's debt was measured in the years he'd missed and the years he couldn't get back and the possibility — the specific, fragile, contingent possibility — that debt erasure meant creditors stopped calling, which meant stability, which meant a court might reconsider, which meant a door might open that had been closed since before the charter.

"Yes," Cole said.

"That's all you're going to say."

"What do you want me to say?"

Polk walked ten paces before answering. "I want you to say something that makes the math not matter."

Cole didn't say anything. The math mattered. The math always mattered. Twenty-four minus one was twenty-three, and twenty-three was failure, and failure meant five years of dying purchased nothing — no land, no clause, no Holdfast, no freedom for any of them. One person boarding the shuttle subtracted not just themselves but everyone. Every colonist's survival was collateral for every other colonist's future. That was the architecture. That was what clause 9.4.2 had always been — a threshold that bound them together by making each person's departure everyone's loss.

"The math matters," Cole said.

"I know," Polk said. "I know it matters."

They walked. The trees hummed. Ren said nothing. She was listening to both of them with the engineer's attention she brought to load-bearing conversations — tracking the stress lines, assessing where the fracture might occur, calculating whether the structure could hold the weight of what was being said.

They reached Holdfast at dusk. The settlement sat on the high ground in the last light — shelters built by colonists, the channel network carrying Dana's creep solution through the ancient infrastructure, the agricultural terraces stepping down the slope where the third-cycle species grew in the lavender soil. The common area where twenty-four people ate together. The Board where Elena's words were pinned. The Bench where Cole had sat after the naming vote and felt something he still didn't have a word for.

The settlement had a name. The name was Holdfast. The name meant what it meant.

Twenty-four people at Holdfast. A shuttle twelve kilometers west with capacity for all of them. Eleven months to the five-year mark. Zero margin. A contract that offered everything they'd left Earth to escape — debt forgiveness, transport, a fresh start — in exchange for the only thing they'd gained. The land. The clause. The ownership that twenty-three dead people had paid for without knowing they were paying.

Cole looked at Holdfast and felt the shuttle behind him and the eleven months ahead of him and the twenty-four lives inside the margin, and the margin was a razor. Eleven months. A choice that would hold or wouldn't.

The colony had a choice.

Cole walked into the settlement. The first person he saw was Joss, coming up from the water junction with a filtration housing under his arm. Joss looked at Cole's face and stopped.

"Something happened."

"Colony meeting. Tomorrow. Full assembly."

Joss set down the housing. The careful motion of a man who'd learned that the things he carried mattered. "How bad?"

Cole looked at Joss. Twenty-seven now. The gangly kid who'd bumped into things was gone. In his place, a young man with steady hands and a face that defaulted to the specific attentiveness of someone who'd learned to read situations by reading Cole — watching for the silences that meant danger, the flatness that meant calculation, the almost-imperceptible shift that meant the math had changed.

"It's a choice," Cole said.

He went to his shelter. Sat at the desk. The paper with the count. Twenty-four. The name underneath it. Holdfast.

The shuttle sat twelve kilometers west in a clearing the forest was reclaiming. The ramp was down. The door was open. The company's offer was forty-two pages of generosity that cost nothing Asterlyne couldn't afford and purchased everything the colony couldn't replace.

Cole sat at his desk and didn't open Elena's data core and didn't write to Lily and didn't calculate anything. He sat with the number and the name and the choice and the eleven months and the open door and the twenty-four people who would have to decide, together, whether the thing they'd built was worth more than the things they'd lost to build it.

The trees hummed. The planet didn't care. It never had.

Twenty-four. Holdfast. Eleven months.

Cole sat in the dark and held it all and didn't let go.

Chapter 25 — "The Math"

Cole called the assembly for noon.

Not morning. Morning was when he called emergencies — the creep advance, the fever, the supply drop that never came. Morning assemblies meant the math had changed and the change was bad and the colony needed to know before the day's work began so the day's work could bend around the new shape of things. The colony had learned this the way they'd learned the soil cycles and the temperature swings and the sound the fauna made before dawn. Morning meant crisis. Morning meant Cole had been awake all night with a number that didn't fit.

Noon meant something else. Noon meant he'd slept on it. Noon meant he'd let the thing settle into his framework and the framework hadn't broken. Noon meant the decision was large enough to require thought but not urgent enough to steal the morning, and the distinction mattered because four years on a planet that killed people for walking the wrong path at the wrong hour had taught the colony to read Cole's scheduling the way they read the sky — as information about what was coming.

He spent the morning at the junction. Membrane check. Seal assessment. The adhesive margin on the housing that separated the colony's water from the planet's water, which was the same water processed through a system Ren had designed and Dana had calibrated and Joss maintained with the quiet reliability of a man who understood that the most important work was the work nobody noticed until it failed. Cole's hands moved through the inspection protocol while his mind held the shape of what he was going to say.

He wasn't going to give a speech. He'd never given a speech. The logistics briefing in Month 1 — forty-four of them, three dead, and he'd stood in front of the colony and delivered numbers like a shift report — hadn't been a speech. It had been an inventory. Every assembly since had been the same: data, options, arithmetic. Cole didn't persuade. He presented. The colony decided. That was Ren's architecture, and the architecture worked because Cole's presentations were honest and Ren's process was fair and the combination of honest data and fair process had produced, over four years, something that functioned.

Today was different. Today he was going to show them the other side of the ledger.

Twenty-four people in the common area at noon.

Cole saw them the way he always saw them — as a count first, as individuals second, as a group third. The count was habit. The count was the first thing his mind did when he entered a room with colonists in it, the automatic tallying that had started in a corporate waiting room on Earth and hadn't stopped for four years and eight months. Twenty-four. The number confirmed itself the way it confirmed itself every morning on his perimeter walk, every evening at the shared meal, every time he scanned a room and felt the specific weight of a total that matched the threshold.

He saw Ren near the front. Standing, not sitting — the engineer's posture, the body that defaulted to readiness. She knew what this assembly was about. He'd told her last night. Not everything. Enough. She'd listened the way she listened — tracking the stress lines, assessing the load. Then she'd said, "Show them all of it," and he'd said, "That's the plan," and she'd looked at him with the expression that meant she was deciding whether to believe him or whether "all of it" meant "all of it that Cole has decided they should see." He'd let the look stand. She'd let him.

Dana sat in the middle row. Quiet-bodied, soil under her nails, taking up the space she'd earned back over eighteen months of being the person who'd saved the colony and betrayed it. The colony had voted to keep her. The vote hadn't restored trust. Trust had been rebuilt the way trust was rebuilt — through the daily accumulation of showing up, of the creep solution working, of the agricultural phases calibrated correctly, of

the botanist who'd transmitted everything to Asterlyne now transmitting nothing to anyone except the colony that had decided she was worth more alive than punished.

Joss stood at the wall near the entrance. Arms crossed. The posture he'd started using after the naming vote — not defensive, observational. Watching the room the way Cole had watched rooms for five years, reading faces for the information faces carried when people didn't know they were being read. Joss had learned it from Cole without either of them naming the transmission. Teacher and student, except the teacher hadn't intended to teach and the student hadn't asked to learn and the learning had happened anyway, the way the colony's culture had happened — in the gaps between the systems.

Haruki sat near Dana. His hands folded in his lap. Steady. The doctor who'd saved Joss during the fever and Patricia during the cough's early months and dozens of others with botanical compounds and field surgery and the calm, diagnostic attention that made people believe their bodies would hold because the man examining them believed it first. Haruki was fifty-six. His face showed it more than his hands did. The face carried four years of alien sun and insufficient sleep and the specific exhaustion of a man who'd treated every wound and buried every body and maintained the same measured calm through all of it because Haruki's calm was the only instrument he had, and he'd never once set it down.

Garrett Polk sat at the back. Always at the back now. The rhetorical force that had built a signal array and nearly dissolved the charter had quieted over the last two years into something Cole didn't have a word for. Not compliance. Not agreement. A repositioning. Polk at the back of the room was Polk watching, calculating, running numbers against a framework that had changed since Month 4 but hadn't disappeared. Polk still distrusted systems. He just distrusted them from inside the system now, which was different from distrusting them while trying to build an alternative.

Cole walked to the front of the common area. He carried the charter. The original. Two hundred pages, printed on the transit ship from the contract tablet, bound with cord Ren had made from processed fiber in Year Two. The document he'd read in a fluorescent waiting room while forty-six other people skimmed and signed. The document that had governed every day of their lives since.

He also carried seven pages of notes. His handwriting. The calculations he'd been running for three years — not the survival math, not the count, not the attrition model. The other math. The corporate math. The numbers Asterlyne hadn't put in the charter because the charter was designed for colonists and colonists weren't supposed to think about the numbers behind the numbers.

He set both on the table. The charter and the notes. The contract they'd signed and the arithmetic they'd never seen.

"This isn't an emergency," he said. "This is information."

He started with the company.

Not with the shuttle, not with the offer, not with clause 9.4.2. Those came later. He started with the thing none of them had ever been shown because the thing none of them had been shown was the reason for everything else.

"Asterlyne Corp filed a resource extraction patent for Parcel 16b's geological substrate fourteen months before our charter was issued." He read from his notes. His voice was flat — the same register he used for junction reports and membrane percentages. Data. "Patent number AX-7714-b. Filed under proprietary mineral rights, sub-category: extra-solar geological assets. The patent covers the mineral composition of the channel network's crystallized substrate. The same compound Dana identified as the base element of the creep's inert phase."

He paused. Let it land. Twenty-four faces processing. Some confused. Some already running the implications.

"The viability assessment for Parcel 16b was conducted twenty-three months before we signed. The assessment team spent eleven days on-surface. They took core samples from the channel network. They cataloged the mineral composition. They filed the patent. Then they left."

"Where did you get this?" Ren's voice from the front. Not accusatory. Professional. The engineer asking for the source data.

"Elena's data core. Appendix files I hadn't opened. Geological survey metadata. Asterlyne's assessment team used the same data formats Elena's colony used — corporate standard. The patent filing was embedded in the survey metadata as a cross-reference. It wasn't meant to be found by colonists. It was meant to be found by corporate auditors."

Cole looked at the room. He'd been holding this for months. Since before the shuttle. Since the long period of silence, when he'd gone back to Elena's data core — not the logs, the appendices, the technical files, the metadata he'd dismissed as irrelevant in Year One because survival had been more pressing than corporate archaeology. The silence had given him time. The time had given him this.

"The mineral substrate in the channels has an estimated extraction value of four hundred billion credits. Asterlyne's total investment in our charter — transport, equipment, supplies, the contract itself — was approximately ninety million. The ratio is four thousand to one."

Silence. The specific silence of people absorbing a number that reframed everything they'd experienced.

"Our charter is the cheapest way to establish a claim. Cheaper than a corporate mining operation, which requires regulatory filings, environmental assessments, labor contracts, insurance. A colonial charter transfers all of those costs to the colonists. We signed a contract that made us responsible for our own survival on land the company had already decided to mine. If we die, the charter terminates and Asterlyne files a new one. If we survive, clause 9.4.2 triggers and the land transfers — but Asterlyne built the contract assuming no charter would reach the threshold. The medical kit stocked for twenty. The viability score inflated by twelve points. The supply drops designed to sustain dependency, not independence. Every insufficiency was a calculated variable in a model designed to produce failure."

He stopped. Picked up the charter. Opened it to the page he'd marked in Year One, the page with the clause he'd found while forty-six other people signed without reading.

"Section 9, Subsection 4, Paragraph 2. Fifty-one percent of original signatories alive at the five-year mark. Land transfer in perpetuity. Irrevocable."

He set the charter on the table. Open. Visible.

"Twenty-four of forty-seven. Fifty-one point one percent. We're at the threshold. We've been at the threshold for eight months. In eleven months, if twenty-four of us are alive, this land is ours. Not Asterlyne's. Not a charter designation. Ours."

He stepped back from the table. Looked at the room.

"That's the math. The shuttle at the old coordinates is the company's response to it. Debts forgiven, transport home, NDA — in exchange for waiving clause 9.4.2. If any of us boards, we drop below threshold. The clause dies. Five years of dying buys nothing."

He stopped talking.

The colony was quiet for eleven seconds. Cole counted.

Then Ren said, "Everyone talks. Cole listens," and the room opened.

It didn't open the way meetings opened — orderly, agenda-driven, the democratic architecture Ren had built channeling discussion through protocol. This opened the way a wound opened. Fast. Messy. The controlled structure of four years of governance buckling under the weight of what Cole had just shown them.

A colonist named Beck — the one who'd been volunteering for night perimeter patrols, the one who'd stopped calculating risk because calculating risk was exhausting — stood up first.

"Ninety million. That's what we cost them."

"That's what the charter cost them," Cole said.

"What's the difference?"

"The charter is a line item. You're overhead."

Beck sat down. His face was doing something between anger and recognition — the specific expression of a man who'd always known, in the way you always knew, that the system didn't value him, but who was now seeing the exact price the system had put on his expendability. Ninety million divided by forty-seven. Less than two million per person. The price of a life on a balance sheet was lower than the price of the mineral substrate under the life's feet.

Kira spoke next. The water system designer, the woman who'd voted against the relocation in Month 10 and walked the path to the southern array every day with her hand on the wall, feeling for erosion. Her voice was steady in the way that Kira's voice was always steady — the register of a woman who'd learned that steadiness was the only reliable tool in a world where the ground moved.

"You've known this. How long?"

"The patent data. Eight months. The financial model — the extraction value, the charter cost ratio — I've been assembling it since Asterlyne went silent."

"Eight months."

"Yes."

Kira looked at him. The look carried the colony's long memory of Cole keeping things — Elena's logs in Year One, Dana's betrayal for thirty-one days, the shuttle's arrival shared only with Ren and Polk. Cole held information the way the channels held water: structurally, by design, releasing it when the system required release and not before.

"You wait," Kira said. "You always wait."

"I wait until the information is useful."

"Useful to whom?"

"Everyone in this room."

Kira held the look for three seconds, then sat. Not satisfied. Not unsatisfied. Just the acceptance of a person who'd lived inside Cole's information architecture for four years and had decided, long ago, that the architecture was flawed and functional and the functionality mattered more than the flaw.

The room broke into the conversations that large groups produce when a single conversation is too heavy for a single thread to carry. Clusters. Side discussions. Two colonists talking near the entrance with their voices low and their faces carrying the strain of people calculating whether home was the planet they stood on or the planet they'd left. Three colonists near Dana, asking questions about the mineral substrate — was

it real, was it valuable, could Asterlyne really mine it without the colony's knowledge? Dana answering with the flat precision that was her recalibrated default: yes, yes, not without the colony's knowledge but without the colony's permission.

Cole stood at the table and let it happen. Ren watched the room from her position near the front, tracking the fracture lines, reading the social architecture the way she read structural loads — looking for the points where the weight exceeded tolerance.

The two came forward after twenty minutes.

A colonist named Seo and another named Parish. Cole knew them by count and by role — Seo had been part of Dana's agricultural team since the relocation, quiet, competent, the kind of colonist who disappeared into the work and emerged only when the work required a voice. Parish ran the secondary water filtration system Ren had installed in Year Three. Both had been in the colony long enough to have buried friends and built shelters and eaten food they'd grown from alien soil.

"We want the deal." Seo's voice was small. Not weak. Small. The voice of a person who was saying something that felt too large for the room.

The clusters went quiet. Not the dramatic silence of a confrontation. The attentive silence of twenty-two people hearing something they'd each thought about in the hours since the shuttle landed and Cole came back from the old settlement with the charter in his hands and eleven months on his face.

"Tell us why," Ren said. Not challenging. Open. The democratic architect doing what the architecture required: giving the voice a floor.

Seo didn't look at Cole. She looked at Ren.

"I'm tired. I'm tired in a way that sleep doesn't fix and the creep solution doesn't fix and the food we grow doesn't fix. I came here because Earth was broken and I thought somewhere else might not be. And it's not broken. It's beautiful. The trees and the soil and the way Dana's crops look in the third phase. But I'm tired. And the shuttle is sitting there offering to take me somewhere I can sleep without listening for the temperature to drop."

Parish said less. "My mother is alive. She was sixty-two when I signed. She's sixty-seven. I've done the math on her math and I don't like the number."

Cole heard it. Both of them. The exhaustion that wasn't physical and the love that was. He heard it the way he heard membrane percentages — as data, as input, as the specific information that a system produced when the system was telling you something about itself. The system was telling him that two people had reached the boundary of what survival meant to them, and the boundary was personal, and the personal was beyond his arithmetic.

Ren opened the floor for response.

Dana spoke first.

She stood from her seat in the middle row and the standing itself was a statement — the woman who'd stood in this room eighteen months ago while twenty-five people decided whether to exile her, standing again, this time choosing to speak rather than absorbing the colony's judgment.

"I transmitted our survival data to Asterlyne for twenty months. Everything I sent made the colony more expendable. The creep solution. The soil cycles. The agricultural phases. I gave them every piece of knowledge we bled for. When I stopped transmitting, the company went silent — not because they lost interest but because they had enough. Enough data to file extraction plans. Enough knowledge to send the

next expedition with a manual instead of a learning curve. The shuttle isn't here because Asterlyne cares whether we're tired. The shuttle is here because twenty-four of us are alive and that number threatens a four-hundred-billion-credit asset."

She sat down. The room processed. Dana's confession had been eighteen months ago. The colony had voted, fought, fractured, and rebuilt around it. But hearing the betrayal reframed as corporate asset protection — hearing Dana name herself as the instrument of the thing Cole had just shown them — carried a weight the original confession hadn't.

Joss pushed off the wall.

"I was twenty-two when I got here." He didn't project his voice. He spoke at the volume of someone talking to the people closest to him, and the room leaned in because Joss's volume was always the right volume — the instinct of a person who'd grown up scared and grown past scared into something steadier. "I'm twenty-seven. Everything I know about water filtration and perimeter maintenance and how to read the soil and when the fauna moves and which path to take after dark and which path to avoid — I learned here. I learned it from Cole and Ren and Dana and Haruki and all of you. I don't have a place on Earth. I don't mean I don't have a home. I mean I don't have the skills that matter there. I know how to live here. That's what I know."

He didn't argue against leaving. He stated what staying meant. The difference was Joss — the way Joss handled things had always been to present the reality he understood and trust the reality to carry its own argument.

Ren spoke. Short. The democratic architect breaking her own convention of moderating rather than participating, because the architecture permitted it and the moment required it.

"This is the vote we've been building toward since Day One. Not the relocation. Not Dana. This one. Whether the thing we built is ours or whether we give it back to the company that sent us here to die profitably. That's the question. Everything else — the exhaustion, the fear, the families on Earth — is real. All of it is real. And the question is still the question."

The room shifted. The conversations changed tone. Not resolved. Shifted. The weight of Ren's framing settling onto the discussion like the substrate settled onto the bedrock — not eliminating the other layers, just establishing which layer was load-bearing.

Cole watched Polk.

He'd been watching Polk since the assembly began, the way he'd been watching Polk since the transit ship. Polk at the back of the room. Arms crossed. Face holding the expression Cole knew as the calculation face — the muscles working under the sunburned skin, the jaw set, the eyes tracking the speakers without following them. Polk was doing math. Not Cole's math. Not the corporate ledger, the extraction value, the charter cost ratio. Polk was running the computation he'd been running since Graham Lyle said "debts forgiven" in a clearing twelve kilometers west.

Daughter on Earth. Settlement on Parcel 16b. Debt erased vs. land owned. The possibility of a door reopening — custody, contact, the chance to be something other than the man who'd left — vs. the certainty of a place he'd built with people who'd watched him nearly destroy them and had voted to keep him anyway. Polk's math didn't have clean variables. Polk's math had a sixteen-year-old girl whose face he hadn't seen in five years inside one column and a colony named Holdfast inside the other, and the columns didn't convert.

The conversation continued for hours. It circled. It stalled. It moved forward in increments that felt like setbacks and in setbacks that were actually consolidation. Colonists spoke and repeated themselves and said things they'd already said in different words because the saying was the process and the process required repetition the way grief required it — not to reach a conclusion but to exhaust every other path until the conclusion was the only path remaining.

Seo and Parish listened. They didn't argue back. They sat with their reasons — tiredness, a mother on Earth — and let the colony's response wash over them without defending against it. Cole watched and recognized the posture. It was the posture of people who'd already decided. The question wasn't whether they would stay. The question was whether the colony could hold their staying without resenting the asking.

Polk didn't speak. The hours moved past him. Arguments Cole could have made — the corporate strategy, the financial exposure, the legal implications of dropping below threshold — went unmade because Cole was watching Polk and understanding, for the first time, that the math he'd been running for five years had a variable he'd never included. The variable was the cost of choosing a place over a person. Cole had made that choice on Day Zero. Left Lily to come here. Left the daughter for the clause, the father for the arithmetic, the person for the plan. He'd spent five years justifying it as strategy, as the only play, as the mathematics of a desperate man in a waiting room with nothing left to lose.

Watching Polk sit in the back of a room deciding the same thing, Cole felt the justification shift. Not collapse. Shift. The way soil chemistry shifted on Parcel 16b — not suddenly, not dramatically, just the slow recalibration of a system adjusting to new data about itself.

Polk's jaw set. The muscles locked. The sunburned skin tightened over the bone.

He didn't speak. The setting was the speaking. Cole read it the way he read membrane percentages — the specific tension that meant the material had reached its final configuration and the configuration was going to hold. Polk was choosing against himself. Choosing Holdfast over the daughter he'd left on Earth, the debt forgiveness that could have reopened the custody door, the chance to see a girl who was sixteen now and might want to see him or might not and the uncertainty made the choice impossible. The choice was being made anyway.

Nobody in the room saw it except Cole. The decision happened in Polk's jaw and Polk's silence and the specific angle of Polk's crossed arms, and the room kept talking around it, and the talking was necessary and the decision was already made.

The conversation died at the four-hour mark the way long conversations die — not with a conclusion but with the exhaustion of alternatives. The room had said everything. Seo and Parish had said they were tired and the tiredness was real. Dana had said the shuttle was corporate strategy and the strategy was real. Joss had said he knew how to live here and the knowledge was real. Ren had said the question was ownership and the question was real. Everything was real. The realities didn't resolve. They accumulated.

Then someone said the thing nobody had said.

It was a colonist named Lana. Younger cohort. She'd been quiet through the entire assembly — the quiet of someone who'd been thinking at a different altitude than the conversation, processing a concern that wasn't about the shuttle or the clause or the corporate balance sheet. She spoke from the third row with a voice that was steady in the way that voices are steady when the person speaking has rehearsed the sentence in their head for hours and the rehearsal has burned away everything except the essential words.

"What about the children?"

The room shifted. The specific shift of a group encountering a thought they'd been circling without touching — the way Cole had circled Elena's final log entries for months before reading them, knowing the content by its shape before he saw the words.

"Two of us are expecting." Lana looked at Cole. "Mika's due in four months. I'm due in six. Our children will be born on this planet. On this land. In Holdfast."

She paused. Cole felt the pause the way he felt temperature drops — in his body, before his mind processed the data.

"They're not signatories. They didn't sign the charter. They weren't in the waiting room. They're not part of the forty-seven. If we invoke clause 9.4.2 — if twenty-four of us are alive on the five-year mark and the land transfers — what happens to the children born here? Do they inherit? Does the land belong to them? Or does Asterlyne's charter language only cover the people who signed, and the next generation is born on land that belongs to their parents but not to them?"

The room stopped.

Not the gradual quieting of a conversation winding down. A full stop. The sound of twenty-four people hitting a wall they hadn't seen because they'd been looking at the wall behind it.

Cole reached for the charter. He'd read it seventeen times. He'd memorized the clauses that mattered — 9.4.2, the supply provisions, the arbitration mechanism, the termination triggers, the liability waivers. He'd studied the document the way he studied membrane seals, looking for the degradation points, the percentages where hold became failure.

He turned to Section 9. Read the transfer language. Read it again.

"Land transfer in perpetuity to surviving original signatories and their legal assigns."

Legal assigns. The words sat on the page. Cole read them a third time. Legal assigns on Earth meant something specific — heirs, designated successors, entities with legally recognized standing. On a planet with no legal infrastructure, no courts, no registry, no mechanism for establishing the legal identity of a person born outside any existing jurisdiction — legal assigns meant nothing. Or everything. The language was a door that opened onto a room that didn't exist yet.

"Does it say anything about children?" Lana asked.

"It says legal assigns."

"What does that mean here?"

Cole looked up from the charter. He didn't have an answer. The framework he'd built over five years — the arithmetic, the logistics, the survival calculation that had sustained him from Day Zero to this room — didn't include this variable. The variable was a child who hadn't been born yet, on a planet with no law, in a settlement with no jurisdiction, under a charter written by a corporation that had designed the language to be parsed by corporate lawyers in corporate boardrooms on Earth.

He looked at Haruki. The doctor was reading the same passage, his steady hands holding the page, his face carrying the expression Cole had seen during every medical crisis — the calm assessment of a problem that might be solvable and might not, the diagnostic attention applied to uncertainty.

"I don't know," Haruki said. The words came out the way Haruki's words always came out — gentle, precise, the admission of ignorance delivered as clinical fact rather than failure. "The language was written for Earth's legal framework. We're not in that framework."

Cole looked at Ren.

Ren was standing very still. The engineer who thought in systems, who'd designed the colony's governance architecture, who'd fought for democratic process because the process was the principle — standing still with an expression Cole hadn't seen on her face before. Not the structural assessment. Not the load-bearing calculation. Something underneath those things. The expression of a person who'd just realized the system she'd built was sitting on a foundation she hadn't examined.

"We'll figure it out when we have to," Ren said.

The words were calm. The words were Ren at her most controlled — the voice she used when a structure showed a crack she couldn't repair immediately, the engineer's discipline of naming the problem and deferring the solution without pretending the problem didn't exist.

Underneath the calm, Cole heard the fear. Not for herself. For the system. For the architecture she'd spent three years building — the democratic process, the council, the governance that had given the colony a structure beyond survival. The architecture assumed the colonists were the colony. If children were born on Holdfast and the charter's language didn't cover them, then the architecture had a gap at its foundation, and the gap would widen under load.

Nobody proposed asking Asterlyne. The thought existed in the room — Cole could feel it, the way he could feel temperature shifts before Dana's instruments confirmed them. Twenty-four people in a room, and not one of them trusted the corporation enough to ask the question that mattered most. They'd learned what Asterlyne's answers sounded like. Corporate poetry. Language designed to preserve optionality, to defer commitment, to say nothing while sounding like everything. "Asterlyne's determination regarding post-natal signatory status will align with the charter's intentions." Translation: we'll decide when deciding benefits us, and the decision will be whatever protects the four-hundred-billion-credit asset.

The question sat in the room. Open. Unanswered. The charter's language was silent — either by design, because Asterlyne's lawyers had anticipated this possibility and chosen not to address it, or by oversight, because Asterlyne's lawyers had never imagined a charter colony surviving long enough for children to be born. Cole couldn't tell which. Both explanations led to the same place: a gap in the text that would be filled by whoever had the power to fill it, and the colonists didn't have that power, and the corporation did, and the corporation's silence was its answer.

"We vote," Ren said.

The vote was simple. Stay or board.

Ren called it with the procedural efficiency she'd refined over three years of democratic governance — the clear question, the open floor for final statements, the show of hands that made every decision visible. No secret ballots. No anonymity. The architecture of transparency applied to the largest question the colony had faced.

Seo and Parish voted to stay.

Cole saw it in their faces before their hands went up. The conversation hadn't changed their exhaustion. Parish's mother was still sixty-seven on Earth, still aging, still existing in a time frame that the three-month relay delay made abstract but couldn't make irrelevant. Seo's tiredness was still bone-deep, the kind of fatigue that four years on an alien planet deposited in the body's infrastructure the way the creep deposited crystallized substrate in the channels — slowly, persistently, becoming part of the structure.

They voted to stay anyway. Not because the arguments had overcome their reasons. Because their reasons existed inside a context that was larger than the reasons. They lived at Holdfast. They'd named it. They'd buried people in its soil and grown food from its dirt and learned the sounds it made at night and in the morning and in the specific hour before dawn when the trees' hum shifted frequency and the sky was the green-dark that had stopped being alien because alien implied a comparison and there was nothing left to compare it to. Their exhaustion was real. The place was real. Both were real and the place was larger.

Twenty-four hands. All of them.

Ren counted. She didn't need to. The count was visible. But she counted because the count was protocol, and protocol was what made the decision legitimate rather than accidental. Twenty-four hands. Twenty-four votes. Unanimous.

"The colony votes to remain," Ren said. "The vote is recorded. The shuttle's offer is declined."

Nobody cheered.

Cole had been on a planet long enough to know what cheering sounded like when it was earned and when it was performance, and this room didn't produce either because the decision wasn't a victory. It was a commitment. The distinction mattered the way membrane percentages mattered — invisibly, structurally, in the space between what something looked like and what it was.

Twenty-four people who'd chosen to stay on a planet that had killed twenty-three of the people they'd arrived with, in a settlement they'd named, on land that a corporation valued at four hundred billion credits and had priced their lives at ninety million, with children coming who might or might not belong to the place they were born in. The choice was made. The question remained.

Polk stood up. Walked to the entrance. Stopped.

Cole watched him. The back of Polk's head. The broad shoulders that had carried anger and conviction and the signal array and the relocation and the Dana vote and every decision Polk had made since signing a charter in a waiting room where he'd thought he was escaping. Polk stood at the entrance of the common area at Holdfast with his back to the room and his face pointed toward the tree line, toward the twelve kilometers of spiral forest between the settlement and the shuttle, toward the direction his daughter existed in if you kept going long enough — through the forest, through the atmosphere, through three months of transit, through the space between this planet and the one where a girl who was fifteen now lived with a mother who'd been granted custody by a court that Polk couldn't afford to challenge.

He stood there for ten seconds. Cole counted.

Then Polk walked into the settlement. Not toward the shuttle. Into the settlement. Toward his shelter, his tools, his perimeter patrol route, the life he'd built from the wreckage of every rational decision he'd ever made.

Cole let the count go.

The shuttle sat at the old coordinates for three days.

Cole didn't go back. Neither did anyone else. The ship existed in the colony's awareness the way the creep had existed before the solution — as a presence, a fact, a thing in the landscape that carried threat and possibility in equal measure. Twelve kilometers west. Ramp down. Door open. Capacity for twenty-four. The corporate offer sitting in its forty-two pages of generosity, waiting for someone to accept the terms and the silence and the NDA and the ride home.

Nobody walked those twelve kilometers.

On the first day, Cole did the membrane check and the perimeter walk and the evening count and sat at his desk and didn't write to Lily. On the second day, he worked the agricultural terrace with Dana, checking the third-phase species, the ones that grew in the lavender soil during the orbital cycle they'd learned to predict. The plants looked right. Dana's calibrations held. The food would come. On the third day, he woke before dawn and walked to the eastern edge of Holdfast where the channel network surfaced and the bedrock dropped toward the forest, and he sat on the rock where Ren had told him he was taking risks, and he listened to the hum of the trees, and he waited.

The sound came at midmorning. The sustained tear of atmosphere. Ascending this time. Moving from west to east, climbing, the shuttle's engines pushing against the planet's gravity with the specific harmonic of a machine leaving a surface it had sat on for three days without collecting what it came for.

Cole watched the sky. Didn't see the shuttle — the canopy was too thick, the distance too great, the vessel too small against the green-shifted atmosphere. He heard it. The sound of Asterlyne's offer retracting into the upper atmosphere, through the cloud layer, into the orbital trajectory that would carry it back to the relay station and the transit route and the corporate infrastructure that existed on the other side of the sky.

The sound faded. The trees hummed. The planet continued.

He walked back to the settlement. The first person he saw was Joss, coming up from the water junction with the housing under his arm, the same walk, the same path, the same reliable arrival that had become the rhythm of Cole's days without Cole designing it that way. Joss looked at Cole's face and read it.

"It left."

"It left."

Joss nodded. Set down the housing. The careful motion. The steady hands. The face of a twenty-seven-year-old who'd just watched the last exit close and was standing on the other side of it with a water filtration housing under his arm and no expression that suggested he wished he were anywhere else.

"Good," Joss said.

He picked up the housing and walked to the junction.

Cole stood in the settlement. Holdfast. Twenty-four people on a planet that didn't care about them, in a place they'd built, on land they'd chosen, with eleven months between them and the clause and the threshold and the ownership that twenty-three dead people had paid for. Lana's question still unanswered. The charter's language still silent. The children still coming.

The shuttle was gone. The door was closed. The colony was on the only side of it that mattered now.

Cole went to his shelter. Sat at the desk. The paper with the count. Twenty-four. The name. Holdfast. He picked up the pencil. Didn't write anything new. The number hadn't changed. The name hadn't changed. Eleven months was a long time and no time and exactly the amount of time they had.

He put the pencil down. The trees hummed. Somewhere in the settlement, Mika was four months from bringing a child into a place that the charter called Parcel 16b and the colony called Holdfast and the child would call home, and the word home would mean whatever they made it mean, whatever the fine print allowed, whatever they fought for when the fine print tried to take it away.

Twenty-four. Holdfast. Eleven months.

The shuttle was gone. The question remained. Cole sat with both.

Chapter 26 — "Eleven Months"

The waiting was the work now.

Ren understood this the way she understood load distribution — not as a metaphor but as a physical fact. The colony's systems were maintained. The water ran clean through the junctions she'd rebuilt. The agricultural terraces produced on Dana's phase-three schedule. The shelters held. The creep solution circulated through the ancient channels with the reliability of infrastructure that had been designed by something patient and maintained by something desperate. Everything worked. The colony was a machine operating within tolerances, and Ren's job was to keep it there. That should have been enough. But the threat wasn't mechanical. The threat was time.

Eleven months. The shuttle had left. The colony had voted. Twenty-four people had watched it go and turned back to a settlement named Holdfast and started the count that would end on Day 1,826 or wouldn't end at all. Ren had tracked the shuttle's ascent from the eastern perimeter, listening to the atmospheric tear fade into the hum of the spiral trees, and felt the specific weight of a closed door — not relief, not regret, the structural awareness that the load had shifted and the new configuration was permanent.

Month 2 of Year Five. The colony held.

Month 3. The colony held.

She stopped waiting for the crisis and started waiting for the waiting to become the crisis instead. Twenty-four people living at the margin, every interaction carrying the hidden charge of fragility. A dropped tool was a held breath. A cough was a prayer. The colony had survived the planet's second cycle and its own social fractures and the creep and the fever and Dana's betrayal and Asterlyne's silence and the shuttle's offer, and now it had to survive eleven months of nothing happening, which was harder than any of it because the human body was built for response, not for suspension.

Ren watched for the structural signs. She knew them. She'd watched the colony fracture three times — the faction split in Month 4, the relocation in Month 10, the Dana vote in Year Three — and each fracture had followed the same engineering pattern: stress accumulated invisibly until a visible event exposed the load that had been building underneath. The event wasn't the problem. The accumulation was.

She couldn't see the accumulation now. That scared her more than seeing it.

Month 4. Mika delivered.

Not the Mika Ren had left on Earth. A different Mika, a coincidence of naming that had landed on Ren like a stone the first time she'd heard it in Month 8 and had never stopped being heavy. This Mika was thirty-one, dark-haired, quiet in the way that observant people were quiet — watching, cataloging, building an internal model of the world that was more complete than anything she shared. She'd been on Dana's agricultural team since the relocation. She'd been pregnant since Month 58 of the charter.

The labor was twelve hours. Haruki managed it in the medical shelter with the specific competence of a man who'd delivered children on Earth and was delivering one on a planet where the air smelled different and the gravity pulled differently and the microbial environment was an unknown that his protocols couldn't fully account for. Dana stood by with compounds — antibacterial, anti-inflammatory, the botanical pharmacy she'd built from the planet's chemistry over four years. Cole stood outside the shelter door for all twelve hours. Ren found him there at hour six and again at hour eleven and both times he was in the same position — back against the shelter wall, hands at his sides, face doing the thing she'd learned to read as calculation running underneath a surface that showed nothing.

He wasn't calculating Mika's survival against the count. He was calculating something else. Ren could tell because the posture was different from the counting posture — the shoulders lower, the head tilted, the stillness that came from a man holding something that wasn't a number. She didn't ask. She stood next to him for four minutes at hour eleven and then went back to Junction 2 because the junction needed checking and the checking was her way of standing next to something she could fix while something she couldn't fix happened inside a shelter behind her.

The child was born at dawn. A girl. Healthy by every measure Haruki could apply, which were the measures of Earth medicine operating inside an alien biosphere, which meant the measures were incomplete — the same uncertainty that had defined every medical assessment for five years. Healthy. Probably. The confidence interval hiding inside the word, the way it always hid.

Ren went to see the child in the evening. The medical shelter was warm — Haruki kept it at a temperature that approximated Earth standard, burning fuel the colony rationed carefully because the fuel was finite and the cold was not. Mika held the girl against her chest. The child was small and red and her face was compressed into the specific expression of a newborn who had arrived into conditions that were, by every conceivable standard, inadequate. The child didn't know this. The child knew warmth and contact and the sound of a heartbeat and the hum of the spiral trees filtering through the shelter walls. That hum would be the first sound she'd hear that wasn't human. She'd grow up thinking it was normal. A child who heard an alien planet the way other children heard traffic — that normalcy would be the most alien thing about her.

Cole came in while Ren was there. He looked at the child the way he looked at the count — with the attention of a man whose primary function was knowing exactly how many people existed inside a number. But the attention shifted. Ren saw it. The machinery behind his face reconfigured from assessment to something else, something that operated in the register she'd identified in Month 27 as the frequency she couldn't detect — the one that existed because Cole was a man and not a machine, despite the architecture he'd built to make the distinction ambiguous.

"She's not a signatory," Cole said. Quietly. To no one.

"She's a resident," Ren said.

Cole looked at her. The look lasted three seconds. Then he left the medical shelter and Ren heard his footsteps on the path toward his own shelter, and the footsteps were the footsteps of a man carrying a new weight that didn't fit the framework he'd built to carry the old ones.

Lana was due in two months. The question from the assembly — what happens to the children born here — sat in the colony's shared awareness like the creep had sat at the forest edge. Present. Advancing. Patient.

The seismic event came on Day 9 of Month 6.

Ren felt it before she heard it. A vibration in the substrate under her feet — not the hum of the trees, which was omnipresent and low and felt in the sternum, but something deeper. Geological. The bedrock shifting, or the channel network redistributing stress along fault lines the colony's survey data had never mapped because the survey data was eleven days of corporate sampling conducted seven years ago by a team that had been looking for mineral value, not tectonic risk.

The first tremor lasted four seconds. Ren counted. The shelters she'd designed flexed — the low, wide profiles absorbing lateral movement the way she'd intended, the joints giving without separating, the engineering holding. She'd built for wind. She hadn't built for seismic. Nobody had told her to build for seismic because nothing in the viability report or Elena's logs or Dana's geological sampling had indicated the planet produced seismic events. The report hadn't mentioned fauna either. The report hadn't mentioned the creep. The report was eleven days of observation used to justify a charter that sent forty-seven people to a planet the company had already decided to mine.

The second tremor came eight minutes later. Stronger. Ren was at Junction 3 by then, running the emergency protocol she'd written after the contamination event — checking seals, checking membranes, checking the infrastructure that separated clean water from the planet's water, which was the same water that had killed Kenji and Priti when a seal failed and the difference between alive and dead was a gap of millimeters. The junction held. She moved to Junction 4. Held. Junction 1. The seal was stressed — the adhesive showing the particular deformation pattern that meant the bond was at seventy percent and dropping. She reinforced it with the secondary compound Dana had formulated after the contamination. The fix would last. Probably.

The third tremor hit at minute twenty-two, and it was different.

The first two had been lateral — the substrate shifting horizontally, the kind of movement that Ren's shelters could absorb because flexible structures handled lateral load. The third was vertical. A lift-and-drop that moved through the settlement's foundation with the specific violence of a system releasing stored energy along a plane the colony was sitting on top of.

Ren heard the structural failure before she saw it. A sound she knew — the particular cracking that meant a load-bearing member had exceeded its tolerance. Not a shelter she'd designed. The older structure. The core storage shelter that Cole had reinforced in Year Two from salvaged pre-fab components and native timber, the one that held the colony's critical reserves: backup water filtration membranes, Dana's pharmaceutical compounds, the medical supplies Haruki couldn't replace, the data cores that contained Elena's logs and the colony's records and the five years of accumulated knowledge that existed nowhere else.

The shelter's western wall buckled. The roof beam — native timber, selected for density and grain, the best material available but not engineered material, not tested against seismic load because the test hadn't existed until twenty-two minutes ago — cracked along the grain and dropped the roof eighteen centimeters on the western side. The shelter didn't collapse. It shifted. Settled into a configuration that was stable enough to stand and unstable enough that any additional load — another tremor, a strong wind, a person moving through the interior — could bring the compromised beam down and take the roof and the walls with it.

Ren assessed it in nine seconds. Structural failure, western beam. Roof compromised but held by the eastern beam and the two lateral supports. Interior accessible but dangerous. Contents recoverable but not safely, not without shoring the western side, which required materials and time and the specific absence of another tremor.

She turned to find Cole already there. He'd come from his shelter at a pace that was faster than walking and slower than running — the controlled urgency she'd learned to read as Cole's crisis mode, the body responding to emergency while the mind maintained the framework that made the response organized rather than reactive.

They looked at the storage shelter together. The western wall's deformation was visible from outside — the bulge in the panels, the gap where the roof had dropped, the particular wrongness that a structural failure communicated to anyone who'd spent enough time reading buildings.

"The filtration membranes," Cole said.

"And Dana's compounds. And the medical stores."

"Can we get them out?"

Ren looked at the structure. Ran the load analysis she'd been running since the sound of the crack. The eastern beam was holding the roof's weight plus the redistributed load from the western beam's failure. The beam was timber. Native timber was strong in compression but unpredictable in sustained lateral stress — it

fractured along the grain rather than deforming, which meant it didn't warn you before it failed. The eastern beam could hold for hours. Or it could hold for minutes. She couldn't tell from outside, and going inside to inspect was the thing that might trigger the failure.

"It's recoverable. But it needs to be shored first. I need two hours and four people and the secondary timber from —"

"We might not have two hours."

"We might not have two minutes. That's why I need to shore it."

Cole looked at the shelter. Ren watched him do the thing she'd seen him do a hundred times — the rapid internal calculation, the framework processing variables faster than conversation could carry them. Risk of another tremor. Value of the contents. Time to shore versus time to retrieve. Number of people required for each option. Probability of structural failure during recovery. The math of a man who'd been converting human situations into arithmetic for five years because the arithmetic was the only language fast enough for the decisions the planet demanded.

"I'll go in," Cole said.

"No."

"The filtration membranes are the colony's water security. Dana's compounds are the colony's medical security. If another tremor hits before we shore it, we lose both."

"If another tremor hits while you're inside, we lose you. And the count drops to twenty-three."

The sentence landed the way structural loads landed — with a specificity that left no room for redistribution. Twenty-three. Below threshold. The five-year mark becomes a date instead of a deadline. Everything they'd survived becomes an experience instead of a purchase. Cole heard it. She could see him hear it. The number entering his framework and the framework adjusting around it, accommodating the variable that was his own body inside a building that might fall.

"I'll go," Joss said.

Neither of them had seen him arrive. He stood three meters behind Cole, the water filtration housing still under his arm — the same housing, the same arm, the same reliable arrival that had become the rhythm of the colony's infrastructure. He'd come from Junction 2 at the first tremor and found them standing in front of the storage shelter calculating who should enter a building that might kill whoever entered it.

"No," Cole said.

"You can't go. Ren explained why. I can."

"Joss —"

"The membranes are in the western storage rack. Dana's compounds are in the sealed containers along the south wall. The medical stores are in Haruki's crates near the entrance. I know where everything is. I maintain this inventory."

Ren watched Cole's face. The machinery was running at a speed she hadn't seen before — not the standard calculation, not the crisis-mode rapid assessment. Something else. Something that involved variables the framework wasn't designed to process. She saw him look at Joss and saw the look carry more than assessment, more than the manager evaluating the capability of a worker. The look carried five years. The look carried fever and a name spoken aloud for the first time and the slow transmission of skills from a man who hadn't intended to teach to a boy who hadn't asked to learn. The look carried Lily.

Cole didn't say no again.

Joss set down the filtration housing. The careful motion. He walked to the storage shelter's entrance and stopped. Looked at the structure the way Ren had taught him to look at structures — for the stress lines, the load paths, the points where the weight was held and the points where it wasn't. He was twenty-seven and he'd learned structural assessment from an engineer on an alien planet and the learning was visible in how he read the building, the specific attention that was Ren's attention, transmitted.

"Stay along the east wall," Ren said. "The eastern beam is holding. Don't touch the western supports. Don't bump the shelving. Move the sealed containers first — they're closest to the entrance. Then the membranes. Leave the data cores."

"The data cores have Elena's —"

"Leave them. Get what keeps us alive. Come out."

Joss nodded. He looked at Cole. The look between them was three seconds long and Ren turned away from it because the look was private in a way that had nothing to do with information and everything to do with the specific bond between a man who'd come to a planet to earn back a daughter and a boy who'd become the son the man hadn't known he was raising.

Joss went in.

Ren counted. She counted the way Cole counted — automatically, the body's metronome marking time against an uncertainty the mind couldn't resolve. Joss moved through the entrance. She heard his footsteps on the shelter floor, careful, measured, the footsteps of a man who understood that the building he was inside was a system under stress and his weight was a variable the system might not tolerate.

Forty seconds. The first container appeared at the entrance. Dana's compounds. Sealed, intact. Joss set it down and went back. Ren moved the container clear.

Sixty seconds. The second container. Medical stores. Haruki's supplies, the inventory that couldn't be replaced because the supply drops had stopped two years ago and the botanical alternatives Dana had developed were supplements, not substitutes.

Ninety seconds. Joss was deeper now. The membranes were on the western rack, which was under the compromised beam. Ren heard him moving — slower, the footsteps deliberate, the sound of a body navigating a space where the geometry had shifted and the safe path was narrower than it had been.

Cole stood at the entrance. Ren saw his hands. They were at his sides, held still. The most violent thing she'd ever seen Cole's body do — the active restraint of a man who wanted to be inside the building and was standing outside it because a woman had said twenty-three and the number had been enough to hold him in place while someone else carried the risk.

The fourth tremor hit at second one hundred and four.

Ren felt it in her knees first. Vertical again. The substrate lifted and dropped and the storage shelter's eastern beam — the beam that was holding everything, the beam that was the reason Joss was alive inside the structure — took the shock and held and Ren heard it hold, heard the wood absorb the energy with a sound that wasn't cracking but wasn't silence either. A groan. The sound of a material at its limit communicating the limit to anyone who understood the language.

Then the western beam, already failed, shifted. The roof dropped another twelve centimeters on the west side. Debris fell. Something heavy hit the floor inside the shelter. Ren heard Joss make a sound — not a scream, something between surprise and exertion, the vocalization of a body reacting to a change in its environment faster than the mind could process what the change meant.

"Joss." Cole's voice. Not loud. Not the voice of a man yelling into a collapsing building. The voice of a man saying a name the way you say a name when the name is the only thing you can send into a space you can't enter.

Silence. Two seconds. Three.

"I'm here." Joss's voice, strained. "The rack came down. I'm — my legs. The rack is on my legs."

Cole moved. Ren grabbed his arm. The grip was structural — the engineer's hand, the grip that meant the thing being held was load-bearing and could not be released.

"If you go in and the eastern beam fails, you both die and the count drops to twenty-two."

"He's trapped."

"I know he's trapped. We shore the entrance. We stabilize the beam. We get him out."

"There isn't time —"

"There is if you help me instead of dying with him."

The sentence was brutal and Ren felt it leave her mouth with the specific weight of a statement that was true and cruel and necessary. Cole's face did something she'd never seen it do. The machinery stopped. Not paused, not recalibrated. Stopped. For one second, Cole Maren was not a framework or a system or a logistics architecture. He was a man standing outside a building that held someone he loved, and the building was falling, and the woman next to him was telling him that entering it was the thing that would destroy everything the person inside it had survived for.

Cole's arm relaxed under her grip. The machinery restarted. The framework came back, and when it came back it was different — running the same calculations but weighted with something the original architecture hadn't included. Something that made the calculations slower and more human and harder to bear.

They shored the entrance in eleven minutes. Ren directed. Cole carried. Two lateral braces against the doorframe. A compression post under the eastern beam, positioned where the stress analysis said the beam was weakest. Native timber and the polymer connectors from the spare shelter kit, assembled with the specific speed of an engineer building against a clock she couldn't see.

Ren went in first. Cole behind her. The interior was disordered — the western storage rack collapsed across the floor, its contents scattered, the filtration membranes pinned under the shelving. Joss was on the floor near the west wall. The rack lay across his legs from mid-thigh down, the combined weight of the timber frame and the equipment it had held pressing him into the floor with the patient force of gravity applied to a mass that exceeded what a human body could move from underneath.

His face was white. Not from blood loss — from the specific pallor of a body managing pain it couldn't escape. His hands were flat on the floor beside him, pressing down, the unconscious effort to lift weight that couldn't be lifted by pressing down harder.

"Hey," he said. The word came out in the tone Joss used when he was trying to make something smaller than it was. The voice of a twenty-seven-year-old who'd spent five years learning that the distance between crisis and routine was measured in the voice you used to describe them.

Ren assessed. The rack was heavy but not immovable. Two people could lift it. The risk was the shift — moving the rack might redistribute the load on the western wall, which might shift the compromised beam, which might bring the roof down. Or it might not. The probability was the kind of probability that engineering couldn't resolve into certainty, the kind that required a decision made inside the margin of not-knowing.

"On three," she said to Cole. "Lift straight up. Don't shift it laterally."

Cole positioned himself at the rack's end. His hands found the timber frame. Ren took the middle section. They lifted on three. The rack rose. Joss pulled himself backward with his arms, dragging his legs from under the weight, the sound he made during the drag the sound of a body being asked to move parts that didn't want to move.

Cole dropped the rack and knelt beside Joss. His hands went to Joss's legs — not medical hands, not diagnostic, just hands. The hands of a man touching someone to confirm they were there, the way you touch a thing to verify that the thing the eyes report is the thing that exists.

"Can you feel your feet?" Ren asked.

"Yes." Joss's face was doing something between relief and the onset of the pain that relief allowed in. "They hurt."

"Good."

They carried him out. Cole took his shoulders. Ren took his legs, supporting under the knees, keeping the fractured bones — she could feel the displacement through the skin, the specific wrongness of geometry that should be straight and wasn't — as immobile as carrying allowed. They brought him into the light. Set him on the ground outside the storage shelter, in the dirt of Holdfast, under the green-shifted sky.

Cole sat in the dirt next to Joss and held him. Not medically. Not strategically. Held him the way a father holds a child who's been hurt, with the body curved around the smaller body, the arms communicating the only thing arms can communicate when language has been exceeded. Ren stood three meters away and watched and felt the structural analysis she'd been running for five years reach a conclusion that wasn't structural.

Cole had let Joss go in. Cole could have gone. Cole was faster, stronger, knew the inventory as well as Joss did. Cole had stood outside the building and not said no a second time because the number twenty-three had held him in place — the framework, the math, the architecture of survival that had kept twenty-four people alive by making every decision subordinate to the count. The framework had saved Cole's life by sacrificing Joss's safety. The framework had worked. The framework was the reason Joss was lying in the dirt with broken legs and internal injuries that Haruki would have to manage with insufficient medicine on an alien planet with one month left on the clock.

The framework was the choice. Cole had chosen the math over the boy. And the math was right. And the rightness was the thing that would break him.

Ren didn't say anything. She stood in the dirt and watched Cole hold Joss and knew that the eleven months of waiting had found their crisis, and the crisis wasn't the tremor or the shelter or the broken bones. The crisis was a man discovering that the system he'd built to save everyone had required him to sacrifice someone — the one person the system was supposed to make the sacrifice worth it for.

Haruki arrived in four minutes. He knelt beside Joss with the measured calm that was his constitution and his treatment and his gift, and his hands moved over Joss's legs with the diagnostic attention that found fractures and assessed damage and communicated through touch that the body being examined was in the care of someone who knew what care meant. Compound fracture, left tibia. Simple fracture, right fibula. Three cracked ribs, at least. Possible internal bleeding — the rack's weight on the abdomen for six minutes, the compression that might have ruptured something Haruki couldn't see without equipment he didn't have.

"He needs to be still," Haruki said. "Complete immobilization. I'll splint. Dana's anti-inflammatory compounds, full dose. The internal — I'll monitor. Watch for distension, pallor changes, heart rate."

"He'll be okay," Cole said. Not a question. Not a statement. Something between them — the specific construction of a sentence that needed to be true and couldn't be verified and was spoken because the speaking was the only act available to a man who'd run out of actions.

Haruki looked at Cole with the expression Ren had seen him use once before — during the fever, when Joss had been twenty-two and burning and Haruki had worked through the night to bring him back. The expression that said: I will do everything I can, and everything I can may not be enough, and I will not lie to you about the margin between the two.

"I'll monitor," Haruki said again. The repetition was the answer.

The respiratory infection arrived in Month 7 like weather Ren had been reading on the horizon for weeks.

She'd seen the precursors. A cough in the common area. A colonist slower on the morning path. The specific lethargy that preceded illness in a closed population, the body's early warning system firing before the pathogen declared itself. She'd learned to read these signs the way she read erosion patterns and seal degradation — as information about a system approaching a failure state, information that was useful only if you acted on it before the failure arrived.

Dana had compounds stockpiled. Four years of botanical pharmacology, refined through three orbital cycles, tested against every pathogen the colony had encountered. The antiviral from the Year Two fever. The antibacterial compounds she'd developed for wound treatment. The anti-inflammatory preparations that had become Holdfast's baseline medicine. Dana's pharmacy was the colony's immune system — external, manufactured, dependent on one woman's knowledge and the planet's chemistry and the specific intersection of the two that had kept people alive when Earth medicine couldn't.

The infection moved through eighteen colonists in nine days. Mild. Haruki confirmed. The same confirmation he'd given in Month 29, the word *mild* carrying its confidence interval, the margin of uncertainty that lived inside every medical assessment on a planet where the biology followed rules that Earth's textbooks didn't contain.

Ren watched the colony operate inside the infection the way she watched structures operate under load. The systems held. The water ran. The agricultural schedules continued, staffed by people who coughed between tasks and took Dana's compounds at the prescribed intervals and moved through the settlement with the particular determination of a population that had been sick before and understood sickness as a tax. Not a crisis. A cost. The cost was paid in reduced efficiency and longer recovery times and the accumulated fatigue that deposited in the body's reserves like mineral sediment in the channels — slowly, invisibly, becoming part of the infrastructure.

Nobody died.

The phrase sat in Ren's awareness for two weeks like a result she didn't trust. Nobody died. Eighteen colonists sick, two weeks of reduced capacity, the water system running on minimum staffing, the agricultural harvest delayed by three days. Nobody died. On a planet that had killed twenty-three people in five years, a respiratory infection moved through the colony and took nothing. The confidence interval held. The margin held. Dana's compounds worked and Haruki's protocols worked and the bodies that had been depleted by fifty-eight months of survival found enough reserve to fight a pathogen that should have been manageable and was.

Ren felt the relief and distrusted it. Relief was a structural risk. Relief was the moment you stopped checking the seal because the seal had held, and the moment you stopped checking was the gap the next failure entered through.

Cole didn't sleep during the two weeks. Ren knew because she didn't sleep either — the engineer's insomnia, the mind running system checks at three in the morning, cataloging every cough heard through the shelter walls and mapping it against the infection's progression curve. She saw Cole in the common area at hours when the common area should have been empty, sitting at the table where he'd laid out the charter and the corporate math, staring at nothing, his body present and his mind running calculations she couldn't see.

Haruki forced him to eat. She watched it happen on Day 8 — Haruki sitting across from Cole in the common area at midnight, setting a bowl of grain in front of him with the deliberate motion of a doctor administering treatment. Cole looked at the bowl. Looked at Haruki. The exchange was silent and complete — the patient recognizing the physician's authority not because the authority was asserted but because the physician's steady hands and measured calm carried a weight that Cole's framework couldn't override.

Cole ate. Haruki watched him eat. Ren stood at the entrance of the common area and saw two men performing a ritual that was older than the colony and simpler than the systems they'd built — one person making sure another person stayed alive by making sure they swallowed food.

Joss was still in the medical shelter. Immobilized. Haruki's splints held his legs in the alignment the bones needed for healing, and Dana's compounds managed the inflammation, and the internal bleeding Haruki had monitored for three weeks had stabilized — not resolved, stabilized, the distinction that meant the body had stopped getting worse without committing to getting better. Joss was conscious. Alert. He asked for water system reports. He asked Ren to bring him the maintenance logs so he could review the junction status from his cot, and Ren brought them because the asking was how Joss stayed inside the colony's work while his body healed, and the staying was what would save him or wouldn't.

The infection passed. Eighteen recovered. Twenty-four held.

Month 8. Ren saw Cole writing.

Not the charter analysis. Not the junction reports or the structural assessments or the inventory logs that constituted the colony's administrative architecture. Writing. On paper. The paper the colony made from processed native fiber — rough, off-white, the texture of something made by hand from materials that weren't designed for the purpose. Cole sat at his desk in his shelter with the door open — the door was always open now, Ren had noticed, a change from Year One when Cole's shelter had been closed and private, the count held inside — and wrote with the pencil he'd been using since the transit ship.

She saw him do it in Month 8 and again in Month 9 and three times in a single week in Month 10. The frequency was the data point. Cole had written to Lily twice in five years — the three sentences about the trees in Month 6, the truth in Month 26. Twice in sixty months. Now he was writing every few days, and the writing took less time each session, and his face afterward was different from the face he'd worn after the first two messages.

Not sad. Not hopeful. Something Ren would call *ready* if she had to name it, and she didn't have to name it because the naming was the kind of intimacy she and Cole didn't practice. They practiced the other kind — the structural kind, the load-sharing, the silence that carried more than speech because speech required choosing what to say and the choosing was a filter and they'd moved past filters.

But she saw the face and cataloged it the way she cataloged everything: as information about a system she was responsible for monitoring.

One night during the waiting — Month 9, the common fire, the hour after the evening meal when the colony gathered not by schedule but by gravity, the pull of twenty-four people toward the warmth and light that humans had gathered around since before they'd had a word for gathering — Cole sat next to Ren and said something quiet.

"The charter never says what happens to the children born here if we lose the threshold."

Ren looked at the fire. Lana's child had been born three weeks ago. A boy. Two children at Holdfast now, neither of them signatories, neither of them accounted for in a document written in a corporate boardroom on Earth by lawyers who'd designed the language for a population that was supposed to die before reproduction became a variable.

"We didn't lose," Ren said.

The words came out before she'd finished thinking them. She heard them land and heard what they carried — the fact and the fear underneath the fact. They hadn't lost. Twenty-four held. The threshold held. But Cole wasn't asking about losing. He was asking about the gap in the text, the silence in the charter where the children's future should have been written, the space that Asterlyne would fill with whatever interpretation served a four-hundred-billion-credit asset.

Cole heard what she wasn't saying. She could tell because he didn't respond — just sat there, quiet in the particular way of a man who'd heard the thing underneath the thing and was filing it alongside his own uncertainty.

They sat with the fire between them and the question between them and the colony around them. Twenty-four people. Two children. The count that mattered and the lives that might not be counted. Ren thought about her partner on Earth — the other Mika, the architect, the person she'd been building something with before the debt spiral made building impossible. She'd left to avoid becoming someone's dependent. She'd come to a planet and become something else — not dependent, not independent, something the language didn't have a word for because the conditions that produced it didn't exist in contexts where words got made. Part of a structure. Load-bearing. The thing she'd always been, transposed from buildings to people.

The children born at Holdfast were part of the structure now. They existed inside the colony's architecture the way the channel network existed inside the bedrock — integrated, essential, their presence altering the system's behavior in ways the original design hadn't anticipated. Whether the charter acknowledged them was a legal question. Whether the colony claimed them was a structural one. Ren knew which question mattered.

She didn't say any of this. The fire was enough. Cole's silence was enough. The question sat between them, unanswered, patient, waiting like everything else.

Month 10.

The transmission arrived on the colony's communication array at 0347, during the magnetic window's third cycle. Ren was awake — the engineer's insomnia, the hours before dawn when the systems check ran in her mind whether she wanted it to or not. She heard the relay's incoming chime from her shelter, the sound she'd wired to carry across the settlement because incoming transmissions were rare enough that missing one was a failure the colony couldn't afford.

She reached the communications hub before Cole. Read the header. Read it again.

TO: Residents of Parcel 16b

Not colonists. Not charter signatories. Not the formal address Asterlyne had used in every prior communication — "Charter participants," "Settlement designees," the corporate vocabulary that acknowledged the contractual relationship between the company and the people it had sent to a planet to die profitably. Residents. The word was neutral. Domestic. The word you used for people who lived somewhere without owning it. Tenants. Occupants. People whose presence was temporary and whose rights were conditional and whose relationship to the land they stood on was defined by someone else's document.

The message was brief. Ren read it standing in the communications hub in the dark, the relay's screen casting blue light across her face, the hum of the trees filtering through the hub's walls.

"Asterlyne Corporation acknowledges receipt of your settlement's continued operational status. As the charter period approaches its contractual conclusion, Asterlyne wishes to affirm its commitment to the wellbeing and transitional support of all Parcel 16b residents. Forthcoming communications will address post-charter administrative procedures. Asterlyne values your contribution to the ongoing development of extra-solar settlement infrastructure."

Ren read it a third time. Translated it the way the colony had learned to translate corporate language — by identifying the words that were doing work and the words that were doing camouflage.

Residents. Not signatories. The language shift that erased the contractual relationship, that repositioned the colonists from parties-to-a-contract to people-who-happened-to-be-somewhere. Residents could be relocated. Residents could be managed. Residents didn't invoke clauses.

Transitional support. The shuttle's offer, reframed. Not renegotiation. Transition. The word assumed departure. The word assumed the colony's presence was a phase, not a permanence.

Post-charter administrative procedures. The charter had a duration. Five years. After five years, the charter concluded. If the clause was invoked, the land transferred. If the clause wasn't invoked, the charter simply ended and Asterlyne retained everything. The phrase "post-charter administrative procedures" didn't specify which outcome the procedures were designed for. The ambiguity was the message.

Ongoing development. Mining. The four-hundred-billion-credit mineral substrate. The channels, the crystallized compound, the planet's ancient infrastructure converted to a line item on a corporate balance sheet.

Cole arrived. She handed him the screen without speaking. He read it. His face was the neutral mask — the resting state that showed nothing because showing things cost energy — but his hands, holding the screen, were still in the way his hands were still when the machinery behind the mask was running at a speed the body couldn't match.

"Residents," he said.

"They've started the language shift."

"One month out."

"One month."

Cole set the screen down. Looked at Ren. The look was three seconds — the same duration as the look in the medical shelter after Mika's child was born, the same duration as a hundred other looks across five years, the specific interval that had become their unit of communication, the three seconds in which the structural information passed between two people who'd learned to read each other the way they read the systems they maintained.

"They know," Ren said.

"They've always known."

"They know we're going to make it."

Cole was quiet. The silence lasted longer than three seconds. When he spoke, his voice was flat in the way that flatness meant compression, the surface held level by the pressure of everything underneath it.

"Elena wrote that. End of Year One. 'We're going to make it.'"

Ren heard it. The echo. The ghost colony's certainty repeated across seven years and a different outcome, the words that had been true when Elena wrote them and false by the time her colony proved them false, and true again now, probably, the confidence interval still hiding inside the word *probably* the way it hid inside *should* and *mild* and every other word the colony used to describe a future it couldn't guarantee.

"We're not Elena," Ren said.

"No."

"We have twenty-four. She had six."

"She had six when she wrote it too. Different six. Different year. Same sentence."

Ren looked at him. Cole's face was doing the thing from Month 27 — the frequency she couldn't detect, the register that existed because the man was not the machine. He was afraid. Not of the planet. Not of Asterlyne. Afraid of the sentence. Afraid that saying *we're going to make it* was the invocation that summoned failure, the structural hubris that preceded collapse, the confidence that preceded the tremor that preceded the beam that preceded the boy on the floor with broken legs.

"Thirty days," Ren said. She didn't say the sentence. She said the number instead, because numbers were Cole's language and the language would carry what the sentence couldn't. Thirty days. Not a hope. A measurement. The distance between where they were and where the clause lived, expressed in the unit that Cole's framework could hold without the framework cracking.

Cole nodded. The small nod. The one that meant the number had entered the framework and the framework had accepted it. The closest thing to faith Cole Maren's architecture could produce.

They stood in the communications hub in the dark. The relay's screen glowed with Asterlyne's message. Residents of Parcel 16b. The company's lawyers had started writing the colony out of its own contract, word by word, the way the creep had advanced on the original settlement — slowly, patiently, dissolving the thing that stood in the path of what the company wanted.

One month.

Ren turned off the screen. The blue light died. The hum of the trees filled the space the light had occupied. She walked to the door of the hub and looked out at Holdfast in the dark — the shelters, the paths, the channel network carrying water through ancient infrastructure, the settlement they'd built and named and held for five years. Twenty-four people asleep in the structures she'd designed, on ground they'd chosen, breathing air that smelled like ozone and something sweet.

Thirty days. The number sat in the dark like a stone. Solid. Countable. Close enough to touch.

Ren closed the hub door behind her and walked to her shelter through the settlement she'd helped build, the same walk she'd done every night for three years. The sameness was what she was fighting for. The fighting looked like walking. It was enough.

Chapter 27 — "Tuesday"

The water filtration line on Junction 3 had developed a hairline fracture in the adhesive margin overnight.

Cole found it at 0514, the way he found most things — by showing up before the light did and putting his hands on the infrastructure until the infrastructure told him what was wrong. The fracture was small. Two centimeters, maybe three. The kind of degradation that Ren's inspection protocol would have caught in three days, that the secondary monitoring Joss had designed would have flagged in five. Nobody would have died from a three-day delay. The water would have run slightly mineral-heavy, the taste changing before the chemistry did, and Dana's filtration compounds would have caught the contamination window before it became a contamination event.

Cole fixed it anyway.

He worked in the pre-dawn dark with his hands and a polymer patch and the specific attention of a man who'd been maintaining systems for 1,826 days and whose hands knew the parts the way his lungs knew air. The adhesive went on cold. He held it in place for three minutes while it bonded, his fingers pressing the patch against the housing, the pressure steady, the force distributed evenly across the margin the way Ren had shown him in Year Two when the junction system was new and his engineering knowledge was warehouse logistics translated badly into alien infrastructure.

His hands knew it now. The translation was complete.

The spiral-trunked trees hummed in the near-distance. The sound came through the filtration shed's walls the way it came through everything on this planet — not heard so much as felt, the sub-audible frequency that lived in the chest and the jaw and the spaces between the bones. He'd felt it every morning for five years. The first morning, it had set his teeth on edge. Now it was the sound of where he was. Not home. Not yet a word he used. Just the sound of the place his hands knew how to fix.

The patch held. He tested it — pressure check, flow rate, the systematic verification that had become reflex. The numbers were clean. The junction was clean. The water would run through Ren's system and into the colony's supply and twenty-four people would drink it today without knowing it had been compromised and repaired before any of them woke.

Cole wiped his hands on his pants. Stood. His knees protested the standing the way they'd been protesting for two years — the specific complaint of a forty-three-year-old body that had spent five years kneeling on rock substrate and sleeping on a cot and carrying loads the body hadn't been designed to carry. He straightened slowly. Let the joints do what they needed to do. The sky through the shed's open doorway was the green-dark of pre-dawn, the color that had no name on Earth because Earth didn't produce it.

He walked out of the shed and into Holdfast.

The settlement was quiet. The shelters Ren had designed — low, wide, built for wind and then rebuilt for seismic after the tremor — sat in their arranged pattern on the rock substrate, dark shapes against the lighter ground. Paths worn into the substrate by five years of feet connected them like veins. The common area where Cole had laid out the charter and the corporate math sat empty, the table still there, the rock outcropping Joss had named the Bench still there, everything still there because things that people built and named and used every day developed a permanence that outlasted the materials.

Cole walked the perimeter. The morning count. He didn't count shelters anymore — he'd stopped that in Year Four, when the number held at twenty-four and the holding made the counting feel different. Not unnecessary. Different. He walked the perimeter because the walking had become ritual, had become

structure — the thing that held him in the hours before the colony woke, when the planet was quiet and his mind was loud and the framework ran without input.

He counted anyway. The body's reflex. Twenty-four.

The number sat where it always sat — behind the sternum, in the space the count had occupied since a fluorescent waiting room on Earth. But the number felt different this morning. Not lighter. Not heavier. Just different the way a key feels different when you know the lock it fits.

Today was Day 1,826.

He'd known the date the way he knew membrane percentages and junction locations and the count — as data, as a number inside the framework, as the specific coordinate in time that the charter designated as the boundary between surviving and owning. Five Earth years. 1,826 days. The number had been running in the back of his mind for months, ticking down the way the attrition model had once ticked down, except this count went in the other direction. Not subtracting. Arriving.

He hadn't told anyone. Ren knew — Ren always knew, the way she knew seal degradation and erosion patterns and the social architecture of the colony she'd helped build. She'd known the date since Month 58 when she'd come to his shelter and said, "Thirty days," and the number had been enough. Dana knew because Dana tracked orbital positions the way other people tracked days, and the orbital math was the calendar and the calendar said today. Haruki knew because Haruki noticed everything, the quiet diagnostic attention that read the colony's emotional weather the way it read vital signs. Joss knew because Joss maintained the data core and the data core held the charter timeline and the timeline ended today.

Everyone knew. Nobody had said it.

The trees hummed. The sky shifted from green-dark to green-pale. The planet turned the way it had been turning for millions of years, indifferent, the rotation carrying Holdfast from dark into light, and the light this morning was the same light as every other morning. That was the point.

Cole went back to the filtration shed. Checked the patch. Held.

Ren found him at the junction at 0738.

He heard her footsteps on the path before he saw her — the specific cadence of Ren's walk, the engineer's gait that was always slightly faster than the terrain required because Ren moved through the settlement the way current moved through the channels, purposefully, on a gradient she'd calculated whether she was conscious of it or not.

She came around the filtration shed and stopped. Cole was sitting on the housing cover with the inspection kit open beside him, running the secondary seal check that didn't need running because he'd already run it at 0514 and the results hadn't changed. He was running it because his hands needed the work the way his lungs needed air — the work kept the framework from processing the date into something it wasn't built to hold.

Ren looked at him. Three seconds. The unit of communication they'd built over five years, the interval that carried everything that speech was too slow for.

"It's done," she said.

Cole set down the inspection tool.

"Five years. Twenty-four alive. Clause 9.4.2."

She said it without ceremony. The democratic architect delivering a result the way she delivered every result — factual, verified, entered into the record. She'd counted. Cole knew she'd counted because the count was protocol. She'd walked the settlement before coming to him. She'd verified the number the way she verified seal integrity, by putting her attention on every junction and confirming that the junction held.

Twenty-four. The number that had been running in Cole's chest since Day Zero, the number he'd calculated in a corporate waiting room while forty-six other people signed without reading, the number that meant fifty-one percent of the original signatories, the number that triggered a clause the company had never expected anyone to reach. The number that meant the land transferred. That Holdfast was theirs.

Cole sat on the housing cover outside the filtration shed with the inspection kit open and the polymer patches arrayed beside him and the patch he'd applied at 0514 holding on the junction behind him, and the number entered his framework and the framework processed it and the processing was not what he expected.

He'd imagined this. Not often — imagining was a luxury the framework didn't permit, and the framework had been right to prohibit it because imagination was a form of counting that went forward instead of backward and forward-counting on a planet that killed people was an invitation to the specific hubris that preceded collapse. But he'd imagined it. Once or twice. In the hours after midnight when the systems were checked and the colony was breathing and his mind, released from the day's calculations, wandered into the territory it usually avoided.

He'd imagined relief. The weight of the number lifting. The framework releasing the count the way a structure releases load when the load-bearing element is removed. Five years of carrying forty-seven down to twenty-four, the attrition model running, the margin narrowing, and then the date arriving and the carrying being over.

What he felt was not relief.

He felt the ground under his hands. The dirt of Holdfast. The rock substrate they'd relocated to in Month 10 when the creep advanced and the colony voted and Ren insisted on the vote and Cole resisted and Ren was right. The ancient channels underneath, carved by something that had lived here before them, infrastructure that outlasted whatever built it. Dana's agricultural terraces in the distance, the third-phase crops growing in soil that followed cycles the colony had learned to predict. The shelters Ren had designed. The paths the colony had worn. The water running through the junction he'd just repaired.

He felt all of it through his hands, the way he'd felt the adhesive bond on the patch, the way he'd felt every system he'd maintained for 1,826 days. Not as data. Not as inventory. As contact. His hands on the ground of a place he'd been touching for five years, and the contact told him everything. Not relief. Recognition. He was here. He'd built this. They'd built this. The building was finished in the way that charters finished — a date on a contract, a legal threshold, a number that crossed a line. And the building was not finished in the way that building was never finished because the junction would need patching again and the membranes would need replacing and the crops would need planting and the water would need cleaning and the children would need raising.

Cole sat in the dirt. Ren stood three meters away, watching him the way she watched structures — for the stress lines, the load paths, the points where the weight was held and the points where it wasn't.

He sat there for a long time.

He didn't cry. His body didn't produce that response to this input. The framework held the way frameworks held — by distributing the load across every member, every joint, every connection that five years of construction had built. The load was not grief and not joy and not the thing between them. The load was the

specific weight of a man sitting on ground that belonged to him, to them, to twenty-four people who'd paid for it with twenty-three people who hadn't survived the purchase.

The trees hummed. The colony woke. He heard it in the sounds that reached the junction from the settlement below — footsteps on paths, a voice calling something ordinary across the common area, the clatter of the cooking station where someone was preparing the morning meal from the third-phase grain Dana had cultivated and the native tubers that tasted bitter and chemical and had become, over five years, the taste of breakfast.

Then the thought arrived.

It came the way thoughts came to Cole — not as emotion first but as data, as a variable entering the framework, the specific information that a system produced when the system contained something the original architecture hadn't accounted for. Two children at Holdfast. Mika's daughter born in Month 4 of Year Five. Lana's son born two months later. Neither of them signatories. Neither of them named in a charter written in a corporate boardroom on Earth by lawyers who'd designed the language for a population that was supposed to die before reproduction became a variable.

The charter said: "Land transfer in perpetuity to surviving original signatories and their legal assigns."

Legal assigns. The phrase that opened onto a room that didn't exist. On a planet with no courts, no registry, no jurisdiction, no mechanism for establishing the identity of a person born outside any legal framework that recognized their existence. The children born at Holdfast were residents of a place that now belonged to their parents, and the belonging was legal, was contractual, was the product of a clause invoked by twenty-four people alive on Day 1,826. But the children's belonging was something else. Something the charter's language didn't contain. Something Asterlyne's lawyers had never written because they'd never imagined the scenario or had imagined it and chosen silence because silence preserved optionality and optionality was the corporation's native language.

The gap was still there. The clause was invoked. The land was theirs. And the question Lana had asked five months ago in a room full of people who'd stopped trusting corporate language — *what happens to the children born here?* — sat in the fine print the way the creep had sat at the forest edge. Present. Patient.

Cole let Ren think he was sitting with the weight of what they'd won. He was. He was also sitting with the space where the win didn't reach. The place in the charter where the children's future should have been written and wasn't. The silence that Asterlyne would fill with whatever interpretation served a four-hundred-billion-credit mineral substrate.

He didn't tell her the gap was still there. She knew. She'd known since the assembly in Year Five when the question stopped the room and the charter's language said legal assigns and legal assigns meant nothing on a planet with no law. She'd said, "We'll figure it out when we have to." The having to was now. The figuring out would come after. After the celebration and the grief and the counting of what they'd won and what they'd lost and the distance between the two.

Cole stood up. His knees complained. He let them.

"I fixed the junction," he said.

Ren looked at the filtration shed. Looked at Cole. The three-second look.

"I know," she said.

She walked back toward the settlement. Cole stood in the dirt outside the filtration shed with the inspection kit open and the polymer patches arrayed and the junction holding behind him. He stood there for another minute. Then he followed her down the path.

He went to the comm station at 0920.

The communications hub was the same structure it had been since Year Two — Ren's design, low-profile, the relay equipment that Asterlyne controlled mounted on the interior wall beside the colony's own antenna that Ren had built from salvaged components in Year Three when trust in the company's infrastructure had eroded past the point of dependency. The relay still worked. Messages still transmitted. The three-month transit delay still separated the colony from Earth by a gap that made communication not conversation but correspondence, each message a letter thrown across a distance that made the throwing an act of faith.

Cole sat at the terminal. The screen glowed blue in the dim interior. The hum of the trees filtered through the walls, the same frequency, the same sub-audible vibration that had been the first alien sound he'd felt and was now the sound underneath every other sound.

He wrote.

Not fast. Not slow. The pencil-on-paper pace that had governed every message to Lily since Month 6, the first one — three sentences about trees and distance and nothing about why. He'd written five messages in five years. Each one a stage in a progression he hadn't planned, a trajectory from avoidance to honesty to something he didn't have a word for because the word required conditions that hadn't existed until now.

The first message: *I'm on a planet very far away. The trees are beautiful. I wish you could see them.*

The second: *I'm on a planet very far away. I came here because I'd run out of reasons to stay. I'm finding new ones.*

The third, fourth, fifth — each one shorter, more direct, the sentences compressing the way sentences compressed when the person writing them was moving closer to the thing the sentences were about. Less explanation. Less distance. The rhetoric of a man approaching something he'd been retreating from since a custody hearing on Earth where a judge had told him, with professional compassion, that absence was not parenting.

Lily was fourteen now. Not the nine-year-old who drew horses and thought he was on a work trip. Fourteen. Five years of growing that had happened in the gap between his messages, in the space that three months of transit delay made abstract but couldn't make irrelevant. She might have received his messages. She might not have. Asterlyne controlled the relay. Asterlyne read everything that passed through the comm infrastructure — Dana had proved that, and Dana's proof was older than her own betrayal, was embedded in the system the way the creep was embedded in the soil cycle, by design. The corporation could have blocked his messages. Could have read them and forwarded them and read them again. Could have filed them as data points in the same assessment model that had priced his life at less than two million credits.

He didn't know what Lily knew. He didn't know if she'd heard from him at all, or if the messages had arrived and been opened by a mother who'd been granted custody by a court Cole couldn't afford to challenge, and the mother had decided the messages were a disruption and the disruption was not in the child's best interest. He didn't know if Lily had read his words about trees and reasons and distance and understood them, or if the words had arrived at a fourteen-year-old girl who didn't remember the father who'd disappeared when she was nine and the words were noise from a stranger.

He didn't know any of it. He wrote anyway.

The message was short. Three sentences again. The same count as the first one, five years ago, when he'd sat in his shelter at Month 6 with paper and pencil and two hours of silence and produced three sentences that said nothing about himself.

These three said something.

I built something. It's not finished. When you're ready, there's a place.

He read them once. Didn't reread. Didn't edit. Didn't spend two hours compressing the distance between what he meant and what he could say. The distance had compressed on its own, over five years, through the specific pressure of living on a planet that didn't permit the luxury of imprecision.

He sent the message. The relay accepted it. The signal entered Asterlyne's comm infrastructure and began the three-month transit to Earth, to a relay station, to a network that would route it to the address Cole had filed on Day Zero, the address of a house he'd never lived in where a girl he'd left was five years older and the five years were his absence measured in her growth.

He sat at the terminal for a moment after the message sent. The blue glow on his face. The hum of the trees through the walls.

Not "come here." Not yet. The invitation was conditional — *when you're ready* — because Cole had learned, over five years, that the people who came to this planet needed to choose it. Not be sent. Not be contracted. Not be calculated into a model that converted their survival into corporate asset value. Choosing was what made the landing survivable. Choosing was what had kept twenty-four people alive through the creep and the fever and the silence and the shuttle and the eleven months of holding.

Lily would choose. Or she wouldn't. The choice was hers in a way that nothing in Cole's framework could influence, and the inability to influence it was the specific helplessness of a father who'd left and was learning, five years late, that the leaving had been a choice too, and choices had costs that arithmetic couldn't calculate.

He turned off the terminal. Left the comm hub. Went back to work.

The evening started the way evenings at Holdfast started — with the meal.

The common area filled the way it filled every night, by gravity rather than schedule, the pull of twenty-four people toward the warmth and light and shared food that five years of surviving together had made as automatic as breathing. Dana's third-phase grain prepared by whoever was on rotation. Native tubers roasted on the flat stones Kira had installed beside the fire pit in Year Three. The fermented native fruit that one of the younger colonists had been refining for six months, the alcohol content low but present, the taste somewhere between wine and regret.

Someone had decided today was a celebration. Cole didn't know who. The decision had moved through the colony the way decisions moved — not from the council or the democratic architecture Ren had built but from the informal network that existed underneath it, the culture that had grown in the gaps between the systems. By the time Cole arrived at the common area, the fire was larger than usual and the fermented fruit was poured into cups and people were standing in configurations that were different from the dinner configurations, looser, less functional, the specific arrangement of a group that had decided to mark something.

Joss was supposed to throw this.

The thought arrived without permission. Joss in the medical shelter, immobilized, his legs splinted, his body holding together through Dana's compounds and Haruki's monitoring and the specific stubbornness of a twenty-seven-year-old who'd survived five years on a planet that had tried to kill him in a dozen different ways and had almost succeeded with a storage rack and a fourth tremor. Joss who'd organized the naming vote. Who'd maintained the water junctions. Who'd become the person Cole hadn't intended to raise and couldn't pretend he hadn't.

Joss was alive. The count was twenty-four. Joss had been alive at 0000 hours on Day 1,826, alive when the clause triggered, alive when the threshold was met. The charter was specific: alive on Year Five, Day One.

Joss was alive on Year Five, Day One. That was the number that mattered. That was the number the framework held.

Cole went to the medical shelter before the celebration.

Haruki was there. He was always there now — the medical shelter had become his primary station since the seismic event, since Joss's injuries required the continuous monitoring that Haruki provided with the same measured calm he'd provided everything for five years. Haruki was checking Joss's splints when Cole entered, his steady hands moving over the timber and cord construction with the diagnostic attention that found misalignment by touch.

Joss was propped on his cot. Alert. Thinner than he'd been a month ago — the immobilization had cost him the physical density he'd built from five years of carrying filtration housings and walking junction paths. His face was sharper. The bones showed. But the eyes were the same — the eyes that had been twenty-two and scared in a transit ship and were now twenty-seven and something else, something that had survived fear by passing through it rather than around it.

"They're setting up out there," Joss said. His voice was tired in a way that rest didn't fix.

"I know."

"I had a plan. For when we hit the date. I was going to —" He stopped. Shifted on the cot. The shifting produced a sound in his throat that he suppressed. "Doesn't matter."

"It matters."

"I was going to organize the whole thing. Music — Beck found a way to make the native reeds vibrate at pitch. And I wanted everyone at the Bench. The whole colony at once. I had a speech."

"You had a speech."

"A short one." Joss tried to smile. The smile was there and then it wasn't, interrupted by something in his body that the smile couldn't override. "Shorter than Cole Maren's logistics briefings."

"Everything's shorter than my logistics briefings."

The joke landed the way humor landed between them — lightly, without performance, the irreverent undertone that Joss had learned from Cole without Cole intending to teach it. Cole sat on the equipment crate beside Joss's cot. The same crate. The same position. The same shelter where he'd sat through the fever in Month 17, holding a cloth to a twenty-three-year-old's forehead and saying his daughter's name for the first time.

Four years between that night and this one. The distance measured not in time but in what the time had held. The creep solution. Dana's confession. The colony's vote, the naming, the shuttle. Eleven months of holding still. The tremor. The rack on Joss's legs. All of it carried. Every count, every loss the framework absorbed because the framework was all he had.

"We made it," Cole said.

"I know." Joss looked at him. The look was the same look he'd given Cole on the night of the fever — twenty-three and burning and saying *when*, not *if*. Except now the burning was different, was in the legs and the abdomen where Haruki monitored for the complications that immobilization and internal injury produced in a body being treated with botanical compounds on an alien planet. And the *when* had arrived. They'd made it.

"You should go out there," Joss said. "They need you."

"They don't need me. They need the count. The count's met."

"Cole." Joss's voice. Not the tired voice. The other one. The one that had solidified somewhere in Year Four, when the filler words burned away and the anxiety directed itself outward, protective rather than self-consuming. "Go."

Cole looked at Haruki. Haruki was standing at the workbench, organizing his supplies with the methodical attention he brought to everything, the steady hands sorting compounds into the categories that only his system understood. He didn't look up. He didn't need to. The silence between Haruki and Cole contained the same information it always contained — the diagnostic assessment delivered without words, the doctor's attention applied to the patient's visitor as thoroughly as to the patient.

"I'll be back," Cole said.

"I know," Joss said.

Cole left the medical shelter. The evening air hit him — ozone and the sweet rot that was the planet's atmosphere, the smell that had set his teeth on edge on Day One and now smelled like the air he breathed. The trees hummed. The fire in the common area threw light across the settlement in patterns that moved with the wind.

He went to the celebration.

Twenty-four people at Holdfast.

Cole stood at the edge of the common area and watched them. Not counting — or counting, but the counting was underneath the watching, the reflexive tally that his body performed while his attention went somewhere else. Somewhere the framework didn't govern. Somewhere the math didn't reach.

Ren was by the fire. Talking to Kira about the water system, probably, or the agricultural schedule, or the structural assessment she'd run that morning, or nothing. Talking because talking was what people did at fires and Ren had learned to do what people did, the engineer who'd spent five years building systems for a colony that had taught her, in the gaps between the systems, that the gaps were where the living happened.

Dana sat on the Bench. The rock outcropping. Soil under her nails. The fermented fruit in a cup she held with both hands, the way you hold something warm. The woman who'd saved the colony and betrayed it and confessed and survived the vote and stayed. The most morally complicated person Cole had ever known, sitting on a rock named by people she'd transmitted to a corporation, drinking fruit fermented from plants she'd cultivated on land she'd helped the colony keep.

Polk was at the back. Always at the back. Standing with his arms crossed and his jaw set and his sunburned face carrying the particular expression Cole had learned to read as the settled configuration — the final position of a man who'd been calculating for five years and had arrived at an answer that didn't convert into the variables he'd started with. His daughter was on Earth. Five years older. The debt forgiveness the shuttle had offered was gone with the shuttle. Polk had chosen Holdfast over the daughter. He'd live with it. The specific weight that wouldn't lift, the cost of a decision made with the jaw instead of the math.

Others. The colonists whose names Cole knew the way he knew membrane percentages — by function and by person, the dual knowing that five years had fused into a single act of attention. Beck, who'd stopped calculating risk and started volunteering for perimeter patrols. Kira, who walked the path with her hand on the wall. Ora, who'd suggested Elena's name for the settlement. Lana, holding her son, the boy born at Holdfast, the child whose legal status the charter didn't address and whose presence in Lana's arms addressed something the charter couldn't reach.

Mika's daughter slept in a shelter nearby. Two children at Holdfast. Two people who hadn't signed anything, hadn't been in the waiting room, hadn't survived the transit or the landing or the creep or the fever. Two people who existed because other people had survived long enough to make them. The charter hadn't

anticipated that. The variable that broke the model the way the planet's second cycle had broken the viability data — not by being hostile but by being alive.

Cole took a cup of the fermented fruit. Tasted it. The taste was rough — chemical, sweet, the specific profile of a fruit that had evolved on a planet where human taste buds were the alien element. Someone had added something to cut the bitterness. It didn't entirely work. He drank it anyway.

"Speech." Beck's voice from the fire. Not demanding. The good-natured provocation of a man who'd survived five years with a logistics manager who'd never given a speech and was enjoying the opportunity to ask for one.

"No," Cole said.

"Come on. Five years. Twenty-four alive. You must have something."

"The junction's fixed. Membrane's at ninety-one percent."

Laughter. The kind of laughter that comes from people who've been together long enough to know what's funny about each other and the knowing is the thing that makes it funny. Cole heard it and felt it land in the place behind his sternum where the count lived, and the laughter didn't displace the count — nothing displaced the count — but it occupied space next to it, the way the children occupied space next to the signatories, present and uncounted and changing the shape of what the count meant.

The celebration was small. Quiet. Not the celebration Joss had planned — no music from the native reeds, no speech, no organized event with the full colony gathered at the Bench. Just people at a fire with fermented fruit and the specific intimacy of a group that had buried twenty-three of the people they'd arrived with and built a place they'd named and were standing in it on a Tuesday in Year Five because the charter said Tuesday was the day.

Ren caught Cole's eye across the fire. Three seconds. The look carried five years of structural assessment and load-bearing and the silence that was their native language. She didn't say anything. She didn't need to.

Cole sat on the Bench. The rock was cold. The fire was warm. The trees hummed.

This was not what he'd imagined. He'd imagined relief. The weight lifting. The framework releasing the load it had carried since Day Zero. Instead, the weight redistributed. The same mass, the same total, but arranged differently — not the count pressing down from above but the ground pressing up from below, the specific force of a place that held you because you'd built it to hold.

He drank the fermented fruit. Tasted the chemistry of an alien world processed through human ingenuity and time. Sat on a rock that had a name and listened to people who had names talking about things that had names and felt the naming — all of it, the naming of the place and the naming of the parts and the naming of the days that led to this one — accumulate into something the framework couldn't calculate and didn't need to.

Holdfast. Twenty-four. Tuesday.

Haruki collapsed at 1947.

Cole didn't see it happen. He heard it — a sound from the medical shelter that cut through the celebration's murmur and the trees' hum and the fire's crackle. Not a crash. Not an impact. The sound of a body folding, the specific acoustic signature of a person whose legs stopped holding them and whose descent was the controlled fall of someone who understood, even while falling, what the falling meant.

Cole was moving before the sound finished. Across the common area, past the fire, down the path to the medical shelter with the stride that was faster than walking and slower than running, the crisis mode his

body had defaulted to since Month 1, the controlled urgency that kept the mind ahead of the legs.

He reached the shelter in forty seconds.

Haruki was on the floor. Not sprawled — seated, his back against the examination table, his legs extended in front of him, his hands flat on the floor beside his hips. The posture of a man who'd managed his own collapse, who'd felt it coming and directed the descent toward the nearest support structure the way Ren directed loads toward bearing walls. Even falling, he'd been engineering.

Joss was trying to get off his cot. The splinted legs wouldn't cooperate. His face was white with the effort and the pain and the specific horror of a man watching a doctor die from a position where he couldn't reach him.

"Stay," Cole said to Joss. Not a request. The voice he used for emergencies. The voice that carried the framework's authority, the one that people obeyed before they processed the instruction.

Joss stayed.

Cole knelt beside Haruki. The doctor's face was gray. Not pale — gray, the specific coloration of skin that wasn't receiving enough blood, the diagnostic sign that Haruki himself had taught Cole to read during the fever when they'd triaged thirty-four colonists and Haruki had pointed at faces and said *watch the color, the color tells you before the pulse does*.

"Cardiac," Haruki said. His voice was steady. Of course his voice was steady. Haruki's voice had been steady through every crisis for five years — through the first autopsy and the fever and the creep death and Patricia's breathing stopping and James's immune system surrendering and every body Haruki had treated and every body he'd failed to save. The voice was steady because Haruki's steadiness was the treatment. It always had been. He was not going to stop being Haruki because Haruki was dying.

"Tell me what to do," Cole said.

"Sit me up. The table."

Cole lifted him. Haruki's weight was less than it should have been — the doctor who'd made Cole eat during the fever had not been following his own prescription. Cole positioned him on the examination table, the surface where Haruki had treated every injury and illness the colony had produced for five years, the flat plane that was Haruki's workbench and was now Haruki's bed.

"Elevated," Haruki said. "Head up. Not flat."

Cole propped him with the medical supplies crate. The angle wasn't right. He adjusted. Adjusted again. Haruki's hand came up and touched Cole's arm — not gripping, guiding. Moving Cole's hands to the right position the way he'd moved Cole's hands during the splinting lesson in Year Two, the diagnostic touch that communicated through contact what speech was too slow for.

"There," Haruki said.

"Dana's compounds —"

"Won't work. This isn't inflammatory. This is structural." Haruki's hand was on his own chest. Not clutching — assessing. The doctor diagnosing himself with the same attention he'd applied to every patient for five years. "Myocardial. The left ventricle. I've been feeling the arrhythmia for three weeks. Didn't say anything because there's nothing to do about it on a planet without a cardiac catheterization lab."

Three weeks. Haruki had known for three weeks that his heart was failing and hadn't said anything because the telling would have changed nothing except the colony's awareness that the doctor who kept them alive

was dying. The information management of a man who understood, the way Cole understood, that some data changed behavior without changing outcomes, and the behavioral change was a cost that the outcome couldn't justify.

Cole heard it and recognized it and hated it and understood it and couldn't argue with it because the argument was the same argument he'd used for five years — the cold logic of withholding information when the information's only effect was fear.

"What do I do?" Cole said.

"You're doing it. Elevated position. Reduce cardiac workload. Oxygen is —" Haruki paused. His hand pressed against his chest. The pause lasted four seconds. Cole counted. Haruki's face tightened, the measured calm cracking for the first time Cole had ever seen, the pressure breaking through the surface that had held for five years. Then the face reset. The calm returned. The crack sealed.

"Oxygen is limited by what the lungs can extract from this atmosphere," Haruki continued. The voice steady. Instructing. "The trace compounds Dana identified in Year One — the ones that interact with human respiratory tissue. They reduce oxygen transfer efficiency by approximately eight percent compared to Earth standard. Under normal conditions, the body compensates. Under cardiac stress, the compensation is insufficient."

He was teaching. Dying and teaching. Delivering the clinical information that a doctor delivered to a colleague who would need to treat patients after the doctor was gone. Cole listened and felt the framework absorb the data and felt the framework crack, the same crack from the fever in Month 17, the same fracture that let the light through — except wider now, wider because the man on the examination table was the man who'd made the crack visible in the first place, the one who'd forced Cole to eat and told him Joss would wake and stood next to every dying body in the colony with the same measured calm, and the calm was leaving, and when it left, something essential would leave with it.

"I'm fifty-seven," Haruki said.

Cole looked at him. Haruki's eyes were clear. Not fever-bright, not glazed. Clear in the way that eyes are clear when the mind behind them is doing something it has decided to do, when the attention is directed rather than diffused, when a person is choosing what to look at in the time they have left.

"I'm fifty-seven. I've lived longer than Elena."

Cole heard it. Elena Vasik, who'd died alone at the ghost colony, whose logs had been the mirror and the map and the warning. Elena, who'd been a scientist and a leader and the last survivor of a colony that failed. Elena, whose final words were two: *Enough, now.* Haruki had read those words. They'd been on the Board in the common area for three years. Haruki was measuring himself against the ghost, the way Cole had measured himself against the ghost for five years, and the measurement came out in Haruki's favor. That was what he wanted Cole to hear.

"We won," Haruki said.

The word sat in the medical shelter between them. Won. Not survived — won. The distinction mattered in a way Cole felt but couldn't articulate, the difference between enduring something and defeating it, between outlasting a system designed to kill you and claiming the thing the system was designed to prevent. The charter was invoked. The land was theirs. Haruki knew this. He'd known it since 0000 hours when the date turned and the clause triggered and the threshold was met. He'd been alive for it. He'd been alive at the five-year mark.

He'd gotten to know.

"Haruki," Cole said. The name came out the way names come out when the saying is the only thing left — not a request, not a statement, just the sound of a person being named by someone who didn't want the person to stop being a person.

"The dosage protocol for Dana's anti-inflammatory is in the blue case. Top shelf. She knows it but you should know it too. Joss's splints need adjustment in four days — the tibial alignment is drifting medially, you can feel it through the cord, here —" He touched his own left leg, showing the position. "Lana's son has a rash that I've been treating with the mild topical compound, second container from the left in the botanical cabinet. It's not serious. Watch for spread."

Instructions. The doctor's final rounds. The patient list handed to the colleague who would carry it forward. Cole listened and memorized because memorizing was what his mind did and Haruki's instructions were the last system the doctor would build and the system deserved the same attention Cole had given every system for five years.

"The arrhythmia protocol, if anyone else develops —"

Haruki stopped. His hand went to his chest again. The pause was longer this time. Seven seconds. Cole counted and hated counting and counted anyway because counting was the only act the framework could perform, and the framework was the only thing between him and the other thing. The thing beneath the numbers. The thing that was not arithmetic.

Haruki's hand reached for Cole's. Found it. Held it.

The grip was steady. Of course the grip was steady. Haruki's hands had been the steadiest thing in the colony for five years — steadier than the shelters, steadier than the junction seals, steadier than the bedrock. The hands that had treated every wound and delivered a child and held Patricia's hand while she died and splinted Joss's legs and forced Cole to eat and performed the first autopsy and the last examination and every act of medicine between. The hands that had been the colony's one irreplaceable instrument.

The grip held for twelve seconds. Cole counted. Then the grip changed. Not released — changed. The specific alteration in muscle tension that Cole had never felt before and recognized instantly because the body knew what the mind refused to process. The grip went from holding to held. From active to passive. From the hand of a person gripping to the hand of a person whose hand was being gripped.

Haruki's eyes were open. Clear. Looking at Cole with the expression Cole had seen a thousand times — the diagnostic attention, the measured calm, the gaze that said *I see you and I know what's wrong and I'll do what I can*. The expression didn't change. It stayed. It was the last thing Haruki's face did.

Cole sat in the medical shelter holding Haruki's hand and felt the number change.

Twenty-three.

The number entered the framework and the framework held it the way it held every number — structurally, without choice, because the architecture existed and holding was the architecture's purpose. Twenty-three. Below threshold. Except the threshold was already met. The clause was already invoked. The date was already past. Twenty-three didn't change the math. The math was finished. Twenty-three changed something else — something the math had never measured, something that existed in the space between the numbers where Haruki had lived for five years, the quiet space where a doctor's calm held everything together. The calm was gone.

Joss was making a sound from his cot. Not words. The sound a person makes when grief is too large for the throat and the throat produces something smaller, something compressed, the vocalization of a body that has received information it cannot metabolize.

Cole didn't let go of Haruki's hand. Not yet. He held it the way Haruki had held things — with attention, with the specific pressure that communicated care through contact, with the steadiness that was not his native mode but had been learned, over five years, from the man whose hand he was holding. He held it and felt the warmth leave it in increments and felt each increment as a subtraction from something he couldn't count.

He sat there for a long time. The trees hummed through the walls. The celebration continued outside — he could hear it, the murmur of voices and the fire's crackle, the sounds of a colony that didn't know yet. That was still celebrating. That was still twenty-four in their awareness because the awareness hadn't been updated and the update was sitting in a medical shelter holding a dead man's hand.

Cole lowered Haruki's hand to his chest. Positioned it over the heart that had stopped. The diagnostic hand resting on the diagnosis. He pulled the blanket up — the same gesture Haruki had made for every death, the covering that was the doctor's final act, the last treatment administered to a patient who could no longer be treated. Cole did it with the care that the gesture required and felt the care burn in his throat and held the burning the way Haruki had held everything — steadily.

He stood. Looked at Joss. Joss's face was wet. The twenty-seven-year-old who'd stopped using filler words and directed his anxiety outward and become the colony's infrastructure and Cole's unrequested son was crying on a cot with broken legs while the man who'd saved his life twice lay covered on the examination table three meters away.

"He knew," Cole said. "He got to know we made it."

Joss closed his eyes. The tears continued. The sound from his throat continued. Cole stood between them — the dead doctor and the living boy. Standing was all that was left. The framework's last output. The body vertical while everything inside it was not.

Joss died three days later.

Cole was not in the medical shelter when it happened. He was at the junction. Running the inspection protocol. The adhesive check, the membrane assessment, the systematic verification that had been his first act on Day 1,826 and was now the act he performed because performing it was the thing his hands knew how to do and his hands needed to know something because the rest of him had stopped knowing anything since Haruki's grip changed from active to passive on the evening of the day they won.

Ren came to tell him.

She walked up the path with the engineer's gait and stopped at the filtration shed and said, "Joss," and the word was enough. One word. One syllable. The name of a twenty-seven-year-old who'd volunteered to enter a building Cole should have entered, whose legs had been crushed by a rack that fell because a tremor shifted a beam that failed because the planet's geology produced seismic events the viability report hadn't mentioned, whose infection had been managed by a doctor who was now dead, whose body had been twenty-seven and stubborn and running on the reserve that youth provided, and the reserve had run out.

Cole didn't go to the medical shelter.

He didn't trust himself to go. The framework that had held him through twenty-three deaths — through Lev and Priya and Vogel and Osei and Farin and Sarah and Lin and Thomas and Marcus Reeves and Thomas Chen and Noor and Suri and the colonist who walked into the forest and the three who died in the fever and the ones who died of equipment failure and accumulated fatigue and the slow cascade of small things stacking until the stacking killed — the framework that had processed every subtraction as data, as input, as the cost of a calculation that led to a clause that led to ownership — the framework would not hold this one.

Not because the number changed something. Twenty-two was just a number. The clause was invoked. The land was theirs. Twenty-two didn't change the math.

It changed the cost.

Joss had volunteered to enter the shelter. Cole had not said no. Ren had said twenty-three and the number had been enough to hold Cole in place while Joss carried the risk. The framework had made the decision — the cold arithmetic of a man who was worth more alive than the boy because the man's death dropped the count below threshold and the boy's injury didn't. The framework had been right. The framework had saved Cole's life by sacrificing Joss's safety. The framework had done what the framework was built to do.

And Joss was dead.

The boy he'd watched become a man. The nervous kid from the transit ship who asked too many questions and bounced his leg and carried water filtration housings under his arm. The twenty-three-year-old who'd burned with fever while Cole held a cloth to his forehead and said his daughter's name for the first time. The twenty-five-year-old who'd come to a water junction and said the settlement needed a name. The twenty-seven-year-old who'd organized the celebration he didn't get to attend, who'd told Cole to go, who'd said *I know* when Cole said he'd be back.

Cole stood at the filtration shed and held the inspection tool and felt the framework process the data and felt the processing fail. Not a clean failure — not a collapse, not the sudden structural catastrophe of a system exceeding its tolerance. A slow failure. A degradation. The framework trying to categorize Joss's death the way it categorized every death — as a subtraction, as a variable, as the cost of a model that had produced the outcome it was designed to produce — and the categorization not fitting. The variable not converting. The input resisting the architecture because the architecture had been built to hold numbers and Joss was not a number. Had never been a number. Had been the reason the numbers mattered.

He'd stayed for a daughter he couldn't save and lost a son he could have.

The thought arrived and Cole received it. The framework couldn't. Receiving wasn't in the architecture. The framework held numbers. The framework held junction percentages and membrane assessments and attrition models and the count. The thought was not a number. The thought was the specific, unbearable recognition that the system he'd built — the same system that had kept twenty-four people alive, that had invoked the clause, that had turned survival into ownership — had required him to choose between the math and the boy. And he'd chosen the math. And the math was right. And the boy was dead.

Cole set down the inspection tool. Sat on the housing cover. The same position he'd been in when Ren told him it was done, eight hours after the junction repair, the morning of Day 1,826 when the world had been a different place, when Haruki was alive and Joss was alive and the number was twenty-four and the number meant they'd won.

He sat there. The trees hummed. Ren stood three meters away and did not speak and did not leave.

The celebration happened anyway.

Not that night. Not for three days. The colony moved through the deaths the way the colony moved through everything — collectively, unevenly, the shared weight distributed across twenty-two people who'd been carrying weight for five years and knew what carrying felt like and carried this too.

Dana prepared the bodies. Cole couldn't. Ren couldn't. Dana could, because Dana had rebuilt herself from the person who'd betrayed the colony into the person who did the things the colony needed done, and the doing was her penance and her contribution and the thing that made her presence earned rather than tolerated. She prepared Haruki with the botanical compounds he'd cataloged himself. She prepared Joss

with the care of a woman who understood that the body she was tending had been, for five years, the body that kept the water clean.

They buried them at Holdfast. Not at the ghost colony. Not twelve kilometers west where Elena's cairn sat in a clearing that wasn't a clearing. At Holdfast. In the soil of the settlement, near the channel network, where the ancient infrastructure ran through bedrock that had been carved by something that lived here before any of them and built things that lasted.

Cole stood at the burial and held the count. Twenty-two. The number sat in his chest the way every number had sat — heavy, structural, without choice. But the number was different now. The number was after. The clause was invoked, the land was theirs, and the number was a measurement of what remained rather than what was needed. The math was finished. The dying had purchased the owning. And the owning had cost Haruki and Joss, whose deaths had come after the math was done, after the framework had served its purpose, as if the planet or the charter or the specific cruelty of survival arithmetic had needed to demonstrate that the cost wasn't something you stopped paying when the bill was met.

Garrett Polk stood at the back of the gathering. His jaw set. His arms at his sides instead of crossed — a change Cole noticed because he noticed everything about Polk, the way he'd noticed everything since the transit ship. Polk looked at the graves and his face held the expression Cole had learned to read as the final configuration, the settled state, the man who'd been calculating for five years and whose calculations hadn't protected him from this. Nobody's calculations had.

Ren said words. Not a speech — Ren didn't give speeches, the same way Cole didn't. She said Haruki's name and Joss's name and the names sat in the air the way names sat when they belonged to people who were gone. The saying was all that kept the belonging from dissolving.

Then the colony went back to the common area. And the celebration happened.

Twenty-two people at Holdfast. The fermented fruit that tasted like the planet's chemistry filtered through human patience. The fire. The Bench. The paths worn bare. The shelters. The channels running beneath the bedrock. The trees humming at the frequency Cole had felt in his chest since Day One, the frequency that had set his teeth on edge and now felt like the sound the ground made when you put your hands on it and held on.

Joss was supposed to throw this. Haruki was supposed to drink it.

Cole drank it. He sat on the Bench with the cup in his hands and the fire's warmth on his face and the colony around him — the twenty-two people who'd survived the math, the planet, the corporation, the clause, the five years — the specific, relentless accumulation of days that turned desperate strangers into the population of a place called Holdfast. He drank the fermented fruit and tasted ashes and tasted something underneath the ashes that he didn't have a name for because the conditions that produced it didn't exist in contexts where names got made.

Twenty-two people alive on a Tuesday. On land that belonged to them. In a place they'd built and named and held. The charter invoked. The clause met. The ownership transferred. And two graves in the soil of the settlement, and a gap in the charter where the children's future should have been written, and a message traveling across three months of void toward a fourteen-year-old girl who might read it or might not.

The planet didn't care. The planet had never cared. The trees hummed. The soil cycled. The channels carried what they carried. The creep retreated and advanced and retreated again on a schedule older than any charter or corporation or species that thought it could own what the planet offered. The planet was a system in motion and they were inside it and the being inside was not conquering or homesteading or claiming. It was living. Just living. The way the things that built the channels had lived, long enough to make something that lasted, and then gone, and the lasting was what remained.

Cole sat with the colony. Twenty-two. The framework held the number the way it held every number. But the framework was different now. Had been different since the fever, since Joss's bedside, since the first message to Lily, since the naming, since the morning he'd sat in the dirt outside the filtration shed and felt the ground press up instead of the count press down. The framework held numbers. The numbers had faces. The faces had names. The names belonged to people he'd watched die and people he'd watched live and two children who slept in shelters on land the charter said was theirs and the charter's silence said might not be.

Invocation and loss arriving at the same moment. The thing the math had never predicted. The thing the math couldn't calculate. The thing that was true anyway.

Cole sat on the Bench at Holdfast. Fermented fruit warm in his hands. Fire on his face. The trees. The twenty-two. He sat with all of it. Winning, losing, the gap between — except it wasn't a gap. It was a space where something would grow, the way things grew on this planet. In cycles. In patience. In the specific persistence of life that didn't ask permission.

That was something.